MONTHLY CURRENT AFFAIRS MAGAZINE

APRIL 2026



- Detailed release for all exams
- Static GK points included
- Category-wise Compilation
- Live Table of Content

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Important Days

Important Days (In Table)

Date	Day	Theme
2nd April	World Autism Awareness Day	Autism and Humanity – Every Life Has Value
4th April	International Day for Mine Awareness and Assistance in Mine Action	Invest in Peace; Invest in Mine Action
5th April	National Maritime Day	Maritime India – Empowering Progress
5th April	Samata Diwas	
6th April	International Day of Sports For Development And Peace	Sport: Building Bridges, Breaking Barriers
7th April	World Health Day	Together for health. Stand with science
8th April	International Romani Day	
8th April	World Banjara Day	
9th April	April Shaurya Diwas	
10th April	World Homeopathy Day	Homoeopathy for Sustainable Health
11th April	National Safe Motherhood Day	
11th April	World Parkinson's Day	
12th April	International Day of Human Space Flight	
13th April	Siachen Day	
14th April	World Quantum Day	
14th April	World Chagas Disease Day	Women at the heart: protecting the next generation from Chagas disease
15th April	World Art Day	
15th April	International Wellness Day	
17th April	World Haemophilia Day	Diagnosis: First Step to Care
18th April	World Heritage Day (International Day for Monuments and Sites)	Emergency Response for Living Heritage in contexts of Conflicts and Disasters
19th April	World Liver Day	Solid Habits, Strong Liver
21st April	Civil Services Day	Viksit Bharat: Citizen-Centric Governance and Development at the Last Mile
21st April	World Creativity and Innovation Day	
21st April	The International Day of Women in Industry	Celebrating Women's Leadership in Industrial Development
22nd April	World Earth Day	Our Power, Our Planet
23rd April	World Book and Copyright Day	
23rd April	English Language Day	
23rd April	Spanish Language Day	
24th April	National Panchayati Raj Day	
24th April	World Day for Laboratory Animals	
24th - 30th April (last week of April)	World Immunization Week 2026	For every generation, vaccines work
25th April	World Malaria Day	Driven to End Malaria: Now We Can. Now We Must
25th April	National Telephone Day	
25th April	National DNA Day	
25th April	International Delegate's Day	
25th April	World Veterinary Day	Veterinarians: Guardians of Food and Health

Date	Day	Theme
26th April	World Intellectual Property Day	IP and Sports: Ready, Set, Innovate
27th April	World Tapir Day	
27th April	Lapu-Lapu Day	
27th April	International Design Day	The spaces in between
28th April	World Day for Safety and Health at Work	Let's ensure a healthy psychosocial working environment
29th April	International Dance Day	
30th April	International Jazz Day	

Important Days With Static

2nd April World Autism Awareness Day

- United Nations General Assembly **designated** 2 April as World Autism Awareness Day (WAAD) **in 2007.**
- **Theme : "Autism and Humanity – Every Life Has Value"**
- Autism, or **autism spectrum disorder** (ASD), is a **developmental disability** that affects a person's ability to communicate and interact with others.

4th April International Day for Mine Awareness and Assistance in Mine Action

- **On 8 December 2005**, the UN General Assembly declared 4 April as the **International Day for Mine Awareness and Assistance in Mine Action.**
- The **theme - "Invest in Peace; Invest in Mine Action."**



5th April National Maritime Day

- Indian celebrates **63rd Maritime day in 2026**
- Theme: Maritime India – Empowering Progress
- To raise awareness about the importance of the maritime sector in India's trade, economy, and security.
- The day was observed as a **tribute to the maiden voyage** of the **first Indian-owned ship, SS Loyalty** (of the Scindia Steam Navigation Company Ltd) **from Mumbai to London on 5th April 1919.**
- **First observed in 1964.**

5th April Samata Diwas



- **Birth anniversary of Babu Jagjivan Ram**, a great leader and social reformer
- Jagjivan Ram was **born on 5th April 1908 in Chandwa in Bihar** to a **Dalit family.**
- He worked hard for equality and justice in society. In 1934, Babuji **founded the Akhil Bharatiya Ravidas Mahasabha** and the **All Indian Depressed Classes League.**
- In 1936, he became a member of the Bihar Legislative Council
- In **1977**, he was made the **Deputy Prime Minister of India.**
- He was a **Member of Parliament for 50 years without a break** and served as a Union Minister for 30 years **-a world record.**
- Babu Jagjivan Ram passed away on July 6, 1986. His **cremation place** is called **'Samata Sthal' in Delhi.**

6th April International Day of Sports For Development And Peace

- **2026 Theme: Sport: Building Bridges, Breaking Barriers**

7th April World Health Day

- World Health Day 2025, will kick off a year-long campaign on maternal and newborn health
- Theme : **"Together for health. Stand with science"**
- The date of 7 April marks the anniversary of the **founding of WHO in 1948.**
- The First World Health Assembly decided to celebrate World Health Day on April 7th, with effect from 1950.

8th April International Romani Day

- Romani were originally traveling court musicians in parts of what is now India and Pakistan.
- The Romani have their own language and culture. In the Middle Ages, they migrated to Turkey, France, Spain.

10th April World Homeopathy Day

- The day is observed on the occasion of the **birth anniversary of German physician** Dr Christian **Friedrich Samuel Hahnemann**, the **founder of homoeopathy**
- **Born in Paris on April 10, 1755**
- The theme of World Homoeopathy Day 2026 is "Homoeopathy for Sustainable Health".
- Organisers: Under the aegis of the **Ministry of AYUSH**
- Jointly hosted by: Central Council for Research in Homeopathy (CCRH) National Commission for Homeopathy (NCH) National Institute of Homeopathy (NIH)
- The Ministry of Ayush will commemorate World Homoeopathy Day 2026 on April 10 at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi, with a two-day interactive forum aimed at discussing the role of homoeopathy in building sustainable healthcare systems.

8th April World Banjara Day



- World Banjara Day (also known as International Roma-Banjara Day) is celebrated annually on April 8.
- In our community (Banjara) people are among Scheduled Tribes, at some places they are considered to be among Scheduled Castes, at some places they are considered to be among Other Backward Class and at some places they are considered as NT-DNT (nomadic tribes-denotified tribes).
- The objective of the celebration is to keep the culture of the community alive and discuss their problems,

9th April Shaurya Diwas

- Shaurya Diwas is observed every year on April 9 to commemorate the exceptional courage and bravery displayed by security forces during the 1965 India-Pakistan conflict.
- observed at Sardar Post in the border district of Kutch in Gujarat.
- The day commemorates the extraordinary bravery displayed by CRPF personnel during the 1965 India-Pakistan conflict.
- It may be recalled that in April 1965, Pakistan attempted to capture Indian border areas under 'Operation Desert Hawk'.
- At that time, CRPF units were deployed at Sardar and Tak Posts in the Rann of Kutch.

11th April National Safe Motherhood Day

- Marking the **birth anniversary of Kasturba Gandhi**, the wife of Mahatma Gandhi and a symbol of strength, simplicity, and womanhood in Indian history.

- The idea of dedicating a day solely to the cause of maternal health was **initiated by the White Ribbon Alliance India (WRAI)** — a coalition of organizations working to reduce maternal mortality and promote safe motherhood.
- **In 2003, the Government of India officially declared April 11** as **National Safe Motherhood Day** — making **India the first and only country in the world** to designate a specific day for maternal health awareness.

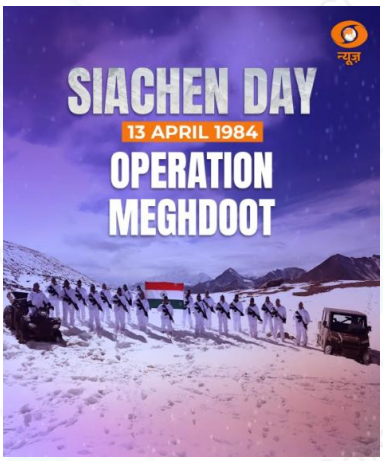
11th April - World Parkinson's Day

- In April **1997, the inaugural World Parkinson's Day (WPD) was established** by the European Association for Parkinson's Disease (now known as Parkinson's Europe) and co-sponsored by the World Health Organization (WHO).
- **James Parkinson's 'Essay on the Shaking Palsy', published in 1817**, recognised **Parkinson's as a medical condition for the first time.** This date marks **Dr. James Parkinson's birthday.**
- Parkinson's disease is a **progressive neurodegenerative disorder** that primarily affects movement, causing symptoms like tremors, slow movements, stiffness, and difficulty with balance and coordination

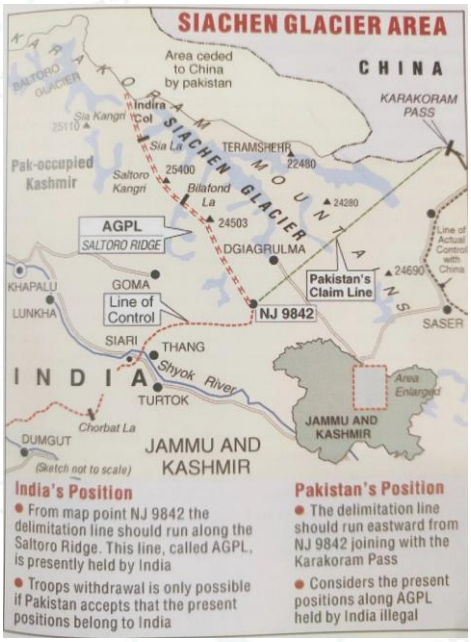
12th April International Day of Human Space Flight

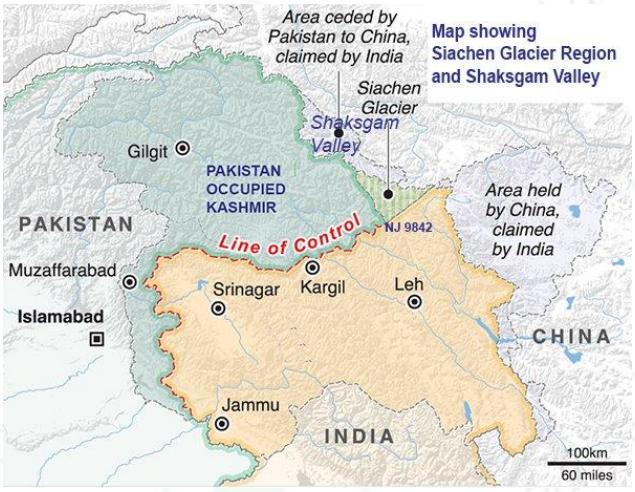
- The General Assembly on April 2011, declared 12 April as the International Day of Human Space Flight .
- 12 April 1961 was the date of the first human space flight, carried out by Yuri Gagarin, a Soviet citizen. This historic event opened the way for space exploration for the benefit of all humanity.

13th April Siachen Day



- **Commemorates Operation Meghdoot (**13th April 1984**),** which marked **India's successful military control of the Siachen Glacier in 1984.**
- **Siachen:** Located at around 20,000 feet **in the Karakoram Range**, is the **longest glacier in this range** and **highest militarized zone globally.**
- The **Saltoro Ridge**, part of the Karakoram, lies southwest of the Siachen Glacier.
- **Siachen** plays a crucial role **in controlling** routes **from Gilgit-Baltistan to Leh and the Karakoram Pass.**
- The **Karachi Agreement of 1949** demarcated the **boundary between India and Pakistan** until a **point called NJ9842**, beyond which the line was left vague due to inhospitable terrain
- **Post-1972 Simla Agreement**, the **Line of Control (LoC) was formalized** but did not address the area beyond NJ9842.
- **Operation Meghdoot:** On 13th April 1984, under PM Indira Gandhi, India launched Operation Meghdoot, **securing control of the Siachen Glacier and Saltoro Ridge,** including key passes like **Bilafond La and Sia La.**



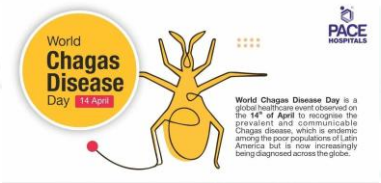


14th April World Quantum Day

- The World Quantum Day is celebrated on April 14, a **reference to 4.14**, the **rounded first digits of Planck's constant:** 4.1356677×10−15 eV·s = 0.000 000 000 000 004 1356677 electron volt second, a **product of energy and time** that is the fundamental constant governing quantum physics.
- **Quantum physics** is the **branch of science** that **deals with the tiniest particles in the universe**, such as atoms, electrons, photons (light particles), and other subatomic particles like quarks.

14th April World Chagas Disease Day

- Chagas disease, also known as **"silent or silenced disease", .**
- Chagas (CHAH-gus) disease is an **inflammatory, infectious disease** caused **by the protozoan parasite, Trypanosoma cruzi.**
  - This parasite is **found in the feces of the triatomine (reduviid) bug.**
  - There are currently **no vaccines** available
  - The World Chagas Disease Day was celebrated for the **first time in 2020.**



- **The theme** : Women at the heart: protecting the next generation from Chagas disease

15th April World Art Day

- Was **proclaimed** at the 40th session of UNESCO's General Conference **in 2019.**

17th April - World Haemophilia Day

- Hemophilia is a **rare, inherited bleeding disorder** where the **blood doesn't clot properly** due to a deficiency or defect in one of the clotting factors. This can lead to prolonged bleeding after injuries, surgeries, or even spontaneous bleeding
- World Haemophilia Day was **first celebrated on the 17th of April 1989, by the World Federation of Haemophilia (WFH)** to honour Frank Schnabel's birthday, the WFH's founder.
- **Theme is : "Diagnosis: First Step to Care"**

18th AprIL World Heritage Day (International Day for Monuments and Sites)

- Celebrated to honour and protect cultural and natural heritage.
- **The International Council on Monuments and Sites (ICOMOS)-NGO- proposed the idea** of observing World Heritage Day**, in 1982**

- It was **approved by** the 22nd **UNESCO General Conference in 1983.**
- **This year theme - Emergency Response for Living Heritage in contexts of Conflicts and Disasters**
- The **World Heritage Convention** is an international agreement **created by UNESCO in 1972.**
- World Heritage Convention was **adopted by countries** around the world **to protect important cultural and natural sites.**

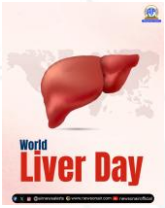
Additional Facts:

- **46th Session of the World Heritage Committee:** Archaeological Survey of India, Ministry of Culture, successfully hosted the 46th Session of the World Heritage Committee **in Delhi** from 21st to 31st July 2024.
- **India's first Archaeological Experiential Museum**: Union Minister Amit Shah inaugurated the Archaeological Experiential Museum **in Vadnagar** on 16th January 2025.

Constitutional and Legislative Provisions Related to Indian Heritage:

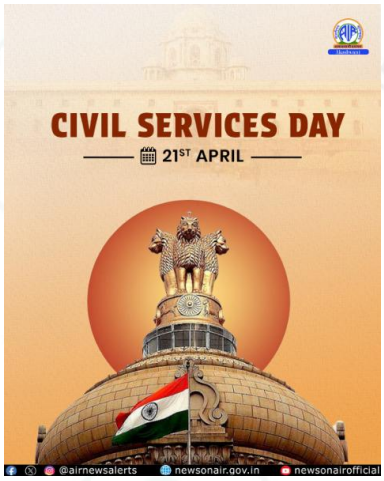
- **Directive Principles of State Policy: Article 49** puts obligation on the State to protect every monument or place or object of artistic or historic interest, declared by or under law made by Parliament to be of national importance.
- **Fundamental Duty: Article 51A** of Constitution states that it shall be the duty of every citizen of India to value and preserve the rich heritage of our culture.
- **Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act (AMASR Act) 1958:** It is an act of the Parliament of India that provides for the **preservation of ancient and historical monuments and archaeological sites and remains of national importance**, for the regulation of archaeological excavations and for the protection of sculptures, carvings and other like objects.

19th April - World Liver Day



- World Liver Day (WLD) is a global healthcare event commemorated every year on the 19th of April with the intent to raise awareness about liver disease in the general public.
- **Theme : Solid Habits, Strong Liver**

21st April Civil Services Day



- Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions will observe 18th Civil Services Day on April 21, 2026.
- **This date was chosen to commemorate the day when Sardar Vallabhai Patel addressed the probationers of Administrative Service Officers in 1947 at Metcalfe House Delhi.**
- **The theme for the Civil Services Day 2026** is "Viksit Bharat: Citizen-Centric Governance and Development at the Last Mile".
- The first official function to celebrate the day was organised at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi on April 21, 2006.
- **The Father of the Indian Civil Service is Charles Cornwallis**, who served as the Governor-General of India from **1786 to 1793**.
- In **1854, the concept of a merit-based modern Civil Service in India was introduced following Lord Macaulay's recommendations in a British Parliamentary report.**
- A Civil Service Commission was set up in London in 1854, and competitive examinations started from the year 1855 itself
- **Shri Satyendranath Tagore, brother of Rabindra Nath Tagore became the first Indian to pass in 1864.**
- Indians continued petitioning for the Civil Services exams to be held in India however it was not until the **First World War** and the **Montagu-Chelmsford reforms**, simultaneous exams in India and England were agreed upon.

- **The Indian Civil Service Examination started being conducted in India from the year 1922**, initially in Allahabad and later in Delhi with the establishment of the **Federal Public Service Commission.**

Post- Independent India:

- Following the implementation of the Constitution of India on January 26, 1950, the **Federal Public Service Commission came to be known as the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC)** and the Chairman and Members of the Federal Public Service Commission assumed the roles of Chairman and Members of the **UPSC** as per Clause (1) of Article 378 of the Constitution.

21st April World Creativity and Innovation Day

- The United Nations designated 21 April as World Creativity and Innovation Day to raise awareness of the role of creativity and innovation in all aspects of human development.
- **The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO),** following the 2005 Convention helps countries strengthen their creative industries and promote artistic freedom.

21st April The International Day of Women in Industry

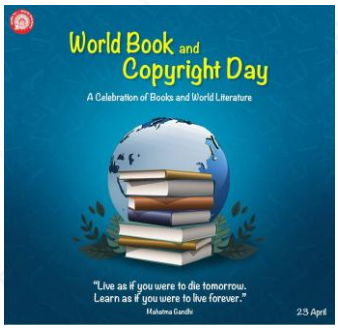
- The International Day of Women in Industry (IDWI), observed each year on 21 April, inaugurated in 2026
- **celebrates the contributions of women to industrial development and promotes a more inclusive** and equitable future for industry worldwide.
- The **Day was proclaimed through a landmark resolution adopted by the UNIDO General Conference during the Global Industry Summit 2025 in Riyadh.**
- **THEME** : Celebrating Women's Leadership in Industrial Development

22nd April World Earth Day



- World Earth Day is celebrated annually across the world on April 22 every year.
- **Earth Day's 2026 theme is** OUR POWER, OUR PLANET
- It is also known as **International Mother Earth Day**, is a globally recognised event dedicated to raising awareness and promoting the sustainability of our planet.
- The **first World Earth Day was held on April 22, 1970, in the United States.**

23rd April - World Book and Copyright Day



- To promote the enjoyment of books and reading; to recognize the power of books as a bridge between generations and across cultures.
- **23 April** is a symbolic date in world literature. It is the date on which **several prominent authors**, William Shakespeare, Miguel de Cervantes and Inca Garcilaso de la Vega all **died.**
- **Rabat has been officially designated as the UNESCO World Book Capital for 2026, marking a major cultural milestone for the Moroccan capital**

23rd April - English Language Day

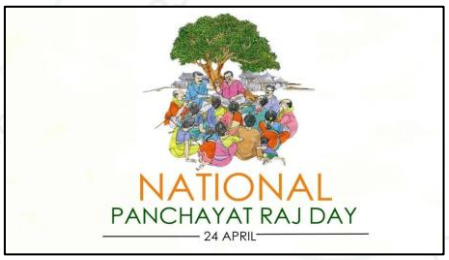
- A United Nations (UN) observance day.
- The day **coincides with** both the **birthday and death day of William Shakespeare** and **World Book Day**
- English Language Day is the result of a **2010 initiative** by the UN's Department of Global Communications, **establishing language days for each of the Organization's six official languages.**

23rd April Spanish Language Day

- April 23rd is celebrated as "Spanish Language Day at the United Nations"

- To raise awareness among UN staff, and the world at large, about the history, culture and use of Spanish as an official language.

24th April - National Panchayati Raj Day



- The **first celebrated in 2010**.
- The day **marks the enactment of the 73rd amendment of the constitution in 1992,** which **gave constitutional status to Panchayats** as institutions of rural local self-government.
- The main provisions of the **Panchayati Raj Act** are outlined **in Part IX of the Indian Constitution**, which consists of **Articles 243 to 243-O**

24th April- World Day for Laboratory Animals



- Instituted in 1979 World Day for Laboratory Animals, **has been a catalyst for the movement to end the suffering of animals in laboratories** around the world and their replacement with advanced scientific non-animal techniques.

24th - 30th April World Immunization Week 2026

- World Immunization Week 2026 **by the World Health Organisation (WHO)** began across the globe.
- The **week-long campaign** from **24th - 30th of April.**
- The World Immunization Week is **celebrated in the last week of April** to promote the life-saving power of immunization.
- **The theme for this year is** : For every generation, vaccines work

25th April World Malaria Day



- World Malaria Day is an occasion to highlight the need for continued investment and sustained political commitment for malaria prevention and control.
- It was **instituted by WHO** Member States during the World Health Assembly of **2007.**
- **THEME: Driven to End Malaria: Now We Can. Now We Must**

About Malaria:

- It is an **acute febrile illness** caused by **Plasmodium parasites**, which are spread to people through the **bites of infected female Anopheles mosquitoes.**
- It is a life-threatening disease **primarily found in tropical countries.**

Transmission

- It is **not contagious**
- **Five species of parasites** can cause malaria in humans and 2 of these species – **Plasmodium falciparum and Plasmodium vivax** – pose the **greatest threat.**

25th April National Telephone Day

- Alexander Graham Bell invented the telephone in 1876.

25th April National DNA Day

- Commemorates the **discovery of the double helix structure of DNA in 1953** by **James Watson and Francis Crick** and the **completion of the Human Genome Project in 2003.**
- **Deoxyribonucleic Acid (DNA)** is the molecule that carries the genetic information for an organism's development and function.

DNA (Deoxyribonucleic Acid)

- DNA is made up of **two linked strands** that wind around each other to form a twisted ladder shape known as a **double helix.**

- The **majority of DNA is found in the cell nucleus** (referred to as **nuclear DNA**), but a **small amount** can also be found in the **mitochondria.**

25th April International Delegate's Day

- In order to **raise awareness of the role of delegates of the Member States to the United Nations**, the UN General Assembly has proclaimed 25 April as International Delegate's Day.
- **Declared by UNGA in 2019**
- International Delegate's Day marks the anniversary of the **first day of the San Francisco Conference (United Nations Conference on International Organization) on 25 April 1945.**
- On this day, **delegates from fifty countries gathered in San Francisco to establish an organization** aimed at restoring world peace and creating a post-war world order.
- **On 26 June 1945**, two months after the first meeting, the **Charter of the United Nations was signed** by representatives from the 50 countries attending the conference.
- This agreement led to the creation of the **United Nations, now comprising 193** Member States, and serves as the main international platform for collective dialogue between its Member States.

25th April World Veterinary Day

- The World Veterinary Day is commemorated to honour the veterinary profession every year on the final Saturday in April.
- For 2026, the day falls on Saturday, April 25
- **Theme:** 'Veterinarians: Guardians of Food and Health'
- **Highlight the systemic role of veterinary services in safeguarding food safety, food security, public health, and animal health worldwide.**

26th April - World Intellectual Property Day



- Designated by WIPO's member states in 2000 with the aim of increasing general understanding of IP.
- Theme:"IP and Sports: Ready, Set, Innovate"
- On this day World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO) Convention came into force in 1970
- The WIPO Convention was **signed at Stockholm on July 14, 1967,** entered into force in 1970 and was amended in 1979.
- **WIPO** is an intergovernmental organization which **in 1974 became one of the specialized agencies of the United Nations system.**

27th April - World Tapir Day



- Raising Awareness of Tapirs **Since 2008**
- Tapirs are **large herbivorous mammals** that inhabit jungle and forest regions of **South America, Central America, and Southeast Asia**.
- Tapirs are **large, plant-eating animals with short trunks**, and they have been around since **prehistoric times.**
- There are **four species of tapirs –** all are now **either endangered or vulnerable** because of habitat loss, hunting, and climate change.

27th April - Lapu-Lapu Day

- It is an important celebration for Vancouver's Filipino community in Canada.
- The day **honours Datu Lapu-Lapu**, the **Filipino chieftain who famously defeated Spanish forces** led by Ferdinand Magellan **in the Battle of Mactan in 1521** and became a national hero.

- The government of British Columbia officially recognised **April 27 as Lapu-Lapu Day in 2023**, acknowledging the **cultural contributions of the Filipino-Canadian community**

27th April International Design Day

- This day commemorates the founding of the International Council of Design on the 27th of April, 1963. Until 2020, this event was celebrated as World Design Day.
- **The theme** - "the spaces in between".

28th April - World Day for Safety and Health at Work

- **In 2003**, the International Labour Organization **(ILO), began to observe World Day**
- To stress the prevention of accidents and diseases at work
- **THEME: Let's ensure a healthy psychosocial working environment**

29th April - International Dance Day

- Also called **World Dance Day.**
- Commemorating the **birthday of Jean-Georges Noverre, the father of modern ballet**
- This day was **first founded in 1982** by the Dance Committee of the International Theatre Institute (ITI), in collaboration with UNESCO

30th April International Jazz Day

- USA (Chicago), will host the 15th Anniversary International Jazz Day **.**
- In **November 2011 the UNESCO General Conference proclaimed** 30 April as "International Jazz Day".

Books

Book	Author	Remark
We, the People of India: Decoding a Nation's Symbols	T.M. Krishna	
Paradiso 17	Hannah Lillith Assadi	Published by HarperCollins
TeenDigest		Launched by The Hindu

Appointments

Appointments (in Table)

Person	Appointment
Min Aung Hlaing	Elected President of Myanmar
Uchral Nyam-Osor	Elected Prime Minister of Mongolia
Nizar Amidi	Elected president of Iraq
Roman Gofman	New Mossad Chief
Lieutenant General Susan Coyle	First woman to head the Australian Army
Lt Gen Pushpendra Pal Singh	General Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Western Command
LT Gen Sandeep Jain	General Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Southern Command
Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth	Vice Chief of the Army Staff
Sharad Satya Chauhan	Punjab vigilance bureau chief
Samrat Choudhary	Bihar Chief Minister
Harivansh Narayan Singh	Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha
Dr. K. S. Somashekhar	Secretary in the Rajya Sabha Secretariat
Chanchal Kumar	Information and Broadcasting Secretary

Person	Appointment
Sanjay Lohiya	Special Secretary, Department of Financial Services
Abhishek Singh	Director General, National Testing Agency
Rohit Kansal	Secretary, Department of Rural Development
Narendra Bhooshan	Secretary, Department of Land Resources
Tejveer Singh	Secretary, Department of Chemicals and Petro-Chemicals
Shukla Verma	Secretary, Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances
Bharat Harbanslal Khera	Officer on Special Duty, Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprise
Ashwini Bhide	Municipal Commissioner of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC)
Burra Vamsi Rama Mohan	Chairman and Managing Director of Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID)
Shri Anurag Kapil	Director (Finance) at NMDC Limited
Campbell Wilson	Resigns as Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Air India
Pirojsha Godrej	Chairperson of Godrej Industries Group
Ajit Agarkar	chairman of the senior selection committee (BCCI)
Santhosh Viswanathan	vice-president and managing director for the Asia Pacific and Japan region – Intel
Sunil Fernandes	Chief Operating Officer (COO) – Coforge
Nidhi Chhibber	NITI Aayog Chief Executive Officer (CEO)
Ashok Kumar Lahiri	NITI Aayog Vice Chairperson
Dr. Gobardhan Das	Full-Time Member of NITI Aayog
Dinesh Trivedi	India's High Commissioner to Bangladesh
Justice Lisa Gill	First woman Chief Justice of Andhra Pradesh High Court
Hrishikesh Roy	ombudsman of the Bihar Cricket Association
Asit Tripathy	President of Odisha Steel Producers' Association
Péter Magyar	Prime Minister of Hungary
Rumen Radev	Prime Minister of Bulgaria
Payal Kapadia	President for 65th Cannes Critics Week
Gagandeep Kaur Grewal	First Sikh woman to be appointed a sheriff in Alberta, Canada
Nitu Sarma	Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Noida International Airport (NIA)
John Ternus	Apple's Chief Executive Officer (CEO)
C. V. Anand	Director General of Police – Telangana

Appointments With Static

Min Aung Hlaing Elected Myanmar President



- Myanmar junta chief Min Aung Hlaing won a parliamentary vote , to become the country's President,
- It is the northernmost country of Southeast Asia.
- Bordering Countries: It is bordered by India in the west, Bangladesh in the northwest; China in the north and northeast; by Laos in the east and by Thailand in the southeast.
- Maritime Borders: It is bounded by the Andaman Sea in the south and by the Bay of Bengal in the southwest.
- Capital City: Naypyidaw.
- Mountain ranges: It consists of Bago Yoma, Rakhine Yoma, and Shan Hills.
- Highest Point: Hkakabo Razi.

- Major Rivers: It is drained by Mekong, Irrawaddy, Salween and Chindwin

Uchral Nyam-Osor elected Mongolia's new Prime Minister





- Uchral Nyam-Osor has been elected Mongolia's new prime minister, becoming the country's third leader in nine months as political instability
- Capital: Ulaanbaatar
- Currency: Tögrög (MNT)

Who is Nizar Amidi?





- **Nizar Amidi has been elected as the new president of Iraq.**
- **Location**: It is a Western Asian country.
- **Bordering Countries**: It is bordered by six nations: Iran to the East; Kuwait to the southeast; Turkey to the north; Syria to the west; Jordan to the southwest and Saudi Arabia to the south.
- **Maritime Border:** The country has a coastline along the northern end of the Persian Gulf.
- **Capital City**: Baghdad.
- **Major Rivers**: Two of the most significant rivers in all of Asia, the Euphrates and Tigris Rivers, drain the land.

Roman Gofman Appointed New Mossad Chief

- Israel has appointed Major General Roman Gofman as the **new head of its foreign intelligence agency**, marking an unconventional leadership choice
- Gofman will officially assume office on June 2, 2026, succeeding David Barnea

Australia Names First Female Army Chief in Historic Move



- Australia has announced a landmark shift in its military leadership by appointing **Lieutenant General Susan Coyle as the first woman to head the Australian Army in its 125-year history.**
- Lieutenant General Susan Coyle will replace Lieutenant General Simon Stuart as Chief of Army

Lt Gen Pushpendra Pal Singh takes over as Western Army Commander

- Lieutenant General Pushpendra Pal Singh, formerly the Vice Chief of the Army Staff (VCOAS), has assumed command as the General Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Western Command.
- He succeeds Lieutenant General Manoj Kumar Katiyar, who superannuated on March 31.

LT Gen Sandeep Jain Assumes Command Of Southern Command



- Lieutenant General Sandeep Jain has assumed command as the General Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Southern Command on 01 April 2026. He succeeds Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth.
- Lieutenant General Sandeep Jain was commissioned into the MAHAR Regiment in June 1988.

Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth assumes role of Vice Chief of Army Staff



- Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth assumed the role of Vice Chief of the Army Staff.
- He is an alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, in Pune.
- He was commissioned into the Armoured Corps in December 1986.

Punjab appoints Sharad Satya Chauhan as new vigilance chief



- Punjab government appointed senior IPS officer Sharad Satya Chauhan as the vigilance bureau chief.
- was holding the charge of Special DGP-cum-managing director, Punjab Police Housing Corporation, has been appointed as the Special DGP-cum-Chief Director, Vigilance Bureau.
- replaces P K Sinha (1994 batch), who has been appointed as OSD, law and order. He will take over as special DGP, law and order on May 1 after Arpit Shukla superannuates.

Nitish Kumar resigns; Samrat Choudhary become next Bihar CM



- Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar stepped down on April 14, 2026, amid hectic political developments in the State.
- Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's resigns after he was elected as a Rajya Sabha member last week
- **Meanwhile Deputy CM Samrat Choudhary become the next CM of Bihar** after he was elected as the BJP's leader of the Legislature Party in the State.
- **For the first time, the BJP is set to have a Chief Minister in the State**

Harivansh elected Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha unopposed



- Harivansh Narayan Singh was elected unopposed as the Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha.
- **It is the third term as Deputy Chairman for the journalist-turned-politician.**
- The Office of the Deputy Chairman, Rajya Sabha, fell vacant after the term of Harivansh ended on April 9.
- It is for the first time that a nominated member has been elected as Deputy Chairman.

Deputy Chairman :

Election

- Elected by Rajya Sabha members
- Simple Majority (present & voting)
- Presided by Chairman

Roles & Functions

Acts as Chairman when:

Office vacant

Vice President acts as President

VP discharges Presidential functions

When presiding:

- Same powers as Chairman
- No first vote, only Casting Vote

When not presiding:

- Acts as normal member
- Can speak & vote normally

Status

- Not subordinate to Chairman
- Directly accountable to Rajya Sabha

Hon'ble Chairman, Rajya Sabha, Shri C. P. Radhakrishnan appoints Dr. K. S. Somashekhar as Secretary in the Rajya Sabha Secretariat

- Hon'ble Chairman, Rajya Sabha has appointed Dr. K. S. Somashekhar as Secretary in the Rajya Sabha Secretariat with effect from April 18, 2026.

Chanchal Kumar appointed Information and Broadcasting Secretary as part of a top-level bureaucratic reshuffle effected by the Centre

- Senior IAS officer Chanchal Kumar has been appointed as Information and Broadcasting Secretary
- Mr. Kumar, a 1992 batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer of Bihar cadre, is currently Secretary, Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER).
- Sanjay Lohiya, Additional Secretary, Ministry of Mines has been appointed as Special Secretary, Department of Financial Services, Ministry of Finance.
- He will take over as Secretary, Department of Financial Services, after the superannuation of incumbent Nagaraju Maddirala on May 31,
- Abhishek Singh, Director General, National Informatics Centre, has been named as Director General, National Testing Agency, Ministry of Education.
- Rohit Kansal, Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Textiles, will be Secretary, Department of Rural Development.
- Narendra Bhooshan, a 1992 batch IAS officer of Uttar Pradesh cadre, has been appointed as Secretary, Department of Land Resources.
- Tejveer Singh, a 1994 batch IAS officer of Punjab cadre, will be Secretary, Department of Chemicals and Petro-Chemicals, in place of Nivedita
- Shukla Verma, who has been appointed as Secretary, Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances.
- Mr. Verma will also hold the additional charge of the post of Secretary, Department of Pensions and Pensioners Welfare.
- Bharat Harbanslal Khera, Additional Secretary, Department of Consumer Affairs, has been appointed as Officer on Special Duty, Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, will take over as after the superannuation of Subhas Chandra Lal Das on April 30

Senior IAS officer Ashwini Bhide appointed as BMC commissioner



- The Maharashtra Government appointed senior IAS officer Ashwini Bhide as the Municipal Commissioner of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), making her the first woman to head one of the oldest and richest civic bodies in the country.
- Incumbent Municipal Commissioner Bhushan Gagrani, who completed his tenure , handed over charge to Ms. Bhide, who will be replaced by IAS officer Lokesh Chandra in her previous post as Additional Chief Secretary in the Chief Minister's Office.

POWERGRID Appoints Burra Vamsi Rama Mohan as CMD

- Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID) has announced the appointment of Burra Vamsi Rama Mohan as its new Chairman and Managing Director (CMD), effective April 1, 2026.

- Vamsi Rama Mohan has assumed charge with immediate effect and will serve as CMD until July 31, 2030, the date of his superannuation, or until further orders.

Shri Anurag Kapil takes charge as Director (Finance), NMDC

- Shri Anurag Kapil, a 1998 batch officer of the Indian Railway Accounts Service (IRAS), has assumed charge as Director (Finance) at NMDC Limited, India's largest iron ore producer
- National Mineral Development Corporation (NMDC), a Navratna Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Steel,

Air India CEO Campbell Wilson Resigns Before Term Ends



- Campbell Wilson has stepped down as the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Air India.
- Wilson had taken charge as CEO and Managing Director in July 2022, after former Turkish Airlines Chairman Ilker Ayci opted out of the role earlier that year amid controversy.
- Wilson's five-year term originally scheduled to run until 2027.

Pirojsha Godrej to be new chairperson of Godrej Industries Group

- Godrej Industries Group announced that Nadir Godrej, Chairperson of the Group, will retire upon turning 75 in August 2026 and will assume the role of Chairman Emeritus.
- **Pirojsha Godrej (45), has been named as Chairperson Designate of the Godrej Industries Group**

Ajit Agarkar to continue as chairman of selectors as BCCI renews contract for one year



- **Ajit Agarkar will continue as chairman of the senior selection committee after the BCCI decided to renew his contract for one more year, keeping an eye on the 2027 ODI World Cup.**
- Under Agarkar's chairmanship, the selected Indian teams between October 2023 to March 2026 reached four ICC tournament finals, winning three of them — two T20 World Cups and one ICC Champions Trophy — and it was a foregone conclusion that his contract will be renewed for fourth year.

Nidhi Chhibber Takes Additional Charge as NITI Aayog CEO



- Nidhi Chhibber has assumed additional charge as the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the NITI Aayog **after the completion of the tenure of BVR Subrahmanyam,** marking an important leadership transition in India's premier public policy institution.
- Nidhi Chhibber is a 1994-batch IAS officer of the Chhattisgarh cadre.
- **Predecessor**: BVR Subrahmanyam, completed his extended three-year tenure as NITI Aayog CEO in February 2026.
- **NITI Aayog:** Established in 2015, NITI Aayog replaced the Planning Commission as India's foremost policy advisory body to promote cooperative federalism, sustainable development, and long-term strategic planning.

Ashok Kumar Lahiri Appointed NITI Aayog Vice Chairperson



- The government has reconstituted the NITI Aayog, appointing Ashok Kumar Lahiri as its vice chairman and four new full-time members.
- **Mr. Lahiri, a former Chief Economic Advisor to the government, replaces Suman K. Bery, who has been the Vice-Chairperson of the government's think-tank since May 2022.**

- Mr. Lahiri, MLA from Balurghat constituency, did not contest the ongoing election in West Bengal.
- **He has also been a member of the 15th Finance Commission.**

Prime Minister Narendra Modi met newly appointed NITI Aayog Full-Time Member Dr. Gobardhan Das.



- Dr. Gobardhan Das was appointed as a Full-Time Member of NITI Aayog
- **NITI Aayog is an advisory body (think-tank) to the government, established through a Union cabinet resolution, replacing the erstwhile Planning Commission.**
  - It is neither a Constitutional nor a statutory body.
- **Mandate**: It has a twin mandate:
  - To oversee the adoption and monitoring of the SDGs in the country; and
  - Promote competitive and cooperative federalism among States and UTs.
- **Chairperson**: The Prime Minister of India.
- **Vice Chairperson**: Appointed by the Prime Minister.
- **Ex-Officio Members**: Up to four members from the Union Council of Ministers are nominated by the PM.
- **Governing Council**: Known as "Team India," it includes the PM, Vice-Chairperson, ex-officio members, full-time members, Chief Ministers of states, and Lieutenant Governors of UTs.

Dinesh Trivedi Named India's High Commissioner to Bangladesh



- Dinesh Trivedi has been appointed India's High Commissioner to Bangladesh, succeeding Pranay Kumar Verma.
- Marking the first time the Modi government has chosen a politician to head an overseas diplomatic mission
- **The Modi government till now has sent only career diplomats to head foreign missions, barring the appointment of former Army chief General Dalbir Singh as envoy to Seychelles in 2019.**

Justice Lisa Gill sworn in as Chief Justice of Andhra Pradesh High Court



- **Governor S Abdul Nazeer administered the oath of office to Lisa Gill as Chief Justice of High Court of Andhra Pradesh,** appointed as the first woman Chief Justice of Andhra Pradesh High Court

Appointment of HC Judges:

- **Article 217 of the Constitution**: It states that the Judge of a High Court shall be appointed by the President in consultation with the Chief Justice of India (CJI), the Governor of the State.
- **High Court judges are recommended by a Collegium comprising the CJI and two senior-most judges.**

Supreme Court Appoints Former Judge Hrishikesh Roy as Bihar Cricket Association Ombudsman

- The Supreme Court has appointed its former judge, Hrishikesh Roy, as the ombudsman of the Bihar Cricket Association, BCA.
- The court noted that former apex court judge **Abhay S. Oka, who was appointed to the post, expressed his unwillingness to continue as the ombudsman as the role involves adjudicatory functions.**

Asit Tripathy Elected President of Odisha Steel Producers' Association

- The Odisha Steel Producers' Association (OSPA) has **unanimously elected Mr Asit Tripathy, former Chief Secretary of Odisha and Advisor to Jindal Steel, as its President at a meeting of its members.**

- OSPA is a newly formed collective platform of leading steel and mining companies in the state, including Jindal Steel, Tata Steel, Jindal Stainless, JSW Steel, AMNS and others.
- The Association seeks to strengthen industry participation, enable knowledge sharing, and facilitate structured engagement with key stakeholders.

Péter Magyar is set to become the Prime Minister of Hungary

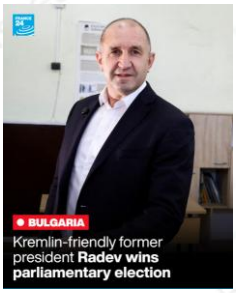




- Péter Magyar is set to become the Prime Minister of Hungary after defeating Viktor Orbán who had been in power for 16 years.
- **Capital:** Budapest
- **Currency**: Forint

Rumen Radev's Party Wins Bulgaria Parliamentary Election





- Bulgaria's eighth parliamentary election in five years has concluded with **former president Rumen Radev's Progressive Bulgaria party emerging as the clear winner. Radev will be the next prime minister.**
- **Capital:** Sofia
- **Currency**: Euro

Filmmaker Payal Kapadia named jury president for Cannes Critics Week



- "All We Imagine As Light" director Payal Kapadia will be the **president of the jury for the 65th Cannes Critics Week, which runs parallel to the main festival and nurtures emerging voices in cinema.**
- Kapadia, who became the first Indian filmmaker to win the Grand Prix award at the Cannes Film Festival in 2024, will lead a panel of international jury members.
- **The festival sidebar, known as 'Semaine de la critique', is organised by the French Syndicate of Cinema Critics.**
- The 65th edition will run from May 13 to 21
- **Her first feature documentary A Night of Knowing Nothing was selected at the Directors' Fortnight at Cannes in 2021 and won L'Oeil d'Or for Best Documentary.**

From Uttar Pradesh to Canada: Alberta gets its first woman Sikh sheriff



- **Gagandeep Kaur Grewal, from the Lakhimpur Kheri district of Uttar Pradesh, has become the first Sikh woman to be appointed a sheriff in Alberta, Canada.**
- A key milestone was in 1991, when Baltej Singh Dhillon became the first turbaned Sikh to serve in the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP), following a national debate over uniform rules.
- More recently, Constable Puneet Deol became the first South Asian female police officer in the Ottawa Police Service in October 2022.
- In **October 2025, Rajbeer Kaur Brar, 35, also referred to as Rajbir Kaur, became Canada's first turbaned woman constable in the Royal Canadian Mounted Police**.

Noida Airport Appoints Nitu Sarma as Interim CEO

- Noida International Airport (NIA) has appointed **Nitu Sarma as Chief Executive Officer (CEO) on an interim basis,** until the Board of Directors conclude a formal selection process.



Apple names insider John Ternus as CEO, Cook to become executive chairman

- Tech giant Apple announced that long-time CEO **Tim Cook** will be stepping down from his role, and **John Ternus**, senior vice president of Hardware Engineering will take over as the CEO starting September 1, 2026.

C.V. Anand is Telangana's new DGP

- The Telangana government appointed senior IPS officer C. V. Anand as the Director General of Police (Head of Police Force).
- He will serve as the head of the Telangana Police.

SHORTS NEWS

- Intel has appointed Santhosh Viswanathan as vice-president and managing director for the Asia Pacific and Japan region.
- Coforge, a leading AI-native engineering services firm, has announced the promotion of Sunil Fernandes to the role of Chief Operating Officer (COO).

Awards

Awards - National

Odisha Police Awarded President's Colour for Service Excellence

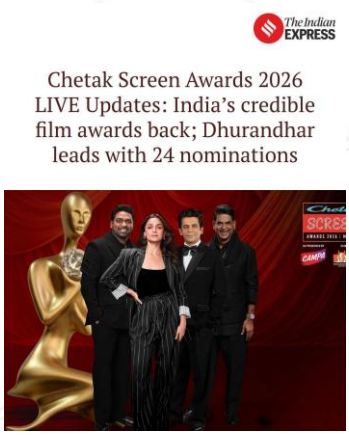
- Odisha Police has been conferred the prestigious President's Police Colour, the highest honour granted to a police force or military unit in India.
- The recognition marks exceptional service, professionalism, and sustained contributions to maintaining law and order.
- The announcement coincides with the 90th Police Foundation Day of Odisha, celebrated on Utkal Divas.
- The President's Police Colour award, also known as 'Nishaan', is the highest honour bestowed upon a police force in India, in recognition of its exceptional service, bravery and professionalism



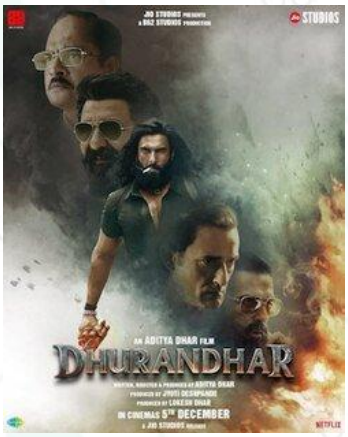
- the President of India's Police Colour is awarded only once to a force .
- It is awarded based on parameters such as discipline, bravery, professionalism, and notable contributions to public safety.
- It is represented by a special flag, worn on the left sleeve of the police uniform.
- An armed force or police unit must have rendered 25 years of exceptional service to be eligible for this prestigious honour.

Chetak Screen Awards 2026

- The Chetak Screen Awards 2026 honoured the finest in Indian cinema
- Dhurandhar emerging as the biggest winner of the night with 14 awards.
- Instituted by The Indian Express Group.







CATEGORY	WINNERS
Best Film	Homebound – Karan Johar, Adar Poonawalla, Apoorva Mehta, Somen Mishra, Marijke DeSouza, Melita Toscan Du Plantier
Best Actor (Female)	Yami Gautam Dhar – Haq
Best Actor (Male)	Ranveer Singh – Dhurandhar
Best Director	Aditya Dhar – Dhurandhar
Best Actor in a Supporting Role (Female)	Shalini Vatsa – Homebound
Best Actor in a Supporting Role (Male)	Akshaye Khanna – Dhurandhar
Best Action	Dhurandhar – Aejaz Gulab, Sea Young Oh, Yannick Ben, Ramazan Bulut
Best Background Score	Dhurandhar – Shashwat Sachdev
Best Choreography	Dhurandhar – Shararat – Vijay Ganguly
Best Cinematography	Dhurandhar – Vikash Nowlakha
Best Dialogue	Dhurandhar – Aditya Dhar
Best Editing	Dhurandhar – Shivkumar V. Panicker
Best Film for Gender Sensitivity	Haq
Best Film Writing (Story & Screenplay)	Homebound
Best Song	Saiyaara – Title Track, Saiyaara (Tanishk Bagchi, Faheem Abdullah, Arslan Nizami) – WINNER
Best OTT Film	Stolen – Gaurav Dhingra
Best Actor (Female) – OTT Film	Sanya Malhotra – Mrs
Best Actor (Male) – OTT film	Abhishek Banerjee – Stolen
Best Director – OTT film	Karan Tejpal – Stolen –
Best Script – OTT film	Stolen

BHU Wins National Moot Court Competition 2026

- **Banaras Hindu University (BHU) secured first place at the Association of Indian Universities National Moot Court Competition 2026, held at Integral University, Lucknow.**
- Received a cash prize of Rs 25,000 along with trophies and medals. Chandigarh University secured the runner-up position and was awarded Rs 11,000
- Ram Manohar Lohia University received the Best Researcher award, while the Army Institute of Law was recognised for the Best Memorial.

Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar

- Recently, the central government has invited nominations for the Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar (PMRBP).
- **It is a prestigious national honour conferred annually by the Government of India.**
- It is awarded to children for exceptional excellence in Bravery, Art & Culture, Environment, Social Service, Science & Technology, and Sports.
- **The Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar organized by the Ministry of Women and Child Development Government of India.**

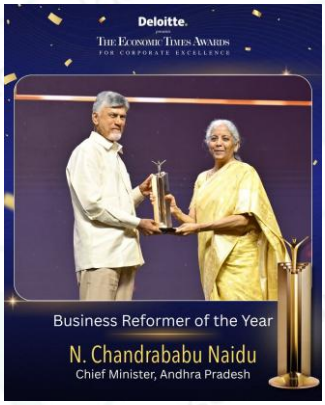
Eligibility for Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar

- A child should be an Indian Citizen.
- **Age**: A child above the age of 5 years and not exceeding 18 years (as of 31st July of respective year).
- **The act/incident/achievement should have been within 2 years of the last date of receipt of application/nomination for the year of consideration.**
- The number of awards will be 25, however, any relaxation to this maximum number may be permitted at the discretion of the National Selection Committee.
- **Each awardee will receive a medal, certificate and citation booklet**

Dr Ravi Shankar receives 'Excellence in Molecular & Precision Oncology Award 2026'

- **Dr Ravi Shankar has been conferred the "Excellence in Molecular & Precision Oncology Award 2026" by Voice of Health, in recognition of his outstanding contributions to the advancement of molecular diagnostics and precision-driven cancer care.**
- The award was presented at a ceremony held in Mumbai recently.
- The award acknowledges Dr. Shankar's work in integrating molecular oncology and precision medicine into routine clinical practice.

Andhra Pradesh CM Chandrababu Naidu to Receive Business Reformer of the Year 2025 Award



- Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu will receive the prestigious Business Reformer of the Year 2025 award by a leading media organization The Economic Times at Mumbai.
- **He has been selected for the award for implementing transformative initiatives such as 'Speed of Doing Business' and 'Speed of Delivering Governance' in the state.**
- He has been recognised for his efforts in creating an investment-friendly ecosystem, introducing progressive industrial policies and boosting investor confidence.

Sur Jyotsna Awards Honour Classical Music Legends

- **The 13th edition of the Sur Jyotsna National Music Awards was held in New Delhi, celebrating excellence in Indian classical music and honouring veteran artists for their lifelong contribution.**
- This year, **renowned Hindustani vocalists Sumitra Guha and Pandit Laxman Krishnarao Pandit** received the prestigious recognition for their dedication to preserving and promoting India's classical music traditions.
- **Every year, artists are selected from vocal and instrumental categories, creating a platform that supports both established masters and young musicians.**
- The initiative aims to preserve India's rich musical heritage while inspiring future generations.

Celebration of Swachhta Pakhwada - Ministry of Culture to Undertake Nationwide Cleanliness and Awareness Activities

- The Ministry of Culture, Government of India, is observing **Swachhta Pakhwada from 16 April to 30 April 2026, reaffirming its commitment to the vision of a clean and green India under the Swachh Bharat Mission.**
- A Swachhta Pledge was administered to officials and staff, emphasizing individual and collective responsibility towards maintaining cleanliness.
- A quiz competition on cleanliness and sanitation awareness was organized in Ministry of Culture.
- **The initiative aims not only to enhance physical cleanliness but also to instill a lasting sense of responsibility and collective manner.**

Short new

- Telangana State Power Generation Corporation (TGGENCO) has received international recognition for its commitment to quality, efficiency, and continuous improvement by achieving the prestigious ISO 9001:2015 (Quality Management System) certification.

Awards - International

Botanist wins WWF award for invasive plants detection app



- **N. Alim Yusuf botany researcher who developed an AI-powered mobile Neophyte ID application** to identify invasive plant species in Kerala has been awarded the WWF (World Wide Fund for Nature) National Award.
- N. Alim Yusuf, a researcher at the Malabar Botanical Garden and Institute for Plant Sciences (MBGIPS), Olavanna, Kozhikode, **received the honour for his innovative application capable of identifying nearly 100 invasive plant species recorded in Kerala**
- He **was presented the award at the National ECHO Youth Innovation Summit 2026, held as part of the International Youth Biodiversity Conference in Telangana.**
- As part of the recognition, he will also receive a seed grant of ₹1.5 lakh from the WWF to further develop and scale his project.

Bollywood Actress Sayani Gupta named Person of the Year by Harvard South Asian Association



- Bollywood Actress Sayani Gupta has been named as the 2026 Person of the Year by the Harvard South Asian Association in recognition of her outstanding contribution to film, storytelling, and representation.
- The **Harvard South Asian Association annually presents the Person of the Year award to individuals who have significantly shaped South Asian identity and representation in public life**.

Elephants in the Fog made history by becoming first Nepali film to be selected in Un Certain Regard section of Cannes Film Festival



- **Nepali feature film Elephants in the Fog has made history by becoming the first Nepali film to be selected in the UN Certain Regard section of the Cannes Film Festival.**
- The film follows a family living in a settlement affected by elephant attacks, focusing on the mother-daughter relationship.
- **Written and directed by Abinash Bikram Shah,** the film will compete at the 79th edition of the festival, scheduled to be held in France from 12th to 23rd May.

- **UN Certain Regard, a section introduced in 1978** that highlights emerging filmmakers and distinctive storytelling voices, runs parallel to the competition for the Palme d'Or and is considered the second most prestigious section at Cannes.

Guntur Municipal Corporation wins UNIDO's 4th Gender Equality Mobilisation Award in Vienna



- **The Guntur Municipal Corporation (GMC) has secured the 4th Gender Equality Mobilisation (GEM) Award, presented by the United Nations Industrial Development Organization (UNIDO) at the International Day of Women in Industry 2026 celebrations in Vienna**
- The award was given for GMC's initiative combining women's empowerment with environmental sustainability.
- **The initiative runs under the UNIDO-supported Sustainable Cities Integrated Approach Pilot (SCIAP), which promotes zero-emission waste management** while bringing women into the green economy.

Arthur Law Named 2026 World Economic Forum Young Global Leader



- The KALE Foundation announced that Arthur Law, Co- founder and Managing Principal of Store friendly Asia, has been named a Young Global Leader 2026 by the World Economic Forum.
- **Arthur is recognised for redefining urban living by enabling households and businesses to reclaim space in some of the world's most densely populated cities.**
- He is the architect behind Storefriendly Asia's transformation from an operator into Asia's leading tech-enabled self-storage platform.
- **The Forum of Young Global Leaders is one of the world's most selective and respected leadership communities, established by the World Economic Forum to identify exceptional leaders under the age of 40 who are already shaping industries, institutions and society.**
- Each year, thousands are nominated globally, yet only around 100 are selected through a rigorous process; in 2026, the cohort comprised 118 individuals from 55 countries.

Samriddh Gram Initiative

- **India's Samriddh Gram initiative has been nominated for the prestigious WSIS/ World Summit on the Information Society Prizes 2026 in the Enabling Environment category.**
- Samriddh Gram is an integrated phygital service delivery model designed by the Department of Telecommunications (DoT).
- **It utilizes the high-speed broadband backbone of BharatNet to transform rural connectivity into a platform for essential social and economic services.**
- **Launched In**: The initiative was active in its pilot phase by 2024–25, with the first Samriddhi Kendra officially inaugurated by Union Minister in Umri Village, Madhya Pradesh, recently.
- To bridge the rural-digital divide by providing one-stop community hubs for essential services.
- To demonstrate the socio-economic impact of integrated service delivery in health, education, and governance.

About WSIS Prizes 2026:

- The World Summit on the Information Society (WSIS) Prizes are a global recognition platform that honors innovative projects leveraging Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) to advance sustainable development.
- **The WSIS Prizes celebrate innovative ICT-driven projects that contribute to sustainable development worldwide.**

- The WSIS Forum 2026 is scheduled to take place from 6–10 July 2026 in Geneva, featuring discussions on emerging technologies, digital inclusion, cybersecurity, and global digital cooperation.

All-Women Cohort Wins 2026 Goldman Environmental Prize

- For the first time in its history, **the Goldman Environmental Prize has recognised an all-women group of winners.**
- Established in 1989 by the Goldman Environmental Foundation, the Goldman Environmental Prize is often called the "**Green Nobel Prize.**"
- **It honours grassroots environmental activists from six continental regions annually.**
- The six winners represent Africa, Asia, Europe, North America, South America and island nations
- **Winners receiving USD 200,000.**
- **All recipients of the award are women**: Iroro Tanshi, from Nigeria; Borim Kim, from South Korea; Sarah Finch, from the United Kingdom; Theonila Roka Matbob, from Papua New Guinea; Alannah Acaq Hurley, from the United States; and Yuvelis Morales Blanco, from Colombia.

Breakthrough Prizes award $18.75 million to 2026 research leaders



- The Breakthrough Prize Foundation announced the winners of the 2026 Breakthrough Prizes, **honoring scientists whose discoveries are significantly driving growth of human knowledge.**
- The Breakthrough Prizes – popularly known as the **"Oscars of Science**" – were created to celebrate the wonders of our scientific age.
- **Co-founded by Sergey Brin, Priscilla Chan and Mark Zuckerberg, Julia and Yuri Milner, and Anne Wojcicki, the prizes are now in their 14th year.**
- This year, six Breakthrough Prizes of $3 million each were awarded.
- In addition, the **Foundation recognized 15 early-career physicists and mathematicians, who share six $100,000 New Horizons Prizes.**

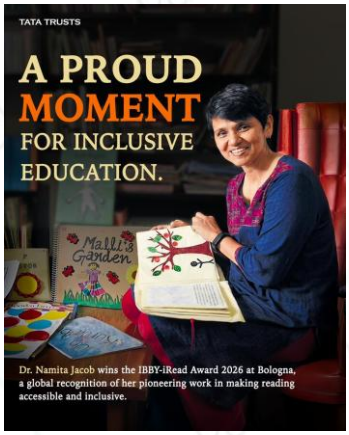
2026 Breakthrough Prize in Life Sciences

- **Jean Bennett, Katherine A. High, Albert Maguire** - For developing a therapy for inherited retinal degeneration that became the first FDA-approved gene therapy for a genetic disease.
- **Rosa Rademakers, Bryan Traynor** - For the discovery of the most common genetic cause of ALS and frontotemporal dementia which charted the path for new mechanistic studies of these diseases.
- **Stuart H. Orkin, Swee Lay Thein** - For elucidating the mechanism driving the switch from fetal to adult hemoglobin and validating it as a therapeutic target for sickle-cell disease and beta-thalassemia.
- **2026 Breakthrough Prize in Mathematics** - Frank Merle
- **2026 Breakthrough Prize in Fundamental Physics** - The Muon g-2 Collaborations at CERN, Brookhaven National Laboratory, and Fermilab
- **2026 Special Breakthrough Prize in Fundamental Physics** - David J. Gross
- **2026 Vera Rubin New Frontiers Prize** - Carolina Figueiredo

2026 Maryam Mirzakhani New Frontiers Prize

- **Amanda Hirschi** - For contributions to symplectic topology.
- **Anna Skorobogatova** - For contributions to geometric measure theory.
- **Mingjia Zhang** - For contributions to the theory of Shimura varieties.

Namita Jacob awarded the IBBY-iRead Outstanding Reading Promoter Award 2026



- **The International Board on Books for Young People (IBBY) through its IBBY-iRead Outstanding Reading Promoter Award hopes to further the cause of reading promotion.**
- Namita Jacob, Director of Chetana Trust, a Chennai-based organisation is one of the winners of the IBBY-iRead Outstanding Reading Promoter Award 2026, along with Kirsten Boie from Germany.
- The announcement was made at the Bologna Children's Book Fair in Italy.
- **This international recognition celebrates her work in making reading accessible to children with disabilities through books in accessible formats, building a more inclusive world**
- It also marks the first time India has received this honour in the Outstanding Reading Promoter category

Alcaraz and Sabalenka win Laureus Sportsman and Sportswoman of the year



- The **Laureus World Sports Awards 2026, held at Cibeles Palace in Madrid.**
- Carlos Alcaraz and Aryna Sabalenka, a Tokyo 2020 Olympian, were named Laureus World Sportsman and Sportswoman of the Year, respectively, **each claiming the prize for the first time in their careers.**
- **Widely regarded as the "Oscars of sport."**

2026 Laureus World Sports Award winners - complete list

- **Laureus World Sportsman of the Year Award:** Carlos Alcaraz
- **Laureus World Sportswoman of the Year Award:** Aryna Sabalenka
- **Laureus World Team of the Year Award:** Paris Saint-Germain
- **Laureus World Breakthrough of the Year Award:** Lando Norris
- **Laureus World Comeback of the Year Award:** Rory McIlroy
- **Laureus World Sportsperson of the Year with a Disability Award:** Gabriel Araújo
- **Laureus World Action Sportsperson of the Year Award:** Chloe Kim
- **Laureus World Young Sportsperson of the Year Award:** Lamine Yamal
- **Laureus Sporting Inspiration Award:** Toni Kroos
- **Laureus Lifetime Achievement Award:** Nadia Comăneci
- **Laureus Sport for Good Award:** Fútbol Más

Sadhvi Satish Sail gets crowned Miss India World 2026



- Sadhvi Satish Sail was crowned Miss India World 2026 **at the grand finale of the 61st Femina Miss India pagenat held in Bhubaneswar**.
- Crowned by her predecessor Nikita Porwal, Sail is all set to represent India at the Miss World 2027 pageant.
- **Sadhvi Satish Sail is a** model and entrepreneur hailing from Goa, Sadhvi has walked multiple shows and been the face of campaigns .

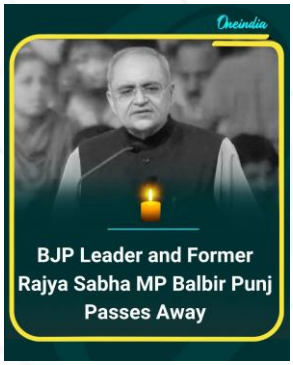
Obituaries

Brazil basketball legend Oscar Schmidt passes away at 68



- Brazil's Oscar Schmidt, one of the most prolific scorers in basketball history, has passed away. He was 68.
- Schmidt, a Hall of Fame inductee in 2013, had played a 30-year professional career in Brazil and Europe and retired in 2003.
- **He represented Brazil in five Olympic Games and four World Cups.**

Passing of prolific writer, thinker and public intellectual, Shri Balbir Punj



- Author, journalist, BJP leader and former Rajya Sabha MP, Balbir Punj, passed away at the age of 76.
- **Author of 'Tryst with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India' and 'Narrative ka Mayajaal'.**

Former IOA chief Ramachandran passes away

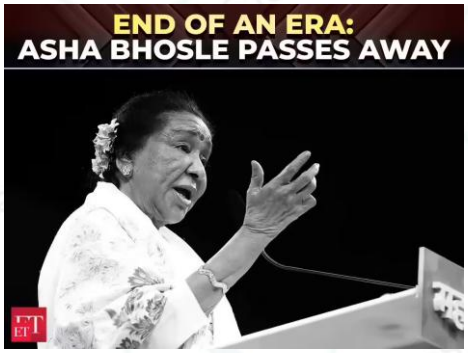


- Former Indian Olympic Association (IOA) president N. Ramachandran passed away. He was 77
- **Ramachandran, who had a long and distinguished career as a sports administrator, headed the IOA from 2014 to 2017** after previously serving as treasurer.
- **Ramachandran received the 'Rashtriya Khel Protsahan Puruskar' from the Government of India in 2011** in the category of 'Establishment and Management of Sports Academies of Excellence'.
- In **August 2016, he received the Olympic Order — Silver — by the International Olympic Committee** for his services to the Olympic movement.

Ex-Union Minister Abu Hasem Khan Choudhury dies at 89

- Choudhury, popularly known as Dalu, was 89.
- He served as an MLA of the Kaliachak Assembly constituency, West Bengal from 1996 to 2006 and was elected to the Lok Sabha from Malda Dakshin for three consecutive terms since 2009.
- He was the Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare in the Manmohan Singh-led United Progressive Alliance (UPA) Government.

Asha Bhosle, singing legend and voice of Bollywood, passes away



- The end of an era, as legendary singer Asha Bhosle has passed away at the age of 92
- Asha Bhosle is the sister of playback singer Late Mangeshkar.
- Her work includes film music, bhajans, classical music, folk songs, ghazals, sangeet and many more.
- She bagged National Film Awards, BFJA Awards and Maharashtra State Film Awards, among others, Asha Bhosle also bagged two Grammy nominations.
- **In 2000, she was honoured with the Dadasaheb Phalke Award**, India's highest award in the field of cinema.
- In **2008, she was honoured by the Government of India with the Padma Vibhushan**, the second-highest civilian honour of the country.

- The **Guinness Book of World Records** acknowledged her in 2011 as the most recorded artist in music history.



C.D. Gopinath, member of India's first-ever Test win, passes away

- C.D. Gopinath, who had been the last surviving member of India's first Test-winning team, passed away, He was 96.
- born in Madras (now Chennai), made his Test debut against England during the 1951-52 series.
- He often referred to cricket as a "noble game"

Veteran Photographer Raghu Rai Dies at 83



- Renowned photographer Raghu Rai passed away
- Born on December 18, 1942, in Jhang, Punjab (now in Pakistan), Mr. Rai was qualified as a civil engineer and only took up photography at 23.
- **Over the years, his photo essays appeared in renowned international publications,** including Time, Life, The New York Times, The Independent, and The New Yorker.
- **He has served three times on the jury of the World Press Photo and twice on the jury of UNESCO's International Photo Contest**
- Mr. Rai received the **Padma Shri in 1972** for his coverage of the Bangladesh war and its aftermath, apart from several national and international awards.
- He **received the Photographer of the Year award in the United States for his photo essay "Human Management of Wildlife in India", published in National Geographic.**
- The French government conferred him with the Officier des Arts et des Lettres in 2009.

Muni Narayana Prasad, scholar and head of Narayana Gurukula, passes away



- Swami Muni Narayana Prasad, renowned scholar and head of the Narayana Gurukula, Varkala, passed away
- Association with the Narayana Gurukula movement in 1955
- The head of the Narayana Gurukula since 1999, he was the third individual to hold that position, after Nataraja Guru and Nitya Chaitanya Yati.
- **A prolific author in Malayalam and English, Muni Narayana Prasad won the Kerala Sahitya Akademi award twice -- in 2015 for his Malayalam translation of Nataraja Guru's commentary on Sankaracharya's 'Soundaryalahari,' and in 2018 for his autobiography 'Atmayanam.'**
- The nation honoured him with the Padma Shri in 2024.

Ex-Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Nadendla Bhaskara Rao dies at 90

- Former Chief Minister of undivided Andhra Pradesh and co-founder of the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) Nadendla Bhaskara Rao died
- **A native of Guntur, became Chief Minister of the undivided State for a month in 1984 after a revolt against N.T. Rama Rao (NTR)**
- He joined the BJP in 2019

SHORT NEWS

- Shiv Ratan Agarwal, Chairman and Managing Director of Bikaji Foods International, passed away at 74

National

Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026', Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026' and Delimitation Bill, 2026' introduced in Lok Sabha



- The Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 was introduced in Lok Sabha on April 16, 2026. **It seeks to amend: (i) the Government of Union Territories Act, 1963, (ii) the Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi Act, 1991, and (iii) the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019.**
- It makes changes with regard to the delimitation of Assembly and Parliamentary constituencies of Puducherry, Delhi, and Jammu & Kashmir.
- **The Bill empowers the Delimitation Commission to carry out readjustment of the Assembly and Parliamentary constituencies.**
- Delimitation will be based on the population as per the latest published census, as on the date of the constitution of the Commission.
- **Number of seats in Assemblies:** The respective Acts specify the number of seats in the Legislative Assembly as follows: (i) 30 in Puducherry, (ii) 70 in Delhi, and (iii) 114 in Jammu & Kashmir.
  - **The Bill instead provides that the Delimitation Commission will determine the number of seats such that it is not less than the above number.**
- **Nominated members in Puducherry Assembly:** Currently, the central government may nominate up to three members to the Assembly.
  - **The Bill provides that this limit will increase to five, of which two will be women. This increase will come into effect after delimitation.**
- **Nominated members in J&K Assembly**: Currently, the Lieutenant Governor may nominate two members to give representation to women.
  - **The Bill provides that this limit will increase to three, after delimitation.**
- **Through the 42nd Constitutional Amendment in 1976, the total number of seats of each state in Lok Sabha and the total number of seats in State Assemblies was frozen based on the 1971 census.**
- This freeze was initially applicable until the publication of the first census after 2000.
- **The 84th Constitutional Amendment in 2001 extended this freeze until the publication of the first census after 2026.**

Along with this Bill, two other Bills have also been introduced:

- (i) the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 which seeks to enable delimitation based on the census specified by Parliament by law, and
- (ii) the Delimitation Bill, 2026 which provides for the constitution of a Commission to carry out delimitation.

The Delimitation Bill, 2026

- The Delimitation Bill, 2026 was introduced in Lok Sabha on April 16, 2026.
- **The Bill provides for constitution of a Delimitation Commission for readjustment and reallocation of seats of Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies.**
- It **also seeks to repeal the Delimitation Act, 2002.**
- **Delimitation Commission**: The central government may, from time to time, constitute a Delimitation Commission

It will comprise of:

(i) a Chairperson who is or has been a Supreme Court Judge,
(ii) the Chief Election Commissioner or an Election Commissioner nominated by the Chief Election Commissioner, and
(iii) the State Election Commissioner of the concerned state.

- **The central government will appoint the Chairperson.**
- The central government will specify the term of the Commission by a notification. It may also extend the term.
- The **Commission will also have 10 associate members in respect of each state, for assisting in its duties.**
- Five of these will be from amongst the state's Lok Sabha MPs, and five from amongst the members of the state's Legislative Assembly.
  - **These members will be nominated by the respective Speakers.**
- **Where the number of members of Lok Sabha of a state is less than five, all the members will be made associate members**. In such cases, the total associate members for the state will be less than 10.
- **Associate members will not have a right to vote or sign any decision of the Commission.**
- **Delimitation will be based on the latest census** for which figures have been published, as on the date of the constitution of the Commission.
- The Commission will determine the number of seats in Lok Sabha to be allocated to each state and union territory, as well as for State Legislative Assemblies.
- Physical features, existing boundaries of administrative unit, facilities of communication, and public convenience must be taken into consideration.
- **Further, every assembly constituency must be delimited to fall wholly within one parliamentary constituency.**
- The Commission will also determine the seats reserved for scheduled castes, scheduled tribes, and women.
- **Constituencies reserved for scheduled castes must be spread across different parts of the state.**
- They must be placed in areas where scheduled caste population is comparatively large relative to the total population.
- **Constituencies reserved for scheduled tribes must be placed in areas where their population is the largest relative to the total population.**
- The Commission will publish its proposal for the delimitation of constituencies along with any dissenting proposals of associate members.

The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026



- **The Union Government has proposed The Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026, which seeks to increase the Lok Sabha's strength from 543 to 850 members.**
- It is a landmark legislative proposal designed to overhaul the composition of the Indian Parliament and the process of redrawing electoral boundaries.
- **It specifically targets Articles 81, 82, and 334A of the Constitution** to address long-standing demographic shifts and gender representation gaps.

Aim:

- To **expand the Lok Sabha to reflect India's significant population growth since the 1971 Census.**

- To enable immediate implementation of 1/3rd reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies by decoupling it from the requirement of a post-2026 Census.
- **To provide a modern legal framework for the Delimitation Commission** to readjust seats based on the latest available demographic data.

Proposed Key Features:

- **Increase in House Strength**: Proposes that the Lok Sabha consist of not more than 815 members from States and 35 members from Union Territories, totaling 850 members.
- **Amendment to Article 82:** Seeks to delete the third proviso that mandates delimitation only after the first Census conducted after 2026. This allows the government to use pre-2026 Census data to redraw constituencies immediately.
- **Expedited Women's Reservation**: Amends Article 334A to allow the 1/3rd reservation for women to take effect immediately after delimitation.

Delimitation Commission 2026:

  - Empowered to redraw constituencies and readjust seat allocations.
  - **Chaired by a Supreme Court Judge (serving or retired).**
  - Includes the Chief Election Commissioner and State Election Commissioners as ex-officio members.
  - Will involve 10 associate members (5 MPs and 5 MLAs) per state, though they will lack voting rights.

- **Seat Rotation**: Seats reserved for women will be allotted by rotation among different constituencies in a State or Union Territory.
- **Judicial Immunity**: Orders issued by the Delimitation Commission and published in the Gazette will have the force of law and cannot be challenged in any court.

Why Women's Reservation Cannot Wait?

- The Lok Sabha failed to pass the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, which aimed to fast-track the implementation of 33% reservation for women in legislatures (introduced by the 106th Constitutional Amendment (2023) by enabling delimitation based on the 2011 Census.

The 106th Constitution Amendment Act (Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam)

- The 106th Amendment, passed in 2023, **remains the primary framework for reservation, though its implementation is currently stalled:**
- It mandates one-third (33%) reservation for women in the Lok Sabha, State Legislative Assemblies, and the Delhi Assembly.
- The **reservation is provided for a period of 15 years, which can be extended by Parliament.**
- It includes a sub-quota for women belonging to Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled Tribes (ST) within the 33%.
- A **controversial clause states that reservation will only come into effect after delimitation is carried out following the first census conducted after the 2023 Act.**
- Reserved seats will be rotated to different constituencies after every delimitation exercise.

Constitutional Articles Involved:

- **Article 368:** Grants Parliament the power to amend the Constitution and lays down the specific procedures for different types of amendments.
- **Article 81 & 82:** Pertaining to the composition of the Lok Sabha and the delimitation of constituencies, which the 131st Bill sought to modify.
- **Article 334A**: Introduced by the 106th Amendment (2023), which the 131st Bill intended to amend to accelerate the women's quota.

To become law, a Constitution Amendment Bill must navigate a rigorous three-step process:

- **Special Majority**: Must be passed by each House by a majority of the total membership of that House AND a majority of not less than two-thirds of the members present and voting.
- **No Joint Sitting**: Unlike ordinary bills, if there is a disagreement between the two Houses, a joint sitting cannot be summoned to resolve the deadlock.
- **State Ratification**: Since the 131st Bill affected the representation of states in Parliament (Articles 81/82), it also required ratification by at least one-half of the State Legislatures before receiving Presidential assent.

The Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025

- The Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025, introduced in the Lok Sabha, **seeks to revolutionize higher education by establishing a single apex regulatory body.**
- The Bill proposes the **creation of the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (the Commission)** as the supreme regulatory authority for higher education in India.
- It **aims to implement the National Education Policy (NEP 2020) by replacing three major existing regulators**: the University Grants Commission (UGC), the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE), and the National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE).

Key Features of the Bill:

- **Three Verticals:** The Commission will operate through three specialized Councils:
  - **Regulatory Council**: Acts as a common regulator for institutional governance.
  - **Accreditation Council**: Oversees the quality assessment and accreditation systems.
  - **Standards Council**: Determines academic standards and learning outcomes.

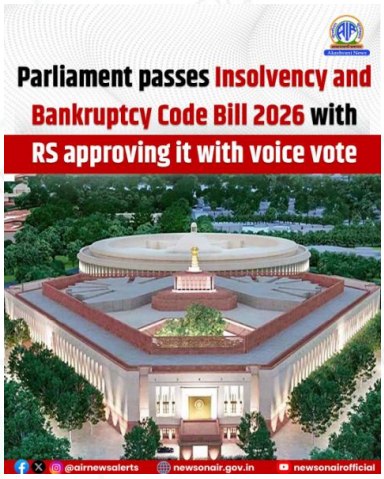
  The Bill covers all Higher Educational Institutions (HEIs) except for legal and medical education, which remain under separate Acts.
- **In a major shift, the Commission and its Councils will have no power to allocate grants; funding authority is moved directly to the Ministry.**
- The Commission features a Chairperson (honorary) and 12 members, while each Council has a President and up to 14 members, primarily eminent experts and government nominees.
- **The Regulatory Council can impose fines between ₹10 lakh and ₹70 lakh for violations and can even order the closure of an HEI.**
- Appeals against the Commission's decisions lie directly with the Central Government.

Lok Sabha passes Jan Vishwas amendment Bill



- The Lok Sabha passed Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026 that seeks to amend 79 Central Acts administered by 23 Ministries to promote ease of doing business and ease of living.
- Through the amendments the 784 provisions of various laws are being proposed to be amended out of which, 717 provisions are being decriminalised to foster Ease of Doing Business, and 67 provisions are proposed to be amended to facilitate Ease of Living.
- The bill will decriminalise minor offenses and implement measures such as revising fines and penalties proportionate to the offence, establishing adjudicating officers and setting up appellate authorities.

Parliament passes Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code Bill, 2026



- The Parliament has passed the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (Amendment) Bill, 2026
- The Amendment seeks to reduce delays, maximise value for all stakeholders, and introduce new provisions that follow global best practices for resolving insolvency.
- New Creditor-Initiated Insolvency Resolution Process (CIIRP): This replaces the largely underutilised "fast-track" process with an out-of-court initiation model.
- Group Insolvency Framework: Introduces a "voluntary group insolvency framework" to facilitate joint resolution of stressed entities within a domestic corporate group, recognizing their interconnected nature.
- Cross-Border Insolvency Framework: Proposes a basic structure for cross-border insolvency enabling easier access for creditors to overseas assets of stressed companies and aligning with international best practices.
- Clean Slate Principle Reinforcement: Explicitly reinforces the "clean-slate principle," stating that once a resolution plan is approved, claims against the corporate debtor are extinguished (unless specified otherwise).

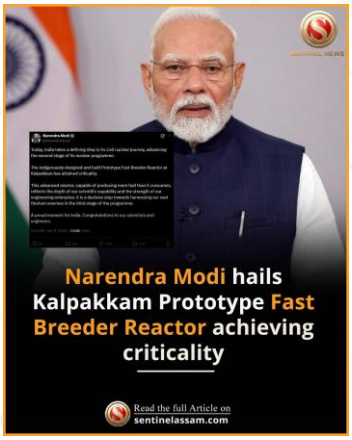
Strict timelines for National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT):

- NCLT to admit Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) cases within 14 days with proof of default enough to admit a case.
- NCLAT to dispose of appeals in 3 months.

Other:

- Sets a timeline of 180 days for completion of liquidation, extendable up to 90 days.
- No Automatic Appointment of Resolution Professional.
- Enhanced Role of Committee of Creditors (CoC)

India First Fast Breeder Reactor (FBR) Achieve Criticality



- Prime Minister of India congratulated scientists as India's first indigenous Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) at Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu, successfully attained criticality.
- A Fast Breeder Reactor is an advanced nuclear reactor that generates more fissile material (fuel) than it consumes while producing electricity.
- It is fast because it uses high-energy (fast) neutrons to sustain the fission chain reaction, unlike conventional reactors that use slow neutrons.

What is Criticality?

- In nuclear physics, criticality is the state in which a nuclear fuel sustains a self-supporting chain reaction.
- It is the point at which the number of neutrons produced by fission is exactly equal to the number of neutrons lost (through leakage or absorption) plus those causing new fissions.
- Developed By: The 500 MWe PFBR has been developed by Bharatiya Nabhikiya Vidyut Nigam Ltd (BHAVINI).
- It uses a Uranium-Plutonium Mixed Oxide (MOX) fuel.
- The reactor core is surrounded with material (Uranium-238). When these U-238 atoms capture fast neutrons, they undergo transmutation to become Plutonium-239, which is a high-grade nuclear fuel.

- Instead of water, it uses Liquid Sodium as a coolant because sodium does not slow down neutrons, allowing the fast reaction necessary for breeding.
- The heat generated by fission is transferred to the liquid sodium, which then heats water to produce steam to turn turbines.

Union Cabinet approves proposal for creation of Bharat Maritime Insurance pool (BMI pool)



- The Union Cabinet has approved the creation of a domestic maritime insurance pool with a sovereign guarantee of Rs 12,980 crore.
- **This is aimed at insulating India's maritime trade from global volatility.**
- The move is expected to significantly reduce dependence on foreign underwriters and ensure uninterrupted risk coverage for Indian shipping.
- The **proposed 'Bharat Maritime Insurance Pool' (BMI Pool) will provide comprehensive coverage across key segments — hull and machinery, cargo, protection and indemnity (P&I), and war risk —** for Indian-flagged and Indian-controlled vessels, including those operating in conflict-prone international waters.
- This is an important step towards powering India's shipping industry to become one of the top maritime nations by 2047.

Cabinet Extends PMGSY-III Till March 2028



- The Centre decided to extend the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana-III (PMGSY-III) beyond March 2025 till 2028-29, with an increase in the outlay by Rs 3,727 crore to Rs 83,977 crore
- **The first phase of the PMGSY was launched on December 25, 2000, by the then NDA government headed by Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee.**
- The second phase was launched in 2013.
- After these two phases, another component of the PMGSY—**Road Connectivity Project for Left Wing Extremism Affected Areas (RCPLWEA)—was launched in 2016** for constructing rural roads in the LWE areas.
- The third phase was launched in 2019, with a sanctioned road length of 1,15,446 km.
- In **September 2024, the Centre had approved the implementation of the PMGSY-IV during the financial year 2024-25 to 2028-29,** with an outlay of Rs 70,125 crore.

Funding Pattern

- PMGSY is **funded jointly by the Centre and States.**
- The **typical sharing pattern is 60:40 for general states and 90:10 for north-eastern and Himalayan states.**
- Funds are allocated for the construction, maintenance, and upgradation of rural roads, ensuring the sustainability of assets

Objectives and Approach



- The primary objective of PMGSY is to ensure connectivity to eligible rural habitations based on population thresholds.
- It **focuses on providing reliable road access to markets, schools, and healthcare facilities.**
- The scheme also aims to improve rural livelihoods by facilitating economic activities, reducing transportation costs, and integrating rural areas with the broader economy.

Key Features

- The scheme ensures the construction of all-weather roads with standardised technical specifications.
- It uses modern technologies such as GIS-based monitoring and quality control mechanisms.
- **A key feature is its emphasis on connectivity to Gramin Agricultural Markets (GrAMs), which strengthens rural supply chains and agricultural marketing.**

Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies (RoSCTL) Scheme



- Recently, the Ministry of Textiles has extended the Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies (RoSCTL) Scheme for exports of apparel/garments and made-ups up to 30th September 2026.
- It is operational from 7th March 2019.
- It aims to reimburse all embedded State and Central Taxes/Levies for exports of manufactured goods and garments.

Features of RoSCTL Scheme

- The rebate under the Scheme shall be in the form of duty credit scrips.
- The scrips shall be issued electronically on the Customs system.
- The duty credit scrips shall be used for payment of Basic Customs Duty on import of goods. These scrips shall be freely transferable.
- The duty credit available in an e-scrip shall be transferred at a time for the entire amount in the said e-scrip to another person and transfer of the duty credit in part shall not be permitted.
- Validity of e-scrip: The period of validity of the e-scrip, of one year from its creation, shall not change on account of transfer of the e-scrip.
- Eligibility: All exporters of garments/Apparel and made-ups manufactured in India are eligible to take benefit under this scheme, except entities/ IECs under the Denied Entity List of the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT).
- Implementing agency: implemented by the Department of Revenue under the Ministry of Finance, not directly by the Ministry of Textiles.
- It has been established as a successor for the old “Rebate of State Levies (RoSL) Scheme.
- The difference between RoSL & RoSCTL Scheme is that under the RoSL Scheme, there was no benefit on the central tax and Levies. But in the RoSCTL scheme, the exporter will get rebate of both State and Central tax and Levies.

Startup India Fund of Funds 2.0 (FoF 2.0)

- The Government has officially notified the Startup India Fund of Funds 2.0 (FoF 2.0) with a ₹10,000 crore corpus **to mobilize venture and growth capital for the domestic startup ecosystem.**
- Startup India FoF 2.0 is a gov**ernment-backed investment vehicle** designed to catalyze domestic capital for startups by contributing to the corpus of SEBI-registered Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs).

- Unlike a direct investment fund, **it acts as a Fund of Funds, meaning it invests in other venture capital funds which, in turn, invest in individual startups.**
- **Launched in**: The second phase (2.0) was notified on April 13, 2026, building on the original FFS launched in 2016.
- **Nodal Department**: Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT).

Key Features:

- Total Corpus: ₹10,000 crore, spread across the 16th and 17th Finance Commission cycles.
- **Focuses on deep tech, innovative manufacturing, and early growth-stage startups supported by smaller AIFs.**
- Includes provisions for the Government and institutional investors to co-invest under an umbrella framework with strict governance safeguards.

RELIEF Scheme Expanded to Egypt and Jordan



- The Government of India has expanded the geographical coverage of the RELIEF (Resilience & Logistics Intervention for Export Facilitation) scheme to include Egypt and Jordan.
- RELIEF is a time-bound, targeted intervention launched to mitigate the financial and logistical risks faced by Indian exporters due to geopolitical tensions in West Asia.
- It acts as a financial buffer against extraordinary war-risk surcharges, freight hikes, and insurance spikes that threaten the competitiveness of Indian goods.
- **Launched In:** The scheme was officially launched on March 19, 2026, as part of the Export Promotion Mission (EPM).
- **Nodal Agency:** ECGC Limited (formerly Export Credit Guarantee Corporation of India).

Aim:

- To prevent order cancellations and safeguard employment in export-linked sectors during maritime crises.
- To provide surety and confidence to exporters, especially MSMEs, allowing them to continue shipments to high-risk zones.
- To stabilize the financial burden on exporters by covering the gap between normal and conflict-era logistics costs.

Key Features:

- The scheme is structured into three complementary components with a total financial outlay of ₹497 Crore:

Component I (Enhanced Cover for Insured Exporters):

- For existing ECGC policyholders, it provides up to 100% risk coverage for war-related and political losses.
- Premiums are frozen at pre-disruption rates, with the government absorbing the additional risk cost.

Component II (Facilitating New Coverage):

- Encourages new exporters to obtain ECGC cover for upcoming shipments with a 95% risk coverage backstop.
- Recently clarified to include those obtaining a fresh ECGC Whole Turnover Policy on or after March 16, 2026.

Component III (Reimbursement for Non-Insured MSMEs):

  - Provides a 50% reimbursement of extraordinary freight and insurance surcharges (e.g., War Risk Surcharge).
  - Capped at ₹50 Lakh per exporter to ensure wide distribution of benefits.
- **Eligible Destinations**: Now covers UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Qatar, Oman, Bahrain, Iraq, Iran, Israel, Yemen, Egypt, and Jordan.

The River Basin Management Scheme: Strengthening Water Governance

- The Government of India has approved the continuation of the River Basin Management (RBM) Scheme for the period 2026–27 to 2030–31 with a significantly increased outlay of ₹2,183 crore.
- **The RBM Scheme is a scientific and institutional framework under the Ministry of Jal Shakti** designed for the integrated management, protection, and sustainable development of India's river basins.
- It shifts water governance from localized projects to a basin-level approach, treating entire river systems—including tributaries, groundwater, and ecosystems—as a single hydrological unit.

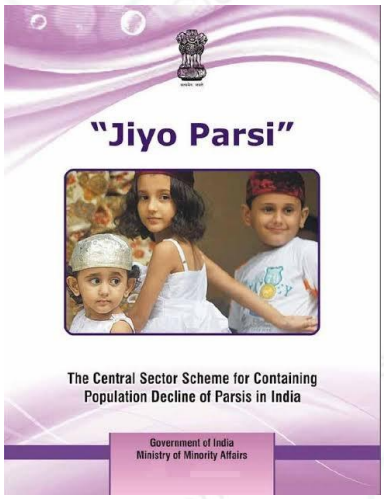
Data/Stats on River Management:

- The **financial outlay has jumped from ₹1,276 crore in the previous cycle to ₹2,183 crore for the 2026–31 period.**
- The **National Water Development Agency (NWDA) has identified 30 river link projects**, with Feasibility Reports completed for 26 and Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) for 15.
- The scheme prioritizes the North Eastern Region and the Indus Basin, focusing on strategic water security in border states.
- The **use of LiDAR and drone-based surveys has improved the accuracy of basin master plans across 11 key sub-sectors.**

Key Features

- Preparation and periodic revision of Master Plans for river basins to indicate necessary works for irrigation, hydropower, and navigation.
- **Extensive use of GIS, remote sensing, and hydrological modeling to prepare Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) for multipurpose projects.**
- Implementation through the NWDA to plan inter-basin water transfers, addressing the surplus vs. deficit water challenge in India.
- **Targeted interventions like the protection of Majuli Island and the construction of raised platforms in flood-prone areas of the North East.**
- Promotion of springshed management and indigenous water conservation practices,especially among tribal communities in hilly regions.

Jiyo Parsi Scheme



- The Universal Parsi Registration Drive special facilitation camp, **organised by the Ministry of Minority Affairs** and around 300 fresh registrations were completed on the Jiyo Parsi portal of Jiyo Parsi Scheme.
- Jiyo Parsi is a flagship **Central Sector Scheme** of the Government of India aimed at arresting the **declining population of the Parsi community.**
- **It was launched in 2013-14** and seeks to stabilise and increase the Parsi population through structured interventions and scientific support.

The scheme provides:

- Medical Assistance for fertility treatment and pregnancy-related care
- Health of Community support including financial assistance for childcare and care of dependent elderly

- Advocacy initiatives such as counselling, awareness campaigns, and outreach programmes
- The Scheme will be implemented through the State Governments with the assistance of respective Parsi Institutions.
- Eligible Parsi couples would be provided financial assistance under the various components of the schemes through **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) mode.**
- The State Governments would get the necessary verification, including biometric authentication of all beneficiaries done.
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Minority Affairs



Skills Outcomes Fund

- Minister of State for Education, Government of India, has launched a national campaign to establish the Skills Outcomes Fund.
- It is a first-of-its-kind initiative aimed at unlocking aspirational livelihoods for youth from low-income backgrounds.
- The fund envisages to mobilise public and private capital to scale outcomes-based financing (OBF) in India's skilling ecosystem, linking investments directly to verified employment outcomes.
- It will be anchored by the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) under the aegis of the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE), in partnership with not-for-profit and philanthropic organizations /stakeholders.
- It would build on the success of India's first outcomes-based initiative, the Skill Impact Bond, launched by the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) in 2021.

Urban Challenge Fund (UCF)

- Union Minister launched the **Operational Guidelines for the Urban Challenge Fund (UCF) and the Credit Repayment Guarantee Sub-Scheme (CRGSS) to revolutionize urban infrastructure financing.**
- The Urban Challenge Fund is a market-linked, reform-driven, and outcome-oriented catalytic instrument. **Unlike traditional grant-based schemes, it uses limited central assistance to de-risk projects, encouraging cities** to access market-based financing and private investments for large-scale **urban** transformation.
- **Implementation** Period: FY 2025–26 to FY 2030–31.
- **Nodal Ministry:** Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA).

Key Features:

- **Catalytic Outlay**: A total Central Assistance of ₹1 lakh crore, designed to mobilize nearly ₹4 lakh crore (4x leverage) in total investments.
- **Funding Ratio:** Central Assistance is limited to 25% of the project cost. At least 50% of funding must be mobilized through municipal bonds, bank loans, and Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs).

Fund Allocation:

  - ₹90,000 crore: Direct project funding.
  - ₹5,000 crore: Project preparation and capacity building.
  - ₹5,000 crore: Credit Repayment Guarantee Sub-Scheme (CRGSS).
- Credit Repayment Guarantee Sub-Scheme (CRGSS): A dedicated sub-scheme to help Tier-II and Tier-III cities, as well as those in hilly and North-Eastern regions.

Nyaya Setu AI Chatbot

- The Vice-President of India and the Minister of Law and Justice unveiled the Nyaya Setu AI Chatbot and its official mascot, Dishika, during the DISHA programme.

- Nyaya Setu is a voice-first, multimodal, and multilingual AI-powered legal assistant. It serves as a comprehensive digital bridge designed to simplify complex legal information for citizens.
- Developed By: The platform was built and is owned as a turnkey AI implementation by the Digital India BHASHINI Division (DIBD).
- Aim: The primary goal of Nyaya Setu is to democratize access to justice by ensuring that language and procedural complexities are no longer barriers for citizens seeking to understand their legal rights and processes.
- Dishika is the official mascot and friendly digital interface of the Nyaya Setu AI Chatbot.
- Aim: The mascot is designed to enhance user engagement, trust, and accessibility, acting as a supportive guide for individuals—especially first-time users—navigating the complexities of the Indian justice system.

Yuva Sangam



- Recently, registrations for institution-led exposure tours across paired regions under Yuva Sangam Phase-VI were held.
- Yuva Sangam is a youth exchange programme that brings young people from different parts of the country together.
- Focus: It is designed for those aged 18–30 years, including students, National Service Scheme and Nehru Yuva Kendra Sangathan volunteers, and young professionals.
- It is anchored by the Ministry of Education and implemented through Higher Education Institutions.
- It creates a structured platform for youth engagement across regions.
- It was launched under the **Government of India's Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat (EBSB) initiative.**
- It supports the experiential learning approach of the National Education Policy 2020, where learning extends beyond classrooms into real-world contexts.
- The programme is structured around the five thematic pillars — the 5 Ps:
- Paryatan (Tourism), Parampara (Traditions & Culture), Pragati (Development & Governance), Paraspar Sampark (People-to-People Connect), and Prodyogiki (Technology & Innovation)...

YUVIKA Programme

- Recently, the Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology highlighted the Government's sustained efforts to nurture scientific temper among the youth, stating that the Yuva Vigyani Karyakram (YUVIKA).
- Yuva Vigyani Karyakram (YUVIKA) is a learning and awareness creating programme of the ISRO.
- It imparts basic knowledge on Space Technology, Space Science, and Space Applications to younger students with a preference to rural areas.
- The programme is aimed at creating awareness about the emerging trends in science and technology amongst the youngsters, who are the future building blocks of our nation.
- It is also expected to encourage more students to pursue Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) based research /career.

Eligibility

- Those who have finished class 8 and are currently studying in class 9 can apply for the programme.
- Three students from each state/Union Territory will participate in this programme every year, covering CBSE, ICSE, and state-board syllabus.

- The selection is based on 8th Standard academic performance and extracurricular activities.
- Students belonging to the rural area have been given special weightage in the selection criteria.
- In case there is a tie between the selected candidates, the younger candidates will be given priority.

This programme involves

- It is a two-week residential programme offered by ISRO.
- It will include invited talks, experience sharing by eminent scientists, facility and lab visits, exclusive sessions for discussions with experts and practical and feedback sessions

ECINet Platform



- Recently, the Election Commission of India (ECI) has urged voters to make informed choices by using the "Know Your Candidates" (KYC) module available on its ECINet platform.
- It is a single-point digital platform developed by the Election Commission of India (ECI).
- It is a new user-friendly digital interface for the electors and other stakeholders such as the election officials, political parties, and civil society.
- It integrates and reoriented over 40 of ECI's existing mobile and web applications.
- ECINET subsumed existing apps like the Voter Helpline App, Voter Turnout App, cVIGIL, Suvidha 2.0, ESMS, Saksham, and KYC App.
- It offers a range of services to voters, including registration, electoral roll search, application tracking, and grievance redressal.
- Additional features include downloading digital voter ID cards (e-EPIC), connecting with election officials, and booking calls with Booth Level Officers (BLOs).
- The platform also includes tools such as cVIGIL for reporting election code violations and Saksham for facilitating accessible services for persons with disabilities.

8th Poshan Pakhwada 2026 will be observed across the country

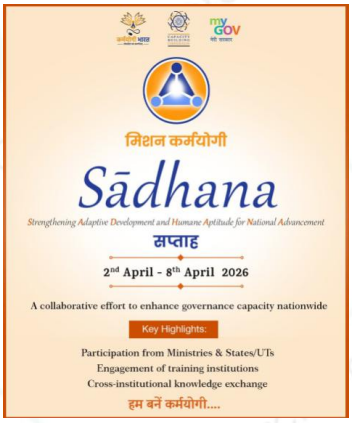


- The Ministry of Women and Child Development will commemorate the 8th edition of Poshan Pakhwada from 9th to 23rd April 2026.
- Aim: It aims to raise awareness about the importance of nutrition and promote healthy eating habits through Jan Andolan and Jan Bhagidari.
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Women and Child Development
- The theme for Poshan Pakhwada 2026 is "Maximizing Brain Development in the First Six Years of Life",

The key focus areas under this year's theme include:

- Maternal and Child Nutrition: Promoting optimal nutrition during pregnancy, exclusive breastfeeding, and age-appropriate complementary feeding.
- Early Stimulation for Brain Development (0–3 years): Encouraging responsive caregiving and early learning interactions.
- Play-Based Education in Early Years (3–6 years) : Supporting holistic development and school readiness.

PM Modi Launched Sadhna Saptah 2026 for Civil Servants' Capacity Building



- Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated and launched Sadhna Saptah 2026 to enhance civil servants' capacity development.
- The Department of Personnel and Training, Capacity Building Commission, and Karmayogi Bharat will launch Sādhana Saptah, 2026 from 2 to 8 April 2026
- It aims to build the capacity, performance and efficiency of civil servants across the country.
- Sādhana Saptah stands for Strengthening Adaptive Development and Humane Aptitude for National Advancement.
- The week is anchored around the Three Sutras: Technology, Tradition and Tangible Outcomes.

Dr. Jitendra Singh Launches first -ever "Administrative Capacity Building" Programme

- Union Minister of State Dr. Jitendra Singh launched the first dedicated programme on "Administrative Capacity Building for Scientists and Academicians".
- aiming to equip scientific and academic leaders with governance and decision-making skills under the Mission Karmayogi framework
- The initiative was announced during a special session of "SADHANA Saptah".

International Election Visitors' Programme (IEVP), 2026

- The Election Commission of India (ECI) has officially commenced the International Election Visitors' Programme (IEVP), 2026 for the upcoming Legislative Assembly elections in Assam, Kerala, and Puducherry.
- The IEVP is a premier international outreach initiative where election managers from across the globe are invited to witness the conduct of Indian elections firsthand.
- It serves as a platform for knowledge exchange and South-South cooperation, allowing foreign delegates to observe the world's largest democratic exercise in action.
- Organisation Involved: Election Commission of India (ECI)

Aim:

- To familiarize international delegates with India's best practices in election management, voter education, and technological integration.
- To demonstrate the integrity and transparency of the Indian electoral process to a global audience.
- To strengthen bilateral and multilateral ties with other Election Management Bodies (EMBs) through the Election Management diplomacy.

Key Features:

- Two-Phase Field Visits:
  - Phase I: Delegates visit Assam, Kerala, and Puducherry (April 2026).
  - Phase II: Delegates visit West Bengal and Tamil Nadu (commencing late April 2026).
- Comprehensive Overview: The programme includes briefings on India's electoral framework, institutional mechanisms, and operational architecture.

First BRICS Health Working Group Meeting 2026

- **The Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare hosted the First BRICS Health Working Group (HWG) Meeting 2026 in New Delhi** to deliberate on collaborative strategies for global health security.
- The BRICS Health Working Group (HWG) is a specialized platform under the BRICS framework.
- It **serves as a forum for senior health officials and technical experts** to coordinate on public health challenges, harmonize regulations, and share evidence-based policy interventions.

- **Host**: Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Government of India (New Delhi).
- **Theme**: Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability

The meeting identified nine priority areas, including **two significant new pillars introduced by India:**

New Priority Areas (India's Initiative):

- **BRICS Mission for Healthy Lifestyles:** Addressing risk factors like unhealthy diets, physical inactivity, tobacco, and alcohol.
- **Promotion of Mental Health and Wellness:** Strengthening services, reducing stigma, and integrating mental health into public health frameworks.

The e-SafeHER Programme



- **The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) launched e-SafeHER, a massive cybersecurity training initiative designed to empower one million women across rural India.**
- e-SafeHER is a specialized Cyber Security Awareness Training Programme tailored for rural women.
- It is anchored under MeitY's larger Information Security Education and Awareness (ISEA) framework and operates on a peer-led, community-based model to bridge the gap between digital access and digital security.
- **The programme trains women to become Cyber Sakhis** (cyber friends) who then act as peer educators within their local communities.
- **C-DAC leads the development of localized, audio-visual modules and training materials adapted into multiple Indian languages to ensure accessibility.**
- The initiative specifically works through women's Self-Help Groups (SHGs) to reach the remotest rural regions without requiring new infrastructure.
- The programme begins in Madhya Pradesh and Odisha before scaling nationally.

ANRF developing AI-based platform 'SARAL AI' to convert complex research publications into simplified rich social media content in many Indian languages

- The Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) is developing an AI-based platform, SARAL AI, to convert complex research publications into simplified social media content in 18 Indian languages.
- **This initiative aims to make scientific advancements accessible to the general public in multiple Indian languages, including podcasts, short videos, posters, and social media content**
- ANRF has launched multiple 'MAHA' (Mission for Advancement in High Impact Areas) programmes, designed as large-scale, mission-driven initiatives to deliver high-impact outcomes in priority sectors

E20 Fuel



- The Central government has implemented a new fuel mandate for petrol pumps to supply E20 fuel with a minimum octane rating of 95 RON.

About E20 Fuel

- It is a blend of 20 per cent ethanol and 80 per cent petrol.
- Ethanol is a biofuel derived from crops such as sugarcane, maize, and grains.
- Advantages: It offers a higher octane rating and potentially cleaner combustion, making it a more advanced alternative.
- While regular petrol in India typically has an octane rating of around 91 to 92 RON, E20 fuel comes with a minimum rating of 95 RON.
- This higher octane helps in smoother combustion.

- Ethanol, also known as ethyl alcohol, is a type of alcohol that is commonly used in various applications.
- Properties: It is a clear, colourless liquid with a characteristic odour and taste.
- Ethanol has the chemical formula C2H5OH and is composed of carbon, hydrogen, and oxygen atoms.
- Pure ethanol is nontoxic and biodegradable, and if spilled, they break down into harmless substances.
- However, fuel ethanol contains denaturants to make fuel ethanol undrinkable.

How is ethanol sourced?

- Ethanol can be produced from various sources, but it is often derived from renewable resources such as crops like corn, sugarcane, barley, and wheat.
- It can also be produced from cellulosic materials like agricultural residues and wood

Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB)

- The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) **recently initiated the bidding process for the development of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) pipeline infrastructure to eliminate bulk movement to the extent possible.**
- It is a statutory body established under the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board Act 2006.
- **Objective**: To protect the interests of consumers and entities engaged in specified activities relating to petroleum, petroleum products, and natural gas and to promote competitive markets and for matters connected therewith or incidental thereto.
- It **has also been mandated to regulate the refining, processing, storage, transportation, distribution, marketing, and sale of petroleum, petroleum products, and natural gas, excluding the production of crude oil and natural gas**, so as to ensure an uninterrupted and adequate supply of petroleum, petroleum products, and natural gas in all parts of the country.
- PNGRB authorises the city gas distribution (CGD) networks, natural gas and petroleum product pipelines, determines tariffs, lays down the technical and safety standards, etc.

The board consists of the following members appointed by the Central Government:

- Chairperson
- Member (Legal)
- Three other members
- **Power of the Board**: Under Section 12 of the Act, certain powers are given to the PNGRB to deal with the complaints and resolve disputes among the entities. The powers under the Act are:
- The Board is empowered to adjudicate and decide any dispute or matter among the entities.
- **The Board, on receiving any complaint from any person, is empowered to conduct an inquiry and investigation.**
- The Board can pass any order or issue any direction or refer the matter for investigation as it thinks fit.
- The **Board has similar powers as given to the Civil Court under the Civil Procedure Code, 1908.**
- The Board is subjected to the principles of natural justice and the provisions of the Act

Nationwide "Nari Shakti Vandan Run" to be Held on 17–18 April 2026 Across Seven Cities



- The Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports will organise a nationwide "Nari Shakti Vandan Run" on 17 and 18 April 2026 across seven major cities, as part of its ongoing initiatives to promote women-led development and strengthen citizen participation in the vision of Viksit Bharat.
- The **event, themed #NariShaktiVandan, will be conducted in Delhi, Cuttack, Patna, Mumbai, Indore, Bengaluru and Jaipur.**
- The "Nari Shakti Vandan Run" is also being organised in the context of the special session of the Parliament from 16 to 18 April 2026,

Education Ministry notifies NCERT as deemed university



- The Education Ministry has issued a notification declaring the National Council for Educational Research and Training (NCERT), as an institution deemed to be a university, enabling it to offer courses/programmes and confer degrees.
- These conditions prevent the NCERT from indulging in any activities that are "commercial" and "profit-making" in nature, and mandate that all academic courses or programmes must conform to the norms and standards prescribed by the UGC and the concerned statutory bodies or councils.
- The notification also mandated the NCERT to start new programmes, off-campus or on offshore campuses, "only in accordance with the norms and guidelines issued by the UGC.
- **About the Deemed Universities/ Deemed-to-be-Universities in India**
- Universities in India are recognised by the University Grants Commission (UGC), which draws its power from the UGC Act, 1956.
- A deemed university or deemed-to-be-university is an accreditation granted to higher educational institutions (HEIs) in India.

  In broad terms, it means that the institution has been granted permission to offer its own degree programs, which are equivalent to those provided by regular universities.
- According to the Ministry of Education, a HEI (other than universities) that works at a very high standard in a specific field of study might be designated as a 'Deemed-to-be-university' by the Central Government on the advice of the UGC.
- This provision was introduced to ensure that more HEIs achieve university status for all practical purposes, because under the UGC Act, 1956, university status can be obtained by institutes established under state or union laws.

Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL)

- **State-owned Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL) has received environmental clearance from the Argentine government to begin deep** exploration of five brine lithium blocks in Catamarca province.
- KABIL is a Joint Venture Company (JVC) formed by three Indian Government Enterprises: National Aluminium Company Ltd. (NALCO), Hindustan Copper Limited (HCL), and Mineral Exploration & Consultancy Limited (MECL).
- It **operates under the aegis of the Ministry of Mines** with an authorized capital of ₹500 crore.
- **Established in**: The company was incorporated on August 8, 2019, following a Joint Venture Cum Shareholders' Agreement signed in New Delhi.

Aim:

- To ensure supply-side assurance and mineral security for India regarding critical and strategic minerals.
- To make India self-reliant in strategic minerals, supporting the Make in India initiative.
- To identify, explore, acquire, and develop mineral assets in overseas countries to fulfill domestic industrial needs.

Department of Posts releases new postcard on People of India

- The Department of Posts has released a new postcard on People of India at **the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya, in collaboration with the Prime Ministers' Museum and Library (PMML) in New Delhi.**
- The release is **part of the ongoing philatelic exhibition titled Ek Bharat, Shreshth Bharat: Celebrating India's Unity and Democracy through Postage Stamps.**

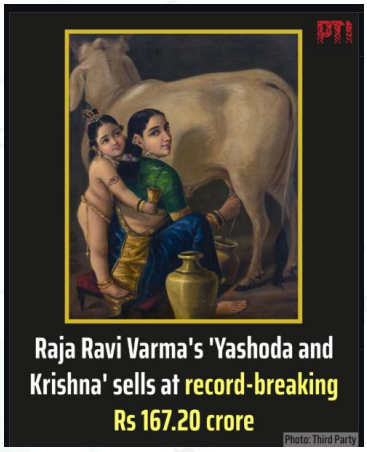
IRCTC launches 'Divya Dakshin Yatra' train for southern pilgrimage tours

- The Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC) has **announced the launch of a new Bharat Gaurav Tourist Train, the "Divya Dakshin Yatra," which is set to depart from Visakhapatnam on April 27.**
- This spiritually focused journey offers an eight-night and nine-day itinerary that covers major pilgrimage and heritage sites across South India, including Kanchipuram, Mahabalipuram, Rameswaram, Madurai, Trichy, Thanjavur, and Tiruvannamalai.

NSTFDC to Celebrate 25th Foundation Day on 10th April 2026 in New Delhi

- The National Scheduled Tribes Finance and Development Corporation (NSTFDC), a Public Sector Undertaking under the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, Government of India, is set to celebrate its 25th Foundation Day on April 10, 2026, at Vishwa Yuva Kendra, New Delhi.
- Established in 2001, NSTFDC serves as an apex organization dedicated to the economic development of Scheduled Tribes across the country.

Raja Ravi Varma



- Raja Ravi Varma's painting 'Yashoda and Krishna' has become the most expensive work of modern Indian art ever sold at auction, fetching a record-shattering ₹167.2 crore.
- Raja Ravi Varma (1848–1906) was a celebrated Indian painter and artist, widely considered the **father of modern Indian art**.
- He is renowned for achieving a unique fusion of European academic techniques with purely Indian sensibilities and subjects.
- **Birth:** Born in 1848 into an aristocratic family in the princely state of **Travancore** (present-day Kerala).
- **Training:** He mastered the medium of oil painting and European realism, which were unconventional for Indian artists at the time.
- He integrated **European oil painting techniques** (such as perspective and chiaroscuro) with Indian mythological and social themes.
- **Mass Production:** In 1894, he established a **lithographic press** to mass-produce his paintings as affordable oleographs.

Defection



- **Seven Rajya Sabha MPs from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), representing more than two-thirds of the party's strength in the Upper House, have defected to the BJP.**
- Defection in a legislative context refers to the act of an elected member of a House voluntarily giving up the membership of their political party or voting against the party's directions without prior permission.
- To curb this instability, the 10th Schedule was added via the 52nd Amendment Act (1985) and later strengthened by the 91st Amendment Act (2003).

Key Features of the Anti-Defection Law

- **Grounds for Disqualification**: A member can be disqualified if they voluntarily resign from their party or defy a party whip (voting instruction) during a division in the House.
- **The Chairman of the Rajya Sabha or the Speaker of the Lok Sabha is the final authority to decide on disqualification petitions.**

- An elected member is legally deemed to belong to the political party that set them up as a candidate for the election.
- The 91st Amendment also limited the size of the Council of Ministers to 15% of the total strength of the House to discourage using ministerial berths as bait for defection.

Exemptions from Disqualification

- A **member will not be disqualified if their original political party merges with another, provided that at least two-thirds of the members of the legislative party agree to the merger.**
- Originally, a split involving one-third of the party members was recognized, but the 91st Amendment deleted this to make switching parties more difficult.
- **If the Chairman rules that a merger has occurred based on the two-thirds threshold, the defecting members are officially recognized as members of the new party.**

Prime Minister Internship Scheme (PMIS)

- The Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) has expanded the Prime Minister Internship Scheme (PMIS) to allow final-year graduate and postgraduate students to apply for paid internships.
- **The PMIS is a flagship phygital initiative of the Government of India designed to provide structured, paid internship opportunities to the youth in India's top 500 companies.**
- It acts as a bridge between formal education and the professional corporate world, offering hands-on experience across diverse sectors.
- **Launched In:** The pilot phase of the scheme was launched in October 2024, following the announcement in the Union Budget 2024-25.
- **Nodal Ministry**: Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA).

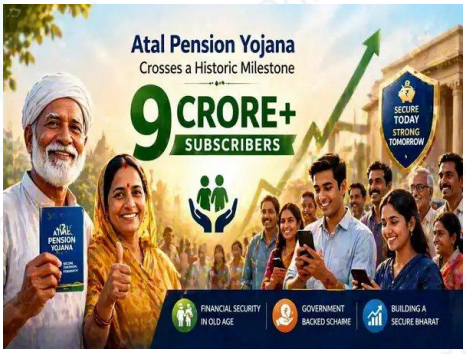
Key Features:

- **Financial Assistance**: a minimum assistance of ₹9,000 per month .
- **Age Criteria:** Open to youth between the ages of 18 and 25 years.
- **Duration**: The scheme typically provides for a 12-month internship period to ensure deep industry immersion.
- Interns are provided with insurance coverage under the Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana and Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana.

New Rules (2026 Expansion)

- Participation is no longer restricted to those who have already completed their degrees; final-year undergraduate and postgraduate students are now eligible.
- **Students must submit a No Objection Certificate** (NOC) from their respective educational institutions.
- The NOC must explicitly state that the internship will not interfere with the student's academic requirements or attendance.
- **The NOC can be signed by the Head of Department (HoD), Dean, Principal, or Training & Placement Officer.**
- These changes are implemented starting with the third round of the pilot phase, accessible via the official portal.

Atal Pension Yojana crosses milestone of over nine crore gross enrollments



- The scheme was launched on 9th May, 2015, with the objective of creating a universal social security system for all Indians, especially the poor, the under-privileged and the workers in the unorganised sector.
- **Administered By:** Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority through National Pension System (NPS).
- **Eligibility**: Any citizen of India can join the APY scheme. The age of the subscriber should be between 18-40 years. The contribution levels would vary and would be low if a subscriber joins early and increases if she joins late.
    - It **provides a minimum guaranteed pension ranging from Rs 1000 to Rs 5000 on attaining 60 years of age.**
    - The amount of pension is guaranteed for lifetime to the spouse on death of the subscriber.
    - In the event of death of both the subscriber and the spouse, the entire pension corpus is paid to the nominee.
    - **Tax Benefits:** Contributions to the Atal Pension Yojana (APY) are eligible for tax benefits similar to the National Pension System (NPS).

Technology Development and Investment Promotion Scheme

- Recently, the union Communications Minister has released revised guidelines for the Technology Development and Investment Promotion (TDIP) Scheme to strengthen the country's global telecom presence.
- **It is aimed at strengthening India's participation in global telecom standardization and accelerating the development of indigenous telecom technologies.**
- **Financial Outlay and Duration:** ₹203 crore for the period 2026–31
- It has been designed as a comprehensive support framework to enable Indian entities to actively contribute to global standards, promote innovation, and enhance India's competitiveness in next-generation telecommunications technologies.
- It **will be implemented through Telecommunications Standards Development Society, India (TSDSI),** Telecom Centres of Excellence, India (TCoE) and Telecommunications Consultants India Limited (TCIL).

The Namaste Scheme



- **The Union Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment announced major progress under the NAMASTE Scheme, highlighting large-scale profiling, PPE distribution, health insurance coverage, and financial assistance for sanitation workers.**
- The National Action for Mechanised Sanitation Ecosystem (NAMASTE) Scheme is a central sector scheme aimed at eliminating hazardous manual cleaning of sewers and septic tanks by promoting mechanised sanitation.
- It focuses on ensuring dignity, occupational safety, and sustainable livelihoods for sanitation workers while replacing manual scavenging with technology-driven sanitation systems.
- **Launched By:** Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment and Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.

Aim:

- To eliminate hazardous manual cleaning practices and promote complete mechanisation of sewer and septic tank sanitation.
- To provide sanitation workers with safety, health security, financial assistance, and alternative livelihood opportunities.

AICTE VAANI Scheme Third Edition Promotes Indian Languages

- The All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) has launched the third edition of its flagship AICTE-VAANI scheme to strengthen the use of Indian languages in technical education.
- **The initiative aims to create a more inclusive academic ecosystem by enabling students to access technical knowledge in their native languages.**
- The AICTE-VAANI (Vibrant Advocacy for Advancement and Nurturing of Indian Languages) scheme seeks to bridge the language gap in higher education.
- It focuses on encouraging research, learning, and dissemination of technical knowledge in regional languages.
- Around 200 conferences, seminars, and workshops will be supported, with each institution receiving up to Rs. 2 lakh.
- These events will span two to three days and will be conducted in 22 Indian languages, including Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Bengali, and Marathi.

Online Gaming Authority of India (OGAI)



- The government recently constituted the Online Gaming Authority of India, comprising six members.
- **It is a regulatory body established under the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act 2025.**
- The authority will be a digital office under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), Government of India. It will be operational starting May 1.
- It will act as the central regulator for online games, including esports, bringing them under a formal registration and classification system.
- The function of the authority will include categorising and registering online games, deciding whether a game qualifies as a money game, and addressing public grievances.
- **It is established to issue guidelines, codes of practice, and directions to ensure compliance**.
- It will also coordinate with financial institutions and law enforcement agencies to ensure effective enforcement.

Membership:

- The authority will comprise 6 members in which the Additional Secretary of the MeitY will be Chairperson .
- **Other five members will include Joint Secretaries from the Ministry of Home Affairs, Information and Broadcasting, Youth Affairs and Sports, Department of Financial Services, and Department of Legal Affairs.**

SAF-Blended Aviation Fuel



- The Indian government has amended the Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) (Regulation of Marketing) Order, 2001, to officially bring SAF-blended fuel under its regulatory ambit.
- **Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) blended with traditional Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) is a drop-in fuel solution designed to reduce the carbon footprint** of the aviation industry without

requiring modifications to existing aircraft engines or infrastructure.

- SAF consists of specially processed aviation-grade hydrocarbons that are chemically similar to traditional petroleum-based ATF.
- **Feedstocks**: SAF is a renewable fuel derived from alternative feedstocks, including crops, biogenic residues, and various waste materials.

New Changes (April 2026 Amendment)

- Previously, ATF was defined strictly as petroleum-based fuel; the definition now includes SAF co-processed in refineries and SAF blended with ATF.
- Bringing SAF under the ATF Control Order allows the government to regulate its marketing and supply chain effectively.
- **Mandatory Blending Targets**: The government has set indicative targets for international flights:
  - 1% blending in 2027.
  - 2% blending in 2028.
  - 5% blending in 2030.

Key Features:

- Offers significant reductions in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions compared to conventional fossil fuels.
- It does not alter the fundamental safety, nature, or performance of aviation fuel.
- The use of **SAF is a key component of ICAO's CORSIA scheme, which requires international flights to offset emissions starting with a mandatory phase in 2027.**

Denotified, Nomadic, and Semi-Nomadic Tribes (DNTs)

- The Union Social Justice Ministry report for 2025-26 highlights a significant lack of state support in issuing community certificates and identifying beneficiaries for denotified, nomadic, and semi-nomadic tribes (DNTs).
- **Communities that were officially labeled as criminal by the colonial British administration under the Criminal Tribes Act (CTA) of 1871.**
- Groups that maintain a mobile or semi-mobile lifestyle, traditionally moving for livelihoods such as trade, pastoralism, or entertainment.
- **These groups were denotified in 1952 when the CTA was repealed**, though many were subsequently monitored under various Habitual Offenders Acts.
- The British codified the criminal label based on the belief that certain castes were addicted to crime by heredity and usage.
- **There are nearly 1,200 such communities spread across various parts of India.**
- Currently, only seven states are actively issuing the DNT community certificates required to access central benefits.
- While many have been assimilated into SC, ST, or OBC lists, approximately 268 communities remain unclassified in any category.

Ministry of Rural Development finalises Calendar of SARAS Aajeevika Melas for FY 2026-27



- The Ministry of Rural Development has finalised the Calendar of SARAS Aajeevika Melas at the National Level for the Financial Year 2026-27,
- Aimed at promoting rural livelihoods, women entrepreneurship and traditional crafts across the country.
- **The SARAS Aajeevika Mela 2026 will be held in Gurugram from 22nd October to 6th November.**

- This will be followed by the SARAS Food Festival 2026 at Sunder Nursery, New Delhi, from 21st November to 8th December.
- The Ministry noted that **SARAS Aajeevika Mela 2027 will run for 28 days,** which will be held at Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium, New Delhi, from 1st February to 28th February next year.

Truck Mounted Attenuator

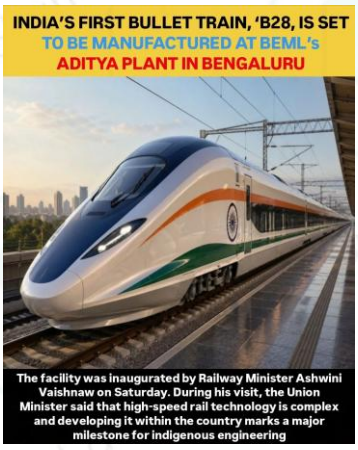


- **Recently, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) has introduced a truck mounted safety system i.e Truck Mounted Attenuator to reduce risks in construction and maintenance zones.**
- Truck Mounted Attenuators are specially designed impact-absorbing safety devices that play a critical role in protecting both workers and road users
- In the event of a collision, these systems absorb and dissipate kinetic energy, reducing the force of impact.

This helps:

- Protect maintenance crews working ahead of the vehicle
- Reduce injury risks for occupants of the impacting vehicle
- Minimize the severity of accidents in highway work zones
- **Early warnings that prevent accidents**: These TMAs are equipped with high-intensity wig-wag warning lights, designed to flash in alternating patterns that form directional arrows.
- These signals provide clear and timely warnings to approaching drivers.
- **It is especially valuable on high-speed highway corridors, during night-time operations and in foggy or low-visibility conditions**
- By alerting drivers well in advance, these systems help prevent collisions before they occur

Railway minister inaugurated facility dedicated to manufacturing of high-speed rail



- Union Railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw **inaugurated Atma nirbhar high speed bullet train manufacturing plant Aditya in Bengaluru BEML Limited (formerly known as Bharat Earth Movers Limited)**
- Aditya, a specialised complex dedicated to the manufacturing of high-speed rail
- The **newly inaugurated Aditya complex is currently designed for the development of coaches for B-28, which is India's first indigenous high-speed electric bullet trainset.**
- It is designed to run at speeds of up to 280 kmph.

The National Panchayati Raj Day 2026 celebrations

- National Panchayati Raj Day is celebrated across India on 24th April
- The national event was held at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, organized by the **Ministry of Panchayati Raj.**

Major Releases:

- **Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI)-2.0:** A report measuring the performance and development of Panchayats nationwide.
- **Meri Panchayat Meri Dharohar**: Three illustrated books a Monograph on Rural Heritage of Tripura, a Monograph on Rural Heritage of Tirupati and 'Uttarkashi: Saumya Kashi: The Soul of Himalayan Heritage' were released under the "Panchayat Dharohar Initiative".

- **Pan-India:** Celebrations were conducted at State, District, Block, and Gram Panchayat levels, with thousands of Gram Sabhas convening to reaffirm the spirit of participatory democracy.
- **Digital Initiatives**: Digital initiatives like e-GramSwaraj and the SabhaSaar Portal were highlighted as primary tools for transparency and ease of governance in rural India.

What is the Panchayat Advancement Index?

- PAI is a **composite index designed to assess the performance and progress of Gram Panchayats (GPs) across India** using socio-economic indicators, identifies development gaps, and supports evidence-based planning.
  - It **aligns with the Localization of Sustainable Development Goals (LSDGs) and the National Indicator Framework (NIF)** developed by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).
  - It **reflects India's commitment to the SDG 2030 Agenda** by promoting participatory, bottom-up governance, assessing GPs development through socio-economic indicators, identifying gaps, and enabling evidence-based planning.
- **Indicators of the PAI:** It is based on 435 unique local indicators across 9 LSDG-aligned themes.
- It is designed to provide a multi-domain and multi-sectoral assessment of Panchayat-level development.
- **Performance Categories of GPs:** Based on their PAI and thematic scores, GPs are classified into five performance categories: Achiever (90+), Front Runner (75–89.99), Performer (60–74.99), Aspirant (40–59.99), and Beginners (below 40).

Supreme Court Allows Minor's 31-Week Pregnancy Termination



- The Supreme Court of India permitted a 15-year-old girl to terminate her 31-week pregnancy, prioritising her fundamental rights and dignity.

Legal Basis:

- **Reproductive autonomy part of Article 21 (Right to Life).**
- Includes dignity, privacy, and personal liberty.

Key Observations:

- "No woman, especially a minor, should be forced to carry pregnancy."
- Emphasised psychological distress and suicide attempts.

Exceptional Circumstances:

- Court prioritised minor's best interests over procedural limits.
- Recognised severe mental, emotional, and social impact.

- **The Medical Termination of Pregnancy (MTP) Act regulates conditions for legal abortion in India**.
- The **standard upper limit for abortion under the MTP Act is generally 24 weeks in special categories**.
- Reproductive autonomy has been recognised by Indian courts as part of privacy and dignity rights.

Safe Travel on National Highways Under Article 21

- The Supreme Court has declared that the safety of commuters against road accidents and the right to safe passage on highways are part of the fundamental right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution.
- **National Highways (NHs) comprise merely 2% of India's total road network but account for nearly 30% of all road fatalities,** highlighting severe infrastructural and administrative vulnerability.
- The Court held that Article 21 imposes a positive obligation on the State to ensure a safe environment, extending beyond protection from unlawful death; fatalities due to avoidable hazards reflect failure of this duty.

- **Immediate Prohibitions**: The Court issued an immediate ban on the construction or operation of any new commercial structures, dhabas, or eateries within the right-of-way of any National Highway.
- **Heavy and commercial vehicles are strictly prohibited from parking or stopping on any National Highway**, carriageway, or paved shoulder, except at officially designated lay-bys and wayside amenities to prevent blind-spot collisions.
- **Enforcement Actions:** District Magistrates have been directed to demolish or remove all unauthorized structures within 60 days.
- **Institutional Mechanism:** A 'District Highway Safety Task Force' must be constituted in every district nationwide to monitor and enforce highway safety protocols.

NCB launches 'Operation WIPE' to crack down on online drug trafficking networks



- The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has launched "Operation WIPE" **to curb the misuse of online platforms for the illegal sale and distribution of pharmaceutical drugs regulated under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act.**
- **WIPE stands for** "Web-based Illicit Activities Prevention & Enforcement".
- Under this initiative, the NCB has so far identified 122 instances involving 62 substances, including commonly abused drugs such as clonazepam, diazepam, and fentanyl.

Abhilekh Patal Portal

- Recently, the Prime Minister of India urged citizens to explore the 'Abhilekh Patal' portal for a deeper understanding of India's historical legacy.

Abhilekh Patal Portal

- It is a **full-featured web-portal to access the National Archives of India's reference media and its digitized collections through the internet.**
- It is a digital repository thoughtfully curated by the National Archives of India (NAI).
- It has a **mission to provide easy access to India's historical archives**, comprising an astounding 7 million records.

The archival collections available through the Abhilekh Patal portal cover a wide range of historical records preserved by the National Archives of India. **These include:**

- Public records transferred from various Ministries and Departments of the Government of India
- Private papers of eminent personalities
- Archival reference media such as photographs, maps, microfilms and rare documents
- Digitised historical government files and archival collections maintained by NAI

The National Archives of India

- It was **established on 11 March 1891 at Calcutta** (Kolkata) as the Imperial Record Department, it **is the biggest archival repository in South Asia.**
- It is the repository of the non-current records of the Government of India and is holding them in trust for the use of record creators and general users.
- **Head office**: New Delhi
- It has one Regional Office in Bhopal and three Records Centres at Bhubaneswar, Jaipur and Puducherry.
- **Nodal Ministry**: Ministry of Culture, Government of India

Nasha Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan

- **The Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment set to launch the upgraded Nasha Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan (NMBA) App 2.0** to strengthen the monitoring under the framework of the National Action Plan for Drug Demand Reduction (NAPDDR).

Nasha Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan

- It was launched on **15th August 2020** by the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment.
- It **was initially launched in 272 identified most vulnerable districts** and **now it has been extended to all districts of the country with effect from 15th August 2023.**
- It intends to reach out to the masses and spread awareness about substance abuse through various activities like:
- Focus on higher educational Institution, university campuses and schools
- Reaching out into the Community and identifying dependent population,
- Focus on counselling & treatment facilities in hospitals & rehabilitation centres
- **Capacity building programmes for a service providers**
- **Target group**: Special emphasis is laid on the participation of stakeholders such as women, children, educational institutions, civil society organizations etc. who may be directly or indirectly affected by substance use

Key Features of NMBA App 2.0

- It is now accessible to citizens with features of undertaking e-Pledge, access to IEC material, helpline support and deaddiction centre details.
- **Dedicated Access for Grant-in-Aid Institutions (GIAs):** GIAs will now be onboarded onto the platform with role-based access, enabling real-time reporting and monitoring of activities at the deaddiction facilities.
- **Real time status of Anudan (Grant) for GIA institutions**: It incorporates Anudan status of all GIAs accessible to DoSJE, States / UTs and GIAs,
- **Nearest De-addiction Centre**: It Allows users to identify the nearest de-addiction centre, enabling quicker referral and improved access to treatment services.

India International Water Week in Sept

- The 9th edition of India International Water Week (IIWW-2026) **will be held on the theme 'Climate Resilient Water Management'**
- From September 22nd - 26th 2026 .
- **Organised by the Union Ministry of Jal Shakti,** will include 49 sessions across various themes in the water sector



Soul Threads

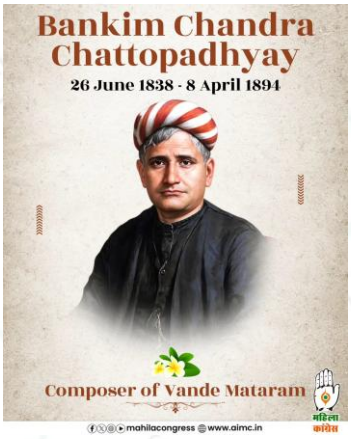
- **The Central Cottage Industries Corporation of India (CCIC) has launched its first heritage designer collection, Soul Threads, marking a major step in its revival and cultural promotion strategy.**
- It is to celebrate and promote India's artisanal legacy through handloom, handicrafts, designer fashion, and cultural performances.
- **Launched By:** Central Cottage Industries Corporation of India (CCIC)

SHORT NEWS

- The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment **will organise a three-day Chintan Shivir with States and Union Territories on the Theme** "Antyodaya ka Sankalp, Amrit Kaal ka Pratibimb – Viksit Bharat @2047" fromApril 24 to 26, 2026 in Chandigarh.

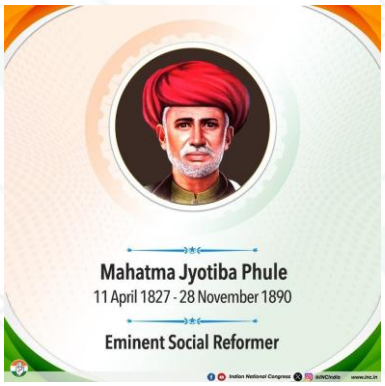
Eminent Personalities In News

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla pays tribute to Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay on his death anniversary



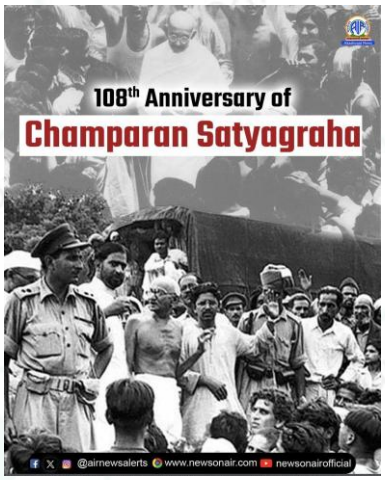
- The death anniversary of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay was observed on 8th April,
- Born on 27th June 1838 in Naihati, West Bengal, Bankim was a brilliant student and joined British service after completing his studies.
- Nationalism and Literature: Through works like Anandamath (banned by the British), which narrates the Sanyasi Rebellion, Bankim became synonymous with India's struggle for independence.
- The national song of India, Vande Mataram, originated from Bankim's Anandamath, becoming a symbol of the freedom movement
- Famous Works: Rajmohan's Wife ((1864) (first novel in English by an Indian).
- His novels Durgeshnandini (1865), Kapalkundala (1866), and Vishabriksha (1873) addressed social issues like women's rights, child marriage, and caste discrimination.
- Also, his notable religious writings include Krishna Charitra.
- Role in the Bengali Renaissance: Bankim started the literary magazine Bangadarshan (1872), which played a key role in fostering Bengali nationalism.

11th April - Mahatma Phule birth anniversary



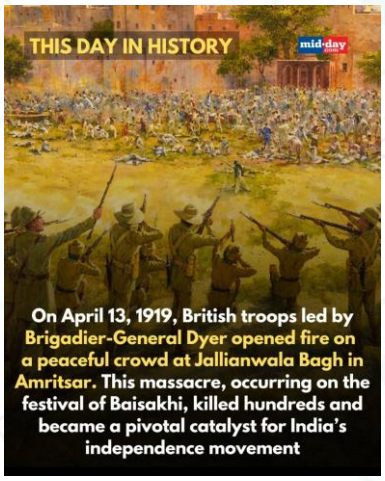
- Dedicated his life **for social equality and upliftment of marginalized communities.**
- Jyotirao Phule was an **Indian social activist, thinker, anti-caste social reformer** and **writer from Maharashtra**. He is also **known as Jyotiba Phule.**
- Phule was **born on 11th April, 1827** in present-day Maharashtra and **belonged to the Mali caste of gardeners and vegetable farmers**.
- In 1848, Mahatma Jyotiba Phule and Savitribai Phule founded the first girls' school in Pune.
- **Ideology:** His Ideology was based on: **Liberty; Egalitarianism; Socialism**.
- Phule was **influenced by Thomas Paine's book titled The Rights of Man** and believed that the only **solution to combat the social evils** was the **enlightenment of women and members of the lower castes.**
- **Major Publications: Tritiya Ratna** (1855); **Powada**: Chatrapati Shivajiraje Bhosle Yancha (1869); **Gulamgiri** (1873), Shetkarayacha Aasud (1881).
- **Related Association:** Phule along with his followers **formed Satyashodhak Samaj in 1873**
- **Title of Mahatma:** He was **bestowed** with the title of Mahatma on 11th May, 1888 **by a Maharashtrian social activist Vithalrao Krishnaji Vandekar.**

Nation marks 108th anniversary of Champaran Satyagraha led by Mahatma Gandhi



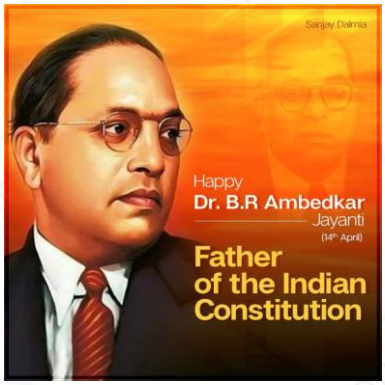
- 10th April marks the 108th anniversary of the Champaran Satyagraha, a defining moment in India's freedom struggle led by Mahatma Gandhi.
- On this day in 1917, in the Champaran district of Bihar, the movement was launched to address the grievances of indigo farmers who were compelled by British planters to cultivate indigo under the oppressive Tinkathia system.
- It also marked Mahatma Gandhi's first experiment with Satyagraha in the country.
- His leadership led to the formation of an enquiry committee, which ultimately resulted in the Champaran Agrarian Act of 1918.
- This act abolished the 'tinkathia' system and provided relief to the farmers, marking the success of Gandhi's first Satyagraha in India.
- Tinkathia System: Under the tinkathia system, European planters forced ryots to cultivate indigo on 3/20th of their landholding, severely restricting their ability to grow food crops.

13th April The Jallianwala Bagh Massacre



- **India marks the 107th anniversary of the Jallianwala Bagh massacre, paying homage to the hundreds of unarmed civilians killed by British forces in 1919.**
- The Jallianwala Bagh massacre, also known as the Amritsar Massacre, was a brutal slaughter of unarmed Indian civilians by British troops under the command of Brigadier-General Reginald Dyer.
- It remains one of the darkest chapters of British colonial rule in India and served as a turning point that shifted the national sentiment from seeking reform to demanding complete independence (Swaraj).
- **The Rowlatt Act (1919):** The British passed the Black Act, which allowed the government to imprison any person suspected of sedition without a trial for up to two years. This sparked widespread Rowlatt Satyagraha led by Mahatma Gandhi.
- **Two popular pro-independence leaders, Dr. Saifuddin Kitchlew and Dr. Satyapal, were arrested in Amritsar, leading to violent protests and a critical security situation in Punjab.**
- **April 13 was the festival of Baisakhi**. Thousands of people—including men, women, and children—gathered at Jallianwala Bagh. Some were there to peacefully protest the arrests, while many rural visitors were simply there to celebrate the festival.
- **General Dyer entered the garden with 50 soldiers and two armored cars.** Without issuing any warning for the crowd to disperse, he blocked the only narrow exit.
- The **British government appointed the Hunter Commission to investigate**.
- **While it censured Dyer, he was not prosecuted** and was even hailed as a Saviour of the Punjab by some imperial loyalists in Britain.
- **Renunciation of Honors**: In protest, Rabindranath Tagore renounced his Knighthood, and Mahatma Gandhi returned his Kaiser-i-Hind gold medal.

April 14 Ambedkar Jayanti



- **Bhimrao Ramjo Ambedkar,** famously known as the **Father of the Indian Constitution,**
- **Born on 14 April 1891**, in **Mhow (now Ambedkar Nagar) in Madhya Pradesh.**
- His birth anniversary on 14 April every year as **Bhimrao Ambedkar Jayanti or Bhim Jayanti or Ambedkar Remembrance Day.**
- His **father, Subedar Ramji Maloji Sakpal**, was a well-read person and **follower of Sant Kabir.**
- **Contributions:** In **1924,** he started an **Association for the welfare of the depressed classes** and **in 1927**, he started the **Bahishkrit Bharat newspaper** to address the cause of the depressed classes.
- He also led the **Mahad Satyagraha in March 1927.**
- He **participated in all three Round Table Conferences.**
- **In 1932, Dr. Ambedkar signed the Poona pact with Mahatma Gandhi,** which abandoned the idea of separate electorates for the depressed classes **(Communal Award).**
- **In 1936,** he **formed the Independent Labour Party** to safeguard the interests of the depressed classes.
- Elected to the **Constituent Assembly from Bengal in 1946.**
- He was the **Chairman of Drafting Committee** and remembered as the **Father of the Indian Constitution.**
- **In 1947**, Dr. Ambedkar became **Minister of Law in the first Cabinet of independent India.**
- **He resigned from the cabinet in 1951,** over differences on the Hindu Code Bill.
- Later in life, He **converted to Buddhism.** He **passed away on December 6, 1956, which is commemorated as Mahaparinirvan Diwas**
- **Chaitya Bhoomi** is a **memorial to B R Ambedkar**, located **in Mumbai.**
- He was also awarded **India's highest civilian honour the Bharat Ratna in 1990.**
- **Journals:**

  Mooknayak (1920)
  Bahishkrit Bharat (1927)
  Samatha (1929)
  Janata (1930)

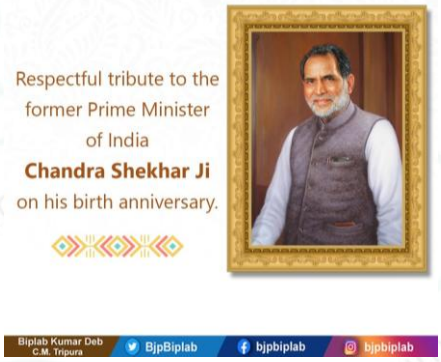
Books:

Annihilation of Caste
Buddha or Karl Marx
The Untouchable: Who are They and Why They Have Become Untouchables
Buddha and His Dhamma
The Rise and Fall of Hindu Women

Organisations:

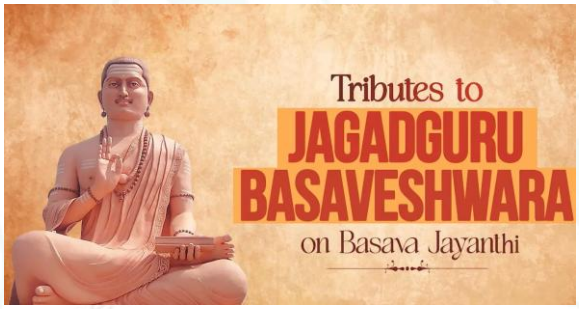
Bahishkrit Hitkarini Sabha (1923)
Independent Labor Party (1936)
Scheduled Castes Federation (1942)

Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar 100th birth anniversary



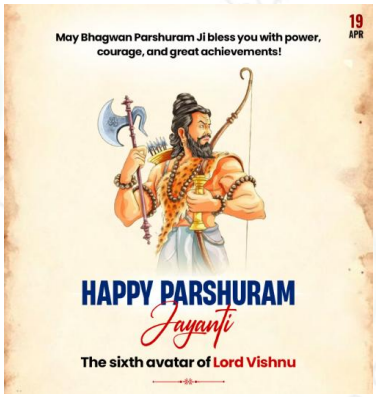
- **Shri Chandra Shekhar was born on April 17, 1927, in a farmer's family in village Ibrahimpatti in District Ballia, Uttar Pradesh. He was President of the Janata Party from 1977 to 1988.**
- In 1962, he was elected to the Rajya Sabha from Uttar Pradesh. He joined the Indian National Congress in January 1965.
- He **came to be as 'Young Turk' leader**
- He founded and edited YOUNG INDIAN, a weekly published from Delhi in 1969.
- During the Emergency (June 1975 to March 1977) YOUNG INDIAN had to be closed down.
- When Emergency was declared on June 25, 1975, he was arrested under Maintenance of Internal Security Act inspite of the fact that he was a member of the Central Election Committee and Working Committee, top bodies of the Indian National Congress.
- **His diary, written in Hindi while undergoing imprisonment during the Emergency period, was later published under the title 'Meri Jail Diary'.**
- A well-known compilation of his writings is 'Dynamics of Social Change'.
- Shri Chandra Shekhar **undertook a marathon walk (Padayatra) through the country from Kanyakumari in the deep South to Rajghat (Samadhi of Mahatma Gandhi) in New Delhi** covering a distance of nearly 4260 kms from January 6, 1983 to June 25, 1983.

Union Minister Rajnath Singh and PM Modi extend greetings on Basava Jayanti



- Basava Jayanti (celebrated on April 20 in 2026) marks the birth anniversary of Lord Basaveshwara, **a 12th-century poet, philosopher, and social reformer who founded Lingayatism.**
- As per the Hindu calendar, the birth of Basavanna falls on the 3rd day of Vaisahaka month in the Shukla paksha.
- **Basaveshwara was born in Bagevadi** (of undivided Bijapur district in Karnataka) in 1131 AD.A 12th-century poet and philosopher, who is celebrated and held in high regard, especially by the Lingayat community, as he was the founder of Lingayatism.
  - The **term Lingayat denotes a person who wears a personal linga, an iconic form of God Shiva**, on the body which is received during the initiation ceremony.
- His spiritual discipline was based on the **principles of Arivu (true knowledge), Achara (right conduct), and Anubhava (divine experience)** and it brought a social, religious and economic revolution in the 12th century.
- **He believed in a society free of the caste system**, with equal opportunity for all and preached about manual hard work.
- **He also founded the Anubhava Mantapa, loosely translated as the forum of experiences, an academy which included Lingayat mystics, saints, and philosophers.**
- **Thus, it was the first and foremost Parliament of India**, where Sharanas (citizens of welfare society) sat together and discussed the socialistic principles of a Democratic set up.

Bhagvan Parshuram Jayanti



- Parshuram Jayanti, observed on April 19, 2026, commemorates the birth of Lord Parshuram, the sixth avatar of Vishnu.
- **Celebrated on the Tritiya Tithi of Shukla Paksha in Vaishakha** (often coinciding with Akshaya Tritiya), he is considered an immortal Chiranjeevi

500 Years of the First Battle of Panipat

- April 21st marks the 500th anniversary of the First Battle of Panipat (April 21, 1526), a **pivotal conflict where the outnumbered forces of Zahir-ud-din Muhammad Babur defeated the Lodi Sultanate.**
- The First Battle of Panipat was a landmark military engagement that signaled the end of the Delhi Sultanate and the beginning of the Mughal Empire in India.
- **Happened In**: The battle took place on April 21, 1526, on the plains of Panipat (present-day Haryana, India).

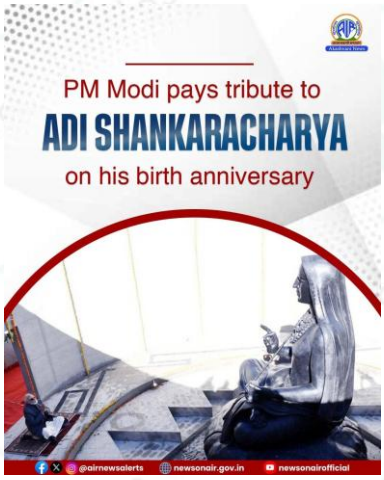
Kingdoms Involved:

- **The Timurid Forces**: Led by Zahir-ud-din Muhammad Babur, a fugitive prince from Ferghana (Central Asia)
- **The Lodi Sultanate**: Led by Ibrahim Lodi, the last Sultan of Delhi.

Background to the Battle:

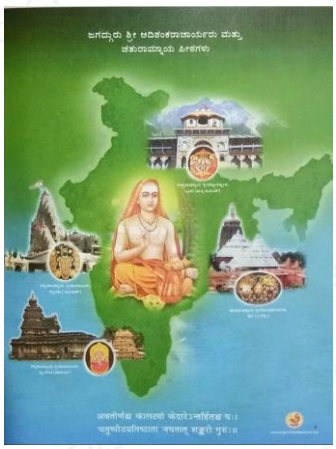
- Babur did not invade India solely for religious conquest; he was a political opportunist invited by disgruntled Lodi nobles.
- **Daulat Khan Lodi (Governor of Punjab) and Alam Khan (Ibrahim's uncle) sought Babur's help to overthrow Ibrahim Lodi's perceived tyranny.**
- Babur, having lost his ancestral lands in Central Asia, viewed Hindustan as a site for a new, permanent kingdom.

Adi Shankaracharya birth anniversary



- The birth anniversary of Adi Shankaracharya, known as Shankaracharya Jayanti, is being observed, Tuesday, 21 April 2026.
- **This year marks the 1238th birth anniversary of the revered philosopher and saint.**
- According to the Hindu calendar, the Jayanti is celebrated on the Panchami Tithi of Vaishakha Shukla Paksha:
- Adi Shankaracharya, or Shankara as he was known, was an ancient Indian philosopher and theologian who lived in the early 8th century CE.
- **Birth**: He was born in Kalady, a village in present-day Kerala.

Philosophical Contributions:



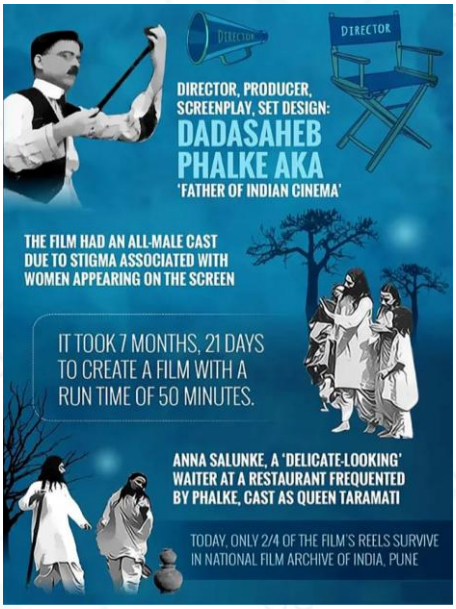
- He is best known for his role in the development and **propagation of Advaita Vedanta, a non-dualistic school of Hindu philosophy.**
- He amalgamated the ideologies of 'Advaita Vedanta' and also explained the basic ideas of Upanishads.
- **His most important work is his efforts to synthesize the six sub-sects, known as 'Shanmata.' 'Shanmata', which literally translates to 'six religions,' is the worship of six supreme deities.**
- Shankaracharya explained the existence of one Supreme Being (Brahman) and that the six supreme deities are part of one divine power.

- He also founded 'Dashanami Sampradaya,' which talks about leading a monastic life
- **He condemned the 'Mimamsa school of Hinduism', which was purely based on ritual practices.**
- **Four Mathas**: He established four prominent monastic centers in India, each associated with one of the cardinal directions: Sringeri in the south, Dwarka in the west, Puri in the east, and Badrinath in the north.
- He **wrote 18 commentaries on major religious scriptures like the Bhagavad Gita, Brahmasutras, and 12 major Upanishads.**
- His **review of 'Brahma Sutra**' is known as 'Brahmasutrabhasya', and it is the oldest surviving commentary on 'Brahma Sutra'.

30 April - Dadasaheb Phalke Birth Anniversary, Father of Indian Cinema

- On April 30, 2025, India celebrates the **155th birth anniversary of Dhundiraj Govind Phalke**, famously known as Dadasaheb Phalke. Hailed as the Father of Indian Cinema
- **Born in 1860 in Trimbak, Maharashtra**
- **Raja Harishchandra (1913): India's First Feature Film**
- After months of struggle, **Raja Harishchandra premiered on May 3, 1913, at the Coronation Cinematograph in Bombay**. It was a **silent, black-and-white film** based on the legendary story of **King Harishchandra**, a symbol of truth and sacrifice in Hindu mythology.
- The **first recipient of the Dadasaheb Phalke Award was Devika Rani**, an **Indian film actress, in 1969.** The award was instituted by the Government of India to honor individuals who have made outstanding contributions to Indian cinema.
- The **54th Dadasaheb Phalke Award** was awarded to **Mithun Chakraborty.** He was presented the award **at the 70th National Film Festival award ceremony on October 8, 2024.**





National/international Festivals

Good Friday

- Good Friday is a solemn Christian holiday observed on the Friday preceding Easter.
- It commemorates the crucifixion of Jesus Christ —an event central to the Christian belief that Jesus is the Son of God.



- For Christians worldwide, the day is marked by prayer, fasting, and profound reflection.
- The history of Good Friday begins in the first century in Roman-occupied Judea.
- The crucifixion took place at a site called Calvary (or Golgotha).

Easter observed worldwide, commemorating resurrection of Jesus Christ after crucifixion



- Easter is a central Christian festival that commemorates the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, symbolising victory over sin and death.
- It represents hope, renewal, and new beginnings, and marks the culmination of Holy Week, which includes Good Friday.
- The date changes each year as it is determined by the lunar calendar, falling on the first Sunday after the full moon following the spring equinox.

Vishu 2026 - Malayalam New Year

- Vishu celebrated on **Monday, April 15, 2026.**
- The day commemorates **Lord Krishna's victory over the demon Narakasura**, symbolizing the triumph of good over evil.
- Vishu is a major **Hindu spring festival** celebrated primarily in **Kerala** and nearby regions of **Tamil Nadu**.
- Vishu marks **new beginnings** and is often considered the **Malayalam New Year**.
- The festival signifies the **Sun's transition into Mesha Rashi.**
- Vishu is observed on the **first day of the Malayalam month of Medam,** (Chingam is the first month of the Malayalam calendar, but Vishu occurs in Medam).

14th April - Maha Vishuba Sankranti and Pana Sankranti - Odia New Year

- Pana Sankranti, **also known as Maha Bishuba Sankranti**, is the **Odia New Year festival .**
- Celebrated **on the first day of the Odia calendar month of Baisakha**, which typically falls on April 14th or April 15th on the Gregorian calendar .

Tamil New Year Puthandu

- Celebrated as the **first day of the Tamil month of Chittirai.**
- As per Drik Panchang, Puthandu will be observed on April 14 in India.
- **Poila Baisakh** is an important festival **celebrated by Bengali communities** across **West Bengal, Tripura, Jharkhand, and Assam.**
- **Shubho Noboborsho**, also known as Pohela Boishakh, marks the **Bengali New Year**.
- It is **also celebrated in Bangladesh.**
- The **West Bengal Legislative Assembly recently** made a significant decision by declaring **'Poila Baisakh**,' the first day of the Bengali calendar, **as 'Bangla Dibas' or West Bengal Foundation Day.**

Akshaya Tritiya 2026

- **Akshaya Tritiya is considered one of the most auspicious days in the Hindu calendar, symbolising prosperity, success, and new beginnings.**
- Celebrated on the **third lunar day (Tritiya) of the bright half of the month of Vaishakha.**
- The word "Akshaya" means "never diminishing," reflecting the belief that wealth, charity, and positive actions performed on this day multiply over time
- **Devotees worship Lord Vishnu and Goddess Lakshmi, purchase gold or property, and engage in charitable acts.**
- The day also holds significance in Jainism, marking the end of Lord Rishabhdev's year-long fast..

State

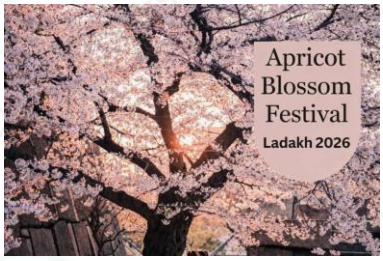
Ladakh

Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena lays the foundation stone for India's first Petroglyph Conservation Park in Leh



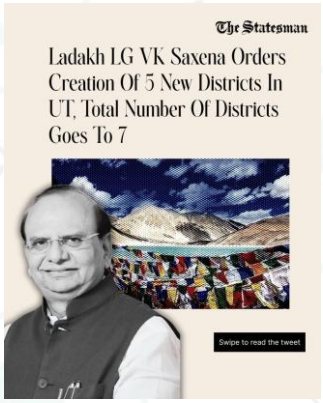
- In a landmark initiative to preserve Ladakh's ancient heritage, Lt Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena laid the foundation stone for India's first Petroglyph Conservation Park on the banks of the Indus River on World Heritage Day.
- **Petroglyphs are prehistoric images, symbols, or carvings etched, pecked, or engraved directly onto rock surfaces.**
- The park aims to serve as a dedicated conservation space for centuries-old rock carvings (petroglyphs) that are increasingly under threat

Apricot Blossom Festival2026



- Apricot Blossom Festival2026 begins in the Garkone village in Kargil.
- It marks the beginning of a vibrant celebration of nature, culture, and local livelihoods in Ladakh.
- Locally known as 'Chuli Mendok', the festival marks the flowering season of apricot trees in the lower-altitude villages of Ladakh's Sham Valley and Aryan Valley, as well as parts of Nubra.
- In 2026, the Apricot Blossom Festival will take place from April 8 to 16, with celebrations moving from one village to another.

Ladakh L-G Saxena approves creation of 5 new districts



- The Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, has approved the creation of five new districts, in total 7, aiming to strengthen administrative efficiency and grassroots governance.

The New Districts: The five newly created districts

- Nubra
- Sham
- Changthang
- Zanskar
- Drass

- **Previous Structure**: Until this decision, Ladakh consisted of only two districts: Leh and Kargil.
  - Nubra, Sham, and Changthang have been carved out of Leh district, while Zanskar and Drass are carved out of Kargil district.
- **The Centre bifurcated the erstwhile State of J&K into two Union Territories** – Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh – on August 5, 2019, when it also abrogated Article 370 of the Constitution that gave special status to the erstwhile State.

Jammu & Kashmir

Hokersar Lake

- The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) recently warned of severe ecological degradation of Hokersar Lake, with over 2,500 kanals encroached.
- **Hokersar, also known as Hokera, is a large natural wetland near Srinagar in Jammu and Kashmir**.
- It spans 13.75 sq.km. and rests at 1,585 meters above sea level.

- The **wetland lies in the Jhelum River basin and receives water mainly from the Doodhganga River (a tributary of Jhelum).**
- It is located in the northwest Himalayan biogeographic province of Kashmir, behind the snow-draped Pir Panchal.
- It is the **largest bird sanctuary in the Kashmir Valley and a designated Ramsar site, recognized for its international ecological importance.**
- It serves as a critical habitat and resting place for various migratory waterbirds from Siberia, Central Asia, and Northern Europe, hosting around 68 waterfowl species, including some endangered ones.
- **Hokersar is rich in aquatic vegetation such as reedbeds and water chestnuts**, which provide food and shelter for fish and birds.

The Indian EXPRESS

Ladakh secures distinct Aadhaar identity, UIDAI removes J&K tag

Ladakh secures distinct Aadhaar identity, UIDAI removes J&K tag

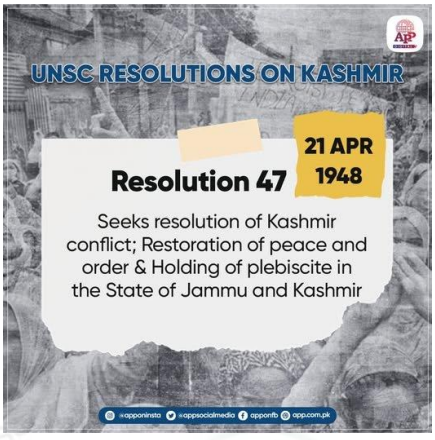


- **Nearly seven years after Ladakh was carved out as a separate Union Territory from the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir in 2019**, residents have finally secured a distinct identity in Aadhaar records, with the 'Jammu and Kashmir' label now replaced by 'Ladakh'.
- Despite the creation of the Union Territory, Aadhaar records continued to reflect 'Jammu and Kashmir' in the 'State' field.

Kathua Border Villages Added to Vibrant Village Programme-II

- The Central Government has included six border villages in Jammu and Kashmir's Kathua district under the Vibrant Village Programme-II to improve infrastructure and ensure full delivery of welfare schemes.
- **Vibrant Village Programme is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme aimed at developing border villages in strategic areas.**
- The scheme focuses on improving road connectivity, housing, tourism, and livelihood opportunities in remote border regions.
- **Kathua** district is located in the Jammu region of Jammu and Kashmir and **shares part of the International Border with Pakistan.**
- **International Border areas are different from the Line of Control and are managed with stronger civilian settlement support.**

Resolution 47 on Kashmir



- On April 21, 1948, the United Nations adopted Resolution 47, a document that fundamentally changed the trajectory of the Jammu and Kashmir conflict.
- **Resolution 47, formally titled The India-Pakistan Question, is a UN Security Council (UNSC) resolution that recommended a three-step process to restore peace and conduct a plebiscite in Jammu and Kashmir.**
- It was passed under Chapter VI of the UN Charter, meaning its provisions were recommendations rather than legally binding directives.

Background:

- **The Invasion**: In October 1947, tribal raiders supported by Pakistan invaded J&K. Maharaja Hari Singh acceded to India to seek military help.
- **By January 1948, despite military gains, India feared a full-scale war**. On the advice of Lord Mountbatten, Prime Minister Nehru approached the UN.

- **New Delhi's request was specific**: ask Pakistan to stop assisting the invaders and deny them use of its territory. India believed its legal case (based on the Instrument of Accession) was foolproof.
- The primary aim was to stop the fighting and establish a democratic mechanism to decide the state's future.

The resolution outlined a three-step sequence:

- Pakistan was to use its best endeavors to secure the withdrawal of tribesmen and Pakistani nationals.
- **Once the Commission was satisfied that the invaders were withdrawing, India was to progressively reduce its forces to the minimum required for law and order.**
- A UN-nominated Plebiscite Administrator would then conduct a free and impartial referendum to decide whether J&K would accede to India or Pakistan.

About Mansar Lake

- A senior police officer recently reviewed security measures at Mansar Lake, a **prominent tourist destination in Samba district of Jammu and Kashmir.**
- It is a freshwater lake located in the Samba district of Jammu and Kashmir
- It lies in the foothills of the Shivalik range.
- It is **oval in shape** and surrounded by green hills and forests.
- The **lake is mainly fed by rainwater and underground springs.**
- On the eastern side of the lake stands the Sheshnag Temple
- **Other temples such as Durga Temple and Umapati Mahadev Temple are also located around the lake.**
- Together with its twin lake, Surinsar, it was designated under Ramsar Convention in November 2005.

Himachal Pradesh

Himachal Pradesh celebrates 79th Foundation Day



- **April 15** has been observed every year as **'Himachal Day'**
- On **April 15, 1948**, the **state was formed by merging 30 small and large princely states.**
- **HP became a part C state on 26th January 1950** with the implementation of the Constitution of India.
- After recommendation of the **State Reorganisation Commission**, HP became a **Union Territory on 1st November 1956.**
- On **18th December 1970** the State of HP Act was passed by **Parliament** and the new state came into being on **25th January 1971.** HP emerged as the **18th state of the Indian Union.**
- State Animal of Himachal Pradesh – Snow Leopard
- State Bird of Himachal Pradesh – Western Tragopan
- State Tree of Himachal Pradesh – Deodar Cedar
- State Flower of Himachal Pradesh – Pink Rhododendron
- The present strength of the Vidhan Sabha is 68

National Parks

- Great Himalayan National Park (a UNESCO World Heritage Site).
- Pin Valley National Park.
- Khirganga, Inderkila, and Simbalbara National Parks.

Uttarakhand

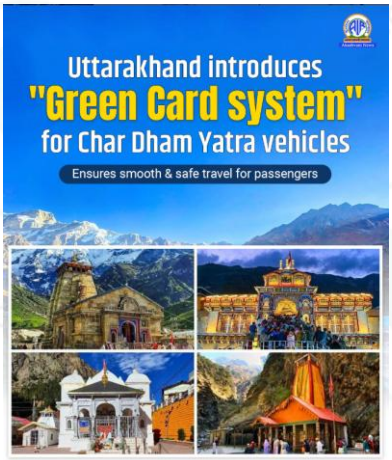
Lakhwar Hydroelectric Project

- North India's water and energy security is set to receive a significant boost as the 300 MW Lakhwar multipurpose project on the river Yamuna in the district Dehradun, Uttarakhand, gathers pace following a high-level review by the Secretary at Ministry of Jal Shakti.

Lakhwar Hydroelectric Project

- It is a multipurpose hydroelectric project planned on the Yamuna river near Lohari Village in the Dehradun District of Uttarakhand.
- **The main project components are a 204 m high concrete gravity dam, 3 steel-lined penstocks, and an underground powerhouse housing 3 vertical Francis turbines of 100 MW each.**
- The project is being developed and currently owned by Uttarakhand Jal Vidyut Nigam.
- **Hydroelectric Capacity**: 300 MW (hydropower to be used by Uttarakhand)
- **Storage Capacity:** 330.66 million cubic meters (MCM)
- **Irrigation Potential**: 33,780 hectares
- The project is expected to generate 612.93 GWh of electricity.
- It **provides drinking water supply to states like Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, and Rajasthan.**
- **Associated Project**: It is linked with the downstream Vyasi Hydroelectric Project (120 MW), forming part of the Yamuna river basin development

"Green Card system" introduced for commercial passenger vehicles to ensure the smooth and safe conduct of the Char Dham Yatra in Uttarakhand



- In Uttarakhand, the "Green Card system" for commercial passenger vehicles has been introduced to ensure the smooth and safe conduct of the Char Dham Yatra.
- The Green Card system will ensure the technical fitness and safety of commercial vehicles participating in the Yatra.
- It will not only certify vehicle fitness but also provide all necessary vehicle-related information instantly in case of an emergency.

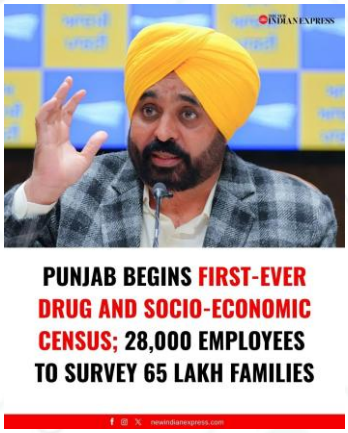
Punjab

Punjab Governor gives assent to anti-sacrilege Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Bill, 2026



- Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Kataria has given assent to the Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Bill 2026, with Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann
- **The Bill proposes stringent punishments exclusively for acts of sacrilege involving the Guru Granth Sahib, which Sikhs revere as their eternal Guru.**
- This is the third such attempt by successive governments in Punjab to enact a stringent law on sacrilege.
- Under the amended provisions, **any act of sacrilege will attract a minimum imprisonment of seven years, extendable up to 20 years, along with a fine ranging from Rs 2 lakh to Rs 10 lakh**.

- If the offence is committed as part of a conspiracy to disturb communal harmony, the punishment escalates to a minimum of 10 years, extendable to life imprisonment, with fines between Rs 5 lakh and Rs 25 lakh.
- The offences have been classified as non-bailable and cognisable, triable by a sessions court, with investigations mandated to be conducted by officers not below the rank of deputy superintendent of police or assistant commissioner of police.
- **The law introduces the concept of a "custodian", encompassing individuals, institutions, and gurdwara committees responsible for the care and protection of a Saroop.**



Punjab Launches First-Ever Caste Socio-Economic Survey

- Punjab has started its first ever drugs and caste-based census and teams from different government departments have fanned out across the state to do a head count of drug abusers.
- The census will be completed within three months and Census- 2027 will also start from May 15 in the state.
- The exercise aims to map land ownership, income levels, and social indicators across caste groups.
- It will also collect data on drug use within households, including the type of substances consumed.



Punjab govt to build glass bridge over Sutlej Lake in Nangal town

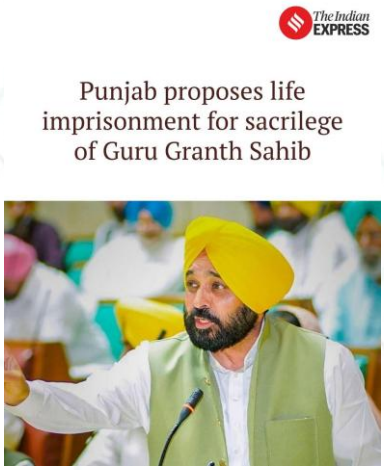
- The Punjab government has decided to construct a glass bridge over Sutlej Lake in Nangal town of the Ropar district of the state.
- This is stated to be North India's first such Glass Bridge.

Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji birth anniversary observed - Prakash Purab

- Recently, the Prime Minister of India offered homage to Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji, a towering spiritual great of our civilization, on the sacred occasion of Parkash Purab.
- In Sikhism, Prakash (light) Purab (day or occasion) refers to the birth anniversaries of Sikh Gurus or significant religious events, symbolising the illumination of spiritual knowledge.
- Guru Tegh Bahadur (1621–1675) was the ninth of ten Gurus of the Sikh religion.
- He was born as Tyaga Mal.
- He came to be known by the name Teg Bahadur (Mighty of The Sword), given to him by Guru Hargobind after he showed his valour in a battle against the Mughals.
- In 1664, Guru Teg Bahadur succeeded Guru Har Krishan Ji as the ninth Sikh Guru.
- He was revered with the honour of 'Hind Di Chadar'.
- He raised an army against the Mughals and introduced the concept of warrior saints.
- He built the city of Anandpur Sahib (in Rupnagar/Ropar district, on the edge of Shivalik Hills, near the Sutlej River, in Punjab).
- His martyrdom is remembered as the Shaheedi Divas of Guru Tegh Bahadur every year on 24 November, according to the Nanakshahi calendar released by the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee in 2003.

The festival of Baisakhi is being celebrated in Punjab

- Baisakhi, also known as Vaisakhi, is the popular spring harvest festival which is celebrated in Northern India, especially by the Sikh/Punjabi community.
- **It is traditionally observed on the first day of the month of Vaishakha in the Hindu solar calendar, which falls in April.**
- The annual festival is observed on April 13 or 14. It marks the Sikh New Year.
- It is primarily a harvest festival, where farmers express gratitude for a good crop yield. It symbolizes prosperity, hard work, and new beginnings.
- It **holds special importance for the Sikh community, as in 1699,** the foundation of the 'Khalsa Panth' or the 'order of the free/pure ones' was laid down on Baisakhi by the tenth Guru of Sikhism, Guru Gobind Singh.
- The **Khalsa was founded by him at Anandpur Sahib, Punjab, in front of thousands.**



Punjab proposes life imprisonment for sacrilege of Guru Granth Sahib

- The Punjab Cabinet approved stringent amendments to an Act on sacrilege, **proposing enhanced penalties, including life imprisonment, to deter incidents of 'beadbi' and uphold the sanctity of Guru Granth Sahib.**
- Also proposes a fine between Rs 5 lakh and Rs 25 lakh.
- There have been several incidents in the past involving 'beadbi' of Sri Guru Granth Sahib and other holy scriptures, which have deeply hurt public sentiments by bruising their psyche and caused unrest in society



Punjab launches Mission Samarth 4.0 with attendance reform

- The Punjab government has officially launched Mission Samarth 4.0, a new phase of its foundational learning flagship program that introduces a state-wide real-time attendance tracking system.
- Parents of students in the state-runs schools will now receive daily SMS alerts regarding their children's attendance
- Already ranked No. 1 in the PARAKH (Performance Assessment, Review, and Analysis of Knowledge for Holistic Development) survey, Punjab is now moving from recognition to results by tightening classroom accountability and scaling proven teaching practices,

Haryana

Ghaggar River

- Recently, **villages situated on the banks of the Ghaggar river in Haryana are witnessing a rise in cancer cases, which is reportedly being attributed to polluted river water.**
- The Ghaggar river is an intermittent river in India and Pakistan that flows only during the monsoon season.
- It **originates in the village of Dagshai in the Shivalik Hills of Himachal Pradesh** at an elevation of 1,927 metres (6,322 ft) above mean sea level.
- The river is known as Ghaggar before the Ottu barrage and as the **Hakra downstream of the barrage.**
- **After passing through the Ambala and Hissar districts of Haryana, it eventually dries up in the Great Indian (Thar) Desert.**

- The Hakra, which flows in Pakistan, is the continuation of the Ghaggar River in India, and they are together called the Ghaggar-Hakra River.
- **Tributaries**: The main tributaries of the Ghaggar are the Kaushalya River, Markanda, Sarsuti, Tangri, and Chautang

Delhi

Delhi–Dehradun Economic Corridor

- **The National Highways Authority of India, in collaboration with Wildlife Institute of India, has released the report Landscapes Reconnected, documenting active wildlife use of underpasses along the Delhi–Dehradun Economic Corridor.**
- The Delhi–Dehradun Economic Corridor is a major greenfield highway and economic connectivity project .
- It is also being recognized as an eco-sensitive infrastructure model, integrating wildlife conservation features within highway development.
- **Located In**: Stretch: Between Ganeshpur and Asharodi
- **Region**: Shivalik landscape

Key Features:

- The corridor includes 97 km of wildlife underpasses across a 20-km eco-sensitive stretch, enabling safe animal crossings.
- It **features one of Asia's largest wildlife elevated corridors**, built at an average height of 6–7 metres for large mammals such as elephants.
- The project uses camera traps, acoustic recorders, and sound studies to improve corridor effectiveness and guide future noise barriers.

CBDT conducts mega outreach with theme 'Bridging Borders, Building Trust' at New Delhi.

- **The Chief Commissioner of Income Tax (International Taxation) North Zone organised a Mega Outreach Programme titled 'Bridging Borders, Building Trust' at New Delhi.**
- The outreach aimed to raise awareness among stakeholders of the provisions of the new Income-tax Act, 2025, the Income-tax Rules, 2026, and the new forms, with an emphasis on International Taxation, Transfer Pricing, and Advance Pricing Agreements.

Uttar Pradesh

Uttar Pradesh launches Jal Pakhwada in schools to promote water conservation

- In Uttar Pradesh, Jal Pakhwada will be organised from **17th April to 30th April** in all schools and educational institutions across the state under the 'Jal Shakti Abhiyan'.
- The government has taken a unique step in the field of water conservation by linking it directly with schools.
- **Through this initiative, lakhs of students will not only become aware of water conservation but will also actively take responsibility for saving water.**
- The effort aims to make water conservation a collective public responsibility, starting from classrooms and extending its impact across society.
- A key feature of the campaign is its robust monitoring system
- **Additionally, a 'water pledge' will be administered daily during school assemblies, and awareness about water conservation will be spread among students and parents to ensure the campaign reaches every household**

Uttar Pradesh top performer under PM's solar power scheme: UPNEDA



- Uttar Pradesh has emerged as the top-performing State under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojna, in March 2026, setting a new national benchmark in rooftop solar deployment.
- With 52,729 installations in a single month, the State has outperformed leading States such as Gujarat and Maharashtra.

PM Surya Ghar-Muft Bijli Yojana?

- About: It is a central scheme to promote the adoption of solar rooftop systems by providing substantial financial subsidies and ensuring ease of installation.
- Objective: It aims to provide free electricity to one crore households in India, who opt to install roof top solar electricity units.
  - The households will be able to get 300 units of electricity free every month.

Gorakhpur's AI-based Flood Warning System



- Gorakhpur's AI-based Urban Flood Management Cell (UFMC) has received appreciation from the Prime Minister's Office and NITI Aayog for its data-driven and proactive flood management model.
- The Urban Flood Management Cell (UFMC) is India's first AI-enabled urban flood early warning and decision support system, established in Gorakhpur, Uttar Pradesh.
- It combines artificial intelligence, real-time sensors, and hydrological modelling to predict rainfall, waterlogging, and flood risks in advance.

Aim:

- To shift urban flood management from a reactive response model to a proactive forecasting model.
- To reduce loss of life, property damage, and urban disruption caused by sudden flooding and waterlogging

Key Features:

- Predicts rainfall and flood risk up to 24 hours in advance with over 80% accuracy.
- Real-time sensors track water levels at drains and hotspots, sending instant alerts when thresholds are crossed.
- Rising water levels automatically activate pumping systems and emergency drainage responses.

Bankey Bihari Temple

- The **Supreme Court recently made it clear that it would not make "any structural changes" to the present arrangement with regard to religious practices at the famous Bankey Bihari temple in Vrindavan.**
- It is a Hindu temple dedicated to Lord Krishna.
- It is located in the holy city of Vrindavan in the Mathura District of Uttar Pradesh.
- 'Banke' means bent, and 'Bihari' refers to Vihari, or enjoyer.
- **At this temple, the primary deity is presented in the 'tribhanga' posture, gracefully tilted at three angles.**
- This distinctive pose, where Lord Krishna is bent at three places, earns Him the beloved name "Banke."
- It **was established by Swami Haridas**, a guru of the famous singer Tansen.

- **Architecture of the temple is influenced by the Rajasthani style.**
- One unique feature of the Banke Bihari temple is that **there are no bells or conchs on the premises.**
- In the freedom struggle, this temple was the main center of revolutionary activities; from here, the revolutionary newspaper "Bundelkhand Kesari" was published secretly

Purvanchal Mahotsav 'Maati-9' Festival



- Speaker of Lok Sabha Om Birla addressed the Purvanchal Mahotsav 'Maati-9' Festival highlighting the region's cultural and spiritual heritage.
- MAATI-9 is a premier cultural festival of the Purvanchal region, centred on the theme Maati (soil).
- It celebrates the deep bond between people and their ancestral roots through heritage, food, tourism, and arts.
- Host: Organised as part of the Purvanchal Mahotsav with participation from cultural groups, artisans, and community representatives.

Tharu Tribe



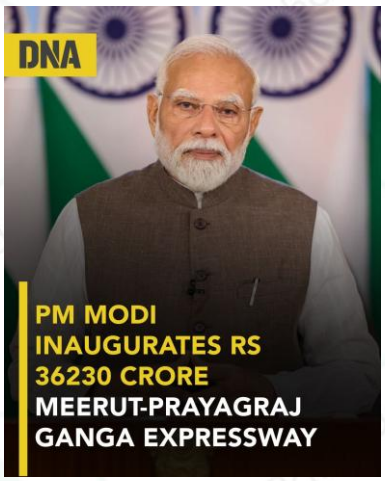
- The Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court **recently set aside a district-level committee's decision to reject the community forest rights claims of the Tharu tribe in Lakhimpur Kheri.**
- The Tharu tribe is one of the indigenous groups living in the Terai plain on the Indo-Nepal border.
- The Tharu are the largest and oldest ethnic group of the Terai region.
- They live in both India and Nepal.
- In the Indian Terai, they live mostly in Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, and Bihar.
- **In 1967, this tribe was documented as a Scheduled Tribe by the Government of India.**
- **Language**: They have their own language called Tharu or Tharuhati, a language of the Indo-Aryan subgroup of the Indo-Iranian group of the Indo-European family.
- **Economy**: Most Tharu practice agriculture, raise cattle, hunt, fish, and collect forest products.
- Most of their food involves rice, lentils, and vegetables.
- **Tharu traditional homes, known as "Badaghar," are made with local materials such as mud, wood, and thatch.**

Society:

- Despite their patrilineal social system, women have property rights greatly exceeding those recognized in Hindu society.
- **Tharu marriages are patrilocal within the tribe.**
- A common feature of the Tharu community is the joint family system of living in long houses.
- Tharus live in compact villages, usually in the middle of a forest clearing.
- The **Panchayat system** (Local Social Council) is very strong in this tribe; the head of the panchayat is called ''Pradhan'' in the local Tharu language.
- **Religion**: The Tharu people practice a unique blend of animism, Hinduism, and nature worship

Ganga Expressway: PM Modi inaugurates 594 km Meerut-Prayagraj industrial corridor

- Prime Minister Narendra Modi **inaugurated the 594-km-long Ganga Expressway, one of the country's longest high-speed corridors,** connecting Meerut to Prayagraj and aimed at transforming connectivity across Uttar Pradesh.
- **Designed for a speed of up to 120 kmph**



- The expressway, **developed as a six-lane corridor with provision for expansion to eight lanes,** is expected to significantly reduce travel time while enabling faster, safer and more efficient movement of people and goods across the state.
- **The expressway will enhance connectivity across 12 key districts -** Meerut, Hapur, Bulandshahr, Amroha, Sambhal, Badaun, Shahjahanpur, Hardoi, Unnao, Rae Bareli, Pratapgarh and Prayagraj
- A key feature of the expressway is a **3.2-km-long airstrip near Shahjahanpur designed for emergency landing of Indian Air Force aircraft.**
- The corridor is also equipped with modern safety and traffic systems, including an Intelligent Traffic Management System (ITMS), CCTV surveillance, emergency call boxes, ambulances and regular patrolling units.
- **The Ganga Expressway will be linked with other major corridors** such as the Purvanchal, Agra-Lucknow, Bundelkhand and Gorakhpur Link expressways

SHORT NEWS

- Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath addressed the **inaugural session of the Northern Region Agriculture Conference in Lucknow on 24th April 2026.**

Madhya Pradesh

"Unnat Krishi Mahotsav 2026: Exhibition and Training" to be held in Raisen from April 11–13



- Union Minister for Agriculture & Farmers Welfare and Rural Development, Shri Shivraj Singh Chouhan, stated that the “Unnat Krishi Mahotsav 2026: Exhibition and Training” to be held in Raisen, Madhya Pradesh from April 11 to 13, .
- The National Agriculture Fair is centered on the powerful themes: “Empowered by Government Schemes, Middleman-Free Markets” and “Secure Harvests, Prosperous Farmers.”

Madhya Pradesh Government forms six-member panel under retired Supreme Court Judge for UCC draft bill



- The Madhya Pradesh Government has hastened the process of implementing the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in the State by constituting a six-member panel headed by a retired Supreme Court Judge to draft a bill recommending provisions within 60 days.
- **Retired Supreme Court judge Justice Ranjana Prasad Desai will head the panel comprising a retired IAS officer, a legal expert, and an academician, among others.**
- **Constitutional Mandate (Article 44)**: UCC is enshrined in the Constitution's Directive Principles, aiming to create a uniform legal framework for civil matters.

About UCC

- A UCC provides for the formulation of one law for the entire country, which would apply to all religious communities in their personal matters such as marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption, and succession.
- Currently, Indian personal law is complex, with each religion adhering to its specific laws.

Personal Laws in India:

- **Hindu Succession Act 1956** governs Hindus, Sikhs, Jains and Buddhists
- **Muslim Personal Law** governs Muslims
- **Indian Succession Act 1925** applies to Christians, Parsis, and Jews
- **The Special Marriage Act provides for the solemnization of interfaith marriage** as well as registration by a Marriage Officer.

Important Judgements and committees recommending UCC

- **Shah Bano Case (1985):** SC Highlighted need for UCC, especially in maintenance matters.
- **Sarla Mudgal Case (1995):** SC Urged UCC for gender equality among religions.
- **Paulo Coutinho vs Maria Luiza Valentina Pereira (2019): SC** Highlights need for uniform laws for consistency.
- **Law Commission (2018)**: No UCC needed now, amend existing laws.
- **Law Commission of India (2022**): It seeks public and religious input on UCC.

Bihar

Govt expands MSP procurement in Chhattisgarh; launches first structured pulse procurement in Bihar

- The Government has significantly expanded procurement operations under the PM-AASHA scheme, with the National Cooperative Consumers' Federation of India Ltd. (NCCF) and the National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India Ltd. (NAFED) playing a central role in Chhattisgarh.
- **The government also launched Bihar's first-ever structured pulse procurement initiative under the Atmanirbhar Pulses Mission.** In a major development, NCCF has initiated organised procurement of masoor (lentil) in Bihar for the first time.

Pradhan Mantri Annadata Aay SanraksHan Abhiyan (PM-AASHA):

- It is an umbrella scheme aimed at ensuring remunerative prices to the farmers for their produce.
- **PM AASHA has three components**, and states can choose whichever one they wish to implement. The three components are:
- **Price Support Scheme (PSS):** In PSS, physical procurement of pulses, oilseeds, and copra will be done by Central Nodal Agencies with the proactive role of state governments.
- **Price Deficiency Payment Scheme (PDPS):** Under PDPS, it is proposed to cover all oilseeds for which MSP is notified.
- **Pilot of Private Procurement and Stockist Schemes (PPPS):** In addition to PDPS, for oilseeds, states have the option to roll out PPSS on a pilot basis in selected districts/Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMCs) of districts involving the participation of private stockist.
- **This scheme will allow private players to participate in the procurement of crops.**

Features of Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses

- **Aim**: Boosting domestic production, reduce import dependence and achieving self-sufficiency (Aatmanirbharta) in pulses by December 2027.
- **Duration**: 6 Years (2025-26 to 2030-31).
- **Ministry**: Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers' Welfare, Government of India
- **Focus Crops**: Tur/Arhar (pigeon pea); Urad (black gram) & Masoor (red lentil).

ASI Begins Excavation at Historic Balirajgarh Site Bihar



- Recently, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has begun excavation at Bihar's historic Balirajgarh site.
- Location: It is located in the Madhubani district of Bihar.
- It holds great mythological and historical significance, with local folklore identifying it as the capital of the legendary King Bali.
- It is believed that this site served as a major administrative hub of the ancient Videha Kingdom.
- In 1938 Archeological Survey of India declared the site of national importance under the Ancient Monuments Preservation Act of 1904.
- Previous Excavation: it has been excavated in five phases from 1962 to 2014.
- During excavation, antiquities of five phases of cultural periods, namely Northern Black soil, Sunga, Kushan,Gupta and later Pala period were discovered.

Jharkhand

Subarnarekha River



- **The Indian Army safely neutralised a high-risk World War II-era bomb weighing approximately 227 kg recovered from the Subarnarekha River in East Singhbhum.**
- The Subarnarekha is a major rain-fed river in eastern India, known as the lifeline of the tribal communities in the Chhota Nagpur region.
- **Its name is derived from the Sanskrit words Subarna (gold) and Rekha (line/streak), referring to the tradition of finding gold particles in its sandy bed.**
- It originates near Piska/Nagri, close to Ranchi, the capital of Jharkhand.
- The river traverses three Indian states: Jharkhand, West Bengal, and Odisha.
- After flowing for a total length of 395 km, it joins the Bay of Bengal near Talsari in Odisha.

Chhattisgarh

Chhattisgarh cabinet approves constitution of high-level committee to prepare draft of Uniform Civil Code



- The Chhattisgarh government has decided to constitute a high-level committee to prepare a draft of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) for its implementation in the state.
- The decision was taken at a cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai in Raipur.
- **Retired judge Ranjana Prakash Desai will lead the panel, while the chief minister has been authorised to nominate its members.**
- Currently, issues such as marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption, maintenance, and family disputes in Chhattisgarh are governed by different personal laws based on religion.
- **Article 44 of the Constitution of India directs the state to work towards implementing a Uniform Civil Code for all citizens.**

Odisha

Kendu Leaf

- Recently, it was observed that tribal communities in Odisha's Koraput fight for their legal rights over kendu leaves for a third consecutive year.
- **Kendu leaf (Tendu Leaf, Diospyros Melanoxylon) is also called "Green Gold of Odisha".**
- It is a nationalized product like Bamboo and Sal seed.
- Kendu leaf is one of the most important non-wood forest products of Odisha.
- It **has a matching aroma with tobacco.**
- **Used to roll tobacco into bidis** (local cigarettes); also holds medicinal value.
- **Key Producer States:** Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Gujarat.
- **Odisha is the third-largest producer after MP and Chhattisgarh.**
- The uniqueness of Odisha Kendu leaves is its processed form. No state produces processed kendu leaves except Odisha.
- Kendu Leaf is covered under Minor Forest Produce (MFP) as per Forest Rights Act (FRA), 2006.

Textiles Ministry launches 'Vishwa Sutra' to promote Indian handlooms globally

- The Vishwa Sutra collection recently made its debut at the **61st Femina Miss India in Bhubaneswar, showcasing 30 distinct Indian handloom weaves** reimagined through the cultural lenses of 30 different countries.
- Vishwa Sutra is a first-of-its-kind designer collection that positions Indian handlooms within a modern, global design
- **It features 30 state-specific weaves from across India, each artistically paired with design sensibilities, silhouettes, and cultural elements from 30 different nations.**

Launched By:

- **Office of the Development Commissioner (Handlooms):** Under the Ministry of Textiles, Government of India.
- **National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT):** Collaborating as the academic and design partner.

Key Features:

- **30-30 Framework:** 30 weaves representing 30 Indian states were inspired by 30 different countries.

Innovative Pairings: The collection showcases unique combinations such as:

- Odisha Ikat with Greek forms.
- Kanchipuram with Norwegian lines.
- Muga Silk with Egyptian elements.
- Patola with Spanish influences.
- Banarasi with UAE-inspired ensembles.

ASI begins drilling into Konark Sun Temple to remove 100-year-old British-era sand

- The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has begun drilling a passage into the Jagamohan (assembly hall) of the 13th-century Konark Sun Temple, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, to remove sand packed inside by the British over a century ago.
- **It is located on the coastline of Odisha in the Puri district.**
- Also called the Surya Devalaya, the temple is dedicated to the Hindu sun god Surya.



- Textual evidence indicates that **Narasimha I (who reigned between 1238 and 1264) of the Eastern Ganga dynasty built the temple in 1250 CE.**
- It was designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1984
- It is a classic example of the Odisha style of architecture, or Kalinga architecture
- The **temple is designed in the shape of a colossal chariot.**
- The temple complex has the appearance of a 100-foot-high solar chariot, with 24 wheels and pulled by six horses, all carved from stone
- **The wheels of the temple are sundials, which can be used to calculate time accurately to a minute.**
- **The temple was constructed using three types of stones** – the laterite stone for the boundary walls, flooring, and staircase; Khondalite for the structure; and Chlorite stone for the door jams and lintel
- **The temple was called Black Pagoda, attributed to its dark facade, by the Europeans who used it for navigation for their ships.**
- The temple remains a site of contemporary worship for Hindus, during the annual Chandrabhaga Festival, around the month of February.

Lanjia Saora Tribe



- It is observed that among the younger members of the Lanjia Saora Tribe community, tradition is being reinterpreted and negotiating modernity on its own terms.
- **Saora is one of the ancient tribes of Odisha and categorized as a particularly vulnerable tribal group.**
- **Other names**: Savaras, Sabaras, Saura, Sora, etc.
- A small number of people are also found in the states of Andhra Pradesh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, and Assam.
- **Language**: They have their own native language called Sora, which is a Munda language, and they are one of the very few tribes of India that have a script for the language, Sorang Sompeng.
- **They show their racial affinity to the Proto Australoid physical characters.**
- They are living in mud-and-thatch homes scattered across undulating terrain.
- The community sustains itself through shifting cultivation, foraging, and small-scale farming.
- Saoras follow an ingrained and intricate religion, having faith in and worshipping a number of gods and spirits, who they believe are the supreme controllers of their regular lives.
- **They have unique art practices, religious customs, as well as a dying tattooing tradition called 'Tantangbo'.**
- Their belief system is closely tied to nature, with rituals, music, and dance forming an integral part of everyday life.
- **Among the most distinctive visual traditions are their large metal earrings —** thick, circular ornaments that are not merely worn but fixed into stretched earlobes, often over years.
- Village guardian deities like Kitungsum are installed at the entrance of the settlement

The Sijimali Bauxite Mine





- Recent violent clashes between tribal villagers and police in Odisha's Rayagada district have left dozens injured following protests against the construction of an approach road for the Sijimali bauxite mine.
- Sijimali is a massive high-grade bauxite reserve that was handed over to Vedanta Limited in 2023 through a government auction.
- The project is currently in its early development stages, having recently received conditional Stage-1 forest clearance from the Central government.
- Located in: The mine covers an area of 1,500 hectares and is spread across the Rayagada and Kalahandi districts of Odisha. I
- It is situated within the Eastern Ghats hill ranges.
- Odisha is the undisputed leader in India's bauxite sector, serving as the backbone of the country's aluminium industry.
- The state's mineral wealth extends beyond bauxite to include significant deposits of iron ore, coal, and nickel.

Resource Data:

- National Share: Odisha accounts for 41% of India's total bauxite resources.
- Production Leader: As of 2021-22, the state contributed approximately 73% of India's total bauxite production.
- Overall Mineral Wealth: The state holds nearly 17% of India's total mineral reserves.

Juang Tribe Girl Leads Change Against Child Marriage



- A 16-year-old Juang tribal girl in Odisha changed the entire mindset of a village related to child health and child marriage.
- Juang is one of the 13 particularly vulnerable tribal groups (PVTGs) of the total 62 tribes found in Odisha.
- They are primarily concentrated in the current districts of Keonjhar and Dhenkanal in Odisha.
- Language: Linguistically, they converse in the Juang language, a member of the Munda family within the Austroasiatic languages.
- The Juangs are known for their clan structure and kinship organisations.
- Occupation: Initially reliant on hunting, gathering, and limited cultivation, the declaration of their forests as reserves during the British colonial era prompted a shift in traditional customs.
- Adapting to these changes, the Juang people showcased expertise in basket-weaving, exchanging their products with neighboring caste villages for essentials like salt, oil, and food.
- Clothing: Historically known as Patuas or "leaf-wearers," Juang women adorned leaf girdles, while men wore small loincloths.
- Beliefs: Although they have some Hindu beliefs, Juangs practice mostly ancient animistic rituals.
- Their supreme god is the sun god. However, they have also adopted the Hindu deities in addition to tribal gods and goddesses.

Sikkim

Sikkim Sundari Radio Boosts Border Connectivity



- **The Indian Army has launched "Sikkim Sundari", the first community radio station in a border village of Sikkim.**
- The initiative, led by the Trishakti Corps, aims to bridge information gaps and empower local communities living near sensitive border areas.
- **"Sikkim Sundari" has been established to provide timely access to essential information in geographically isolated regions.**
- The station will broadcast local news, weather updates, and details of government schemes, ensuring that residents remain informed despite challenging terrain and limited connectivity infrastructure.

Operation HimSetu: Army battles heavy snow to rescue hundreds in North Sikkim after bridge collapse near Tarum Chu

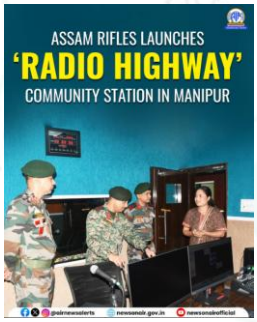




- The Army's Eastern Command launched a major rescue mission, Operation HimSetu, on Wednesday to evacuate over a thousand tourists stranded in North Sikkim after a series of massive landslides and a bridge collapse severed vital road links
- the Trishakti Corps has successfully rescued 135 tourists from the Lachen area, prioritising those with medical emergencies,

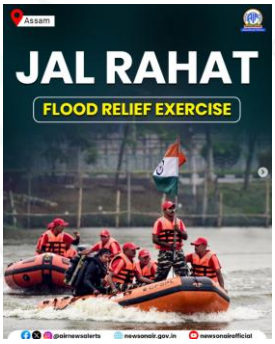
Assam

Assam Rifles launches a Community Radio Station at Pallel Garrison in Manipur



- The station, named "Radio Highway" with the tagline "Pallel ki Vaani," was established under Operation Sadbhavana.
- **Its primary goal is to bridge communication gaps in remote areas of Manipur where difficult terrain and limited mobile connectivity present significant challenge**
- The station provides essential updates including local news, weather reports, and information on government welfare schemes.

Joint flood relief exercise in Assam, Guwahati



- The Indian Army conducted a large-scale joint flood relief exercise, "Exercise Jal Rahat," at the Indian Institute of Technology Guwahati.
- The **exercise was organised by the Red Horns Division under the Gajraj Corps** to strengthen preparedness for flood-related emergencies in the region.
- The drill brought together personnel from the Army, National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), and the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB), demonstrating coordinated rescue operations and inter-agency synergy.
- The **exercise focused on operational modalities during flood situations,** including evacuation protocols, deployment of advanced technology, and rapid response coordination.

Rongali Bihu Celebrations Mark Assamese New Year Festivities



- It is one of the major festivals of Assam which is commonly known as Bohag bihu.
- It is the most popular Bihu that celebrates the onset of the Assamese New Year and the coming of spring.

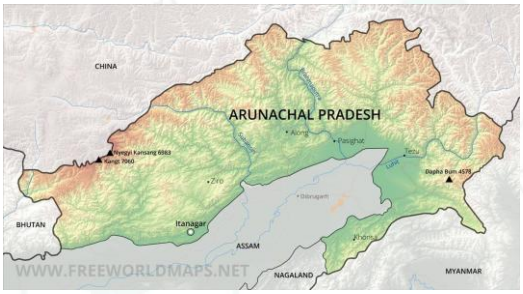
- The word 'Rongali' is derived from 'Rong' which means Happiness and celebrations.
- This festival reflects the rich culture of Assamese society.
- During the celebration, traditional pat or muga silk or cotton mekhela chadors are worn by ladies (the two-piece attire).
- As a sign of affection and respect, gamocha, the traditional Assamese towel, also known as Bihuwaan, is exchanged

Key Facts about Bihu

- Bihu is celebrated by people from all parts of Assam irrespective of caste, creed or religious background.
- The first Bihu is known as the Rongali Bihu or Bohag Bihu, which is celebrated in the month of April.
- The second Bihu is known as Kati Bihu or Kongali Bihu, which is celebrated during the month of October
- Finally there is Magh Bihu, which is observed during the month of January

Arunachal Pradesh

Arunachal Pradesh



- India has officially rejected China's latest attempt to rename places in Arunachal Pradesh, labeling it a mischievous attempt to manufacture baseless narratives.
- **The primary dispute stems from China's refusal to recognize India's sovereignty over Arunachal Pradesh.**
- Beijing periodically engages in standardizing names for locations within the state—the most recent instance occurring in April 2026—to create a digital and cartographic record of its claims.

China's Claims:

- **Zangnan**: China refers to the state as Zangnan (South Tibet) and claims it as part of the Tibet Autonomous Region.
- **Beijing argues that the region has historical and cultural ties to Tibet**, particularly the Tawang region, which is home to a prominent Buddhist monastery.
- **The McMahon Line**: China rejects the McMahon Line (the 1914 boundary between British India and Tibet), calling it an illegal colonial imposition.
- **The state finds mention in the Mahabharata and Kalika Purana as the Prabhu Mountains.**
- Legend holds that Lord Krishna married Rukmini here and Sage Vyasa meditated in its hills.
- **Until 1972, the region was administratively known as the North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA).**
  - **January 20, 1972**: Became a Union Territory and was renamed Arunachal Pradesh.
  - **February 20, 1987**: Attained full statehood as the 24th state of the Indian Union.
- **Archaeological Heritage**: Remains at sites like Ita Fort (14th century) and Bhismaknagar testify to its ancient civilization.
- **Capital**: Itanagar.
- **Neighboring Indian States**: Assam and Nagaland.
- **International Borders:** Bhutan (West), Myanmar (East), and China/Tibet (North).

Cabinet approves two hydro-electric projects in Arunachal Pradesh



- The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) approved investing ₹26,069.5 crore for the construction of Kamala Hydro Electric project, alongside an investment of ₹14,105.83 crore to construct the Kalai-II hydro-electric project.
- Cumulatively, infusing about ₹40,176 crore to construct two major hydroelectric power projects in the northeastern state.
- The Kamala Hydro-electric project would account for a total installed capacity of 1,720 megawatts and is expected to generate 6,870 million units of energy annually.
- It spans across Kamle, Kra Daadi and Kurung Kumey districts of Arunachal Pradesh.
- The project, which is expected to complete in eight years, is a joint venture between state-owned National Hydroelectric Power Corporation (NHPC) and the government of Arunachal Pradesh.
- The Kalai-II hydro-electric project, would house an installed capacity of 1,200 MW and would be able to generate 4,852.95 million units of energy annually.
- It is being implemented a joint venture between mini-ratna THDC India Ltd and the state government.
- From both the projects individually, Arunachal Pradesh would be receiving 12% free power and an additional 1% earmarked for the Local Area Development Fund (LADF).

Nagaland

Indigenous knowledge: Researchers decode cancer-fighting potential of traditional Konyak Naga herbal medicine





- Researchers in a preliminary investigation, identified traditional herbal formulation **used by the Konyak tribe of Nagaland for its anti-cancer potential, providing valuable scientific insight into indigenous medicinal practices.**
- The Konyaks can be found in the Mondistrict of Nagaland and also in the Tirap and Changlang districts of Arunachal.
- The **term 'Konyak' is believed to have been derived from the words 'Whao' meaning 'head' and 'Nyak' meaning 'black' translating to 'men with black hair'.**
- The **Konyaks are of Mongoloid origin** and about 95% of the population follows the Christian faith now.
- Traditionally, facial and body tattoos were closely linked to social status and life achievements.
- They **speak the Konyak language belonging to the Northern Naga sub branch of the Sal subfamily of Sino-Tibetan.**
- The Konyak society is a patriarchal society and the eldest son of the family usually inherits the paternal property.
- **Festivals occupy an important place in the lives of the Konyaks**. The three most significant festivals were Aolingmonyu, Aonyimo and Laoun-ongmo.
- They are skilled in the art of making firearms. They are also skilled in handicrafts like basket making, cane and bamboo works, brass works etc.

Manipur

Manipur observes Khongjom Day at War Memorial Complex



- On **23rd April**, Manipur observed Khongjom Day **at the Khongjom War Memorial Complex** in **Thoubal District.**
- The event was **graced by Governor Ajay Kumar Bhalla.**
- Every year, Khongjom Day is observed on April 23 to **commemorate the valour and sacrifice of Manipuri heroes** who laid down their lives in the **historic Anglo-Manipuri War of 1891.**

Anglo- Manipuri War of 1891



- During the war, the tiny **kingdom of Manipur fought against the British colonial expansion**, and many people lost their lives
- **Major Paona Brajabashi** was the **commander who led the Manipuri Army** against the British columns coming from Myanmar.
- Despite their brave efforts **Manipur lost its sovereignty to the British,** and it became a princely state under tighter British control.
- Later, on **August 13, 1891, Yubraj Tikendrajit and Thangal General**, two martyrs of Manipur, were **hanged in front of the public at Pheidabung**, now known as **Bir Tikendrajit Park.**
- This was a shocking incident for the people of Manipur. Every year on **August 13**, the **Manipuris observe Patriots' Day** as a tribute to those martyrs.

Meghalaya

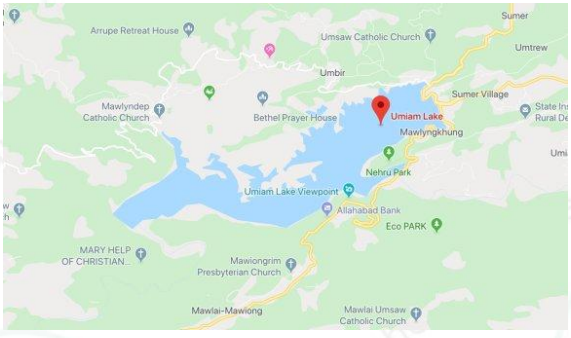
Kulsi River

- A **proposed hydropower project on the Kulsi River is facing opposition from local residents.**
- It is a **south-bank tributary of the Brahmaputra River.**

Course:

- It is composed of three rivers, namely Khri, Krishniya, and Umsiri, all of which originate from the West Khasi hill ranges of Meghalaya from an elevation of over 1800 metres and flow north.
- **The river is known as Khri in the upper catchments, and after being joined by two other tributaries, namely Krishniya and Umsiri, within the Khasi hills in Meghalaya, it flows northwest and enters Assam at Ukium.**
- **Finally, it outflows into the Brahmaputra near Nagarbera.**
- The total length of Kulsi is about 220 km, out of which 100 km is in Meghalaya and the rest, 120 km, is in Assam.
- **It is considered one of the last refuges of the endangered Gangetic dolphin (Platanista gangetica gangetica) in Assam.**

Umiam Lake



- The Meghalaya government recently announced that **Lumpongdeng Island in the middle of Umiam Lake will be kept out of the proposed luxury resort project, following protests and concerns raised by local stakeholders**.
- **Umiam Lake**, also known as **Barapani Lake,** is a **man-made reservoir** in the state of Meghalaya 15 km north of Shillong, the capital of Meghalaya.

- **It was created in 1965 as part of the Umiam Umtru Hydroelectric Power Project, which was the first hydroelectric project in Northeast India.**
- The project was initiated by the Assam State Electricity Board (ASEB) with the assistance of the Government of India and the Canadian International Development Agency (CIDA).
- The project involved the construction of a dam across the **Umiam River, which is a tributary of the Brahmaputra River.**

Meghalaya Grants Official Status to Khasi and Garo

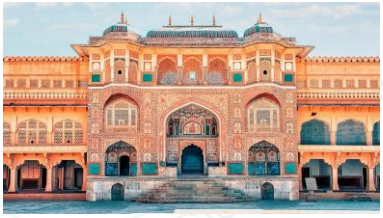


- The Meghalaya cabinet announced the indigenous Khasi and Garo languages as the official languages of the state, in addition to English.
- The approval of the Meghalaya Official Languages Ordinance, 2026 by the state cabinet.
- **The move comes amid a long-standing demand for the inclusion of Khasi and Garo – the languages of the state's two largest tribes – in the Eight Schedule of the Constitution.** Currently, all official business in the state is carried out in English
- In due course, necessary amendments will also be made to relevant acts, including the Meghalaya State Legislature (Continuance of English Language) Act, 1980.
- **Once these amendments are completed, legislators will be able to speak and debate in Khasi and Garo during assembly sessions, alongside English,".**

Rajasthan

Amber Fort





- The Rajasthan High Court, while hearing a plea against **alleged illegal elephant rides near Amber Fort, recently issued notices to the state govt. and multiple respondents.**
- Amber Fort, also known as Amer Fort, is located in Amer, a town located approximately 11 kilometers from the city of Jaipur in Rajasthan.
- It **was constructed atop a hill.** It was originally **built by Raja Man Singh I**, the Kachwaha Rajput ruler, in the late 16th century.
- **Man Singh was one of the trusted generals of Emperor Akbar** and one among the Navaratnas of his court.
- **Prior to shifting their capital to Jaipur, Amer was the capital of the Kachhwaha Rajputs.**
- It underwent significant expansion and renovation under the reign of Jai Singh I as he is credited with constructing the impressive Diwan-i-Khas (Hall of Private Audience) and the Sheesh Mahal (Mirror Palace) within the fort complex.
- **It is a UNESCO World Heritage Site**. **Its architecture is a noteworthy fusion of Rajput (Hindu) and Mughal (Islamic) styles.** It was built using pink and yellow sandstones.

Centre approves Jaipur Metro Project Phase-2 costing over ₹13,000 crore



- The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved the Jaipur Metro Project Phase-2, a 41-km corridor comprising 36 stations, at a total project cost of over Rs 13,000 crore,
- The project will be implemented by the Rajasthan Metro Rail Corporation Limited (RMRCL), a 50:50 joint venture of the government of India and the government of Rajasthan.

Gujarat

Narcotics Analysis & RAG-based Investigation Tool (NARIT-AI)



- **The Gujarat Police has introduced** the Narcotics Analysis & RAG-based Investigation Tool (NARIT-AI) **to address declining conviction rates in drug-related cases**, which fell to 25% in 2022.
- NARIT-AI is a specialized, private artificial intelligence system designed to assist law enforcement officers in the investigation and prosecution of complex narcotics cases.
- **it operates within a closed environment specifically trained on Indian legal statutes and judicial precedents.**
- To ensure that investigating officers (IOs) adhere strictly to the primacy of procedure required by the NDPS Act, where even minor lapses can lead to acquittals.
- The **tool utilizes Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) technology**.
- Instead of searching the open internet, it references a specific data library containing the NDPS Act, the three new criminal laws (BNS, BNSS, BSA), and thousands of Supreme Court and High Court judgments.

India's First Water-Neutral Railway Depot



- Kankaria Coaching Depot in Ahmedabad has become India's first 'water-neutral' railway depot **by recycling wastewater used in coach washing and maintenance.**
- The Kankaria Coaching Depot in Ahmedabad, Gujarat, is the first railway depot in India to achieve water neutrality by treating and reusing wastewater generated during routine railway coach cleaning and maintenance.
- It **minimizes freshwater dependency by ensuring that almost all operational water demand is met through recycled water, promoting sustainable railway infrastructure.**

Key Features:

- The depot **uses phytoremediation**, an eco-friendly process where specially selected plants naturally absorb pollutants and purify wastewater before reuse.
- **Wastewater passes through wetland treatment**, followed by carbon filtration, sand filtration, and ultraviolet (UV) disinfection to ensure safe and efficient reuse.

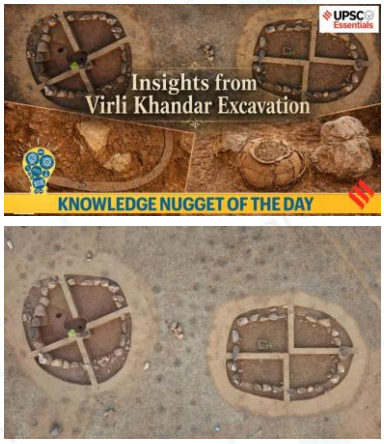
India Approves First Semiconductor SEZ at Dholera

- The government has cleared a special economic zone (SEZ) **for the country's first semiconductor fabrication plant, to boost efforts to develop a domestic chip manufacturing base and reduce import dependence.**

- The newly notified SEZ has been granted to Tata Semiconductor Manufacturing Private Ltd, which plans to invest around Rs 91,000 crore in the project.
- **Spread over 66.16 hectares, the facility at Dholera in Gujarat** is expected to create nearly 21,000 jobs.

Maharashtra

Virli Khandar Excavation



- An ongoing excavation at a megalithic site in Virli Khandar has revealed distinctive burial architecture, rare artefacts and unusual pottery arrangements, offering fresh insights into ancient funerary practices in Vidarbha.
- **The site, located in Pauni tehsil of Bhandara district, in Maharashtra is currently being excavated**
- **The site was selected for three reasons**, including its unique burial pattern, stone circles and within them menhirs, making it a composite megalithic structure — a combination of two burial types
- **Significant artifacts have been recovered from one of the burials, including copper objects such as a necklace, iron implements like axes, chisels, ladles and arrowheads, semi-precious stone beads, notably etched** carnelian beads, and a gold earring.
- Fragmentary bone remains have also been recovered alongside these finds.

What are menhirs?

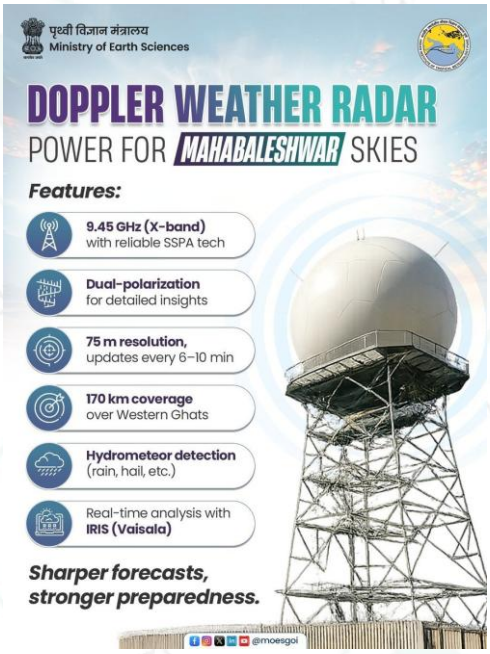
- A menhir is a standing or an upright stone, which is usually tapered at the top.
- **It is man-made, in that it is sculpted and placed by humans, and usually quite large.**
- The largest surviving menhir, the Grand Menhir Brisé or the Great Broken Menhir in Brittany, France, once stood at 20.6 m tall.
- The term 'menhir' is derived from the Brittonic "maen" meaning "stone", and "hîr" meaning "long", and entered the archaeological lexicon in the late 18th century. **It was first used by French military officer**

Maharashtra to launch first stargazing fest at Lonar Crater



- The Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation (MTDC) has launched the **Khagol Darshan Mahotsav 2026, the state's first-ever stargazing festival.**
- The event is taking place at **Lonar Crater in Buldhana and Harihareshwar in Raigad from April 24 to 26, 2026.**
- AstronEra, which focuses on protecting Maharashtra's night skies through research, policy, and community outreach, has partnered with the Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation (MTDC) to host a stargazing festival for the first time in the state.
- **AstronEra is an endorsed partner of Dark Sky International, an organisation that certifies and assists in the conservation of starry sky parks, communities, and other locations worldwide.**
- The Dark Sky movement focuses on protecting areas with minimal light pollution, which allows for clear views of the stars and the cosmos.
- This **initiative coincides with the International Dark Sky Week (from April 13 to 20)** that is being observed for the first time in the state. It encourages citizens worldwide to 'Go Dark' by reducing light pollution.

IITM Pune Inaugurates X-Band Doppler Weather Radar at Mahabaleshwar under Mission Mausam



- The Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM), Pune, under the Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES), inaugurated a state-of-the-art X-band Dual-Polarization Doppler Weather Radar at the High Altitude Cloud Physics Laboratory (HACPL), Mahabaleshwar, under Mission Mausam
- **Strategically installed at an altitude of approximately 1400 metres above mean sea level in the Western Ghats, the radar will function as a "weather eye in the sky," continuously scanning the atmosphere to track rainfall, clouds, and storm systems in real time.**
- It will play a crucial role in monitoring rapidly changing local weather conditions in Mahabaleshwar, a region known for sudden rainfall, fog, and strong winds.
- Its dual-polarization capability provides **detailed insights into cloud microphysics, including precipitation characteristics, drop size distribution, and storm structure.**

Maharashtra launches rural health push to plug service gaps



- The Maharashtra government on April 1 rolled out the '**Mazhe Gaav, Aarogya Sampann Gaav' (My Village, Health-Prosperous Village) campaign**, a statewide initiative to bolster rural healthcare delivery and expand access to public health services.
- The programme is being implemented by the Public Health Department .
- the campaign will prioritise awareness generation and last-mile delivery of government health services in rural areas.

DRI Mumbai busts gold smuggling syndicate in Op Dhahabu Blitz

- DRI Mumbai busts gold smuggling syndicate in Op Dhahabu Blitz; approx. 30 kg gold worth ₹38 crore seized, 24 women carriers arrested
- Under Operation Dhahabu Blitz, 24 foreign nationals were intercepted.
- In a major crackdown on organised gold smuggling, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), has busted a syndicate, seizing 29.37 kg of gold valued at Rs 37.74 crore and arresting 24 carriers.

Elephanta Island

- The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has unearthed a 1,500-year-old T-shaped stepped reservoir on Elephanta Island, highlighting advanced ancient water management.
- Elephanta Island, locally known as Gharapuri (City of Caves), is a UNESCO World Heritage site located in the Mumbai Harbour.
- It is world-renowned for its majestic rock-cut cave temples, primarily dedicated to the Hindu god Shiva, which represent the pinnacle of Indian rock-cut art and sculpture.

Recent Discovery

- A T-shaped massive structure (14.7m long) built with imported stone blocks from the mainland, used to combat the island's rocky runoff and store monsoon water.
- A dyeing vat for textiles and large storage pots suggest the island was an industrial and commercial center, not just a religious site.
- Over 3,000 sherds of Mediterranean amphorae and West Asian torpedo jars prove that the island had maritime links with Rome and Mesopotamia.

- The discovery of 60 coins, including silver and copper coins of King Krishnaraja (Kalachuri dynasty), helps firmly date the island's peak activity to the 6th century CE.
- Original Name: Local inhabitants called it Gharapuri.
- The name Elephanta was given by Portuguese explorers in the 16th century after they found a massive monolithic stone elephant near the island's landing area.
- The 6th-century excavations (including the recent coins of King Krishnaraja) suggest the Kalachuris were the primary patrons of the main caves.
- Konkan Mauryas: Historical records suggest they ruled the region before the Kalachuris.



Key Characteristics of Elephanta:

- Main Cave (Cave 1): A sprawling 60,000-square-foot rock-cut temple featuring a complex layout of halls, pillars, and shrines.
- Sadashiva (Trimurti): The most iconic sculpture on the island, a 20-foot high masterpiece depicting Shiva as the Creator, Preserver, and Destroyer.
- Gangadhara & Ardhanarishvara: Elaborate relief panels depicting the descent of the Ganges and the union of Shiva and Parvati as half-male and half-female.
- Geological Composition: The caves are carved out of solid basalt rock, typical of the Deccan Trap formations.
- Dual Religious Influence: While primarily Shaivite (Hindu), there are also smaller groups of Buddhist stupas on the island, indicating a syncretic religious history

Goa

SAMPANN Platform



- Recently, the Goa government and the Cochin Port Authority have taken a significant step towards modernizing pension disbursement by signing agreements to onboard the SAMPANN digital platform.
- SAMPANN (System for Accounting and Management of Pension) is the flagship digital pension and financial management platform of the Department of Telecommunications.
- It is managed by the Office of the Controller General of Communication Accounts (CGCA).
- It was launched on 29th December, 2018.
- It provides direct credit of pension into the bank accounts of pensioners.

Features of SAMPANN Platform

- It is a cloud-based, end-to-end pension management system of the Department of Telecommunications.
- Direct disbursement of pension on a timely basis without intermediaries
- Single window system for complete pension process
- Online grievance management for the pensioners, reducing paperwork
- Tracking of pension status from home encourages transparency and accountability.

Commonwealth Parliamentary Association

- Recently, the Commonwealth Parliamentary Association India Region Zone VII Conference was inaugurated in Goa by the Lok Sabha Speaker.

- Commonwealth Parliamentary Association is one of the oldest established organisations in the Commonwealth.
- It was founded in 1911.
- It is a membership association which brings together Members, who are united by community of interest, respect for the rule of law and individual rights and freedoms.
- The Association is made up of over 180 Legislatures (or Branches) divided up between nine geographic regions of the Commonwealth.
- Its mission is to promote the advancement of parliamentary democracy by enhancing knowledge and understanding of democratic governance, youth engagement in democracy, gender equality and equal representation.
- Headquarters: London, United Kingdom
- It comprises a total of 32 Legislatures, After the Africa Region, India has the largest number of member Branches of the CPA.

Administratively, the CPA India Region is divided into 9 zones.

- Zone 1: Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand
- Zone 2: Delhi, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, Punjab
- Zone 3: Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim, Tripura
- Zone 4: Odisha, West Bengal
- Zone 5: Bihar, Jharkhand
- Zone 6: Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan
- Zone 7: Goa, Gujarat, Maharashtra
- Zone 8: Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Telangana
- Zone 9: Kerala, Puducherry (UT), Tamil Nadu
- The CPA India Regional Chairperson: Lok Sabha Speaker, Parliament of India
- Secretariat: It is based within the Lok Sabha at the Parliament of India

Telangana

Operation Octopus 2.0: 52 arrested, including 32 bank officials, in pan-India cyber fraud crackdown by Hyderabad Police

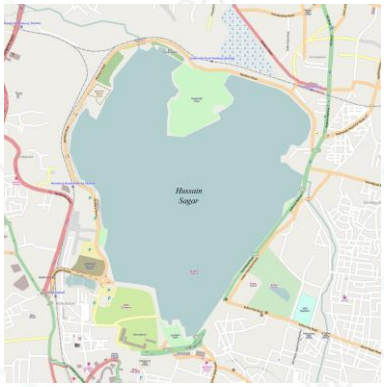
- **Hyderabad City Police** arrested 52 persons, including 32 bank officials, in a coordinated multi-state crackdown on organised cyber fraud networks under 'Operation Octopus 2.0',
- Carried out across nine States over seven days, targeting bank officials, mule account holders and intermediaries allegedly involved in facilitating large-scale cyber frauds.

Telangana launches 'Spandana', an all-women response system to enhance safety for women and children



- The Telangana government launched 'Spandana', an all-women first responder system aimed at strengthening safety measures for women and children in the city.
- **The system has been introduced to enable women in distress to communicate more freely with female police personnel**, while also reinforcing the existing Dial 100 and 112 emergency response systems.
- Police said that upon receiving a distress call related to women or child safety, the information would be immediately relayed to the designated Spandana team in the respective zone, which would reach the location within minutes.

Hussain Sagar Lake



- Hussain Sagar lake is **emitting a strong foul odour as rising summer temperatures trigger heavy algal bloom.**
- It is an artificial lake located in Hyderabad, Telangana.
- It is also called Tank Bund and lies on a tributary of River Musi.
- It **spreads across an area of 5.7 sq.km. It is one of the largest man-made lakes in Asia.**
- **It is the largest heart-shaped mark among the marks** formed by 78 heart-shaped lakes and 9 heart-shaped islands on the face of the earth.
- The **United Nations World Tourism Organisation has named the lake "Heart of the World".**
- It was constructed in 1562 AD during the reign of Ibrahim Quli Qutb Shah, the fourth ruler of the Qutb Shahi dynasty.
- The lake was named after Hussain Shah Wali, the chief engineer who designed and supervised its construction.
- **It is renowned for its monolith of Lord Buddha that stands right in its centre.** It has a height of 16 m and weighs almost 350 tonnes.
- It had been of significance in the early days since it connected the twin cities of Hyderabad and Secunderabad.
- It was **initially built to cater to the irrigation needs and other water needs of the city**. Until the year of 1930, it was used for the same purpose.
- Indira Park, Lumbini Park, and Sanjeevaiah Park surround the lake on three sides.
- **Over the years, Hussain Sagar Lake has become polluted through the entry of untreated sewage and industrial effluents through the nalas that flow into the lake**

Telangana Police launches AI-enabled EAGLE Force website to combat drug abuse

- The Telangana Police launched an AI-enabled website for the Elite Action Group for Drug Law Enforcement (EAGLE Force), aimed at strengthening public participation and enhancing the State's anti-drug efforts.
- The website introduces a suite of artificial intelligence-driven tools focused on prevention and early intervention.
- Among them is 'Sahay AI', a chatbot designed to answer drug-related queries,
- 'Shield AI', which helps individuals assess their risk related to substance use, and
- 'Mitra TG', a screening tool aimed at helping parents and teachers identify early signs of substance abuse among teenagers.

Cyberabad Police launch 'Arrive Alive' campaign, stress road safety

- Cyberabad Police , Hyderabad, Telangana launched the 'Arrive Alive' campaign in Gachibowli, aimed at preventing road accidents and promoting safe travel among motorists and pedestrians.
- **The top priority for police is to ensure that every citizen reaches home safely and stressed that road safety is a shared responsibility.**

Telangana Govt Declares Cancer a Notifiable Disease to Strengthen Surveillance

- The Telangana government has issued orders making cancer a notifiable disease, mandating compulsory registration and reporting of all diagnosed cases across the State as part of a move to strengthen surveillance and public health response.

What are notifiable diseases?

- It is any disease that is required by law to be reported to government authorities.
  - Responsibility of notifying any disease and the implementation lies with the state government.
  - The collation of information allows the authorities to monitor the disease, and provides early warning of possible outbreaks.
- Other notified diseases: AIDS, hepatitis, dengue, etc.

'Operation Chabutra' on Hyderabad streets

- The initiative titled Operation Chabutra is being carried out across Hyderabad, Telangana particularly in the south and Old City areas, where police say complaints of harassment, intimidation and petty crime tend to surface after midnight.
- The operation involves intensified patrolling and surprise crackdowns on groups of youths gathering on streets after midnight.
- The term 'chabutra' itself reflects a long-standing social culture in parts of the Old City, where residents, particularly youth, gather on raised platforms or 'arugu' during summer nights.

Andhra Pradesh

Araku Old Seed Festival Promotes Tribal Biodiversity



- **The 17th annual Old Seed Festival held in Killoguda village of the Araku region in Andhra Pradesh** highlighted the importance of conserving indigenous seed diversity and strengthening natural farming practices.
- **Organised by the Sanjeevini organisation,**
- Farmers from Araku, Rampachodavaram, the Nilgiris in Tamil Nadu, and Koraput in Odisha participated in the festival

Facts for Exams

- **Dhimsa is a traditional tribal dance performed mainly by Adivasi communities in the Araku Valley** region of Andhra Pradesh.
- **Koraput in Odisha** is known for its rich agrobiodiversity and traditional millet cultivation.
- **Araku Valley is famous for organic coffee** cultivation and tribal farming systems.
- Indigenous seed conservation supports climate resilience, food security, and biodiversity protection.

HRD Minister Nara Lokesh announces 'Project Punarvika' to support children fighting rare, crippling diseases

- Project Punarvika is an initiative launched by the Andhra Pradesh government, announced by Nara Lokesh, to support children suffering from rare and crippling genetic diseases.
- **The project was inspired by the case of infant Punarvika, who was diagnosed with Spinal Muscular Atrophy Type-1 (SMA-1)** and required an extremely expensive gene therapy reportedly costing ₹16 crore.
- **Focus on early diagnosis of rare genetic diseases.**
- Financial assistance for high-cost treatments.
- Improved access to specialized medical care.
- Long-term support, including counselling for families.
- **Collaboration with international pharmaceutical companies to reduce therapy costs.**
- Promotion of domestic manufacturing of expensive rare-disease drugs.
- Policy advocacy with the Union Government to strengthen rare disease support frameworks.

Chenchu Tribe

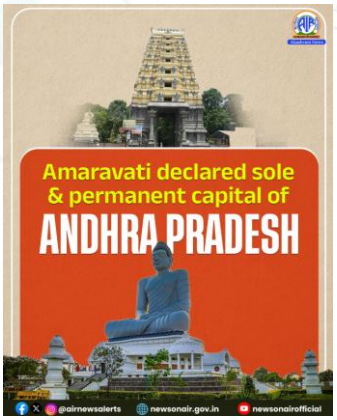


- Recently, **Chenchu tribals in Amrabad Tiger Reserve opposed relocation from forest areas, citing livelihood concerns.**
- The Chenchus primarily reside in the Nallamalai forests of Andhra Pradesh.
- They are one of the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs) in Andhra Pradesh.
- **They are also found in Telangana, Karnataka, and Odisha.**
- The Chenchus have been classified as the Proto Australoid group.
- **Language**: They speak variants of Telugu, the Dravidian language of the region.
- **A Chenchu village is known as "Penta".**
- Each penta consists of a few huts that are spaced apart and are grouped together based on kinship patterns.
- Small conjugal families predominate, women taking equal rank with men and marrying only upon maturity.
- **"Peddamanishi" or the village elder, is generally the authority to maintain social harmony in a family or a village.**
- The Chenchu live life with exemplary simplicity. Most of them still gather food from the forest and roam in it to find things to meet their needs.
- The **Chenchus collect forest products like roots, fruits, tubers, beedi leaf, mohua flower, honey, gum, tamarind, and green leaves and make a meagre income from it by selling these to traders and government cooperatives.**

Religion and Belief

- Chenchus worship a number of deities. Chenchus have also adopted certain religious practices from Hindus.
- **They mainly believe in Bhagaban Taru who resides in the sky and Garelamai Sama, who is the Goddess of forest.**
- For ages, the Chenchus have been associated with the famous Srisailam temple (dedicated to Lord Shiva and Devi Brahmaramba) in Andhra Pradesh, situated at the heart of Chenchu land

Amaravati to now be permanent capital of Andhra Pradesh; Parliament passes Reorganisation Bill, 2026



- Parliament has passed the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation (Amendment) Bill, 2026, with the Rajya Sabha approving it
- The Lok Sabha has already passed a Bill, which amends the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act, 2014. It accords statutory status to Amaravati as the sole capital of Andhra Pradesh.
- Under the original 2014 Act, Hyderabad was designated as a temporary joint capital for Telangana and Andhra Pradesh for up to ten years.
- The amendment confirms Amaravati as the successor capital to Hyderabad, effective retroactively from June 2, 2024.

States Reorganisation Act (1956):

- It was based on the recommendations of the Fazal Ali Commission.
- The act led to the reorganization of state boundaries across India, significantly altering the political map of the country.
- The States Reorganisation Act, 1956 merged the Telugu-speaking areas of Hyderabad state with the Andhra state to create the enlarged Andhra Pradesh.

- On 2nd June, 2014 the northwestern part of Andhra Pradesh was separated and 29th state Telangana was created through the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act, 2014.

Karnataka

Yana Caves, known for black rock formations, declared Geo-heritage Site of National Importance



- Known for its striking black crystalline rock formations and religious significance, the **Yana Caves in Karnataka has been declared a 'Geo-heritage Site of National Importance' by the Ministry of Mines through the Geological Survey of India (GSI).**
- Located in the Western Ghats in Uttara Kannada district, Yana Caves features massive karst limestone structures, including **two prominent monolithic outcrops -- Bhairaveshwara Shikhara (120 m) and Mohini Shikhara (90 m).**
- A **Geo-heritage Site of National Importance refers to a location with unique and irreplaceable geological features** — such as formations, fossils or landscapes, recognised for their scientific, educational and aesthetic value.
- These sites serve as natural records of earth's evolution and are protected for research and geotourism.

PM Modi Inaugurates Guru Bhairavaikya Mandira in Mandya



- Prime Minister Narendra Modi on April 15, 2026, inaugurated the Guru Bhairavaikya Mandira at Sri Kshetra Adichunchanagiri in Karnataka's Mandya district.
- **The Guru Bhairavaikya Mandira has been built in honour of Sri Sri Sri Dr Balagangadharanatha Mahaswamiji, the 71st pontiff of the Adichunchanagiri Math.**
- The memorial reflects his contributions to society, particularly in the fields of education, healthcare, and social service.
- **Dravidian architecture is characterised by temple towers known as gopurams.**

Shree Chamundeshwari Temple



- The Karnataka High Court has taken strong exception to the State defying judicial orders prohibiting construction activities in Sree Chamudeshwari Temple, Mysuru
- **It is a Hindu temple located on the top of Chamundi Hills, about 13 km from the palace city of Mysuru in the state of Karnataka.**
- It is dedicated to Goddess Chamundeshwari, who is an avatar of Durga.
- The original shrine is considered to be built by the Hoysala rulers from the 12th century and later by the Vijayanagara Empire in the 17th century.
- Notable though are the 1000-odd, stone stairway steps that lead to the **temple carved sometime in mid-17th CE by Maharaja Dodda Devaraja of Mysuru.**
- **It is considered as Shakti Peetha and is one among the 18 Maha Shakti Peethas**
- The temple is of a quadrangular structure.
- **Built in Dravidian style**, it consists of the main doorway, entrance, Navaranga Hall, Antharala Mantapa, Sanctum Sanctorum, and Prakara.

CARI Bengaluru Becomes First CCRAS Institute to Achieve ISO 15189:2022 Accreditation in Biochemistry & Haematology

- The Clinical Laboratory at the Central Ayurveda Research Institute (CARI), Bengaluru has achieved ISO 15189:2022 accreditation in Biochemistry and Haematology.
- **It has become the first institute under the Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences to receive this distinction.**
- The accreditation certifies that the laboratory meets globally accepted standards for accuracy, reliability, and safety in diagnostic services.

Namo Drone Didi Yojana

- Karnataka has the most number of women self-help groups (SHGs) to have undergone training as drone pilots under the 'Namo Drone Didi Yojana' (NDDY).
- It is a central sector initiative to empower women-led Self-Help Groups (SHGs) promoted under Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana – National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM) by providing them with drone technology for agricultural services.
- It aims to provide drones to selected SHGs for rental services to farmers for agriculture purposes (application of liquid fertilizers and pesticides for the present).
- A total of 15,000 drones will be provided to selected women SHGs between 2024-25 and 2025-26.
- Central Financial Assistance @ 80% of the cost of drone package up to a maximum of Rs. 8.00 lakhs will be provided to the women SHGs.
- For the remaining 20% cost, SHGs can seek loans from the National Agriculture Infrastructure Financing Facility (AIF) with a 3% interest subvention.
- One of the members of the women SHGs will be selected for 15 day training consisting of mandatory drone pilot training and additional training for agriculture purpose for nutrient and pesticide application.
- It is implemented by converging the resources of Department of Agriculture & Farmer's Welfare (DA&FW), Department of Rural Development (DoRD) and Department of Fertilizers (DoF) and Lead Fertilizer Companies (LFCs).

Appemidi Mango



- Appemidi mango (tender mango in Kannada) is facing the threat of climate change and experts are stressing the need for in-situ conservation of the natural trees in the Aghanashini valley of Karnataka.
- Appemidi Mango is found exclusively in the Uttara Kannada and Shivamogga districts of Karnataka.
- It is small and tender; it is regarded as the king among raw mango varieties.
- It is highly sought after by the South Asian pickle industry.
- These mangoes are pulpy, known for their distinctive aroma and long long shelf life.
- It has received GI (geographical indication) tag in 2009 in recognition of its culinary and cultural heritage,
- Uses: It is a traditional pickling variety of mango from Karnataka.

Keralam

IIM-Kozhikode launches 'Uyare' project to empower women entrepreneurs





- Indian Institute of Management Kozhikode has launched the 'Uyare' project.
- The initiative is a research-led initiative aimed at strengthening grassroots entrepreneurship among women associated with the Kudumbashree network.
- **Kudumbashree is a massive, three-tiered community network in Kerala launched in 1997 to eradicate poverty through women's empowerment, covering over 48 lakh women.**

Thrissur Pooram

- Even as the celebrations of the Thrissur Pooram festival was scaled down in view of the firework unit explosion that claimed around 15 lives, **thousands thronged the ground of the Vadakkunnathan temple in Thrissur city recently to witness the festival.**



Thrissur Pooram

- It is one of the most popular temple festivals in Kerala.
- It is held at the **Thekkinkadu Maidanam of Vadakkunnathan Temple in the heart of the Thrissur district, every year in the Malayalam month of Medam (April-May).**
- The history of Thrissur Pooram dates back over 200 years.
- **Often called the "Mother of all Poorams**." It was the **brainchild of Raja Rama Varma,** or famously known as Sakthan Thampuran, the Maharaja of Cochin (1790–1805).
- It unites ten temples in a spectacular display of devotion and rivalry.

Highlights:

- **Elephant Processions**: Over 50 richly adorned elephants carry idols amid Panchavadyam music and melam beats.
- **Kudamattam**: Thrilling parasol exchanges between rival groups showcase precision and flair.
- **Fireworks Spectacle**: Midnight display features aerial bursts and ground effects lasting hours.
- **Panchapradakshinam**: Deities circle the ancient Vadakkunnathan Temple in a sacred ritual.
- **Ilanjithara Melam:** A mesmerizing performance of traditional instruments

Muthuvan Tribe

- A recent report by the Kerala Food Commission has **spotlighted significant discrepancies in the distribution of ration supplies in Edamalakkudy, Kerala's sole tribal panchayat, primarily inhabited by the Muthuvan tribe.**
- The Muthuvans, or Mudugars, live in the Western Ghats mountains in the Indian states of Kerala and Tamil Nadu.
- The **Muthuvan language is a special language spoken by the Muthuvan people.**
- It belongs to the Dravidian language family.
- There are **two different groups** among the Muthuvan, and they speak slightly different dialects, **they call each other Malayalam Muthuvan and Pandi Muthuvan.**
- They are known for coexisting with the wildlife with their traditional knowledge and understanding of hills.
- The Muthuvan adhere to community endogamy and clan exogamy.
- These tribal people follow a unique system of governance called the 'Kani System'.

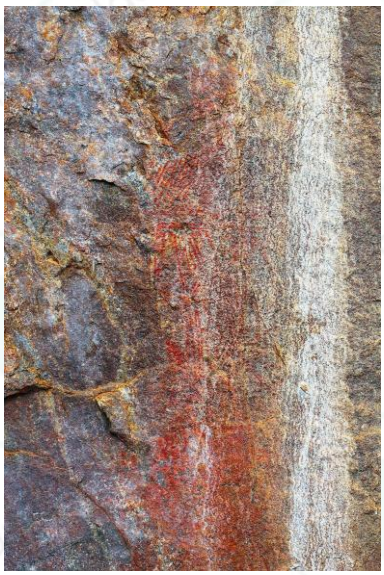
- They are **animists and spirit worshippers** and also worship the forest gods.
- They believe that the spirits of their ancestors are to be the first migrants to the hill forests.
- **Virippukrishi (a form of shifting cultivation) is their traditional means of livelihood,** and they cultivate a wide variety of food grains that are used only for consumption.

VACB launches 'Operation Earth Guard' to curb illegal soil mining in Kerala

- The Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) **launched a Statewide surprise inspection drive titled 'Operation Earth Guard'** following intelligence inputs about widespread irregularities, violations and corruption in the excavation and transportation of ordinary earth across the State.
- The drive, titled 'Operation Earth Guard', found that **permits and transit passes issued for house-building purposes are being systematically misused to extract and transport soil far beyond permissible limits.**

Tamil Nadu

Rock art site rediscovered in the Nilgiris



- Recently, the Yaakai Heritage Trust reported the rediscovery of a **prehistoric rock painting site called Oor Pare in the Nilgiris district of Tamil Nadu.**
- The site is located near Vellarikombai village in the Kotagiri region, at an altitude of around 1100 meters above sea level.
- **The rock shelter is traditionally used by indigenous Irula and Kurumba communities**, especially during honey collection activities.
- The paintings are classified into fine line drawings, thick stroke figures, and geometric composite forms.
- The artwork features anthropomorphic figures with conical headdresses, elongated human forms, ladder-like body structures, and ritual symbols like dot-filled rectangular patterns, indicating links to prehistoric ritual practices and supernatural beliefs.
- Evidence of repainting and superimposition points to multi-phase artistic activity across different cultural periods.
- **Other Sites:** Nearby important rock art sites include Eluthuparai and Tholikkiparai, known for similar multi-layered chronological painting traditions.

Noyyal River

- Farmers dependent on Noyyal river in the region are looking forward to accelerating their campaign for securing the commitment of the next government for its remediation.
- **Noyyal River is a tributary of the Kaveri River and flows through Tamil Nadu.**
- It begins from numerous small streams in the Vellingiri Hills of the Western Ghats.
- It flows through the districts of Coimbatore, Tirupur, and Erode and meets the Cauvery River at the Noyyal village in Karur District.
- Total Length: 158 km
- **It is a seasonal river with rapid flows during the monsoon periods.**
- Until the early 20th century, the Noyyal was the main drinking water source for the region.
- Today the Noyyal is one of the most polluted rivers in India

Fossil Bed dating back to Holocene period discovered in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu

- A Fossil Bed dating back to the Holocene period has been discovered in Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu.
- **This discovery significantly enriches the Quaternary fossil record of the country.**

- The fossil bed represents deposits formed during the Holocene marine transgression, when rising sea levels inundated previously exposed coastal plains and created extensive shallow marine environments suitable for sediment deposition and fossil accumulation
- **The site contained marine invertebrate fossils** – primarily bivalves and gastropods – embedded in ancient sedimentary formations

Pykara Lake



- The **Madras High Court has refused to lift the temporary stay on operating boating services for tourists on Pykara Lake in the Nilgiris district, Tamil Nadu.**
- Pykara Lake is situated at a distance of about 20 km from Ooty, in the Nilgiri district of Tamil Nadu.
- It is formed as a result of the construction of the Pykara Dam over the Pykara River.
- The **Pykara River, which originates from the Mukurthi peak, is the largest river in the district** and is revered by the Todas, an Adivasi community, who consider it to be sacred.
- The dam **also has a powerhouse, which is one of the oldest power plants in South India and is generating about 60 megawatts of electricity.**
- A few hundred meters north of the lake, the river tumbles down the rocks to form the famous Pykara Falls.
- Pykara Falls consists of two cascades that fall from a height of about 55 meters and 61 meters, respectively.
- **The lake is surrounded by the thick forest of Mukurthi National Park (MNP).** As part of the Western Ghats, it MNP has been a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1st July 2012.

Defence

Millitary Exercise

Indian Army contingent to participate in 4th edition of India-Egypt Joint Special Forces Exercise, Cyclone-IV



- The Indian Army contingent has departed for Egypt to participate in the fourth edition of the India - Egypt Joint Special Forces Exercise, Cyclone - IV, scheduled to be conducted at Anshas from 09 to 17 April 2026.
- It is a joint special force exercise held between India – Egypt.
- It is the fourth edition of this exercise.
- It is an annual event conducted alternatively in India and Egypt.

Country	Exercise
Australia	Austra Hindbah
Bangladesh	Sampriti
China	Hand in Hand
France	Shakti
Indonesia	Garuda Shakti
Kazakhstan	Prabal Dostykk
Kyrgyzstan	Khanjar
Maldives	Ekuverin

Country	Exercise
Mongolia	Nomadic Elephant
Myanmar	Imbex
Nepal	Surya Kiran

Oman	Al Nagah
Russia	Indra
Seychelles	Lamitiye
Sri Lanka	Mitra Shakti
Thailand	Maitree
UK	Ajeya Warrior
USA	Yudhabhayas, Vajra Prahar

Exercise Dustlik

- **Recently, the Indian Army contingent departed for participating in the 7th edition of the Exercise Dustlik.**
- It is a **joint military exercise conducted between India and Uzbekistan.**
- The drill is scheduled to be conducted at the Gurumsaray Field Training Area in **Namangam, Uzbekistan**, from April 12-25,
- It is a yearly event conducted alternatively in India and Uzbekistan.
- **Participating Forces:** Indian Army's Battalion of the MAHAR Regiment and 15 personnel from the Indian Air Force.
- **Aim**: To foster military cooperation and enhance combined capabilities to execute joint operations in semi-mountainous terrain.
- **Key operational aspects to be practiced include land navigation, strike missions on enemy bases and seizure of enemy-held areas.**

Indian Army Showcases Apache Firepower at Exercise Brahmastra



- The Indian Army demonstrated the combat strength of its latest attack helicopter, the Boeing AH-64 Apache, during a live firing exercise 'Brahmastra' at the Pokhran Firing Range.
- The exercise aimed to test both operational readiness and coordination between pilots and ground crews
- Pokhran Field Firing Range is a military testing site in Rajasthan.
- Light Combat Helicopter Prachand is India's first indigenously developed attack helicopter.

Indian Army flags off its first blue water sailing expedition, Samudra Sahas

- The Samudra Sahas Sailing Expedition, undertaken by the Regiment of Artillery as part of its bicentenary celebrations, was ceremonially flagged off from Marve, Mumbai
- The expedition is also a tribute to the enduring maritime legacy of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj.
- **The voyage is being conducted in four legs**: Mumbai to Vijaydurg, Vijaydurg to Goa, Goa to Vijaydurg and Vijaydurg to Mumbai.
- **The expedition is being conducted with administrative and operational support from the Indian Navy and the Indian Coast Guard.**

INS Nireekshak Visits Sri Lanka for Joint Naval Training

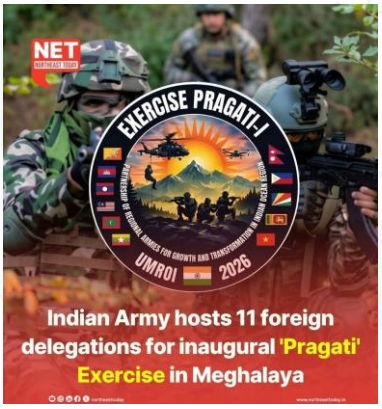


- INS Nireekshak, the Diving Support and Submarine Rescue Vessel of Indian Navy, arrived at the port of Colombo, Sri Lanka, on 21 Apr 2026
- **To participate in the 4th edition of IN-SLN DIVEX 2026, a bilateral diving exercise scheduled from 21-27 Apr 2026.**
- The IN-SLN Diving Exercise (DIVEX) is a **key bilateral engagement that stands as a testament to the deep-rooted maritime partnership between India and Sri Lanka.**
- As part of India's humanitarian outreach, the **ship will be presenting two BHISM (Bharat Health Initiative for Sahyog Hita & Maitri) cubes to the Sri Lankan authorities under the Government of India's 'Aarogya Maitri' initiative.**
- These state-of-the-art portable medical units capable of handling up to 200 emergency cases are designed to provide rapid response and are equipped with essential medicines and surgical tools for basic procedures.

INS Nireekshak

- It is a Dive Support and Submarine Rescue Vessel of the Indian Navy.
- **Built by Mazgaon Shipbuilders in 1985**, the ship has been in service with the Navy since 1989 and was commissioned in the year 1995.

Indian Army Hosts Exercise Pragati in Meghalaya



- The Indian Army is set to host military delegations from 11 friendly countries for the inaugural edition of the **multilateral exercise 'Pragati' at the Foreign Training Node in Umroi, Meghalaya.**
- 'Pragati' – an acronym for Partnership of Regional Armies for Growth and Transformation in the Indian Ocean Region – symbolises efforts toward cooperative growth and security.
- **The exercise aims to strengthen defence cooperation, enhance interoperability, and build mutual trust among participating nations.**
- According to the Indian Army, the initiative reflects a shared commitment to collective security and regional stability.

Indian Navy commissions stealth frigate INS Taragiri at Naval Dockyard in Visakhapatnam

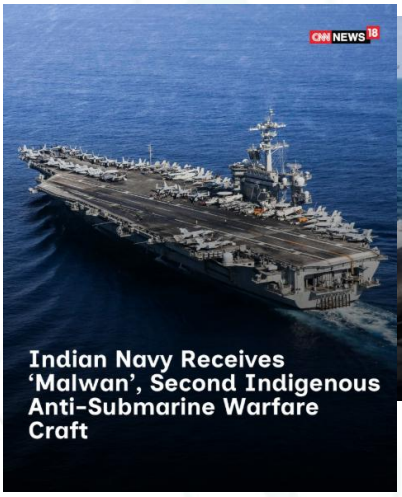


- Defence Minister Rajnath Singh commissioned the advanced stealth frigate INS Taragiri in Visakhapatnam.
- The warship is an advanced stealth frigate under Project 17A of the Indian Navy.
- Built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDL), Mumbai,
- Driven by a Combined Diesel or Gas (CODOG) propulsion plant, Taragiri is designed for 'High-Speed - High Endurance' versatility and multi-dimensional maritime operations.

Project 17A

- It is an Indian Navy initiative to construct seven advanced stealth guided-missile frigates.
  - It comprises frigates, all named after prominent mountain ranges in India i.e., INS Nilgiri, INS Himgiri, INS Udaygiri, INS Taragiri, INS Dunagiri, INS Vindhyagiri, and INS Mahendragiri.
  - A frigate is a versatile, medium-sized warship designed for high speed and maneuverability.

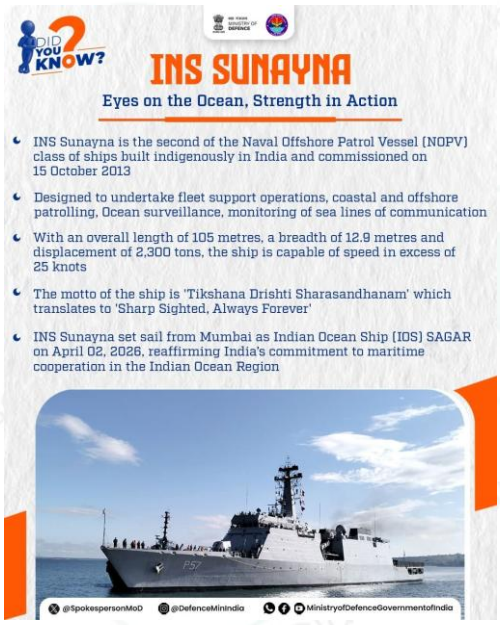
India commissions its third nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine—INS Aridhaman





- India commissioned its third nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine (SSBN) Aridhaman (S4).
- INS Aridhaman, a larger 7,000-tonne vessel, will carry more K-15 missiles, as well as the longer-range K-4 nuclear-capable submarine-launched ballistic missiles (SLBM) that can hit targets 3,500 km away.
- The submarine is powered by an upgraded 83 MW pressurised water reactor (PWR) developed by the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC).
- INS Arihant was the first vessel under the SSBN project, and was followed by INS Arighat. INS Arihant was launched in July 2009 and was quietly commissioned in 2016.
- The second indigenous SSBN, INS Arighat, was commissioned in August 2024.
- India is part of a select group of countries with nuclear triad capabilities. These include the United States, Russia, China, and France.

INS Sunayna



- Recently, the Indian Navy's offshore patrol vessel INS Sunayna reached Male as part of its deployment under the Indian Ocean Ship (IOS) SAGAR initiative.
- It is the second Saryu-class offshore patrol vessel of the Indian Navy.
- It was designed and constructed indigenously by the Goa Shipyard Limited.
- It was commissioned at Kochi on 15th October 2013.
- It is based under Southern Naval Command.
- Functions: It is designed to undertake fleet support operations, coastal and offshore patrolling, ocean surveillance and monitoring of sea lines of communications and offshore assets, and escort duties
- Two diesel engines propel INS Sunayna and enable it to achieve speeds in excess of 25 knots.
- The armament fit includes one 76 mm gun with an electro-optic fire control system, Close-in Weapon Systems (CIWS) and CHAFF launchers.
- The motto of the Indian Navy's INS Sunayna is "Tikshna Drishti Sharasandhanam", which translates to "Sharp Sighted, Always Forever"
- It can also carry a helicopter.

Malwan: Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft

- The Indian Navy marked a significant step in its maritime defense capabilities with the official delivery of 'Malwan', the second of eight indigenously built Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Crafts (ASW SWC).
- Malwan is a high-tech, waterjet-propelled warship designed specifically for specialized naval operations in coastal and shallow waters.

- Manufacturer: The ship was indigenously designed and constructed by Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL), Kochi.
- Specifications: It was built to the Indian Navy's specific requirements and adheres to the Classification Rules of DNV (Det Norske Veritas).
- The name is derived from the coastal town of Malwan in Maharashtra, which is historically significant for its ties to the maritime heritage of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj.
- The vessel continues the legacy of the erstwhile INS Malwan, a naval minesweeper that served the nation until 2003.
- Dimensions: The vessel measures approximately 80 metres in length and has a displacement of 1,100 tons.

INS Shachi

INS Shachi Launch Marks NGOPV Naval Modernisation Boost



- The Indian Navy marked a major indigenous shipbuilding milestone with the launch of Shachi (Yard 1280), the first of eleven Next Generation Offshore Patrol Vessels (NGOPVs), at Goa Shipyard Limited.
- Shachi is the lead ship of the Next Generation Offshore Patrol Vessel (NGOPV) . The name is derived from Indian mythology, meaning one who renders assistance.
- These vessels are designed to be highly versatile, indigenously built platforms that will significantly augment the Indian Navy's existing fleet of ten Offshore Patrol Vessels.

The construction of the eleven-ship NGOPV project is being undertaken concurrently at two major Indian shipyards:

- Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL), Goa: Builder of the first ship, Shachi.
- Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE), Kolkata: Working on subsequent vessels in the class.

INS Dhruv

- Recently, the **Indian Navy has deployed its specialised missile-tracking and ocean-surveillance vessel INS Dhruv into the Arabian Sea immediately before Pakistan's declared live-firing window.**
- It is India's first dedicated nuclear missile tracking and ocean surveillance ship.
- It was commissioned on 10 September 2021.
- It **was built by Hindustan Shipyard Limited** in collaboration with Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and National Technical Research Organisation (NTRO)
- **Displacement Capacity**: It displaces 15000 tons.
- It is powered by two diesel engines in CODAD configuration each generating 9000KW.
- **It is equipped with powerful X-band and S-band** AESA(active electronically scanned array) radars, it can track nuclear-capable ballistic missiles and satellites from thousands of kilometres away.

ALH MK-III Helicopter

- Recently, the Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) handed over four Advanced Light Helicopter (ALH) Mk III Maritime Role (MR) helicopters to the Indian Coast Guard.



- **It is the maritime variant of the indigenous Dhruv Advanced Helicopter.**
- These have been indigenously manufactured by Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL).

Features of ALH MK-III Helicopter

- It is a multi-role twin-engine helicopter equipped for demanding maritime operations.
- It is equipped with advanced avionics, a modern glass cockpit, and night operation capability.
- **Uses:** It is used for maritime surveillance, search and rescue, casualty evacuation, coastal security, law enforcement, VIP travel, troop transport, logistics, and anti-piracy.

Key Facts about Indian Coast Guard

- It is a maritime armed force operating under the Ministry of Defence, Government of India.
- **It was raised on February 1, 1977.**
- It was formally established in 1978 by the Coast Guard Act, 1978 as an independent armed force of India.
- **Functions**: The ICG was envisioned to address emerging maritime challenges and safeguard India's expanding marine interests.
- **The Headquarters of the ICG is located in New Delhi, and is under the command of the Director General Indian Coast Guard.**
- **Moto**: "VAYAM RAKSHAMAH" – WE PROTECT

Astra Mk2 Missile



- **India is planning to equip Mirage 2000 jets with Astra Mk2 missiles, enabling long-range interception up to 240 km and strengthening aerial dominance**.
- It is a Beyond Visual Range (BVR) air-to-air missile.
- It is being developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO).
- In addition to various laboratories of DRDO, more than 50 public and private industries, including Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, have contributed towards successful realisation of the weapon system.
- **The Astra Mark-1 air-to-air missile with a strike range of around 90-100 kms is already in the Indian Air Force and is already integrated with the LCA Tejas and the Su-30 MKI fighter jets.**
- The Astra Mark 2 would give the Indian Air Force an edge over the adversaries in air-to-air combat and can also be offered as an export product to friendly foreign countries.

Features

- While the Astra Mark-1 is a single-pulse, smokeless solid-fueled motor, the Astra Mark-2 uses a dual-pulse solid rocket motor for extended reach and better kinematics during the kill phase.
- Astra Mk-1 is 3.6 m (12 ft) long with a diameter of 178 mm (7.0 in) and weighs 154 kg with a maximum range of 110 km.
- The Astra Mark 2 will be a bigger missile with a diameter of 190 mm and weigh close to 175 kg.
- Range: 200–240 km (high altitude conditions)
- Astra Mk-2 will use the indigenous seeker manufactured by Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL).

Hwasong-11Ga

- North Korea recently conducted a series of weapons tests including the launch of a Hwasong-11ga fitted with a cluster munition warhead.
- The Hwasong-11Ga, known as the KN-23 in the West, is a short-range ballistic missile.
- **It was developed by North Korea**
- It is a single-stage, solid-fuel missile fitted with a cluster munition warhead.
- It can carry a nuclear, chemical, or conventional warhead weighing around 500 kg.

What Makes Cluster Bombs the 'devil's weapon'?

- Cluster munitions are widely considered among the most controversial weapons in modern warfare.
- A single missile or bomb releases dozens to hundreds of smaller submunitions in mid-air, dispersing them across a wide target area.
- **This characteristic has earned them the nickname "devil's weapon" due to their indiscriminate nature.**

BRO celebrates 47th Raising Day of Project Chetak at Bikaner in Rajasthan on April 04.

- Project Chetak of the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) celebrated its 47th Raising Day at Bikaner in Rajasthan ,marking over four decades of dedicated service in the strategically important regions of the western sector.
- on this day in 1980, the project played a vital role in developing and maintaining infrastructure in Rajasthan, Punjab and the northern parts of Gujarat.
- with its motto "Chetak ka Prayas, Desh ka Vikas", Project Chetak is one of the largest projects of the BRO in terms of geographical area.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh addresses 'Sansad Khel MahaKumbh' in Lucknow

- Defence Minister Rajnath Singh attended the third edition of the Sansad Khel Mahakumbh in Lucknow
- **The primary objective of the Sansad Khel Mahakumbh** is to provide a platform for young talent to showcase their abilities while nurturing discipline, teamwork, and a spirit of healthy competition.

Indian Navy to host first edition of Commanders' Conference 2026 in New Delhi

- First edition of Indian Navy's biannual Commanders' Conference 2026 is scheduled over a period of three days at Nausena Bhawan, New Delhi, from 14 Apr to 16 Apr 2026.
- **The Apex Level Conference offers a stage for comprehensive review of Navy's operational posture to protect national maritime interests, capability development and strategic alignment with national security objectives.**

First phase of Naval Commanders' Conference 2026 concludes in New Delhi

- The first edition of the biannual Naval Commanders' Conference 2026 concluded in New Delhi.
- The apex-level conference, held from April 14 to 17, served as a **key platform to review the Navy's operational and material preparedness, infrastructure, logistics and human resource initiatives.**
- A key highlight of the conference was the **release of the Indian Navy Maritime Security Strategy (INMSS-2026) by the naval chief**. Aligned with Defence Forces Vision 2047 and Indian Navy Vision 2047,
- On the sidelines, the **Navy hosted 'Sagar Manthan',** bringing together senior leadership and domain experts to deliberate on defence R&D reforms and enhancing industry participation in capability development.



India To Host First High-Level CAPF Conference

- India will host the first high-level conference of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) where Prime Minister Narendra Modi will be the chairperson.

Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF)

- 7 forces under Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA)
- **Total strength:** ~1 million personnel
- **Roles**: Internal security, border management, industrial security, special duties
- **Term "CAPF" replaced "paramilitary forces" in 2011 (older term still used)**

Forces (with roles & strength)

- **CRPF (Central Reserve Police Force):** Internal security, anti-insurgency
- **BSF (Border Security Force):** India–Pakistan & India–Bangladesh borders
- **CISF (Central Industrial Security Force):** Industrial & strategic installations
- **ITBP (Indo-Tibetan Border Police)**: India–China border
- **SSB (Sashastra Seema Bal):** India–Nepal & India–Bhutan borders
- **Assam Rifles:** Northeast security + India–Myanmar border
- **NSG (National Security Guard):** Counter-terrorism, VIP protection

INS Kalpeni

- An **Indian Navy fast attack craft, INS Kalpeni, recently arrived at Gan in the Addu Atoll, marking a significant step in the ongoing maritime engagement between India and the Maldives.**
- It is a fast attack craft of the Indian Navy.
- It belongs to a series of 10 Fleet Car Nicobar class Waterjet Fast Attack Craft (FAC) built by the Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers (GRSE), Kolkata for the Indian Navy.
- It **was commissioned into the Indian Navy on October 14, 2010.**
- The **ship is named after Kalpeni Island in the Lakshadweep group of islands.**
- The **ship is based at Kochi** under the Southern Naval Command with the primary role of Coastal Surveillance and Defence.
- It **specialises in anti-smuggling, Vessel Boarding Search & Seizure as well as Search & Rescue operations.**



LAUNCH OF DSC A 23 (YARD 328) - FOURTH SHIP OF DIVING SUPPORT CRAFT (DSC) PROJECT

- DSC A 23, the fourth ship of five Diving Support Craft (DSC) project **was launched on 19 Apr 2026 at Titagarh, Kolkata (WB**)
- The construction of Diving Support Craft is being undertaken by M/s Titagarh Rail Systems Limited (TRSL), Kolkata.

DRDO Gives Prajna System to MHA

- The Ministry of Home Affairs has received an indigenously developed satellite imaging system, **'Prajna', to enhance the real-time decision support for the security agencies.**
- The **AI-enabled system**, developed by the DRDO's Centre for Artificial Intelligence and Robotics (CAIR), will strengthen the country's internal security, playing a key role in monitoring sensitive regions and supporting counter-terrorism operations.

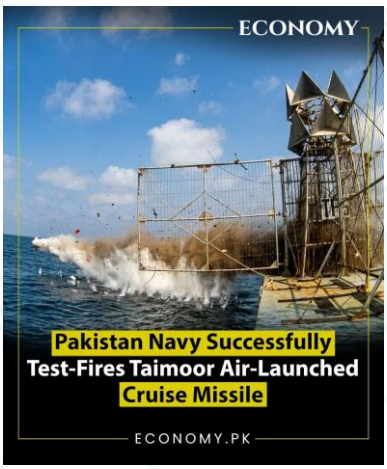
R-37M Missile





- In a major development for India's air superiority, **Moscow recently greenlit the sale of its formidable R-37M ultra-long-range air-to-air missile to New Delhi.**
- The R-37M missile, known by its NATO reporting name AA-13 Axehead, is a long-range air-to-air missile developed by Russia.
- It is **designed to eliminate enemy fighter jets and drones beyond visual range (BVR).**
- People often call the **R-37M an "AWACS Killer"** because it can go after large and important enemy aircraft.
- Measuring approximately 4.2 metres long and weighing nearly 600 kilograms, the **R-37M carries a 60-kilogram high-explosive fragmentation warhead intended for large airborne targets.**
- It features a jettisonable rocket booster that allows it to achieve a range of 300 to 400 kilometers.
- Its **speed can reach hypersonic levels,** up to Mach 6. It is the world's fastest known air-to-air missile class

Pakistan Tests Taimoor Anti-Ship Cruise Missile



- Pakistan has successfully test-fired an indigenously developed 'Taimoor' air-launched cruise missile (ALCM).
- **The anti-ship weapon system can reportedly strike land and sea targets at ranges of up to 600 km.**

The Atlas Drone Swarm System



- The Chinese recently unveiled the Atlas drone swarm system, a **state-of-the-art military asset capable of launching and controlling nearly 100 drones through a single human operator.**
- The Atlas system is an independent, mobile drone swarm operations unit that serves as a mini-battlefield network on wheels.
- It **combines mass launch capabilities with advanced artificial intelligence to execute complex military maneuvers.**
- **Developed By**: The system is manufactured by the China Electronic Technology Group Corporation (CETC), a state-owned conglomerate.
- The **primary goal is to provide a highly mobile, difficult-to-detect unit capable of reconnaissance, communication, deception, and precision attacks across a large perimeter.**
- **Drones are truck-launched**
- A single system can carry and simultaneously launch up to 96 small- and medium-sized drones.
- **The system is small and independent, making it easy to hide, camouflage, and operate from remote corners or difficult terrain.**

Project DANTAK

- Project DANTAK of the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) celebrated its 66th Raising Day, in Thimphu, Bhutan.

- **Project DANTAK is a premier infrastructure development initiative by the Government of India in the Kingdom of Bhutan.**
- **Organisation**: It is a project under the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) of India.
- **Established In:** The project was established in April 1961.
- The project aims to develop critical national infrastructure and strengthen connectivity across Bhutan to support the country's socio-economic transformation and the India-Bhutan partnership.

Key Features

- Under this project, over 1,500 km of roads have been constructed across the Kingdom.
- **It built Bhutan's first motorable road and the vital East–West Highway connecting Trashigang to Thimphu.**
- The project was instrumental in the construction of the Paro International Airport and the Yongphula Airport.
- **Recent focus has shifted to capacity enhancement, including the double laning of critical stretches like the Confluence–Haa road and the 168-km Samdrup Jongkhar–Trashigang highway.**

DRDO Chief Unveils Advanced Armoured Platforms in Maharashtra

- **Chairman, Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), Dr Samir V Kamat, unveiled the Advanced Armoured Platforms (Tracked and Wheeled) at the premises of the DRDO's laboratory in Ahilyanagar, Maharashtra.**
- Both the Tracked and Wheeled platforms have been integrated with indigenously designed advanced features to meet the mobility, firepower and protection requirements.
- **TATA Advanced Systems Limited and Bharat Forge Limited carried out the manufacturing of the platforms.**
- Both the platforms have been integrated with an indigenously designed & developed 30 mm Crewless Turret.
- **The 30 mm crewless turret, along with the 7.62 mm PKT is configured to launch Anti-Tank Guided Missiles as well.**

Indian Army raises 16th 'Bhairav' Battalion at Maratha Light Infantry Centre in Belagavi

- The Bhairav Battalion, also referred to as a Bhairav Light Commando Battalion**, is part of the Indian Army's efforts to build lean, high-mobility tactical units that can operate between conventional infantry and Special Forces**
- It is the 16th 'Bhairav' Battalion at the prestigious Maratha Light Infantry Regimental Centre in Belagavi. **These battalions are intended to give the army faster, more flexible options in modern conflict, while relieving some pressure on elite Special Forces formations**.
- The Maratha Light Infantry Regimental Centre, one of the oldest and most respected training establishments of the Indian Army.

Luzon Island

- China's military Southern Theater Command recently conducted live-fire drills, rapid maneuvers, and sea-air coordination exercises in waters east of Luzon Island
- It is the most important island of the Philippines, housing more than half of the country's total population.
- Luzon is the largest and most economically significant island in the Philippine archipelago.



- It is **situated in the northern part of the Philippines, bounded by the Philippine Sea to the east, the South China Sea to the west, and the Luzon Strait to the north,** which separates it from Taiwan.
- The island was significantly impacted by the 1991 eruption of Mount Pinatubo.
- It is the site of Manila, the national capital.

National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) 75th Anniversary

- The National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) marked a historic milestone as it launched celebrations for its 75th anniversary
- NRAI unveiled its special 75-year commemorative logo, symbolising seven and a half decades of excellence, discipline, and achievement in Indian shooting.
- **NRAI presented a 75-year logo memento to the Hon'ble Sports Minister as a token of gratitude** .
- The occasion also saw the **official launch of the NRAI Athlete App, a transformative digital platform that positions NRAI as India's first fully digitised sports federation.**
- The **app will serve as a one-stop ecosystem for athlete management**—from onboarding and registering 7,50,000 youth participants under the federation's grassroots programme, to issuing certificates, maintaining records, and monitoring the performances of India's elite and international shooters.

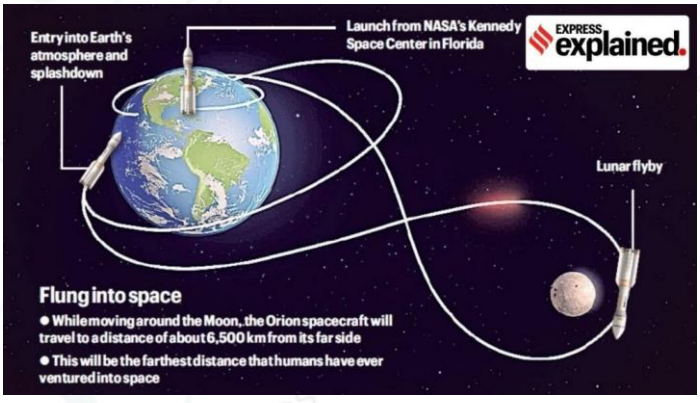
Army chief Upendra Dwivedi inducted into International Hall of Fame at U.S. Army War College



- India's Army chief General Upendra Dwivedi was inducted into the International Hall of Fame of the US Army War College in Pennsylvania, becoming the third Indian head of the army to receive such honour.
- General Dwivedi, a distinguished fellow of the US Army War College, is the third Indian Chief of Armed Forces to be inducted in the International Hall of Fame after General V K Singh and General Bikram Singh.

Science & Technology

Artemis II Mission



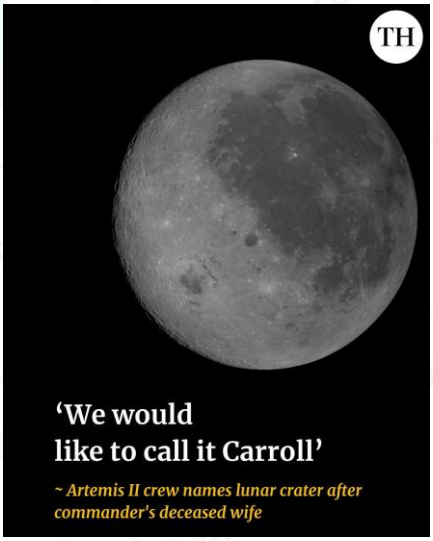
- NASA is set to launch the Artemis II mission on, April 1, 2026, marking the first time humans will venture to the Moon's neighbourhood since the Apollo 17 mission in 1972.
- The Artemis II mission will take three to four days to reach the Moon's neighbourhood — roughly the same time the Apollo missions took to land on the lunar surface.
- The Apollo missions used Saturn V rockets, which are the most powerful rockets ever built.
- Both the SLS rocket and the Orion spacecraft being used for this mission
- This is the first time that the SLS rocket and Orion spacecraft are being used to carry astronauts.
- carrying four astronauts - The rocket will be crewed by three American astronauts — mission commander Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover and Christina Koch — and Canadian astronaut Jeremy Hansen

The path

- The Artemis II Mission will make two rounds of the Earth before embarking on its journey towards the Moon.

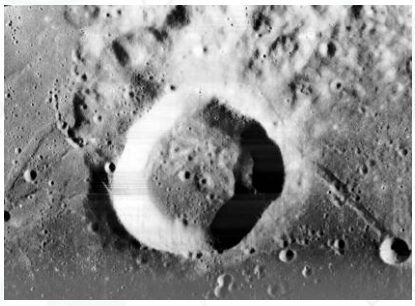
- Once there, it will go around the Moon before starting the return journey to Earth.
- While moving around the Moon, the Orion spacecraft will travel to a distance of about 6,500 km from the far side of the Moon.
- This will be the farthest that humans have ever ventured into space.
- The Apollo missions that landed on the Moon reached an altitude of just about 110 km from the far side of the lunar surface, while moving around it.
- Artemis II is sort of a test-ride mission, meant to test and validate all systems before astronauts finally make the landing on the Moon in 2028.
- The Artemis I mission in 2022, which was uncrewed but followed roughly the same path to the Moon and back, though it stayed in space for a longer duration, about 25 days, to carry out tests.

Lunar crater named after Artemis commander's deceased wife



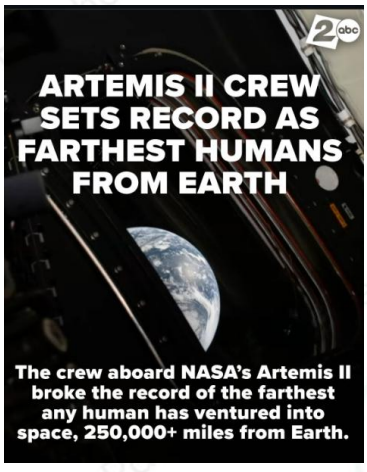
- Artemis astronauts at the outer edge of human space travel had named a crater in honour of the deceased wife of mission commander Reid Wiseman - call it Carroll
- The crater can be seen "at certain times of the Moon's transit around Earth
- The Artemis II crew dubbed another crater "Integrity," in honor of the name they have given their spacecraft.
- Lunar Craters are bowl-shaped landforms created by Volcanism and Cratering, about 4.5 billion years ago, shortly after Earth was formed.
- There are hundreds of thousands of moon craters ranging from less than a mile across to giant basins.

What is the Difference between Craters on the Moon and Earth?



- Both the earth and the moon have been hit by multiple objects like asteroids throughout their existence, but craters on the moon are of a more permanent nature than those on earth.
- This is because of processes like erosion, tectonics, and volcanism.
- According to NASA, these three processes keep the surface of the earth crater-free and remove traces of collisions that have happened in the past.
- Currently, the earth has less than 200 known craters while the moon has thousands.
- An absence of atmosphere means there is no wind system and no weather on the moon, and hence no cause for erosion of existing craters.
- The absence of tectonics prevents the moon's surface from forming new rocks or causing a shift in the existing surface patterns, unlike that on earth.
- Lastly, the absence of volcanism (in recent history) makes it impossible for craters to be covered.

NASA's Artemis II Sets Record as Farthest Human Journey from Earth



- NASA's Artemis II entered its fifth day in space on 6th April. The astronauts are now preparing for a close flyby of the Moon and to reach a record-breaking distance from Earth.
- The Orion spacecraft, carrying four astronauts, reached about 252,752 miles from Earth during a flyby of the Moon's far side, surpassing the Apollo 13 record of 248,655 miles set in 1970.

- Four astronauts aboard NASA's Artemis II test flight around the Moon made history at 12:56 p.m. CDT, at 11:27 PM India Standard Time.
- At their closest approach, the astronauts will come within about 4,067 miles of the Moon's surface, becoming the first humans to directly observe parts of its far side in decades.
- The Orion spacecraft has reached the Moon's gravitational sphere, placing the crew on a path that will take them over the lunar far side.
- Soon, the astronauts on board Artemis II will become the farthest-travelling humans in history.

NASA's Artemis II moon mission astronauts make first-ever 'ship to ship' call to ISS

- NASA's Artemis II mission made history again when the crew, traveling on their Orion spacecraft, completed the first-ever ship to ship call between a human moon mission and the International Space Station.
- This was the first time people traveling near the Moon communicated directly with people in a spacecraft orbiting Earth. During the call, Christina Koch on Artemis II spoke with Jessica Meir on the space station.
- The two had earlier worked together on the first all-female spacewalk in 2019.

Artemis II splashes down

- **After a historic journey around the Moon, the four astronauts onboard NASA's Artemis II mission returned to Earth this morning (April 11).**
- The Orion spacecraft, carrying astronauts Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover and Christina Koch of the US, and Jeremy Hansen of Canada, splashed down in the Pacific Ocean, off the coast of southern California.
- **The four astronauts were the first to venture near the Moon in more than five decades, and even though they did not make a Moon landing**, the trajectory of their spacecraft took them further in space than any of the Apollo missions that made the Moon landings in the 1960s and 1970s.



- Their spacecraft reached from the Earth at its furthest, which was about 6,606 km more than the distance the Apollo 13 mission reached in 1970.
- **The success of the Artemis II mission clears the deck for the first human Moon landing in more than five decades, tentatively scheduled for 2028 right now.**

PACE Satellite

- **Researchers recently found that NASA's PACE satellite can now detect nitrogen dioxide pollution at a fine enough scale to isolate emissions from individual factories and highway corridors.**
- The Plankton, Aerosol, Cloud, and ocean Ecosystem (PACE) is a NASA satellite mission that studies global ocean biology, aerosols, and clouds.
- It was **launched in February 2024** into a Sun-synchronous orbit.
- PACE's primary instrument is the Ocean Color Instrument (OCI), a highly advanced optical spectrometer to measure the ocean's colour across a spectrum from ultraviolet to shortwave infrared.
- It also features two polarimeters – the Spectro-polarimeter for Planetary Exploration (SPEXone) and the Hyper Angular Research Polarimeter (HARP2).



- **The data from PACE allows researchers to study microscopic life in the ocean and particles in the air, advancing the understanding of issues including fisheries health, harmful algal blooms, air pollution, and wildfire smoke.**

SpaceX to Launch Rosalind Franklin Rover to Mars 2028

- NASA has **given approval for the agency's Rosalind Franklin Support and Augmentation (ROSA)** project to begin implementation, underscoring the agency's continued partnership with ESA's (European Space Agency) Rosalind Franklin mission.
- The **mission, part of the European-led ExoMars programme**, aims to search for signs of past or present life on the Red Planet.
- The Rosalind Franklin rover, developed under the leadership of the European Space Agency with support from NASA, is specifically designed to detect biosignatures of life.
- **Its primary objective is to explore the Martian subsurface, where evidence of life is more likely to be preserved**. This mission is a key part of astrobiology research, which seeks to understand whether life exists beyond Earth.
- NASA has selected SpaceX's Falcon Heavy rocket to launch the Rosalind Franklin mission from Launch Complex 39A at NASA's Kennedy Space Center in Florida.

South Atlantic Anomaly (SAA)

- The South Atlantic Anomaly is actually splitting into two zones now, making things trickier for satellites in low Earth orbit.
- The South Atlantic Anomaly (SAA), or the "Bermuda Triangle of Space'', is a dip in the Earth's magnetic field which allows cosmic rays and charged particles to reach lower into the atmosphere.
- It is southeast of South America and southwest of Africa. In this area, the planet's magnetic field dips down.
- It lies roughly between latitudes 5 and 40 degrees South and between longitudes 0 and 80 degrees West — the precise strength, shape, and size of the SAA varies with the seasons.
- It was first identified in the 19th century.

Why Does it Occur?

- Earth's magnetic field acts like a protective shield around the planet, repelling and trapping charged particles from the Sun.
- SAA exists because the Earth's inner Van Allen radiation belt comes closest to the planet's surface, causing an increased flux of energetic particles.
- This leads to the penetration of solar energetic particles deep into Earth's atmosphere, posing severe problems for airplanes and ships' positioning systems as well as spacecraft electronic systems..

What are the Van Allen Radiation Belts?

- The Van Allen radiation belt is a zone of energetic charged particles, most of which originate from the solar wind.
- The particles are captured by and held around a planet by that planet's magnetic field.
- It surrounds Earth, containing a nearly impenetrable barrier that prevents the fastest, most energetic electrons from reaching Earth.
- The outer belt is made up of billions of high-energy particles that originate from the Sun and become trapped in Earth's magnetic field, an area known as the magnetosphere.
- The inner belt results from interactions of cosmic rays with Earth's atmosphere.
- The Van Allen belts are most intense over the Equator and are effectively absent above the poles.

- These radiation belts serve both protective and hazardous roles; while they shield Earth from harmful cosmic radiation, they can pose risks to satellites and human space missions, as the particles can interfere with electronic systems.
- They were discovered in 1958 by James A. Van Allen, the American physicist who designed the instruments on board Explorer 1, the first spacecraft launched by the United States

Gaganyaan Astronauts Begin Mission Mitra in Ladakh



- Mission Mitra stands for Mapping of Interoperable Traits & Reliability Assessment.
- Led by ISRO's Human Space Flight Centre (HSFC), it aims to simulate space-like challenges on Earth and understand how crews and support teams operate under extreme stress.
- Under Mission Mitra, ISRO's Human Space Flight Centre (HSFC) is placing the selected astronaut team in high-altitude, low-oxygen, extreme-cold conditions to study how humans perform- physically and mentally- when pushed to the edge, in an environment that can mimic parts of deep-space stress.
- The mission is being carried out in Ladakh's high-altitude terrain, known for its freezing cold, low oxygen levels and isolation.
- These factors make Ladakh an ideal terrestrial analogue for space: difficult to survive in, physically demanding, and mentally taxing, perfect for testing future space crews.
- Mission Mitra is inspired by the European Space Agency's CAVES programme, where astronauts train in dark, confined cave systems to mimic space conditions.

Astronomers Find Unusual Solar System With Two Earth-like Planets

- Astronomers have identified a peculiar planetary system located nearly 120 light-years away from Earth, challenging long-held theories of how solar systems form.
- The system contains two Earth-like planets, often referred to as "super-Earths", but its overall structure defies conventional models observed in our own Solar System.
- The newly discovered system hosts two rocky planets similar in size and composition to Earth.
- Such planets, known as super-Earths, are slightly larger than Earth and may possess rocky surfaces or layered interiors.
- The discovery has led scientists to consider alternative formation mechanisms, including "inside-out" models where planets may form or migrate differently than previously believed

Antariksh Venture Capital Fund



- Recently, the Union Minister said that India's dedicated Antariksh venture capital fund for the space sector has progressed steadily, with investment in selected startups expected to begin from the first quarter of FY2027.
- It is a close ended fund registered with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) as a Category II Alternative Investment Fund (AIF).
- It is a SEBI registered Alternative Investment Fund.
- Key Investor: Indian National Space Promotion and Authorization Centre (IN-SPACe), Department of Space, Government of India.
- The Fund is sponsored by SIDBI Venture Capital Limited.

- The Fund's investment objective: To provide much-needed capital to companies in the space sector at various stages of development as well as support the scaling of operations and the commercialization of new technologies, empowering the companies to contribute to India's broader space ambitions.
- It is looking to invest exclusively in Indian companies operating in the Space sector with Technology Readiness Level (TRL) of 4 and above

Indian National Space Promotion and Authorization Centre

- It is a single-window, independent, nodal agency that functions as an autonomous agency in the Department of Space (DOS).
- It is formed following the Space sector reforms to enable and facilitate the participation of private players.
- It is responsible to promote, enable, authorize and supervise various space activities of non-governmental entities (NGEs) including building launch vehicles & satellites and providing space-based services; sharing space infrastructure and premises under the control of DOS/ISRO; and establishing of new space infrastructure and facilities.

"Spacecraft Mission Operations: SMOPS-2026"

- The second edition of the International Conference on "Spacecraft Mission Operations: **SMOPS- 2026" with the theme "Innovative Operations for Smart and Sustainable Space Mission Management – Next Generation" held in Bangalore,** India.
- The conference, jointly organised by the Indian Space Research Organization (ISRO), the Astronautical Society of India (ASI), and the International Academy of Astronautics (IAA).
- **It aims to cover a wide range of topics related to mission operations** management, advanced mission design, automation, large constellations management, human spaceflight mission, space robotics, space policy, lunar and interplanetary exploration, cybersecurity in space systems, artificial intelligence, etc.

Direct-to-Device (D2D) Technologies

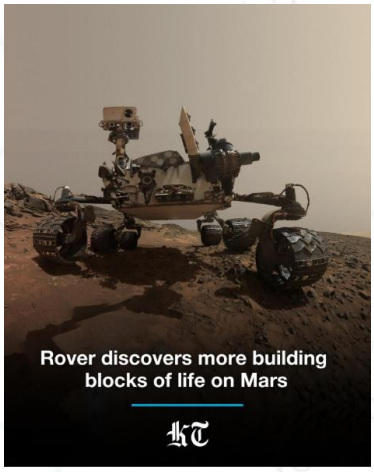


- The Department of Telecommunications (DoT) recently organized a high-level workshop through the Telecommunication Engineering Centre (TEC) to explore Direct-to-Device (D2D) satellite communication.
- Direct-to-Device (D2D) is an emerging satellite communication technology that allows standard, off-the-shelf mobile devices (like your smartphone) to connect directly to satellites without the need for specialized hardware, satellite phones, or intermediate ground equipment.
- It essentially turns satellites into cell towers in space, extending cellular coverage globally.

Key Features:

- Unlike traditional satellite telephony which requires bulky handsets with large antennas, D2D works with existing 4G and 5G smartphones.
- By using Low Earth Orbit satellites (500–2,000 km altitude), the latency (delay) is significantly reduced compared to traditional geostationary satellites.
- It eliminates the need for expensive ground-based towers in geographically challenging terrains like mountains, deserts, or islands.
- Early-stage D2D focuses on low-bandwidth services like emergency text alerts, though it is evolving toward full voice and data capabilities.

NASA's Curiosity rover detects organic molecules on Mars: 'Building blocks of life'



- The Curiosity rover, part of NASA's Mars Science Laboratory mission, has found a mix of organic molegules on Mars.
- This includes chemicals that are considered to be the "building blocks of life".
- **Of the 21 carbon-containing molecules in the sample, seven have been detected for the first time on Mars,** The detection has renewed the confirmation that the red planet once use to have the right chemistry to support life.

Mars Curiosity Rover

- It is a U.S. robotic vehicle designed to explore the surface of Mars.
- **It was launched aboard an Atlas V rocket from Cape Canaveral Air Force Station, Florida on Nov. 26, 2011, and landed on Aug. 5, 2012,** after taking eight months and 10 days to reach the Red Planet.
- The rover is currently roaming Mars' landscape looking for signs of life and learning about the Red Planet's unique environment.

NASA's Nancy Grace Roman Telescope to map space 1,000 times faster than Hubble



- NASA has completed the final assembly of the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope
- **built at the Goddard Space Flight Center in Maryland**, the observatory is expected to become one of the most powerful survey telescopes ever developed.
- **Roman will study dark energy, galaxy formation and distant planetary systems on an unprecedented scale**
- Its main mirror is 2.4 metres wide, similar in size to the Hubble Space Telescope.
- Its field of view is nearly 100 times larger in a single image. This allows it to scan large regions of space much faster.
- **Roman can collect survey data nearly 1,000 times faster than Hubble**, making it ideal for wide-field cosmic mapping.
- **Nancy Grace Roman is known as the "Mother of Hubble" for her role in advancing space astronomy.**
- The Roman Space Telescope **will operate from Lagrange Point 2 (L2),** nearly one million miles from Earth.
- Roman also carries a **specialised instrument called a coronagraph**, which blocks bright starlight to reveal faint planets orbiting nearby.

Giant Magellan Telescope (GMT)

- The Giant Magellan Telescope (GMT) is currently in its final design phase as of April 2026.
- The **Giant Magellan Telescope Consortium is advancing plans for the Giant Magellan Telescope (GMT), a next-generation observatory that could reshape how scientists study planets, stars, and galaxies.**
- The GMT project, backed by a consortium of 16 universities and research institutions, is currently in its final design phase – a necessary step before it can be considered for major federal funding.
- **The telescope is planned for Las Campanas Observatory in Chile's Atacama Desert, a location known for its exceptionally dark, dry, and stable skies – ideal conditions for astronomy.**

- The GMT is expected to have a significant impact on the studies of exoplanets, especially those located within habitable zones of stars.
- **Scientists would observe light from the planets to detect signs of life-supporting atmospheres.**
- Apart from planets, the telescope will allow scientists to peer deep into the universe's history to observe the development of galaxies several billion years ago.

Blue Origin achieves first landing of reused New Glenn rocket booster but satellite misses orbit



- The **reusable booster of the New Glenn rocket launched from Florida by Jeff Bezos' company Blue Origin touched down successfully but the rocket failed to deploy the AST BlueBird 7 SpaceMobile communications satellite it was carrying into the correct orbit.**
- The booster, named "Never Tell Me the Odds," landed successfully on the drone ship Jacklyn after launch from Cape Canaveral, Florida.

China Finds Rare Moon Mineral for Advanced LED Technology

- Chinese researchers have discovered a **new lunar mineral named Cerium–Magnesium Changesite,** marking the 11th known mineral identified from the Moon.
- The finding was announced by the China Geological Survey and is considered a major development in extraterrestrial geology.
- **The mineral was discovered in a lunar meteorite, the first of its kind to have fallen within China**, providing researchers with a rare opportunity to study naturally delivered Moon material on Earth.
- **One of the most striking features of Cerium-Magnesium Changesite is its fluorescent behaviour,** meaning it emits light under certain conditions.
- This property could have practical applications in advanced technologies, particularly in the development of next-generation LED materials.

G20 Satellite



- Indian Space Research Organisation Chairman V. Narayanan announced that the **proposed G20 Satellite is expected to be launched in 2027 for G20 member nations.**
- The G20 Satellite is a proposed collaborative Earth observation satellite being led by India for the benefit of G20 countries.
- **It is designed to study climate change indicators, monitor air pollution patterns, and improve global weather observation and forecasting systems.**
- To provide shared satellite-based data for climate monitoring, disaster forecasting, and environmental management among G20 nations.

Key Features:

- It will monitor atmospheric changes, greenhouse gas patterns, and climate-sensitive environmental parameters across regions.
- The satellite will help map aerosol concentration, pollution hotspots, and transboundary pollution flows for better policy intervention.
- **It will support early warning systems for cyclones, floods, droughts, and extreme weather events using real-time Earth observation data.**

Dung Beetles Use Milky Way for Night Navigation

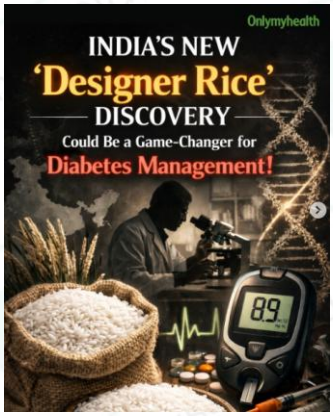


- Scientists have discovered that **dung beetles roll in remarkably straight lines—even in complete darkness by using the band of light created by our galaxy, the Milky Way.**
- The Dung Beetle, scientifically known as the Scarabaeidae family within the Animal Kingdom's order Coleoptera.
- They are robust, compact insects known for their hard, protective exoskeletons and strong, clawed legs adapted for digging and rolling dung.
- They vary in color, with some species displaying dull, black or brown hues, while others exhibit metallic shades of blue, green, or copper.
- Dung beetles are found worldwide, on every continent except Antarctica.
- They live in habitats that range from desert to forest.
- They feed on the feces of large herbivores during both their larval and adult stages.
- **They play major ecological roles in nutrient cycling, soil aeration, seed dispersal, and parasite/flies suppression.**

China launches Pakistani satellite

- **China launched a Pakistani satellite from its Taiyuan Satellite Launch Centre in north China's Shanxi Province.**
- The **satellite named PRSC-EO3** was lifted off by a Long March-6 carrier rocket and successfully entered its planned orbit.
- This is the fourth Pakistani satellite launched by China since last year.

Designer Rice



- **Scientists at CSIR – National Institute for Interdisciplinary Science and Technology in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, have developed a "designer rice" that packs three times the protein of normal grains** while maintaining a low glycemic index (below 55) to help manage diabetes.
- Instead of genetic modification, the scientists have used **food-processing technology.**
- They took broken rice, the bits usually sold at a discount—ground them into flour, and blended them with protein and micronutrients like iron, folic acid, and Vitamin B12.
- They then "reformed" this mixture into grains that look, feel, and taste exactly like the rice we know.
- **Protein powerhouse**: While normal rice has about 6–8 per cent protein, this version boasts over 20 per cent.
- **Fortified defense**: It bridges the gap for anaemia by embedding iron, folic acid, and Vitamin B12 directly into the grain's structure.

Fructose

- A recent study presents **fructose as a significant biological driver of conditions such as obesity, metabolic syndrome, and related chronic illnesses,** challenging conventional understandings of dietary sugars.
- It is a **member of a group of carbohydrates known as simple sugars, or monosaccharides.**
- It is one of the three most common natural monosaccharides. (The other two are glucose and galactose.)

- **Chemical Formula**: $C_6H_{12}O_6$ (same as glucose but with a different structure).
- Fructose is the **most water-soluble monosaccharide.**
- It is commonly known as **fruit sugar. Fructose naturally occurs in fruits, vegetables, honey, sugar cane, and sugar beets.**
- Fructose is significantly sweeter than glucose, making it ideal for use in beverages, desserts, and snacks.
- **Fructose and glucose combine to form the disaccharide sucrose, which we know as common sugar/table sugar.**
- **However, fructose needs to be converted into glucose by the liver before it can be used by the body.**
- Unlike other sugars, **fructose does not require insulin to be absorbed and therefore has a low impact on blood glucose levels.**
- When the digestive system doesn't absorb fructose properly, it can cause stomach pain, bloating, diarrhea and gas. This is known as fructose intolerance.

Dopamine

- Researchers recently showed for the first time that **dopamine dysfunction in the entorhinal cortex, a critical memory-related brain region, contributes directly to impaired memory formation.**
- **Dopamine is a hormone and a type of neurotransmitter**, or chemical messenger, made in your brain.
- **Your** nervous system uses it to send messages between nerve cells. These messages also travel between your brain and the rest of your body.
- This unique neurotransmitter affects your body, brain, and behavior.
- Dopamine is the chemical that mediates pleasure in the brain.
- **It is released when your brain is expecting a reward.**
- When you come to associate a certain activity with pleasure, mere anticipation may be enough to raise dopamine levels.
- It's a big part of our unique human ability to think and plan. It helps us focus, work towards goals, and find things interesting.
- **Dopamine is also made in other parts of your body, where it acts as a hormone.**
- High or low dopamine levels are associated with diseases including Parkinson's disease, restless legs syndrome, and attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD).

Dopamine acts as a hormone to help:

- relax or tighten your blood vessels when needed
- control your salt levels and urine production
- control how much insulin you make
- **slow down some parts of your digestion**
- **Dopamine is found in humans as well as animals**, including both vertebrates and invertebrates.

WHO approves first malaria treatment for infants



- The World Health Organization announced that it had given prequalification approval to a malaria treatment for newborns and infants for the first time.
- **Artemether-lumefantrine is the first antimalarial formulation designed specifically for the youngest victims of the mosquito-borne disease.**

What is Claude Mythos?



- Artificial intelligence company Anthropic has unveiled a preview of what it says is the most powerful model it has ever built — an advanced system called Claude Mythos —
- Anthropic has opted for a limited preview under a new cybersecurity initiative called "Project Glasswing", through which the model will be made available only to a small group of technology companies, infrastructure operators and security organisations.
- **The National Quantum Mission (NQM)**
- The Union Minister for Science & Technology, recently announced that the National Quantum Mission (NQM) has achieved a historic 1,000-km secure quantum communication milestone in less than two years.
- The National Quantum Mission is a specialized initiative aimed at seeding, nurturing, and scaling up scientific and industrial R&D in Quantum Technology (QT).
- It seeks to make India a leading nation in the quantum domain, which is considered the next frontier of computing and communication.
- Launched in: The mission was formally approved by the Union Cabinet in April 2023 and became operational in October 2024.

Memristor

- **Researchers from the University of Cambridge have reported a new kind of brain-inspired nanodevice, a hafnium-oxide memristor that could dramatically cut artificial intelligence's (AI) energy use.**
- 'Memristor' is a combination of 'memory' and 'resistor'.
- It is an **electronic component whose resistance depends on the history of current flow, allowing it to "remember" past electrical states.**
- A resistor is a small device that applies a fixed amount of resistance to a current passed through it.
- Unlike a resistor, a **memristor has variable resistance and 'remembers' the resistance.**
- When the current is removed, the memristor 'remembers' the resistance it offered and maintains it.
- **Memristors are nanomaterial and don't take up much space**. Their energy demand is also very small.
- They are usually made of a thin layer of titanium dioxide (TiO_2) sandwiched between two metal electrodes.

Applications of Memristor

- Due to their ability to store previous resistive states, **memristors are viable non-volatile random-access memories (NVRAM) for computers, industrial automation systems.**
- Memristors have been identified as viable components for augmenting or potentially replacing transistors in integrated circuits (ICs).
- Researchers are exploring the viability of using memristors **to build neuromorphic (brain-like) systems for artificial intelligence**

BioNEST Centre Boosts Food Startup Innovation at CFTRI



- Union Minister for Science and Technology Dr. Jitendra Singh inaugurated the BIRAC-BioNEST Incubation Centre at the **Central Food Technology and Research Institute (CFTRI).**
- The initiative aims to bridge the gap between laboratory research and commercial applications by **fostering startup-driven technologies in food processing and biotechnology.**

- The BioNEST Incubation Centre has been developed as a modern facility with dedicated incubation suites and shared infrastructure.

Glutathione

- Researchers **recently discovered glutathione's key part in maintaining the smooth operations of a protein-producing hub in the cell called the endoplasmic reticulum (ER).**

About Glutathione

- Glutathione is an antioxidant produced in the body through enzymatic reactions.
- It is a tripeptide consisting of three amino acids (glutamate, cysteine, and glycine) and is naturally produced in the liver.
- These **amino acids that make up glutathione are non-essential amino acids that our body can produce on its own when needed.**
- In addition to being produced naturally by the body, glutathione can be given intravenously, topically, or as an inhalant. It's also available as an oral supplement in capsule and liquid form.
- Some of the most abundant food sources of glutathione include cabbage, Brussels sprouts, garlic, onions, broccoli, and cauliflower.

Benefits:

- **Glutathione is often called the "master antioxidant" because of its crucial role in protecting and detoxifying cells.**
- It is involved in tissue building and repair, making chemicals and proteins needed in the body, and in immune system function.
- It also can play a role in treating certain genetic conditions.
- **Glutathione levels in the body may be reduced by a number of factors,** including poor nutrition, environmental toxins, and stress. Its levels also typically decline with age.

Newcastle Disease

- Recently, reports of Newcastle disease circulating across Europe, poultry producers across the UK are being urged to step up vigilance as the virus continues its westward spread.
- It is caused by avian paramyxovirus serotype 1, affects chickens and a wide range of other birds.
- It is a highly contagious and often severe disease found worldwide that affects birds including domestic poultry.
- The disease appears in three forms: lentogenic or mild, mesogenic or moderate and velogenic or very virulent.
- The lentogenic strains are very widespread but cause few disease outbreaks.
- Transmission: Infected birds shed virus in exhaled air, respiratory discharge, and feces.
- The virus can remain alive in manure for up to 2 months and in dead carcasses for up to 12 months, however, it is easily killed by disinfectants, fumigants and direct sunlight.



Surveillance Focus

Newcastle disease in Europe: lessons for UK poultry keepers

This focus article was prepared by **Zoe Treharne** of the APHA Avian Expert Group, with **Ashley C Banyard** and **Craig S Ross** of the APHA Virology Department, and **Paul Gale** of the APHA International Disease Monitoring team.

What is Newcastle disease?

Newcastle disease (ND) is a highly contagious viral infection affecting poultry, caused by virulent strains of avian paramyxovirus type 1 (APMV-1). ND can cause variable clinical signs such as respiratory or neurological disease, diarrhoea, depression, decreased feed intake, egg drop and soft-shelled eggs. The virus is shed in faeces and respiratory secretions, and spreads rapidly via direct contact or contaminated materials such as feed, water, equipment and clothing.

British poultry have remained free of ND since the last confirmed case in gamebirds in 2006. ND is a notifiable animal disease and any suspicion of ND in Great Britain (GB) must be reported immediately to the APHA. Failure to do so is an offence under the Diseases of Poultry (England) Order 2003. The current risk for disease in GB is low.[1]

Pigeon paramyxovirus type 1 (PPMV-1) is a virulent variant of APMV-1 and is endemic in GB in wild and feral pigeons.[2] Captive (non-poultry) and wild birds are also known to carry virulent strains of APMV-1. Recent developments in Europe have prompted renewed concern, and a timely reminder to consider ND in disease investigations and review preventive measures.

Current situation: a European resurgence

In 2025 (up to 31 July 2025), Poland has reported 76 outbreaks of ND – 44 in commercial poultry flocks and 32 in captive birds.[3] It is understood that some of the commercial outbreaks occurred in vaccinated birds, but no further information on the vaccines used is available.[3,4]

Outbreaks have also been reported in poultry in Bulgaria (one), Malta (two), North Macedonia (two) and Slovenia (one), and captive bird (non-poultry) cases have been reported in the Czech Republic (two), Germany (one), the Netherlands (one) and Slovenia (one).[5] The map in Fig 1 shows the outbreaks reported in poultry between January and July 2025. In the Netherlands, PPMV-1 was detected in one flock of captive pigeons in May.[5]

The Polish outbreaks span across central and eastern regions and into the north west[3] and may indicate biosecurity lapses. Affected flocks include broilers, layers and turkeys, some of which had been vaccinated. It is possible that the emergence of ND in vaccinated flocks is due to ineffective vaccination protocols or a build up of infection pressure because of low immunity within the surrounding avian population, such as non-vaccinated flocks or wild birds. Antigenic diversity between vaccine strains and contemporary wild-type strains may also impact on the level of vaccinal protection seen.

Mandatory vaccination was introduced in April 2025 in Poland, with follow-up serology to test for efficacy.[3]

The affected commercial farms in Poland have culled more than 4.3 million poultry while the non-commercial smallholder farms have culled 1096 birds.[3]

"It is understood that some of the commercial outbreaks occurred in vaccinated birds"

Fig 1: Map showing outbreaks (blue dots) of Newcastle disease in poultry in Europe between January and July 2025, reported to the World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH). Source: WOAH, https://wahis.woah.org/#/dashboards/country-or-disease-dashboard

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Symptoms

- It usually presents as a respiratory disease, but depression, nervous manifestations, or diarrhoea may be the predominant clinical form.
- Respiratory signs – gasping, coughing, sneezing and rales
- Nervous signs – tremors, paralyzed wings and legs, twisted necks, circling, spasms, and paralysis

- Apartial or complete drop in egg production may occur. Eggs may be abnormal in color, shape, or surface, and have watery albumen
- Treatment: There is no treatment for Newcastle Disease, although treatment with antibiotics to control secondary infections may assist.

Bacille Calmette-Guérin (BCG) Vaccine



- **India has delivered 13 tonnes of Bacille Calmette-Guérin (BCG) vaccines and related materials to Afghanistan's Ministry of Public Health.**
- The BCG vaccine is a live attenuated (weakened) vaccine primarily used to provide protection against Tuberculosis (TB).
- It is the **only licensed vaccine available against TB** and is one of the most widely administered vaccines in the world, typically given to newborns.
- **Developed By:** It was developed by French scientists Albert Calmette and Camille Guérin at the Pasteur Institute. After 13 years of research, it was first administered to humans in 1921.

Aim:

- To prevent severe forms of childhood TB, such as TB meningitis and disseminated TB.
- To **reduce the overall global burden of tuberculosis**, especially in endemic regions.
- To provide cross-protection against other mycobacterial diseases like Leprosy and Buruli ulcer.

Components of the Vaccine:

- A live attenuated strain of Mycobacterium bovis, a bacterium that causes TB in cattle but is weakened for human use.
- **Typically includes stabilizers like glycerol, citric acid, and various salts (sodium, potassium, magnesium) to maintain potency.**
- The vaccine is often supplied in a freeze-dried (lyophilized) form requiring diluents for reconstitution.
- The **vaccine introduces a weakened form of the bacteria** into the body, which primes the immune system to recognize mycobacterial proteins.
- **This stimulates the production of T-cells and antibodies without causing the disease itself.** Upon future exposure to Mycobacterium tuberculosis, the immune system can mount a rapid and effective defense.

Key Features

- Injected intradermally (into the skin), usually in the upper left arm.
- **Beyond prevention, it is used as a form of immunotherapy to treat certain types of bladder cancer.**

Psychedelics



- Recent study revealed that Psychedelics can temporarily 'loosen' the brain patterns that support the feeling of a 'me', allowing researchers to watch that system reorganise itself in real time.
- These are drugs that induce states of altered perception, behaviour, consciousness and thought, often with increased awareness of the senses.
- Psychedelics are non-addictive and non-toxic. Compared to illicit drugs, psychedelics cause much less harm to the end user.
- The term 'psychedelic' comes from two Greek words denoting mind or soul and manifesting.

- It is a subset of psychotropic substances that can alter a person's thoughts and perceptions, and elicit intense hallucinations.
- Most psychedelics work by increasing the availability of serotonin—a mood stabilising hormone—in the brain by binding to serotonin receptors (a molecule on the cell surface that binds to a specific chemical, causing a specific effect).
- Regulation in India: In India, the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act 1985 prohibits the use of psychedelic substances.

Keytruda

- **Recent investigations have exposed a dangerous counterfeit market for Keytruda in India, where hospital-level breaches** and high drug prices have led to fakes being sold to desperate patients.
- **Keytruda is the brand name for Pembrolizumab, a revolutionary immunotherapy drug used to treat various advanced and aggressive cancers.**
- Unlike traditional treatments that attack the tumor directly, **Keytruda is a checkpoint inhibitor** that helps the body's own immune system identify and destroy cancer cells.
- **Developed By**: It is manufactured by the U.S.-based global pharmaceutical giant Merck & Co. (known as MSD outside the U.S. and Canada).
- **The primary goal of Keytruda is to remove the brakes on the immune system.**
- Specifically, it seeks to prevent cancer cells from hiding from the body's T-cells, thereby allowing the immune system to launch an effective attack against the tumor.
- **In India, Merck provides a buy five, get 30 free scheme to help eligible patients (those with insurance/income below ₹25 lakh) manage the high cost of treatment**.

GLP-1 Drugs Use, Risks, and Regulation

- Multiple variants of GLP-1 drugs have been recently introduced in the Indian market, and concerns have emerged regarding their on-demand availability through retail pharmacies, online platforms, wholesalers, and wellness clinics.
- GLP-1 drugs (glucagon-like peptide-1 receptor agonists) are medications developed to treat both type 2 diabetes and obesity by correcting hormonal imbalance - stimulating insulin release and suppressing excess glucagon -to bring blood sugar back under control.
- The drugs regulate blood sugar and appetite and are also used to treat obesity.
- Essentially, they slow down the gastric emptying, increasing the feeling of fullness.
- This decreases patients' appetites and thereby leads to their weight loss.

Diabetes

- Diabetes is a chronic disease that occurs when the pancreas does not produce adequate insulin, or when the body cannot effectively use the insulin it produces, leading to high blood sugar.
- If left untreated, it can lead to complications like blindness, kidney failure, heart attacks, stroke and lower limb amputation.
- Insulin and glucagon are hormones produced by the pancreas that regulate blood sugar (glucose) levels.
- Insulin helps convert food into energy and lowers blood sugar by enabling cells to absorb glucose, while glucagon raises blood sugar when levels drop too low.
- Together, the two hormones keep blood sugar within a healthy range.

Environment

India withdraws bid to host COP 33 in 2028



- India has withdrawn its candidacy to host the 33rd Conference of Parties (COP33) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) in 2028, citing a "review of its commitments for 2028."
- Following the confirmed hosts of Australia and Turkey (COP31, 2026), and Ethiopia (COP32, 2027), India's withdrawal leaves South Korea as the only contender to fill the vacancy for COP33 in 2028.

United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC)

- About: The UNFCCC is the primary international treaty aimed at preventing "dangerous human interference with the climate system."
  - It serves as the primary international treaty for coordinating a global response to stabilize greenhouse gas (GHG) concentrations and prevent dangerous human interference with the climate system.
- Establishment and Objective: Adopted in 1992 at the Rio Earth Summit and entering into force in 1994, its core objective is to ensure food security and allow sustainable economic development while ecosystems adapt to climate change.

Government notifies Two Key Institutions as Repositories

- The National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) notified two premier scientific institutions—CMLRE, Kochi and ARI, Pune—as designated National Repositories under Section 39 of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002.
- A National Repository is a government-designated institution authorized to keep voucher specimens (physical samples) of biological resources in safe custody.
- Under Section 39 of the Biological Diversity Act, these repositories act as the official legal guardians of newly discovered species and microbial cultures, ensuring they are preserved for future research and to prevent biopiracy.

The Two New Repositories:

Referral Centre Bhavasagara at the Centre for Marine Living Resources and Ecology (CMLRE), Kochi

Focus: Deep-Sea Biodiversity.

- Collection: Houses over 3,500 taxonomically identified and geo-referenced specimens, including deep-sea fishes and invertebrates.

MACS Microorganism & Fungal Collection at Agharkar Research Institute (ARI) Pune

- Focus: Microbes and Fungi.
- MACS Collection: Specializes in anaerobic and extremophilic microorganisms (those that live in extreme conditions without oxygen).
- Fungal Collection: A leading repository for authenticated fungal cultures collected from diverse Indian habitats.

India Leads Globally in Nagoya Protocol Compliance Certificates



- India has emerged as the global leader in biodiversity compliance, issuing 3,561 Internationally Recognized Certificates of Compliance (IRCCs), which accounts for over 56% of the total certificates issued worldwide under the Nagoya Protocol.
- The Nagoya Protocol is a supplementary agreement to the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD).
- It provides a transparent legal framework for the effective implementation of one of the three objectives of the CBD: the fair and equitable sharing of benefits arising out of the utilization of genetic resources.
- Adopted in: October 29, 2010, in Nagoya, Japan.
- Entered into Force: October 12, 2014.

Members:

- There are currently 141 parties to the Nagoya Protocol (including 140 UN member states and the European Union).
- India and the Nagoya Protocol:
- Signatory: India signed the protocol in 2011 and ratified it in 2012.
- Legal Framework: India implements the protocol through the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, and the Biological Diversity Rules, 2004.
- Authorities: The National Biodiversity Authority (NBA), headquartered in Chennai, acts as the primary body.

Recently, Varkala has been named in the inaugural 20 Cities Towards Zero Waste initiative.



- Varkala Municipality in Kerala has been selected as the only city from India in the inaugural "20 Cities Towards Zero Waste" initiative.

About 20 Cities Towards Zero Waste Initiative

- It is an initiative led by the UN Secretary-General's Advisory Board on Zero Waste, with support from UN-Habitat and the UN Environment Programme (UNEP).
- It highlights cities demonstrating ambitious and innovative approaches to reducing waste, advancing circular economy solutions, and building more sustainable, resilient, and inclusive urban systems.

Vantara University Launched for Wildlife and Veterinary Sciences



- **Vantara, the wildlife conservation initiative founded by Reliance Industries Executive Director Anant Ambani, announced the setting up of a university, dedicated to wildlife and veterinary sciences, in Jamnagar, Gujarat**
- The university will offer undergraduate, postgraduate, fellowship, and specialised programmes in disciplines such as wildlife medicine and surgery, behavioural sciences, genetics, epidemiology, conservation policy and One Health.



Per- and Polyfluoroalkyl Substances

- Recently, the European Union (EU) Parliament approved updated EU water pollution standards and added Per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances (PFAS) into the pollutants list which needs to be monitored.
- These are toxic, man-made, hazardous chemicals.
- These are also known as the Forever Chemicals.
- They are a large family of fluorinated chemicals that have partially or completely fluorinated carbon chains of varied lengths.
- Because the carbon-fluorine bond is one of the strongest, these chemicals do not degrade easily in the environment.
- Subgroups: Perfluorooctane sulfonic acid (PFOS) and Perfluorooctanoic acid (PFOA), and persistent organic pollutants (POPs).
- These subgroups are currently listed under the Stockholm Convention as industrial POPs.
- They are ingredients in various everyday products.

Example, PFAS are used to keep food from sticking to packaging or cookware, make clothes and carpets resistant to stains

- PFAS are used in the aerospace, automotive, construction, and electronics industries. Over time, PFAS may leak into the soil, water, and air.
- Regulation: The Stockholm Convention has listed some PFAS, such as Perfluorooctane sulfonic acid (PFOS) and Perfluorooctanoic acid (PFOA), as persistent organic pollutants (POPs).

Tar Balls



- Tar balls are small, dark, sticky, or hardened blobs of weathered crude oil found floating on the ocean surface or washed ashore on beaches.
- They are essentially the remnants of oil that has undergone physical and chemical changes due to environmental exposure.

Tar balls are complex mixtures consisting of:

- Hydrocarbons: Primarily heavy, high-molecular-weight compounds like paraffins and aromatics.
- Asphaltenes: These provide the characteristic black color and sticky texture.
- Impurities: They often trap sand, shells, seaweed, and microplastics as they roll along the ocean floor or beach.
- Sulfur and Metals: Trace amounts of nickel and vanadium are often present, depending on the source of the crude oil.
- The formation of tar balls is a result of a process called weathering:
- Oil Release: It begins with an oil spill from ships, offshore platforms, or natural oil seeps on the ocean floor.

- Evaporation & Dissolution: Lighter components of the oil evaporate into the air or dissolve in water.
- Emulsification: The remaining heavy oil mixes with seawater to form a thick, mousse-like emulsion.
- Fragmentation: Wind and waves break this thick oil into smaller pieces.
- Solidification: As the lighter fractions continue to leave, the residue hardens into sticky, dense spheres (tar balls) that are carried by currents to the shore.

They are highly resistant to environmental degradation and can remain in the marine environment for a long time.

- They can range from the size of a coin to that of a basketball.
- In India, they are most prominent on the western coast (Gujarat to Goa) between April and September due to south-westerly winds and currents.

Lead



- A study by Toxics Link, a Delhi-based research and advocacy group, has found high levels of lead contamination in soil near battery recycling units across Delhi-NCR.
- It is a naturally occurring element found in small amounts in the earth's crust.

Properties

- It is a soft, silvery white or grayish metal in Group 14 (IVa) of the periodic table.
- Lead has a bright lustre and is a dense, ductile, very soft, highly malleable, bluish-white metal that has poor electrical conductivity.
- It is also highly resistant to corrosion and because of this property is used to contain corrosive liquids (e.g. sulphuric acid).
- Occurrence: It is usually found in ore with zinc, silver and copper and is extracted together with these metals.
- The main lead mineral is galena (PbS). Other common varieties include cerussite ($PbCO_3$) and angelsite ($PbSO_4$).
- Uses of Lead
- The principal use of lead is for lead-acid batteries for vehicles, backup emergency systems, the telecoms sector and fork lift trucks.
- Lead is also used in rolled and extruded products, compounds in the glass and plastics industries, shot and ammunition and for radiation shielding.

Barnawapara Wildlife Sanctuary



- Recently, Blackbucks were reintroduced into their natural habitat at Rampur grassland in Barnawapara Wildlife Sanctuary.
- Barnawapara Wildlife Sanctuary Location: It is located in the northern part of the Mahasamund district of Chhattisgarh.
- It is named after the Bar and Nawapara forest villages, which are in the heart of the sanctuary.
- The tributaries of Mahanadi are the source of water.
- The River Balamdehi forms the western boundary, and the Jonk River forms the northeastern boundary of the sanctuary.
- It mainly consists of tropical dry deciduous forest.

- It is home to neelgai, wild boar, tigers, leopards, Indian bison, porcupines, pythons, antelopes, sambhar and cheetal, along with 150 species of birds, including parrots, blackbucks, herons, egrets, peafowl, etc

Umred–Pauni–Karhandla Wildlife Sanctuary

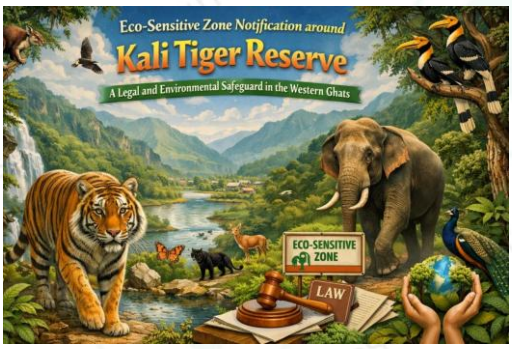


- Recently, a melanistic (black-colored) spotted deer, commonly known as a chital, has been spotted at the Umred–Pauni–Karhandla Wildlife Sanctuary near Nagpur.
- Location: It is spread over Pauni tehsil in Bhandara district and Umred, Kuhi, and Bhivapur Taluka of Nagpur district in Maharashtra.
- It was established in 2013 and is spread across an area of 189 sq. km.
- It is surrounded by the Wainganga River and the Gose Khurd Dam along the northeast boundaries of the sanctuary, while State Highway 9 and Bhiwapur Town bound the southern side.
- The forest along the Wainganga River connects this sanctuary to the Tadoba Andhari Tiger Reserve.
- It lies 80 km from Pench Tiger Reserve and 50 kilometers southwest of Nagzira Wildlife Sanctuary

Eturnagaram Wildlife Sanctuary

- Recently, a massive forest fire has engulfed hundreds of hectares of Eturnagaram Wildlife Sanctuary in Mulugu district.
- **Eturnagaram Wildlife Sanctuary is located near the border of Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, and Telangana of Telangana.**
- It was established in 1952.
- **Rivers**: It has a water source called Dayyam Vagu, which separates the sanctuary into two parts.
- The **river Godavari also passes through it.**
- The famous Sammakka-Saralamma Temple is situated inside the sanctuary.

Kali Tiger Reserve



- The Union environment ministry proposes an Eco-Sensitive Zone around Karnataka's Kali Tiger Reserve, spanning 663.32 sq km.
- It is located in the central portion of the Uttara Kannada (North Canara) district of Karnataka.
- The Tiger Reserve comprises two important protected areas of the region viz., Dandeli Wildlife Sanctuary (475.018 Km^2) and Anshi National Park (339.866 Km^2).
- These two protected areas are contiguous to each other and form a single tract of the protected area located in the biologically sensitive Western Ghats.
- It shares a border with Bhimghad Wildlife Sanctuary in the north, which is further connected to Radhanagari and Koyna wildlife sanctuaries in Maharashtra.
- To the west, Kali Tiger Reserve shares borders with five protected areas in Goa.
- The terrain is incredibly diverse, ranging from rolling hills and steep escarpments to riverine valleys and plateaus.
- River: The Kali River, which forms the major source of water for Uttara Kannada, flows through the tiger reserve, hence the name.
- Vegetation: It is a blend of semi-evergreen and moist deciduous forests, interspersed with patches of bamboo and grasslands.

Kugti Wildlife Sanctuary


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- Recently, a rare white female albino Himalayan 'tahr' has been recorded in the Kugti Wildlife Sanctuary at Bharmour in Chamba district.
- Kugti Wildlife Sanctuary is the second largest sanctuary located in Himachal Pradesh .
- It houses the famous Manimahesh temple, an attraction to thousands of pilgrims despite the difficult terrain and extreme cold conditions.
- It has a high-altitude sanctuary between Ravi and Chenab rivers.
- It is surrounded by Dhauladhar Wildlife Sanctuary on South-East direction and Tundah Wildlife Sanctuary in the North-West direction.
- It is at altitudes ranging from 2,195 meters to 5,040 meters

Navegaon-Nagzira Tiger Reserve

- The Navegaon Nagzira Tiger Reserve (NNTR) in Maharashtra's Gondia will get control of the buffer notified area in its vicinity from April 1.
- Navegaon-Nagzira Tiger Reserve is located in the state of Maharashtra.
- It is located in the heart of the central Indian Tiger Landscape, which contributes almost 1/6 of the total tiger population of the country.
- It was declared a tiger reserve in 2013; it is the fifth tiger reserve in Maharashtra.
- It comprises the notified areas of Nawegaon National Park, Nawegaon Wildlife Sanctuary, Nagzira Wildlife Sanctuary, New Nagzira Wildlife Sanctuary, and Koka Wildlife Sanctuary.
- It has linkages with Kanha, Pench, and Tadoba Tiger Reserves.
- Topography: The topography is undulating, and the highest point, viz. 'Zenda Pahad', is around 702 m above Mean Sea Level.

India-born cheetah gives birth to four cubs at Kuno; total population reaches 57


MP/ India-Born Female Cheetah Delivers 4 Cubs In Kuno, Population Rises To 57

Deccanchronicle.com

- Four cubs have been born to an India-born cheetah in Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh, takes India's total population of cheetahs to 57.
- **This is the first recorded cheetah birth in the open forest since India's reintroduction programme for the big cat species,** Project Cheetah, was launched in 2022, as all previous births have taken place inside Kuno's large-ranging enclosures.

Kuno National Park:

- It is located in the Sheopur district of Madhya Pradesh.
- **It is nestled near the Vindhyan Hills.**
- Originally established as Kuno Wildlife Sanctuary in 1981, it was upgraded to a national park in 2018.
- **The park's historical significance lies in its role as a relocation site for Asiatic lions under the "Asiatic Lion Reintroduction Project,".**
- It **derives its name from the meandering Kuno River** (one of the main tributaries of the Chambal River), which flows from south to north and divides the park into two sections.

Emperor Penguin and Antarctic Fur Seal



- The International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) has officially uplisted the Emperor penguin and the Antarctic fur seal to the Endangered category due to the devastating impacts of climate change.

- The Emperor penguin is the largest of all living penguin species and a sentinel species that serves as an indicator of the health of the Antarctic ecosystem.
- They are iconic for their survival in the harshest conditions on Earth and are currently facing a sharp decline due to human-induced greenhouse gas emissions.

Habitat:



- They are native to Antarctica and rely heavily on fast ice—sea ice that is fastened to the coastline or ocean floor.
- This ice serves as a critical habitat for raising their chicks and during their annual moulting season.
- IUCN Status: Endangered

About Antarctic Fur Seals:

- The Antarctic fur seal is a marine mammal that is part of the eared seal family.
- Their survival is intrinsically linked to the Antarctic marine ecosystem, particularly the availability of krill, which is their primary food source.
- They inhabit the Antarctic and sub-Antarctic waters, with a major breeding stronghold at South Georgia.
- Rising ocean temperatures are pushing their habitat and food sources further south or to greater depths.
- IUCN Status: Endangered

Jumping Spiders

- A **team of scientists recently discovered two new species of jumping spiders named Mogrus shushka and Mogrus pune**, thriving in the country's drylands and urban green spaces.

Mogrus shushka and Mogrus pune

- These are **two newly discovered arachnids belonging to the genus Mogrus**, a group of medium-sized jumping spiders typically found in the arid regions of Africa, Europe, and Asia.

Mogrus shushka:

- It was **identified in Desert National Park, Rajasthan**, a region better known for its sand dunes and iconic desert wildlife.
- Derived from the Sanskrit word shushka for 'dry,' the name reflects the extreme, arid conditions in which the spider thrives.
- It is highly adapted to intense heat, low humidity, and sandy terrain, conditions that define the Thar desert.

Mogrus pune:

- It was **discovered in the Alfa Laval Biodiversity Park in Maharashtra**. It was named after the city of Pune.
- **Male M. pune can be easily distinguished by a heart-shaped bump on its reproductive organ** and uniquely curved structures, while the female possesses a distinctively wide and membranous central depression.

Indian Softshell Turtle



- Recently, during a routine check police rescued 16 Indian Softshell turtles in Greater Noida.
- Indian softshell turtles (Nilssonia gangetica) are one of the largest freshwater turtle species in the world.

- It is also known as the Ganges Softshell turtle.
- Habitat: These turtles inhabit deep rivers, streams, canals, lakes and ponds, typically preferring areas with sandy or muddy bottoms.
- Mainly found in Indus, Ganges, Meghna, Brahmaputra, Yamuna, Narmada and Mahanandi river basins.

Conservation Status

- IUCN Red List: Endangered
- Wildlife Protection Act, 1972: Schedule I

The Indian EXPRESS

A routine check, moving jute bag: How 16 Indian Softshell turtles were rescued in Greater Noida

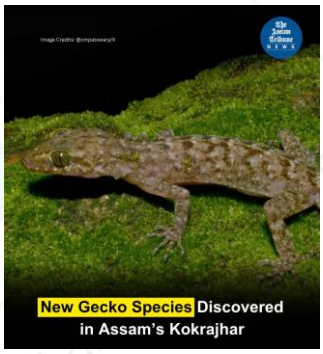


Indian Crested Porcupine



- Recently, it was observed that the Indian crested porcupine has begun feeding on saffron corms beneath the soil, hollowing out harvests before they can bloom in Kashmir.
- It mainly occurs on rocky hill sides but is also found in tropical and temperate scrublands, grasslands, and forests.
- They are also found throughout the Himalayan Mountains, reaching up to elevations of 2400 meters.
- Distribution: It is found throughout southeast and central Asia and in parts of the Middle East, including such countries as India, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Pakistan, Israel, Iran, and Saudi Arabia.
- Lifespan: 18 to 20 years
- It is nocturnal, with the species seeking shelter in caves, between rocks, or in its burrow during the day.
- Conservation Status IUCN Red List: Least Concerned
- Quills: A porcupine's best defense is the formidable set of quills on its back. But it can't "throw" them. When alarmed, the Indian Porcupine launches its quill for a backward attack.

Cyrtodactylus jayadityai



- Recently, researchers **discovered a new gecko species in Tripura** and named it as Cyrtodactylus jayadityai.
- It is a newly discovered species of bent-toed gecko from Tripura.
- **Habitat**: It inhabits lowland forest patches.
- It is **primarily nocturnal**, emerging at night to forage and retreating into burrows and crevices during the day.

What are Geckos?

- These **are reptiles and are found on all the continents except Antarctica**.
- These colorful lizards have adapted to habitats from rainforests, to deserts, to cold mountain slopes.
- These are mostly small, usually nocturnal reptiles.

Cyrtodactylus raimonaensis



- Recently, a new species of bent-toed gecko has been discovered in Assam and reseaechers named it as "Cyrtodactylus raimonaensis".

Cyrtodactylus raimonaensis

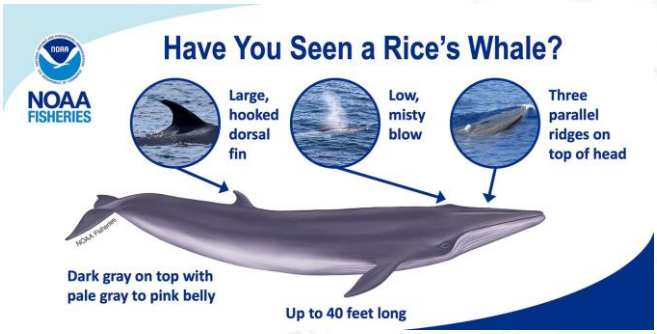
- It is a species of bent-toed gecko.
- It belongs to the Cyrtodactylus genus which is amongst the largest groups of geckos worldwide.

- It **has been found near Raimona National Park in Kokrajhar district, Assam and named after the park itself.**

Key Facts Raimona National Park

- **Location**: It is located in the north-western part of Assam.
- It lies along the India-Bhutan border and is situated at the foothills of the Eastern Himalayas.
- **It is connected with Phibsoo Wildlife Sanctuary and Jigme Singye Wangchuck National Park.**

Rice's Whale



- Scientists fear that the USA administration's plan to expand oil drilling in the Gulf of Mexico will push Rice's Whales to extinction.
- Rice's whales are members of the baleen whale family Balaenopteridae.
- These are most closely related to Bryde's whales.
- In 2021, the Rice's whale was recognized as a new species, evolutionarily distinct from other Bryde's whales around the world.
- Distribution: It is the only whale species that lives year-round in the Gulf of America.
- Diet: They are mainly dependent on silver-rag driftfish.

Conservation Status

- IUCN Red List: Critically Endangered.

Indus River Dolphin



- Recently, it was observed that conservation reserves, citizen science, and habitat protection gives the Indus River dolphin a fighting chance in India.
- **The Indus River dolphin (Platanista minor) is one of the rarest mammals.**
- **Distribution**: It presently only occurs in the Indus River system, along with a remnant population in the Beas River.
- It is functionally blind. It has extremely reduced eyes without lenses.
- **Instead of vision, it relies entirely on echolocation to navigate, hunt and avoid obstacles in the highly turbid waters.**
- This allows it to use its long, sensitive snout to probe the riverbed for prey. Side-swimming is extremely rare among cetaceans and is a signature feature of this species.
- **Diet**: These are carnivores (piscivores). They feed on a variety of fish and crustaceans, including prawns, carp, catfish, and gobies.

Conservation Status

- **IUCN Red List:** Endangered
- **Wildlife Protection Act 1972**: Schedule I.

The Himalayan Griffon



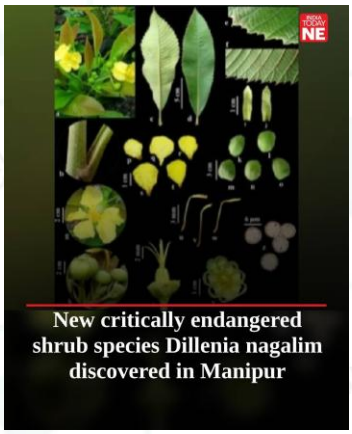
- The Dudhwa Tiger Reserve witnessed a rare sight of several Himalayan Griffon vultures collapsing.
- A total of 25 vultures were found dead, while six were rescued in an unconscious state and given injections.
- **The International Union for Conservation of Nature's (IUCN) Red List lists the raptor (Gyps himalayensis) as 'Near Threatened'.**

Morchella Mushroom Cultivated in Controlled Conditions in Kashmir



- **Recently, the Sheri Kashmir University of Agriculture and Sciences (SKUAST) in Srinagar has cultivated the Morchella mushroom for the first time in controlled condition.**
- It is an edible mushroom from the Ascomycota group.
- **Morels or Morchella is locally known as Kangaech or Gucchi mushroom.**
- It grows naturally in specific high elevation forest ecosystems during a narrow rainy season.
- **Properties:** It is a highly valued gourmet mushroom known for its intense and distinct flavour, superior nutritional profile and medicinal properties.
- **Appearance**: They are pale yellow in colour with large pits and ridges on the surface of the cap, raised on a large white stem.
- **Ideal weather conditions for the great morel are daytime temperature is between 15 and 20 Celsius and night-time temperatures are in the five to nine**.
- **They grow in conifer forests across temperature regions, and the foothills in Himachal Pradesh, Uttaranchal, and Jammu and Kashmir.**
- They may or may not grow in the same spot the next season, which only makes the process of collection more tedious.
- It is **known to be one of the most expensive mushrooms**

Dillenia nagalim



- A team of researchers recently discovered a new plant species in Manipur's Kamjong district, naming it Dillenia nagalim.
- The name "nagalim" is derived from "**Naga" (referring to the indigenous Naga communities) and "lim," meaning land,** reflecting the plant's origin in a region predominantly inhabited by the Tangkhul Naga tribe near the Indo-Myanmar border.
- The **species is currently known only from a single location, making it endemic to the area**.
- The **plant grows in open tropical deciduous forests.**
- The species has been provisionally classified as "Critically Endangered" under IUCN criteria.

Recently, the Uttarakhand High Court stayed the felling of oak trees in Mussoorie for construction by the Municipal Council



- Oaks are found in diverse habitats around the world, with a broad distribution in North America, Europe, Asia, and parts of Africa.
- They can adapt to various climates, from temperate to subtropical regions.
- These are the dominant, climax tree species of the moist temperate forests in the Indian Himalayan region.
- Oaks found in Uttarakhand are Banj oak, Moru oak, Kharsu oak, Rianj oak, and Phaliath oak
- Oaks thrive in a variety of climates but are commonly found in temperate zones. They can endure cold winters and warm summers.
- They can tolerate different soil types, including sandy, loamy, and clayey soils.

- The species are providers of numerous ecosystem services such as conservation of soil, water, native flora and fauna, and serve as a lifeline for the local communities.

Annatto



- **Annatto seed growers pitch for government support as these seeds are the world's second most important natural colourant after caramel.**
- It is a natural food colouring and flavoring agent obtained **from the seeds of the achiote tree (Bixa orellana).**
- Achiote tree is native to tropical America and is also cultivated in Asia and Africa, especially in areas where coffee is grown.
- The **ripe fruits of annatto on drying yield annatto seed which serves as the raw material for the production of annatto colour.**
- The crop is completely rain-fed and requires no pesticides or fertilizers, just pruning of branches as part of crop management.
- **Colour**: The bold color comes from carotenoids, which are plant pigments that are found in the coating of the seed

Applications of Annatto

- The annatto seed is widely used as a **natural food colour and dye.**
- Its color can also be extracted from the seed and then **added to foods as a dye**.
- Some also use annatto to boost the **flavor of certain dishes.**
- It has a mild, **peppery flavor** when used in large amounts as well as a nutty and floral scent.
- Annatto is **rich in several key antimicrobial compounds**, which can limit the growth of bacteria, fungi, and parasites

Earthquake Lights



- Recently, small earthquakes shook parts of the Aegean Sea near Turkey and Greece and floating lights appear in the sky after an earthquake near Turkey which is called earthquake lights by the scientists.
- Earthquake lights are flashes, streaks, balls, or tall pillars of light that sometimes appear in the sky right before, during, or just after an earthquake.

Formation

- Earthquakes happen when huge tectonic plates push and grind against each other.
- This stress squeezes rocks in the crust, especially those containing quartz or certain minerals.
- The pressure creates electric charges inside the rocks.
- These charges then flow upward through cracks and faults until they reach the surface. Once there, they bump into air molecules and ionise them, stripping electrons and creating glowing plasma.
- The result is visible flashes or steady beams with no heat or fire.



Mount Semeru



- The Mount Semeru, the tallest and one of the most active volcanoes in Indonesia, erupted multiple times, sending thick ash plumes up to 1,100 metres into the sky.
- Mount Semeru, also known as Mahameru (The Great Mountain), is an active stratovolcano (composite volcano).
- It is characterized by its steep profile and periodic, explosive eruptions. It is the highest peak on the island of Java and a sacred site in local culture.
- **Location: Island: East Java, Indonesia.**
- It is part of the Tengger Massif, a volcanic complex that includes the famous Mount Bromo.
- Located on the Pacific Ring of Fire, where the Indo-Australian Plate subducts beneath the Sunda plate (which is part of Eurasian Plate).
- Mount Semeru is a product of subduction zone volcanism.





- The denser Indo-Australian oceanic plate sinks into the mantle beneath the Sunda Shelf.
- The highest point is called Mahameru. The active crater, Jonggring Seloko, is located southeast of the summit.

A 'very strong' El Niño is likely to develop along the Pacific Ocean

- A 'very strong' El Niño is likely to develop along the Pacific Ocean during the latter half of this year and persist till the end of 2026, the US-based National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA)
- The El **Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO) is a global ocean-atmospheric phenomenon that is based on the ocean surface temperature along the equatorial and central Pacific Ocean.**
- **ENSO has three phases :** El Niño (warm), neutral and La Niña (cool) and the phase is based on the Relative Oceanic Niño Index, a temperature value measured of a specific region, known as the Niño 3.4, along the Pacific Ocean.
- These phases alternate once every two to seven years.
- El Niño affects global weather and is known to cause extreme heat, drought and below average rainfall.

Union Minister Bhupender Yadav announces Shekha Jheel Bird Sanctuary as Ramsar site



- Recently, the Shekha Jheel Bird Sanctuary in Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh was designated as a Ramsar site, taking India's total to 99.
- **Location:** It is located in the state of Uttar Pradesh.
- **this marks the state's 12th Ramsar Site**
- It is a typical monsoonal wetland of the Gangetic plains.
- **It is a fresh water perennial water body that came into existence after the formation of the Upper Ganges Canal in 1852 which flows adjacent to the lake.**
- It acts as a crucial stopover on the Central Asian Flyway.
- It is providing a vital habitat for migratory birds such as the Bar-headed Goose, Painted Stork.

Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav announces addition of two new wetlands to India's Ramsar network (JAN 2026)

- The wetlands in Kutch in Gujarat and Etah in Uttar Pradesh have been recognised as Ramsar sites
- **The designation of Patna Bird Sanctuary in Etah and Chhari-Dhand in Kutch as Ramsar sites.**
- The designation of these two sites under the Ramsar Convention takes the total number of such **wetlands in India to 98.**
- **Siliserh Lake in Alwar district, Rajasthan, and Kopra Jalashay near Bilaspur, Chhattisgarh**, have been added to the List of Wetlands (95th – 96th).

Ramsar Convention – Key Facts

- **Adopted:** 1971 in Ramsar, Iran
- **Came into force:** 1975
- **Nature:** Intergovernmental treaty for conservation and wise use of wetlands
- **Membership:** ~90% of UN member states are contracting parties
- **India's participation:** Became a member on 1 February 1982
- To be declared a Wetland of International Importance, a site must meet at least 1 of 9 Ramsar criteria.

India Submits New Climate Targets to UN



- India has submitted its revised climate targets for 2031-2035 to the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC),
- This is India's third NDC, the first two having been submitted in 2015, pertaining to the year 2025, and then in 2022, for 2030.
- **The development comes after the Cabinet in March approved the nationally determined contributions (NDC) -- the non-binding, voluntary climate action plans that every country is obligated to decide upon and implement under the 2015 Paris Agreement.**

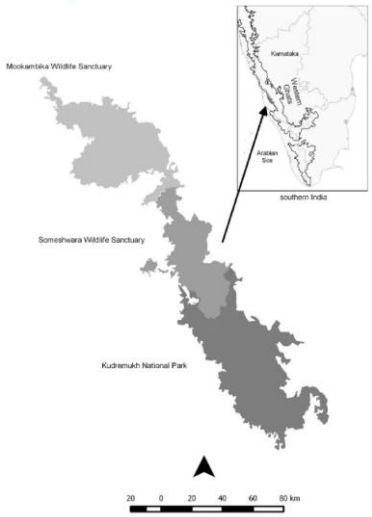
Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs), for 2031-35

- committing to attain at least 47 per cent reduction in the emission intensity of its GDP (emission per unit of GDP) from the 2005 baseline by 2035.
- India also committed to "achieve about 60 pc cumulative electric power installed capacity from non-fossil fuel-based energy resources by 2035 with the help of transfer of technology and low-cost international finance
- **"create a carbon sink of 3.5 to 4.0 billion tonnes of CO2** equivalent through forest and tree cover by 2035 as compared to the baseline year of 2005"

Achievements

- **India "achieved 40 pc cumulative electrical power installed capacity from non-fossil fuel-based energy sources in 2021** and reduced the emission intensity of India's GDP from 2005 levels by 33 pc in 2019; nine and eleven years before the target year of 2030, respectively

Mookambika Wildlife Sanctuary



- **Sewage from commercial activities related to religious tourism in Kollur has emerged as a threat to the Mookambika Wildlife Sanctuary in Udupi district**, with the depleted Souparnika river carrying sewage and sludge to the core area in summer.
- It is located in the Udupi district of **Karnataka**.
- Set in the Western Ghats, the sanctuary covers an area of approximately 370 sq.km.
- **The sanctuary is named after the presiding deity of the Kollur Mookambika Temple**, which is located within its boundaries.
- It forms a vital connecting link between Someshwara Wildlife Sanctuary located on the southern side and Sharavathi Wildlife Sanctuary located on the northern side.
- **At the heart of the sanctuary lies the revered Kodachadri Peak, often referred to as a "botanical paradise."**
- The sanctuary boasts two significant rivers – River Chakra and River Souparnika.
- It is **home to many beautiful waterfalls such as Koosalli waterfalls and Belkal Theertha waterfalls.**

Col. Sher Jung National Park

- The Himachal Pradesh High Court quashed a recent notification **declaring areas of at least three grama panchayats around the Col Sher Jung National Park at Simbalbara in Sirmaur district as an Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ).**
- Col. Sher Jung National Park, also known as Simbalbara National Park, is located in the Paonta Valley of the Sirmaur (Sirmour) **district in Himachal Pradesh along its border with Haryana.**
- **It is named after the famous freedom fighter and ardent environmentalist Colonel Sher Jung.**
- The park is located in the lower Shiwalik region and extends into the middle and upper Shiwaliks.
- **Geographically, it is at the confluence of three biogeographic regions:** the Himalayas, the Gangetic plain, and the semi-arid region.
- It touches Kalesar National Park of Haryana to its south and west.
- The Simbalbara River flows through Simbalbara National Park and is a lifeline for the park's plants and animals.

Amchang Wildlife Sanctuary

- The **Gauhati High Court recently directed the Assam govt to respond to a petition alleging that the forest department floated an e-tender for felling trees in Amchang Wildlife Sanctuary without obtaining mandatory forest clearance from the central govt**.

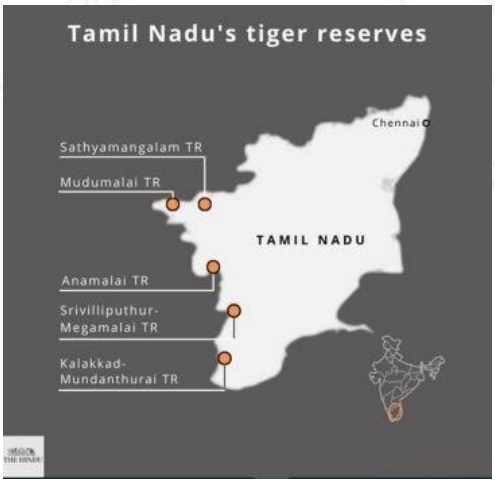
- It is located in the eastern fringe of Guwahati city in Assam.
- The **sanctuary was formed by merging three reserve forest areas:** South Amchang Reserve Forest, Amchang Reserve Forest, and Khanapara Reserve Forest.
- It stretches from the Brahmaputra River in the north to the hilly forests of Meghalaya in the south, **forming a continuous forest belt through Meghalaya's Maradakdola Reserve Forests**

Bhoramdeo Wildlife Sanctuary



- The **Chhattisgarh government is set to launch a new jungle safari in the Bhoramdeo Wildlife Sanctuary soon.**
- Bhoramdeo Wildlife Sanctuary, also known as Bhoramdev Wildlife Sanctuary, is located in the Kawardha district of Chhattisgarh.
- It is **part of the larger Maikal range of the Satpura hills,** which is known for its unique ecosystem.
- It is **part of the Kanha-Achanakmar Corridor, which connects Kanha National Park in Madhya Pradesh with Achanakmar Wildlife Sanctuary in Chhattisgarh.**
- Named after the famous Bhoramdeo Temple situated nearby.
- **Bhoramdeo Temple, an ancient temple complex dating back to the 7th to 11th centuries, was built by the Nagvanshi dynasty.**
- The temple is dedicated to **Lord Shiva** and is often referred to as the "Khajuraho of Chhattisgarh,".
- The region surrounding Bhoramdev Wildlife Sanctuary is **inhabited by various tribal communities, including the Baiga, Gond, and Kanwar tribes.**
- **Rivers**: This wildlife sanctuary is the origin of the Fen and Sankari rivers.

Srivilliputhur- Meghamalai Tiger Reserve



- Recently, the Election authorities set up a special polling station for just five voters inside the Srivilliputhur- Meghamalai Tiger Reserve under the Andipatti Assembly constituency, Tamil Nadu.

Srivilliputhur- Meghamalai Tiger Reserve

- It is located in the state of **Tamil Nadu.**
- It lies in the ecologically sensitive Western Ghats region.
- It **was formed in February 2021 by combining Grizzled Squirrel Wildlife Sanctuary and Megamalai Wildlife Sanctuary.**
- It will function as a connecting link between Kerala's Periyar Tiger Reserve and Tamil Nadu's Southern Kalakkad-Mundanthurai Tiger Reserve.
- **The Srivilliputhu Megamalai Tiger Reserve (SMTR) area primarily relies on three perennial rivers:** Vaigai, Suruliyaru, and Shanmuganathi.

National Institute for Pre-Clinical Research (NIPCR)

- **The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) has officially upgraded and renamed its Hyderabad-based animal resource facility to the National Institute for Pre-Clinical Research (NIPCR).**
- The National Institute for Pre-Clinical Research (NIPCR) is a flagship permanent institute under the aegis of the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR).

- It **serves as a critical bridge between laboratory discovery and human clinical trials**, focusing on the validation of biomedical innovations.
- **Establishment**: The institute was approved by the Cabinet Committee on November 18, 2015, and officially created as a permanent ICMR institute on January 1, 2016.
- Aim: Its primary objective is to fortify India's self-reliance in drug discovery and medical technology by providing a world-class platform for pre-clinical testing and translational research.

New Approach Methodologies (NAMs):

- NAMs are a suite of cutting-edge research technologies that include Microphysiological Systems (MPS), cell-based assays, and organoid models. They are integrated into research to provide high-fidelity data that closely mirrors human biology.
- **NAMs function by utilizing sophisticated bio-engineering and molecular biology technique**

Applications:

- Identifying potential side effects in human-like tissues before clinical trials begin.
- Creating mini-organs to study the progression of specific diseases and the impact of gene therapies.
- **Allowing researchers to test thousands of chemical compounds rapidly in cellular environments.**
- Complementing in vivo animal models to provide a more comprehensive data set for Made in India healthcare solutions.

Jamun



- **According to a new study, Jamun has been found to have originated much earlier than previously believed, with India playing a central role in its evolutionary history**.
- It is an important indigenous minor fruit of commercial value.
- It is **also known as black plum**, Indian black cherry, Ram jamun etc. in different parts of India.
- **Distribution**: The original home of jamun is India and also found in Thailand, Philippines, Madagascar and some other countries.
- **In India, the maximum number of jamun trees are found scattered throughout the tropical and subtropical regions.**
- It also occurs in the lower range of the Himalayas up to an elevation of 1,300 meters and in the Kumaon hills up to 1,600 meters.

Required Climatic Conditions for Jamun

- **Soil**: It can be grown in deep loam and a well-drained soil is needed.
- Jamun can grow well under salinity and waterlogged conditions too.
- It prefers to grow under tropical and subtropical climate.
- **It requires dry weather at the time off towering and fruit setting.**
- In subtropical areas, early rain is considered to be beneficial for ripening of fruits and proper development of its size, colour and taste

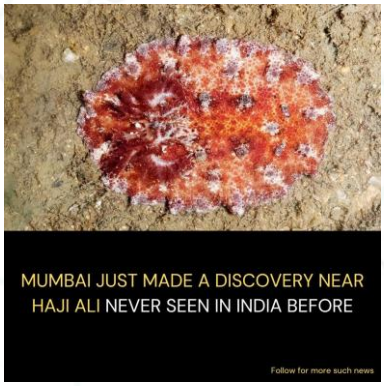
Stauranthera aureoglossa



- A team of botanists recently discovered a **new plant species with a unique 'golden tongue' in the shaded streams of the Himalayas, named Stauranthera aureoglossa**.
- It is a new plant species.
- It was **discovered in** the dense, mid-elevation evergreen forests of the Kamle and Upper Subansiri districts of **Arunachal Pradesh.**
- It is a perennial herb clinging to damp rocks and soil right beside flowing streams and rivulets.

- The **plant stands out from its closest relatives with a distinct, bell-shaped, bluish-purple flower.**
- It is an endangered species.

Sea Slugs



- **A rare sea slug, Discodorid cebuensis, has been recorded in India for the first time after being spotted recently at Haji Ali, Mumbai**.
- Sea slugs, sometimes called ocean slugs, water slugs, or nudibranchs, are **soft-bodied marine molluscs** found in all the world's oceans, from shallows to the deep sea.
- They are a type of gastropod, a large group of mollusks that includes both marine and land species such as snails and slugs.
- They **have no shells, quills, or mantle cavities.**
- They look like naked snails, i.e., without shells.
- **They are usually found in coral reefs, and their presence is a significant indicator of a strong coral ecosystem**.
- Sea slugs are renowned for their vibrant colours and intricate patterns, which often serve as warning signals to predators due to their toxicity.
- **Some can photosynthesise, producing their own food with sunlight.**
- Most sea slugs are active throughout the day, but some species are also nocturnal

Eulophia picta



- **Scientists recently identified a rare orchid species, Eulophia picta, in central Andhra Pradesh,** marking the first recorded presence of this species in the region.

About Eulophia picta

- It is a medium-to-small, hot-growing terrestrial orchid.
- It is **commonly known as Nodding Swamp Orchid or pink nodding orchid.**

Habitat and Distribution:

- It is found from India to Southeast Asia to Australia in moist grasslands, sandy areas behind beaches, and rainforests.
- It is also found in semi-deciduous and deciduous dry lowland forests at elevations up to 1000 m, with underground, spherical pseudobulbs.

Description:

- A distinctive leafy species with three to five broad, smooth, ribbed leaves and up to 20 pale pink, rarely white flowers.
- The flowers do not open but remain as a tube.

Limnonectes motijheel



- Indian scientists recently discovered a rare, fanged mud-nesting frog, Limnonectes Motijheel, **in Namdapha Tiger Reserve, Arunachal Pradesh.**
- It is named after Motijheel Lake, known for its rich amphibian diversity.
- **It belongs to a group commonly called Fanged Frogs**
- These frogs are found across South and Southeast Asia and are known for their unusual breeding habits.

Namdapha Tiger Reserve

- Namdapha, a national park and tiger reserve, **lies on the international border between India and Myanmar** within Changlang District in the state of Arunachal Pradesh.
- It is located at the junction of the Indian Sub-Continent Bio-geographic region and the Indo-China Bio-geographic Region.
- **It is nestled between the Dapha Bum ridge of the Mishmi Hills of the northeastern Himalayas and the Patkai ranges.**
- It has a common boundary with Kamlang Wildlife Sanctuary (Arunachal Pradesh).

Pushkarmema curajae

- Researchers from the Central University of Rajasthan recently identified a new species of cyanobacteria named Pushkarmema curajae from Pushkar Lake in Ajmer.
- **The genus name Pushkar and species name curajae are dedicated to Pushkar Lake and Central University of Rajasthan.**
- P. curajae could potentially **be used to develop drugs, biofertilizers, and even nutrient-rich supplements that improve immunity and overall health.**

About Cyanobacteria

- They are photosynthetic microscopic organisms found naturally in all types of water.
- **They were originally called blue-green algae (though they are not true algae) because dense growths often turn the water green, blue-green, or brownish-green.**
- They are usually unicellular, though they often grow in colonies large enough to see.
- They are **prokaryotic organisms** (lack a true nucleus and membrane-bound organelles).
- While often a green or blue-green colour, they can also be white, brown, blue, yellow-brown, or red.
- **They live in fresh, brackish (combined salt and fresh water), and marine water.**
- **They photosynthesise like plants and have similar requirements for sunlight**, nutrients, and carbon dioxide to grow and produce oxygen.
- In **addition to being photosynthetic, many species of cyanobacteria can also "fix" atmospheric nitrogen**—that is, they can transform the gaseous nitrogen of the air into compounds that can be used by living cells.
- They have the distinction of being the oldest known fossils, more than 3.5 billion years old.
- High nutrient concentrations can promote a population explosion of these organisms and result in algal blooms, especially during warm weather.

Olive Ridley Turtle



- **Olive Ridley turtles from Tamil Nadu have begun migrating towards the Sri Lanka Dome, a little-known but highly productive ocean region.**
- It is the smallest and most abundant of all sea turtles found in the world.
- It gets its name from the olive green colouration of its carapace (shell).
- It is **best known for its unique mass nesting, called Arribada,** where thousands of females come together on the same beach to lay eggs.
- They are mainly found in the warm waters of the Pacific, Atlantic, and Indian oceans.
- **Odisha's Gahirmatha Marine Sanctuary is known as the world's largest rookery (a colony of breeding animals) of sea turtles.**
- They are omnivorous, meaning they feed on both plants and animals.
- They are **solitary, preferring the open ocean**.

Conservation Status of Olive Ridley Turtle

- **IUCN Red List**: Vulnerable

- **CITES**: Appendix I
- **Wildlife Protection Act, 1972:** Schedule 1

Nilgiri Tahr



- The Tamil Nadu Forest Department, in coordination with Kerala, is conducting the third synchronized Nilgiri Tahr survey.
- **The Nilgiri Tahr (Nilgiritragus hylocrius) is the only mountain ungulate in southern India among the 12 species found in the country.**
- They inhabit open montane grassland habitats at elevations ranging from 1200 to 2600 meters.
- Their distribution is currently restricted to a narrow 400 km stretch of the Western Ghats, from the Nilgiris in the north to the Kanyakumari hills in the south.
- **The largest population is found in Eravikulam National Park (Kerala), with other significant populations in the Nilgiris and Anamalai hills.**
- **IUCN Red List**: Listed as Endangered.
- It is the **State Animal of Tamil Nadu**.
- An endemic species to the Western Ghats.

Dolphin Friends Initiative

- The forest department in Prayagraj has launched the Dolphin Friends volunteer network **to strengthen conservation of the endangered Gangetic dolphin through community participation and regular river monitoring.**
- Dolphin Friends is a dedicated community-based volunteer network created to monitor the movement, breeding, and habitat conditions of the endangered Gangetic river
- To protect and monitor the endangered Ganges river dolphin, especially during sensitive breeding seasons like the monsoon.

Cyborg Botany

- Scientists are **advancing a field known as cyborg botany to bridge the gap between biological signals and electronic data, allowing plants to communicate their internal health in real time.**
- A hybrid system at the intersection of biology, engineering, and materials science that turns plants into living circuit boards.
- Cyborg botany is an emerging hybrid field **that integrates living plants with electronic components to create cybernetic organisms capable of sensing and communicating biological information.**

Aim: To detect biotic and abiotic stressors at their source—the cellular or genetic level—to allow for intervention before visible damage occurs.

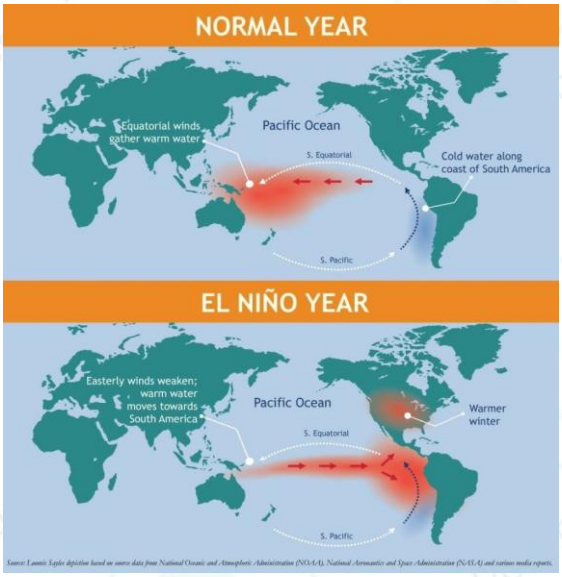
How It Works?

- Scientists embed nanowires and electronic transistors directly into plant cell walls to act as biosensors.
- **Biodegradable, electrically conductive materials like PEDOT act as living wires within plant tissue, carrying biochemical signals to external devices**.
- The system taps into the plant's natural biochemical responses to light, moisture, and pests, converting these internal signals into digital data

Super El Niño



- Experts warn of a potential Super El Niño later this year, **which could push global temperatures to record heights in 2027 and trigger devastating weather extremes worldwide.**
- El Niño is the **warm phase of the El Niño-Southern Oscillation** (ENSO) cycle, characterized by the unusual warming of surface waters in the central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean.
- It is a climate pattern that disrupts normal weather conditions, typically occurring every three to seven years.
- **Under normal conditions, trade winds blow from east to west along the equator**, pushing warm surface water toward Asia and allowing cold, nutrient-rich water to rise (upwelling) near South America.
- **During El Niño, these trade winds soften or shift direction (becoming westerly wind bursts).**
- Without strong winds to hold it back, warm water slides eastward toward the Americas in the form of a Kelvin wave.
- **This warm pulse pushes down the thermocline (the boundary between warm surface water and cold depths), preventing cold water from reaching the surface.**
- The warmer ocean surface heats the atmosphere above it, altering global jet streams and precipitation patterns.



About Super El Niño:

- A Super El Niño is an exceptionally strong event defined by sea surface temperature anomalies in the Niño 3.4 region spiking by at least 2OC (3.6OF) above the long-term average.
- **Only a few such events have occurred since 1950, with some models now predicting the strongest event in 140 years for the 2026–27 cycle.**

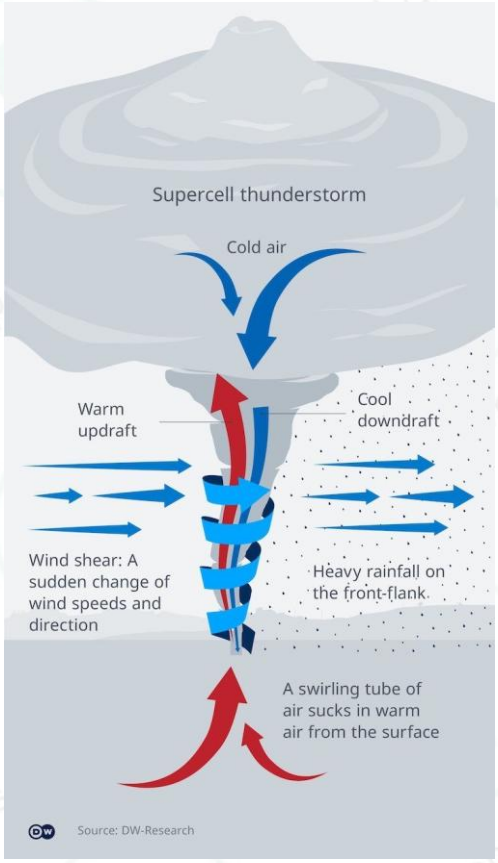
Factors Affecting/Causing It:

- A massive buildup of heat below the ocean surface is already feeding into seasonal forecasts, often a precursor to rapid surface intensification.
- **Strong bursts of wind from the west act as fuel, racing more warm water eastward and preventing the system from neutralizing.**
- The general rising trend in ocean temperatures makes modern El Niños appear stronger than historical ones, as the baseline temperature of the Pacific is already elevated.

Tornado

- Recently, a large tornado touched down in Kay County, Oklahoma, USA.
- The United States experiences the highest frequency of tornadoes globally, particularly in the region known as “Tornado Alley”.

About Tornado



- It is a **vertical, land-based column of violently rotating air** that forms from the base of a thunderstorm to the ground.
- It is **characterised by a rapid cyclonic circulation** and is often seen as a cloud-filled condensation funnel extending from the sky to the ground.
- When such a rotating column of air forms over a water body, it is known as a waterspout.

Formation of Tornado

- Tornado formation is closely linked to **interactions between contrasting air masses.**
- A collision of warm, moist air (usually from tropical regions) with cool, dry air (typically from polar or upper regions), **especially in the presence of a low-pressure system or trough, leads to the formation of thunderstorms and may trigger tornadoes.**
- **Wind Speeds and Movement**: It typically exhibits wind speeds ranging from 105 to 322 km/h, but some extreme events can exceed this range.
- Tornadoes occur most commonly in mid-latitude regions (between 20° and 60° latitude in both hemispheres) where cold polar air meets warm tropical air, producing frequent thunderstorm activity.

Heatwaves

- **The Andhra Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority (APSDMA) has issued a severe heatwave warning for 14 mandals and heatwave conditions for 28 others across the state.**
- A heatwave is a period of abnormally high temperatures, more than the normal maximum temperature, that occurs during the summer season.
- It is **a condition of air temperature which becomes fatal to the human body when exposed.**
- Qualitatively, it is defined based on the temperature thresholds over a region in terms of actual temperature or its departure from normal.



Key Data and Stats on Heatwaves in India

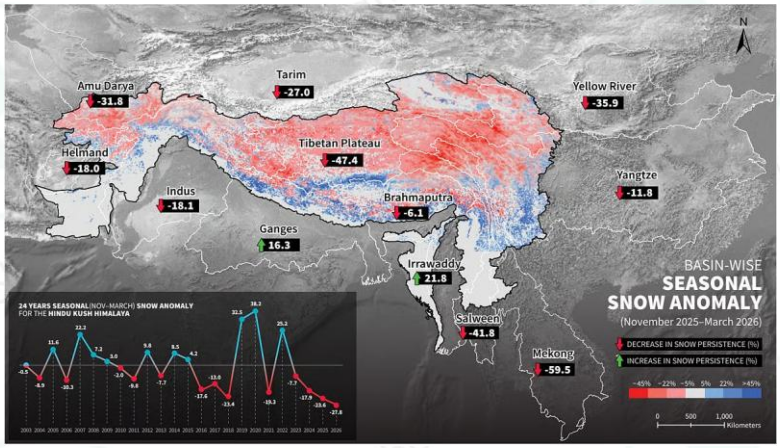
- **Recent Extremes**: Over 207 mandals in Andhra Pradesh recorded temperatures exceeding 41°C.
- **Peak Recorded Temperature**: Salur in the Manyam district recorded a maximum temperature of 45.2°C.
- **Widespread Impact:** Severe heat is currently impacting 14 mandals specifically in Srikakulam and Parvathipuram Manyam districts.
- **Historical Trend**: Disasters like heatwaves are estimated to cost India up to 2% of its GDP annually while eroding government revenue.

Factors Causing Heatwaves

- **Climate Change:** The world is facing more frequent and extreme weather events due to shifting global climate patterns.
- **Anticyclonic Circulation**: Large-scale sinking of air which compresses and heats the lower atmosphere, preventing cloud formation.

- **Urban Heat Island Effect**: Urbanization and the use of concrete in cities trap heat, leading to higher localized temperatures compared to rural areas.
- **El Niño Modoki**: Variations in ocean temperatures that can alter wind patterns and bring dry, hot air over the Indian subcontinent.

Hindu Kush Himalaya

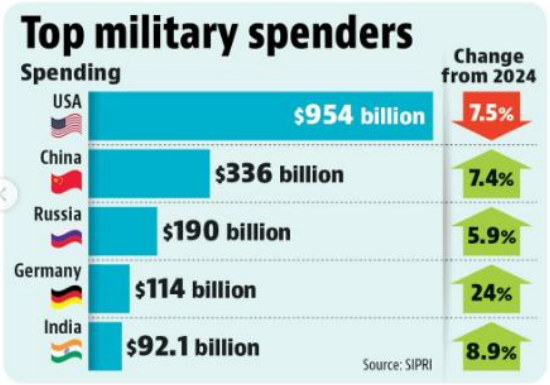


- **According to a new report by the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH) region sees a record 27% drop in snow persistence.**
- Hindu Kush Himalaya extends around 3,500 km over **eight countries** — Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, China, India, Nepal, Myanmar, and Pakistan.
- It **runs northeast to southwest and divides the valley of the Amu Darya (the ancient Oxus River) to the north from the Indus River valley to the south.**
- It is **considered the Third Pole (after the North and South Poles) and has significant implications for climate.**
- The HKH forms the largest area of permanent ice cover outside of the North and South Poles and is home to 4 global biodiversity hotspots.
- **The HKH region is the source of ten large Asian river systems**: the Amu Darya, Indus, Ganges, Brahmaputra, Irrawaddy, Salween, Mekong, Yangtse, Yellow River, and Tarim.
- **HKH may be divided into three main sections**: the eastern Hindu Kush, the central Hindu Kush, and the western Hindu Kush, also known as the Bābā Mountains.

Index/rankings/reports

India Becomes Fifth Largest Defence Spender Globally

- India ranked as the world's fifth-largest defence spender in 2025, according to the latest **report by the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI).**
- SIPRI stands for Stockholm International Peace Research Institute and is based in Sweden.
- With military expenditure reaching $92.1 billion, India **accounted for 3.2% of total global defence spending.**
- This placed the country **behind only the United States, China, Russia and Germany.**





Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district ranks first in National Nutrition Fortnight awareness campaign



- **Ahilyanagar district of Maharashtra has secured the first rank in the country** for conducting awareness activities under the eighth National Nutrition Fortnight campaign implemented by the Women and Child Development Department.
- **The district has recorded a total of 324,075 activities so far.**
- Pune district has achieved the second position nationwide.
- **This year's Nutrition Fortnight is centered on the theme** "Brain Development in the First Six Years of a Child's Life."

Bloomberg Billionaires Index 2026: Gautam Adani overtakes Mukesh Ambani, becomes Asia's richest



- Gautam Adani has moved ahead of Mukesh Ambani to become the richest individual in Asia, according to the latest update from the Bloomberg Billionaires Index.
- Adani, Founder-Chairman, Adani Group, now placed 19th in the global list with a net worth of $92.6 billion.
- **On the global stage, Elon Musk continues to dominate the rankings,** retaining the top position with an estimated net worth of $656 billion.

Rank	Name	Total Net Worth (in USD)	Country	Industry
1.	Elon Musk	656 billion	United States	Technology
2.	Larry Page	286 billion	United States	Technology
3.	Jeff Bezos	269 billion	United States	Technology
4.	Sergey Brin	266 billion	United States	Technology
5.	Mark Zuckerberg	239 billion	United States	Technology

India ranked 3rd globally in RE capacity

- India has climbed to the 3rd position globally in renewable energy (RE) installed capacity, **surpassing Brazil, according to the Union Ministry of New and Renewable Energy**.
- India has become the world's third-largest country in installed renewable energy capacity, reflecting its rapid progress in the transition toward a low-carbon and sustainable energy system.

Key Data / Stats:

- **Global Rank**: 3rd (after China and United States)
  - **India has emerged as the third-largest country in the world** in renewable energy installed capacity, reflecting rapid progress in green infrastructure.
- **Total non-fossil installed capacity**: 283.5 GW
  - This represents the combined installed capacity from solar, wind, hydro, nuclear, and other non-fossil sources, strengthening India's clean energy mix.
  - **India recorded its highest-ever annual addition of non-fossil power capacity, indicating accelerated expansion of renewable infrastructure.**
  - A major share of the growth came from decentralized household and commercial rooftop solar systems, improving distributed energy access.
- Peak RE share in electricity generation: 51.5%

FAO Food Price Index



- Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) Food Price Index rose in March 2026, largely due to higher energy costs linked to the escalating conflict in the Middle East

FAO Food Price Index

- It is a measure of the monthly change in international prices of a basket of food commodities.
- It consists of the average of five commodity group price indices (cereal, vegetable, dairy, meat and sugar), weighted with the average export shares.
- Base year: 2014-16.

What is the Food and Agriculture Organization?

- It is a specialized agency of the United Nations that leads international efforts to defeat hunger and improve nutrition and food security.
- Its goal is to achieve food security for all and make sure that people have regular access to enough high-quality food to lead active, healthy lives.
- Members: It consists of 195 members – 194 countries and the European Union, FAO works in over 130 countries worldwide.
- Its sister bodies are the World Food Programme (WFP) and the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD).
- Reports published by the FAO: The State of the World's Forests (SOFO), The State of World Fisheries and Aquaculture (SOFIA), The State of Agricultural Commodity Markets (SOCO), The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI).
- Headquarter: Rome (Italy)

Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises



- Recently, the National Statistics Office (NSO) has launched the first-ever Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises (ASISSE).
- Alongside the survey, the NSO has also released a user-friendly guide titled "Know Your Survey: A User Guide to ASISSE" to enhance awareness and participation.
- It is launched by the National Statistics Office, under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).
- It is aimed at developing a comprehensive database of the incorporated services sector of the country.
- The survey uses the Goods and Services Tax Network (GSTN) database as a sampling frame.
- The survey covers corporate entities in the services sector – companies registered under the Companies Act, 1956/2013 or Limited Liability Partnership Act, 2008.
- The ASISSE will survey over 1.21 lakh enterprises, making it one of the largest exercises of its kind.
- It will be conducted under the provisions of Collection of Statistics Act, 2008, as amended in 2017 and through the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2023.

Key Facts about National Statistical Office

- It is the central statistical agency of India responsible for collecting, processing, and disseminating official statistical data.
- The NSO was formed in 2019 by merging two key statistical bodies to improve efficiency, coordination, and data quality in India's statistical system.

- It plays a crucial role in evidence-based policymaking, planning, and governance.
- The NSO is headed by the Chief Statistician of India (CSI), who oversees all statistical activities and ensures coordination between departments..
- It functions under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation.

State of India's Bats (SoIbats) 2024–25 Report

- The first-ever national assessment, State of India's Bats (SoIbats) 2024–25, **has flagged a critical data deficit and research neglect despite bats being the largest order of mammals in the country.**
- It is India's first comprehensive national-level assessment of bat species, conducted by the Nature Conservation Foundation (NCF) and Bat Conservation International (BCI).
- The report aims to map the diversity, distribution, and conservation status of bats to provide a baseline for future environmental policy.

Key Findings of the Report:

- **West Bengal (68 species) and Meghalaya (66 species) have the highest bat diversity in India.**
- While caves and trees remain primary natural roosts, bats are increasingly utilizing man-made structures like dilapidated buildings and government monuments.
- The report emphasizes that **bats are vital for pollination, seed dispersal, and pest control**, which directly impacts agricultural productivity and soil nutrition.

Types of Bat Species in India:

- India is home to 135 species, classified into 16 endemic and 7 threatened species:
- **Critically Endangered**: Kolar Leaf-nosed Bat (found in only one cave in Karnataka).
- **Endangered**: Includes the Nicobar Flying Fox, Salim Ali's Fruit Bat, and Andaman Horseshoe Bat.

About Bats:

- Bats belong to the order Chiroptera and are the only mammals capable of true and sustained flight.
- They occupy a unique evolutionary niche, with a history of co-speciation with viruses dating back 52 million years.
- **Most microbats navigate using biological sonar**. They emit high-frequency ultrasonic calls (20–200 kHz) and decode the echoes to map their surroundings in total darkness.
- **Ranges from the Bumblebee Bat** (2 grams, the world's smallest mammal) **to the Flying Fox (2-meter wingspan, 1.5 kg weight).**
- Contrary to popular belief, **bats are not blind;** many species use light cues to orient themselves during flight.
- Their wings are modified hands with thin membranes stretched between long fingers. Hanging upside down is an evolutionary advantage, as their legs are too small to run for a dead-stop takeoff.

International

India and South Korea sign four MOUs in various fields

- India and South Korea signed four MoUs during South Korean President Lee Jae Myung's visit to India.

The agreements include:

- Cooperation in Sports
- Cooperation in Cultural and Creative Industries



- MoU on **Establishment of the Industrial Cooperation Committee in the field of Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs)**
- Framework for the India-Korea Digital Bridge to deepen cooperation in AI, semiconductors, and information technology



Additional Outcomes:

- Joint declaration to resume negotiations for upgrading the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).
- Launch of India-Korea Financial Forum and Economic Security Dialogue.
- Cooperation expansion in shipbuilding, defence, critical minerals, and supply chains.

Bilateral relations:

- Bilateral relations between India and South Korea, **officially known as the Republic of Korea, were established in 1962 and upgraded to Ambassador-level in 1973.**
- South Korea's open market policies found resonance with India's economic liberalization, and its 'look east policy' and 'act east policy'.
- During PM Modi's visit to ROK in May **2015, the sides elevated the ties to 'Special Strategic Partnership'.**
- President Moon's India visit marked the 45th anniversary of bilateral diplomatic ties.
- Cooperate with India in areas like the Indian ocean region
- **Capital**: Seoul
- **Currency**: Korean Republic won

India-Japan Data Pact for AI Smart Cities

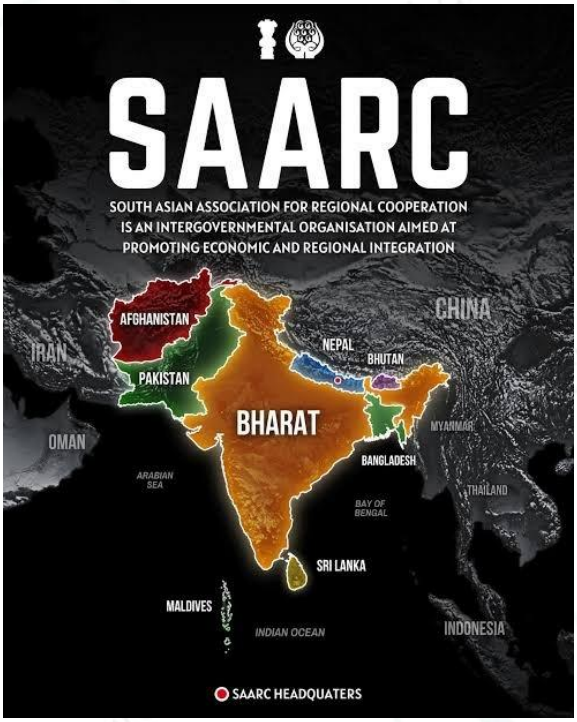


- India and Japan have signed a major Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to incorporate construction data in the urban AI systems, enhancing the development of smart cities in both countries.
- **This agreement was declared during the outer venues of the first Japan-India AI Strategic Dialogue, and it connects Japanese openBIM standards with the Indian platform of IUDX.**
- The initiative aims to improve how construction data is used in smart city planning and digital governance.
- The **MoU was signed between ONESTRUCTION Inc., a Japanese company specialized in open-standard construction data, and DataKaveri Systems**, the commercial division of the Centre of Data of Public Good of IISc Bengaluru.
- The transaction links the openBIM platform of ONESTRUCTION, which is built with the global standard of building information, IFC, with the Intelligent Universal Data Exchange (IUDX) of DataKaveri, which works in 55 Indian smart cities.

Important Facts for Exams

- IUDX stands for Intelligent Universal Data Exchange and supports smart city data sharing.
- DataKaveri Systems is the commercial arm of IISc Bengaluru's Centre of Data for Public Good.
- **IFC is an internationally recognised open standard for construction data exchange.**
- Digital twins are virtual models of physical cities used for planning and governance.

India approves ₹30 billion for Maldives under SAARC swap



- India has approved the first withdrawal of ₹30 billion under its continuing economic and financial assistance to Maldives.
- **The funds are being released under the first drawdown of the SAARC Currency Swap Framework,**
- The withdrawal under the 'Framework on Currency Swap Arrangement for SAARC countries' was signed between RBI and the Maldives government during President Mohamed Muizzu's State visit to New Delhi in October 2024.

What is the Currency Swap Arrangement?

- The word swap means exchange.
- A currency swap between two countries is an agreement or contract to exchange currencies with predetermined terms and conditions.
- **The facility is to provide swap support as an alternative source of funding for short-term foreign exchange liquidity requirements.**

South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)



- **Establishment**: SAARC was established with the signing of the SAARC Charter in Dhaka (Bangladesh) on 8th December 1985.
- **Member States**: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka.
- **Secretariat:** Kathmandu (Nepal)
- **The India–Africa Forum Summit (IAFS)**
- **India is set to host the Fourth India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS) 2026 in late May, marking the first such gathering in over a decade since 2015.**
- The India–Africa Forum Summit (IAFS) is the official institutional platform for African-Indian relations. It serves as a high-level consultative mechanism between the Government of India and the member states of the African Union (AU) to promote South-South cooperation.
- **Established In:** First Summit: April 4–8, 2008, in New Delhi, India.
- **2008 (New Delhi):** The inaugural meeting between India and 14 African countries chosen by the AU. It focused on rising oil and food prices.
- **2011 (Addis Ababa, Ethiopia):** Held at the AU headquarters, this summit expanded the partnership's scope to include 15 African nations and focused on infrastructure development.
- **2015 (New Delhi):** The largest-ever turnout, involving delegates from all 54 African nations. It was a major diplomatic outreach by the Modi government to solidify India's presence on the continent.

9th Indian Ocean Conference



- **India Foundation, in association with the Government of Mauritius, organised the 9th Indian Ocean Conference—IOC 2026—in Mauritius from April 10 to 12, 2026.**
- The **theme of the conference** was "Collective Stewardship for Indian Ocean Governance."
- The conference brings together leaders, policymakers, and experts from across the Indian Ocean Region to deliberate on

shared responsibilities, cooperative frameworks, and the future of regional governance.

Rajnath Singh to Attend SCO Defence Meet



- Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will visit Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, on April 27–28 to participate in the Defence Ministers' meeting of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO).
- **The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation was founded in 2001 and focuses on political, economic, and security cooperation.**
- India and Pakistan became full members of the SCO in 2017.
- The SCO includes China, Russia, India, Pakistan, and several Central Asian nations.
- **Bishkek is the capital of Kyrgyzstan .**

The "snapback" sanctions are imposed by the United Nations



- The sanctions on Iran have been reimposed via a mechanism known as "snapback" which was included in the 2015 nuclear deal signed between Iran and the world powers.
- These sanctions come as Iran's economy is already struggling. France, the UK and Germany triggered the re-imposition of sanctions on Iran at the UN Security Council.
- **Snapback Mechanism**: It allows any Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) participant, to reimpose UN sanctions if Iran commits "significant non-performance."

The 'Yellow Line' Security Strategy



- The Israeli government has officially expanded the Yellow Line strategy from the Gaza Strip to southern Lebanon, **establishing a militarized buffer zone that extends up to the Litani River.**
- **The Yellow Line is a specific military demarcation and strategic construct used by the Israel Defense Forces (IDF) to establish a fortified, static buffer zone within hostile territory.**
- Unlike traditional political borders, it serves as a free-fire zone where Israel maintains direct, open-ended military control.

Established In:

- **Gaza Strip**: First introduced in October 2025 as part of a peace framework proposed by US President Donald Trump.
- **Southern Lebanon**: Replicated in April 2026 following the ceasefire with Hezbollah, applying the Gaza Model to the northern front.

United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (UN ESCAP)

- The United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (UN ESCAP) has released its 2026 Economic Survey, warning that the West Asia conflict is driving up energy and food costs.
- **UN ESCAP is the most inclusive intergovernmental platform in the Asia-Pacific region and serves as one of the five regional commissions of the United Nations.** It comprises 53 member states and 9 associate members, representing nearly two-thirds of the world's population.

- **Established In**: 1947 in Shanghai as the Economic Commission for Asia and the Far East (ECAFE) to aid post-WWII reconstruction.
- **Renamed to ESCAP in 1976 to reflect its broader social mandate and relocated its headquarters to Bangkok, Thailand.**
- **Aim** To promote regional cooperation to overcome challenges such as income inequality, climate change, and gender disparities.
- To guide the region in achieving the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).
- To support member states in emerging more robust and future-focused following global shocks like the COVID-19 pandemic.

Symbiosis unveils Asia's first UNESCO chair on Gender Inclusion & Skill Development

- Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Skill Development & Entrepreneurship and Minister of State for Education Jayant Chaudhary successfully launched the UNESCO Chair on Gender Inclusion and Skill Development
- **The initiative was part of the International Conference on "Women Leading the Future of Work" organised in collaboration with UNESCO at Symbiosis Skills and Professional University (SSPU), Pune**
- Under the aegis of this Chair, **10,000 girls have been trained on future skills in sunrise sectors** such as robotics, automation and semi-conductor technology, advanced manufacturing and defence technology.
- **The initiative has positioned SSPU as a global hub for skill development**, research, and innovation, aligned with UNESCO's international priorities

Bnei Menashe



- The Government of India's advisory about the security situation in Israel, amid the ongoing war in West Asia, came into focus recently **when Israel airlifted around 240 individuals from Mizoram to Tel Aviv as part of Israel's 'Operation Wings of Dawn'.**
- The **Bnei Menashe, known in India as the Shinlung, is an ethnic community that hails from the northeastern states of Mizoram and Manipur.**
- They are a community of about 10,000 people from Tibeto-Burman ethnic groups. They include members of the Chin, Kuki, and Mizo groups.
- **The population claims to be descendants of the Biblical tribe of Manasseh, one of the Ten Lost Tribes of Israel, which were exiled by the Assyrian Empire in 722 BC.**
- They are Christians converted into Jews and observe traditional Jewish practices and celebrate holidays such as Sukkot.
- After a centuries-long exodus through Persia, Afghanistan, Tibet, and China, **the community reached India's northeast and settled in Manipur and Mizoram.**
- Historians believe this community may have arrived in India within the last 300–500 years.

Operation Wings of Dawn

- In **2025, the Israeli government launched 'Operation Wings of Dawn' to facilitate the immigration of the remaining members of the Bnei Menashe community to Israel.**
- The programme includes flights, conversion classes, housing, Hebrew lessons, and other benefits.
- **According to the recent Israeli Government plan, approximately 1,200 community members are expected to immigrate to Israel by the end of 2026.**
- A second stage, slated for completion by 2030.

Druzhba Pipeline



- The Druzhba pipeline that carries Russian oil through Ukraine to Hungary and Slovakia has been repaired and can resume operations, the Ukrainian President has announced recently, ending a months-long standoff between Kyiv and Budapest.
- The **Druzhba Pipeline, also known as the Friendship Pipeline, is one of the biggest crude oil pipeline networks in the world.**
- It was built in the 1960s to supply oil from the USSR to countries in Europe.
- Today, it is the largest principal artery for the transportation of Russian (and Kazakh) oil across Europe.
- The total length of the pipeline system, including all its branches, is around 5500 km.
- **The official beginning of the Druzhba network is in Almetyevsk in the Russian Federation, where pipelines carrying crude oil from Siberia, the Urals, and the Caspian Sea meet.**
- The current capacity of Druzhba is 1.2–1.4 million barrels a day, possibility to increase up to 2 million barrels a day.



Aspero

- Archaeologists in Peru recently **uncovered a structure at Áspero that appears to have been used to observe the sky,** adding detail to what is known about early scientific practices in the Caral Civilisation.
- **It is a late preceramic archaeological site associated with the Norte Chico civilization** (also called Caral-Supe civilization), one of the oldest known civilizations in the Americas.
- It is **located in Peru** on the right bank of the Supe River, only 500 meters from the Pacific Ocean.
- **It was a major urban center with monumental architecture**, including large platform mounds and sunken circular plazas, serving as a hub for trade, agriculture, and religious rituals.
- **Áspero functioned not only as a fishing center but also as a place for the development of scientific and ritual knowledge.**



Atacama Desert

- Recently, it was observed that light pollution is threatening the world's darkest skies in the Atacama desert.

About Atacama Desert

- **Location**: It is the driest desert in the world, located in northern Chile.
- It is **nestled between the Andes Mountains on the east and the Pacific Ocean on the west.**
- It forms a continuous strip for nearly 1,000 km along the narrow coast of the northern third of Chile.
- **Bordered by:** It is bordered by Argentina, Peru, and Bolivia
- It also hosts 12 volcanoes, mainly located in the western outliers of the Andes.



- **Temperatures are comparatively mild throughout the year**. The average temperature in the desert is about 63 degrees F (18 degrees C).
- **Region has the largest natural supply of Sodium Nitrate, which can be used for producing fertilizers and explosives, amongst other things**.
- The oldest artificially mummified human remains have been found in the Atacama Desert

UAE Announces Exit from OPEC, Decision to Take Effect from May 1, 2026



- The United Arab Emirates has announced it will exit the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and the broader OPEC+ alliance, with the decision taking effect from May 1, 2026.

Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries

- It is a permanent intergovernmental organization of oil-exporting countries.
- **It was established in 1960 by the five founding members Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, and Venezuela.**
- **Objective**: Its primary objective is to stabilize global oil markets and ensure fair prices for producers along with a steady supply for consumers.
- **Member countries:** Currently, it has 12 members, including Algeria, Congo, Equatorial Guinea, Gabon, Libya, Nigeria, and the United Arab Emirates (Decided to quit from May 1 2026).
- Angola withdrew its membership effective 1 January 2024.
- **Headquarters:** Vienna, Austria.
- OPEC members collectively hold more than 75–80% of the world's proven crude oil reserves.

What is OPEC+?

- It is an extension of the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries formed in 2016.
- It **consists of 22 oil-exporting countries** which meet regularly to decide how much crude oil to sell on the world market.
- **Members of OPEC+:** It comprises 12 OPEC countries plus Azerbaijan, Bahrain, Brunei, Kazakhstan, Russia, Mexico, Malaysia, South Sudan, Sudan, and Oman.
- These nations aim to work together on adjusting crude oil production to bring stability to the oil market

Pompeii



- **AI has helped archaeologists at Pompeii reconstruct the face and final moments of a man killed during the AD 79 eruption of Mount Vesuvius.**
- It is a preserved ancient Roman city located near modern-day Naples, Italy.
- It lies at the southeastern base of Mount Vesuvius.
- The **area was originally settled in the Bronze Age on an escarpment at the mouth of the Sarnus** (modern Sarno) River.
- Pompeii was built on a spur formed by a prehistoric lava flow to the north of the mouth of the Sarno River.
- Pompeii was founded around the 6th century BC by the Samnites, an ancient Italian tribe. It was conquered and absorbed into the Roman Empire in 80 BCE.

- At its height, **the small city had a thriving economy based on trade and agriculture**.
- The city featured a complex municipal water system, an amphitheater, and a gymnasium.
- The city was buried in volcanic ash following the eruption of Mt. Vesuvius in 79 CE, instantly killing its inhabitants and preserving the city in a remarkable state of preservation.
- Pompeii was basically lost and forgotten until it was rediscovered in 1748.
- It is the only archaeological site in the world that provides a complete picture of an ancient Roman city.
- **It is a UNESCO World Heritage Site**



China completes 11 km underwater tunnel beneath Yangtze river

- China recently completed an 11.18-km-long high-speed underwater tunnel beneath the Yangtze River, **enabling bullet trains to run at speeds of up to 350 kmph.**
- The **Yangtze River, known in China as the Chang Jiang or Yangzi, is the longest river in both China and Asia** and the third-longest river in the world after the Nile River and the Amazon River.
- It is also considered the longest river to exclusively flow within the borders of a single nation.
- It is 6,300 kilometers long.
- **It begins in the mountains of Tibet.**
- It runs through mountains for most of its length.
- More than 700 streams and rivers flow into the Yangtze.
- The Yangtze empties into the East China Sea near Shanghai in east-central China.
- **Many of China's largest cities, including Shanghai, Wuhan, and Chongqing, are situated along the river.**



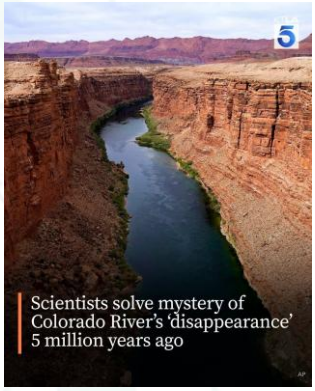
The Indian EXPRESS

China completes 11 km underwater tunnel beneath Yangtze river, bullet trains to run at 350 kmph speed



Colorado River

- Recently, the mystery of the Colorado River's missing water has finally been solved by scientists from the University of Washington, **revealing a critical shift in the American West's hydrological cycle.**
- It is a **major river of North America.**
- **Origin**: It rises in the Rocky Mountains of Colorado, U.S.
- It flows generally west and south for 1,450 miles (2,330 kilometres) **into the Gulf of California in northwestern Mexico.**
- It **flows through seven U.S. states and two Mexican states.**
- The river drains a vast arid and semiarid sector of the North American continent.
- It **is often referred to as the "Lifeline of the Southwest."**





- **Lakes**: It forms several major reservoirs, including Lake Mead and Lake Powell.
- **International boundary**: Colorado forms an international boundary between Arizona (US) and Mexico.
- **One of the Colorado River's most famous features is the Grand Canyon**, which it carved over millions of years.
- **Grand Canyon landscape is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and a major tourist attraction.**
- The river also flows through Canyonlands National Park and Horseshoe Bend in Arizona

Tuvalu



- As the Pacific island nation of Tuvalu battles rising sea levels that threaten to **put large parts of the island entirely underwater by the end of this century**, its citizens are making efforts to safeguard their future while preparing for the worst impacts of climate change.
- **Tuvalu, formerly known as the Ellice Islands**, is a Polynesian island country in the west-central Pacific Ocean.
- It is the **4th smallest country in the world with 26 sq.km. of land.**
- It sits **about halfway between Australia and Hawaii.**
- Its neighbours include Kiribati, to the north, and Fiji, to the south.
- **It comprises nine islands (four reef islands and five coral atolls).**
- The Funafuti atoll is the capital of Tuvalu and is also the most populous among all the 9 atolls.
- **There are no rivers**. Tuvalu's climate is hot and rainy.
- **Languages**: Tuvaluan, English is widely used.
- **Currency**: Tuvalu dollar (equivalent to the Australian dollar)

Lake Issyk-Kul



- Underwater archaeologists recently unveiled a hidden city in Lake Issyk-Kul, revealing a lost civilization from seven hundred years ago.
- **It is located in northeastern Kyrgyzstan.**
- Surrounding the lake are the snowcapped Tian Shan mountains (the Heaven's mountains).
- **It was formed roughly 25 million years ago and has an endorheic basin**, meaning it has no outflow to other bodies of water like rivers or oceans.
- The **water in the lake is blue and brackish.**
- **It is located at an altitude of 1600 meters. It is after Lake Titicaca in South America, the world's second-largest high mountain lake.**
- It is the **second-largest saline lake in the world after the Caspian Sea**. It is also the largest lake in Kyrgyzstan.
- Owing to its depth, low salinity, and warm springs, it does not freeze, even in winter. Issyk-Kul translates as "hot lake".
- **In 1976, it was included on the Ramsar list as a wetland of international importance**

Finland Builds World's First Permanent Nuclear Waste Vault



- Finland is preparing to operationalise the world's first permanent underground repository (the Onkalo facility)for highly radioactive nuclear waste.
- **Located beneath Olkiluoto Island, the Onkalo facility is designed to safely store spent nuclear fuel for up to 100,000 years.**
- **Most countries currently store such waste in temporary cooling pools or dry casks, which are safe only for limited periods.**

40 years of the Chernobyl Disaster



- The **world marks the 40th anniversary of the Chernobyl disaster, which remains the most expensive man-made catastrophe in history with costs exceeding $700 billion**.
- The Chernobyl disaster is the worst accident in the history of nuclear power generation.
- It involved a catastrophic meltdown and explosions at Unit 4 of the Chernobyl nuclear power station, **located near the industrial town of Pripyat in the former Soviet Union (now Ukraine).**
- On **April 25-26, 1986**, technicians attempted an experiment to test the Unit 4 RBMK reactor's safety systems.
- The RBMK reactor **was a graphite-moderated system that lacked a pressure-retaining containment structure**—a final physical barrier to limit radioactive releases.
- On **April 26, the chain reaction went out of control**, leading to explosions that blew off the reactor's heavy lid and **dispersed 3.5% of the nuclear fuel into the atmosphere.**
- A resulting graphite fire drove prolonged radioactive emissions for several days, which were carried across Ukraine, Belarus, Russia, and as far as Sweden by air currents.

India Calls Expansion Of Permanent Members With Veto Essential For UNSC Reform



- India's Permanent Representative to the UN, asserted **that any UNSC reform without expanding permanent membership and granting veto power would only perpetuate existing imbalances.**
- India maintains that the UN Security Council (UNSC) is currently suffering from a crisis of legitimacy and representativeness.
- The **core of India's argument is that the veto and membership are the two fundamental aspects that have created a skewed power dynamic.**
- India rejects the introduction of intermediate or new categories of membership, arguing that such piece-meal approaches only complicate negotiations and preserve the relative advantage of the current five permanent members (P5).

Outcomes of the Inter-Governmental Negotiations (IGN):

- **Rejection of New Categories**: India cautioned against creating membership categories without veto power, stating it would further complicate wide-ranging views.
- **Historical Analysis of Power Ratios**: India highlighted that the 1960s reform (expanding only non-permanent seats) shifted the permanent-to-non-permanent ratio from 5:6 to 5:10, inadvertently increasing the P5's relative power.

- India raised the issue of effective vetoes used by both elected and non-elected members to block outcomes like Presidential Statements and Sanctions Committee decisions for narrow national interests.
- **India reiterated its alignment with the African model,** asserting that new permanent members must receive the veto as long as it exists.

UNSC :

- It is one of the five principal organs of the United Nations (UN), with the primary responsibility of maintaining international peace and security.
- **Established in 1945 through the UN Charter as one of the 6 principal organs of the UN.**
- Under the UN Charter, all member states must comply with UNSC decisions.
- It determines threats to peace, recommends settlement methods, imposes sanctions, and authorises military actions.

Structure and Membership

- The UNSC consists of 15 members, each having one vote.

Five permanent members (P5) with veto power:

- China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom, and the United States.
- **Ten non-permanent members, elected by the UN General Assembly for two-year terms, with equitable geographical representation:**
- 5 from Africa/Asia, 1 from Eastern Europe, 2 from Latin America, and 2 from Western Europe/others
- The UNSC is headquartered at the United Nations Headquarters in New York City.
- **UNSC Reform Proposal (2024)**
- **Proposed by:** G4 Nations (India, Brazil, Germany, Japan)

Madman Theory



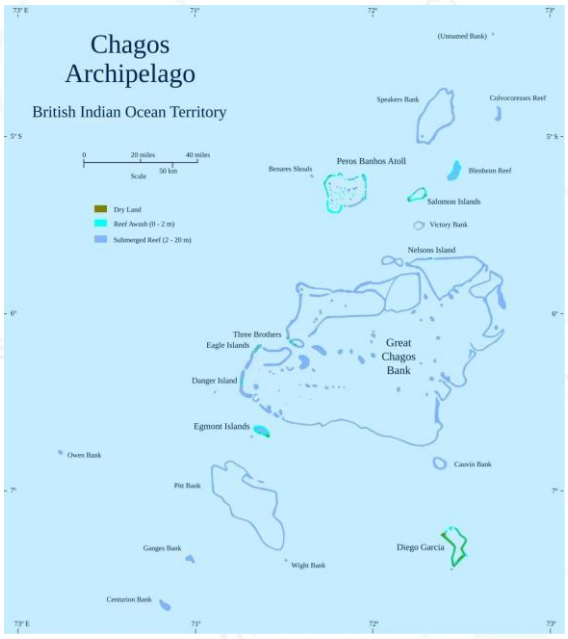
- The Madman Theory has returned to global strategic discourse amid debates over the foreign policy posture of Donald Trump during the ongoing West Asia crisis.
- The Madman Theory is a foreign policy and strategic doctrine in which a leader deliberately cultivates an image of being unpredictable, irrational, or willing to take extreme action.
- The aim is to make adversaries believe that escalation—including war or even nuclear confrontation—is possible, thereby forcing concessions.

The "Axis of Autocracy"



- **China, Russia, and Iran are regarded as part of the "Axis of Autocracy," a term used in Washington policy circles to refer to the strategic alignment of authoritarian states.**
- This term is often seen in the news, especially in the context of the ongoing conflict.
- Recently, it came into focus again when, a day before the ceasefire was announced, China and Russia, **Iran's key strategic allies, vetoed a United Nations Security Council (UNSC) resolution aimed at enhancing security and protecting commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz.**

U.K. pauses its plan to cede Chagos Islands after U.S. opposition



- Recently, Britain's government said that it had put on hold its deal to cede sovereignty of the Chagos Islands.
- **Chagos Islands Location:** It is an island group located in the central Indian Ocean.
- **It is about 1,000 miles (1,600 km) south of the southern tip of the Indian subcontinent.**
- It is an overseas territory of the United Kingdom that was established on November 8, 1965
- **The principal islands in the archipelago** include the Diego Garcia atoll, Danger Island, Egmont Islands, Eagle Islands, Nelsons Island, Peros Banhos atoll, Three Brothers Islands, and the Solomon Islands.
- **Diego Garcia is the largest and the most southerly island of the Chagos Archipelago**.
- There are no rivers and lakes on the islands.

Philippines Joins Pax Silica Chip Supply Initiative



- The Philippines has joined a United States-led initiative, "Pax Silica", **aimed at securing global semiconductor and technology supply chains.**
- As part of the initiative, the United States and the Philippines will jointly develop a 4,000-acre industrial hub in Luzon.
- The project is expected to be located within the Luzon Economic Corridor, a **key manufacturing and logistics region that includes the capital, Manila**.
- "Pax Silica" is a US-led framework designed to secure the full technology supply chain, from extraction of raw materials to advanced manufacturing and data infrastructure.
- **The Philippines has become the 13th member, reflecting the growing alignment among US partners.**

The United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

- India achieved a major diplomatic milestone, by sweeping four unopposed elections to key subsidiary bodies of the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC).
- ECOSOC is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations, serving as the central platform for fostering debate, innovative thinking, and forging consensus on international development goals. To serve as a principal UN organ for policy coordination and consensus-building on economic, social, and development issues.
- Established in: The Council was established by the UN Charter in 1945.

Recent Elections and India's Selection:

- In the April 2026 elections, India secured seats in four distinct bodies:
- Committee on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights: Former diplomat Preeti Saran was re-elected in her personal capacity.
- Commission on Science and Technology for Development.
- Committee on Non-Governmental Organisations.
- Committee for Programme and Coordination.

United Nations Development Partnership Fund

- Recently, the Indian Permanent Mission to New York with the board of directors of the United Nations Development Partnership Fund reviewed the whole gamut of the fund's operations.
- It was established in 2017, with $150 million, led by the Government of India.
- The Fund supports Southern-owned and -led, demand-driven and transformational sustainable development projects across the developing world.
- It focuses on least developed countries and Small Island developing States.
- United Nations agencies implement the Fund projects in close collaboration with partnering Governments.
- The fund is a notable example of South-South cooperation with the system.
- Its thematic reach spans all 17 SDGs, with several initiatives addressing more than one Goal.
- These include climate resilience, environmental sustainability, renewable energy, gender equality, health and pandemic response, education and skills, livelihoods, infrastructure, water and sanitation, and agricultural development.
- Under this, the Commonwealth Window of this Fund aims to catalyze the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) in the developing countries of the Commonwealth of Nations.
- It is managed by the United Nations Office for South-South Cooperation (UNOSSC)

Argentina formally withdraws from World Health Organization



- Argentina has officially completed its withdrawal from the World Health Organization (WHO), effective March 2026, following a one-year notification period initiated by President Javier Milei's administration.
- The WHO is a specialized agency of the United Nations responsible for international public health. It acts as a coordinating authority on global health work, setting norms and standards while providing technical support to countries.
- Established in: It was founded on April 7, 1948.
- Aim: The primary objective of the WHO is the attainment by all peoples of the highest possible level of health, defined not just as the absence of disease but as a state of complete physical, mental, and social well-being.
- Argentina is the second-largest country in South America and the eighth-largest in the world.

Border Nations:

- North: Bolivia and Paraguay.
- Northeast: Brazil and Uruguay.
- West: Chile (separated by the Andes).
- East: The South Atlantic Ocean.

Key Geological Features:

- The Andes Mountains
- The Pampas
- Patagonia
- The Paraná River System

Angola



- Angola emerges as an important alternative to West Asia in gas supplies to India
- Location: It is located on the southwestern Atlantic Coast of Africa.
- Bordering Countries: It is bordered by the Republic of the Congo (Northwest), Democratic Republic of the Congo (North & Northeast), Zambia (Southeast) and Namibia (South)
- Maritime Boundary: It shares a border with the Atlantic Ocean.
- Capital City: Luanda

Geographical Features of Angola

- It has a tropical climate with a marked dry season. The climate is largely affected by the northward flow of the cold Benguela Current off the coast, and elevation.
- Major rivers: Cuango River and Cuanza River, vital for hydropower and inland water transport.
- Major Water Falls: The largest is the Calandula Waterfalls (also known as the Kalandula Falls) on the Lucala River.
- Highest peak: Mount Moco, the tallest mountain in Angola.

Denis Manturov

- Russia's First Deputy Prime Minister Denis Manturov visited India on 2nd- 3rd April, 2026.
- — The Russian First Deputy PM's visit to New Delhi comes days after India cleared procurement of a fresh batch of five S-400 missile systems from Russia.

India has sent a consignment of one thousand metric tonnes of rice to Burkina Faso as humanitarian assistance.



- It is a landlocked country in western Africa.
- Bordering countries: It shares its borders with six other nations: Mali to the north and west, Niger to the east, and Benin to the southeast, while to the south it touches Togo, Ghana, and Ivory Coast.
- Capital City: Ouagadougou
- Terrain: It is predominantly characterized by savannahs, plateaus, and low mountains in the southwest.
- The northern region, known as the Sahel, is arid and desert-like.
- Highest mountain: Mount Tenakourou
- Rivers: Black Volta, Red Volta, and White Volta (These 3 converge in Ghana and form the Volta River).
- Lakes: The country's largest lake, Lake Bam, lies near the center of the country

Scarborough Shoal



- China is employing ships and a barrier to tighten control of the entrance to the Scarborough Shoal in the South China Sea amid roiling tension with the Philippines over the disputed feature.
- **Scarborough Shoal is a disputed atoll in the South China Sea, claimed by both China and the Philippines as part of their territory.**
- It is called Huangyan Island by China and Panatag Shoal, or Bajo de Masinloc by the Philippines.
- It was **named for the HMS Scarborough**, an English ship chartered by the East India Company that struck the atoll in the 18th century.
- It is the **largest atoll in the South China Sea.**

What is the Dispute?

- **China's claim**: China makes a historical claim to the area, stating that they can trace their ownership of the area back to the Yuan Dynasty of the 1200s.
- **Philippines claim**: The Philippines claim the area on the basis of geography, as it is much closer to the Philippines' main island of Luzon, which contains the capital, Manila.
- **It is considered within the Philippines' 200-nautical mile exclusive economic zone,** based on the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

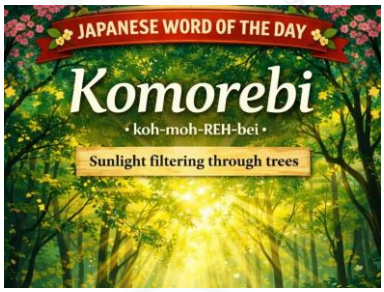
Lake Neuchâtel



- In an amazing find for archaeology, **over 1,000 Roman artefacts have been recently uncovered in Lake Neuchâtel in Switzerland,** offering an insight into life at the time of the Roman Empire.
- Lake Neuchâtel is the largest lake entirely within Switzerland.
- It is nestled at the foot of the Jura Mountains.

Komorebi

- The Japanese word Komorebi has recently gone viral globally, trending across social media platforms for its poetic expression of sunlight filtering through tree leaves.
- **Komorebi is a beautiful Japanese word that refers to the dappled sunlight that passes through the leaves and branches of trees.**
- It is not merely a visual description, but also captures the emotional calm, serenity, and reflective mood associated with such a moment.
- **It reflects the close relationship between language and natural surroundings in Japanese culture.**



Sulphur

- The West Asia conflict disrupts supply chains, deeper shocks emerge and Sulphur may not grab headlines like oil, but it quietly powers industry and agriculture.
- **Sulphur (identified by the letter S) is a non-metallic chemical element**.
- It can be found as a pure element or as sulphate or sulphide minerals.
- It occurs naturally in the environment and is believed to be the thirteenth most abundant element in the earth's crust.

Properties

- In its pure form, sulfur is a tasteless, odorless, brittle solid with a pale yellow color.
- It's a poor conductor of electricity that doesn't dissolve in water.
- **It combines directly with almost all the elements with the exception of gold, platinum and the noble gases**.
- In India it is mainly found in Puga Valley (Jammu & Kashmir), Barren Island of Bay of Bengal, Andhra Pradesh Kerala and Himachal Pradesh

Uses of Sulphur

- Sulphur is an essential raw material for many chemical industries and is essentially used for the production of sulphuric acid.
- Sulphuric acid is a strong mineral acid which is used in ore processing, fertilizer manufacturing, oil refining, waste water processing and chemical synthesis.
- **The powdered form of sulphur produced by sublimation process is generally used in rubber vulcanisation, agricultural dusts, pharmaceutical products and stock feeds.**
- Sulphur is used as a light-generating medium in the rare lighting fixtures known as "sulphur lamps".
- **Sulphur compounds are also used in detergents, fungicides, dyestuffs and agrichemicals**

City of Seattle becomes first city govt in US to host life-size statue of Swami Vivekananda

- **City of Seattle has become the first city government in the United States to host a life-size statue of Swami Vivekananda at Westlake Square Park.**
- The life-size bronze statue was jointly unveiled by Seattle Mayor Katie Wilson and the Consul General of India in Seattle.

University of Oxford launches nationwide UK tour of Shikshapatri to mark its 200th anniversary



- The Bodleian Libraries at the University of Oxford have launched a nationwide UK tour of the Shikshapatri to mark its 200th anniversary.
- The Shikshapatri is one of the most significant and rare Hindu scriptures. **Shikshapatri, which means a letter of teachings was composed in 1826 at Vadtal in Gujarat by Sahajanand Swami.**
- Organised in collaboration with leaders of the Swaminarayan faith, the tour will showcase the manuscript in major temples, offering thousands the chance to view the sacred text that emphasises ethical living and spiritual guidance.

Sports

Khelo India Games

Khelo India Tribal Games Conclude with Karnataka on Top

- Karnataka emerged as the overall champion at the inaugural Khelo India Tribal Games (KITG) 2026, while host state Chhattisgarh finished ninth in the final medal tally.
- The first-ever Khelo India Tribal Games 2026 concluded in Chhattisgarh, marking India's first national multi-sport event dedicated specifically to tribal athletes.
- The Games were held from 25th March to 3rd April 2026 across venues in Raipur, Jagdalpur and Surguja in Chhattisgarh.

- Mascot: "Morveer" is the official mascot of the Khelo India Tribal Games 2026.
  - The name is rooted in the local cultural ethos, where "Mor" means "our own" and "Veer" represents bravery and strength.



Champion: Karnataka secured the top position in the medal tally with 23 gold, 8 silver and 7 bronze medals (Total: 38).

- Odisha – Rank 2: 21 Gold, 15 Silver, 21 Bronze (Total: 57)
- Jharkhand – Rank 3: 16 Gold, 8 Silver, 11 Bronze (Total: 35)
- Maharashtra – Rank 4: 6 Gold, 10 Silver, 4 Bronze (Total: 20)
- Chhattisgarh – Rank 9: 3 Gold, 10 Silver, 6 Bronze (Total: 19)

National/ International Championships

Indian shooters top ISSF Junior World Cup 2026 standings in Cairo



- Indian shooters topped the standings at the ISSF Junior World Cup 2026 in Cairo, Egypt, with a rich haul of 16 medals - five gold, six silver and five bronze .
- **Hemant Burman won silver in the men's 50 metre rifle 3 positions event**
- In the mixed trap team event, Zuhair Khan and Addya Katyal clinched bronze, marking India's first shotgun podium at the Cairo meet
- **India fielded 71 shooters, the largest contingent among 284 shooters from 25 federations.**

Gold Medalists (ISSF Junior World Cup 2026 - Cairo):

- **Vanshika Chaudhary:** Gold in Women's 10m Air Pistol individual and Mixed Team.
- **Chirag Sharma**: Gold in 10m Air Pistol Mixed Team, He achieved this victory alongside his partner, Vanshika Chaudhary,
- **Divyanshu Dewangan & Shambhavi Kshirsagar**: Gold in 10m Air Rifle Mixed Team (Junior World Record).
- **Prachi Gaikwad:** Gold in Women's 50m Rifle 3 Positions.
- **Shiva Narwal**: Gold in Men's 10m Air Pistol.

India secures gold and silver in Kabaddi at Asian Beach Games



- India ended the Kabaddi competitions in the Asian Beach Games with the women's team clinching a gold medal and the men's team settling for silver in the competitions being held in Sanya, China.
- **This is India's first gold in this edition of the Asian Beach Games - women's team**
- **Organised by the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA),** the Asian Beach Games is a multi-sport event focused on beach and coastal disciplines.
- **First held in Bali, Indonesia, in 2008,** the Games showcase sports not always featured at the Asian Games.
- The **2026 edition is being staged entirely in the resort city of Sanya**
- At the 2016 edition, India won 24 medals, including two gold, four silver, and 18 bronze.

2026 Asian Boxing Championships



- **Vishvanath Suresh won the 50kg title at the Asian Boxing Championships 2026 in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, as Indian men concluded their campaign at the continental meet with a total of six medals - one gold, a silver and four bronze.**
- The Indian boxing squad finished second on the table with five golds, one fewer than Kazakhstan.
- However, they claimed the most medals across men's and women's categories with an overall tally of 16, which includes five gold, three silver and eight bronze.
- India's performance was headlined by the women's team, which topped the medal charts in the gender with 10 medals, including four gold, two silver, and four bronze.

Asian Boxing Championships 2026: Indian medal winners (men)

- Vishvanath Suresh (50kg) - **gold medal**
- Sachin Siwach (60kg) - silver medal
- Akash (75kg) - bronze medal
- Lokesh (85kg) - bronze medal
- Harsh Choudhary (90kg) - bronze medal
- Narender Berwal (90+kg) - bronze medal

Indian Greco-Roman wrestlers win five medals at Asian Wrestling Championships 2026 in Bishkek



- Indian Greco-Roman wrestlers finished the continental championship with a rich haul of five medals - two silver, three bronze.
- The women's freestyle competitions also kicked off.
- A total of 30 Indian wrestlers – 10 each for women's, men's freestyle and Greco-Roman categories – are competing at the continental championships.

India wins 16 medals including seven gold at World Archery Para Series in Bangkok



- The inaugural World Archery Para Series held in Bangkok, Thailand (concluded 4 April 2026),
- India finished on top with an overwhelming seven gold.
- Overall, India won 16 medals - seven gold, five silver and four bronze.

Full list of Indian medallists

- Para Compound Women (Individual): Payal Nag - Gold, Sheetal Devi - Silver
- Para Compound Men (Individual): Toman Kumar - Gold, Shyam Sunder Swami - Bronze
- Para Recurve Women (Individual): Bhawna - Gold
- Para Recurve Men (Individual): Harvinder Singh - Silver
- W1 Women (Individual): Swati Chaudhary - Silver
- Para Compound Women's Team: Payal Nag and Sheetal Devi - Gold
- Para Compound Men's Team: Toman Kumar and Shyam Sunder Swami - Gold
- Para Compound Mixed Team: Sheetal Devi and Toman Kumar - Gold
- Para Recurve Women's Team: Bhawna and Rajshri Dhanraj Rathod - Bronze

- Para Recurve Women's Team: Vijay Sundi and Harvinder Singh - Gold
- Para Recurve Mixed Team: Bhawna and Vijay Sundi - Bronze

Football

Al-Ahli Saudi FC Defend AFC Champions League Elite Title with 1–0 Win over Machida Zelvia

- In football, Al-Ahli of Saudi Arabia successfully defended the AFC Champions League 2026 Elite crown after beating first-time finalist Machida Zelvia of Japan

Cricket

PM Modi inaugurates six BCCI indoor cricket academies across northeast India

- The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) marked a significant milestone in the expansion of cricketing infrastructure with the inauguration of six state-of-the-art Indoor Cricket Academies across North-East India by the Honourable Prime Minister of India, Shri Narendra Modi.
- **The academies are located in Rangpo (Sikkim), Doimukh (Arunachal Pradesh), Imphal (Manipur), Madankurklang (Meghalaya), Aizawl (Mizoram), and Dimapur (Nagaland)**



Vaibhav Suryavanshi becomes youngest to score 1,000 runs in T20s

- **Vaibhav Suryavanshi became the youngest player, and the fastest by balls faced, to complete 1,000 runs in Twenty20 cricket as the 15-year-old smashed a 36-ball century in the Indian Premier League**
- The previous record was held by Australia's Mitchell Owen, who completed 1,000 runs in 533 balls.
- **36-ball century in the Indian Premier League was the third fastest in IPL history, after Chris Gayle's 30-ball ton in 2013 and Suryavanshi's own 35-ball hundred last year.**

KL Rahul becomes first Indian to cross the 150-run mark in an innings

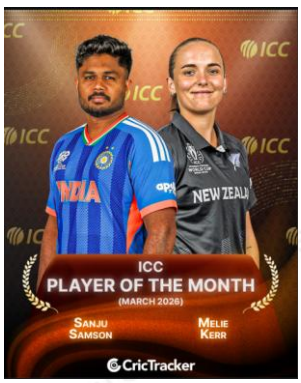


- KL Rahul, become the third cricketer to hit 150 runs in tournament history and registering the highest individual score by an Indian player in the IPL.
- After Chris Gayle (175 against Pune Warriors India in 2013) and Brendon McCullum (158* against Royal Challengers Bengaluru in 2008), **KL is the third batsman to score 150 runs in a single IPL inning.**
- This was also the fastest of KL's six IPL hundreds

MCA Introduces Domestic Player Contract System

- The **Mumbai Cricket Association (MCA) has decided to implement annual contracts for its players, effective from the 2026-2027 season onwards.**
- The MCA has decided to introduce Grades A, B, and C, where players will be remunerated and the proposal was passed during the recent Apex Council meeting.
- Grade A players will be paid between 12 lakh to 20 lakh per annum, Grade B cricketers will be paid between 8 lakh to 12 lakh, while Grade C players will get 8 lakh rupees.
- **The MCA has become the first association to have a contract system for its players.**

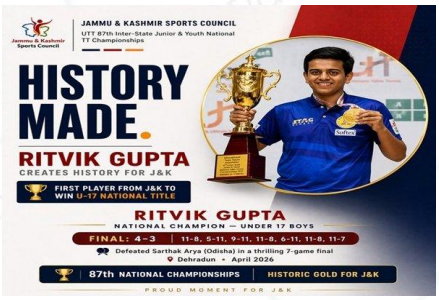
Sanju Samson named ICC men's Player of the Month for March



- New Zealand's Amelia Kerr have been named the ICC Women's Player of the Month for March 2026

Table Tennis

J&K's Ritvik Gupta Wins Under-17 Boys National Table Tennis Title



- Jammu and Kashmir has achieved a historic milestone in table tennis as Ritvik Gupta clinched the Under-17 Boys National title **at the UTT 87th Inter-State Junior and Youth National Table Tennis Championships, organised under the aegis of the Table Tennis Federation of India.**
- Ritvik Gupta has become the first player from Jammu and Kashmir to win a national championship title in the Under-17 Boys category,

Chess

Aronyak Ghosh becomes India's 95th GM



- Aronyak Ghosh became India's 95th GM after 4 years of his first GM norm.
- **The Kolkata chess player achieved his final norm at Bangkok Chess Club Open .**

India's Grandmaster R. Vaishali Wins FIDE Women's Candidates 2026 in Cyprus

- In chess, India's Grandmaster R. Vaishali won the FIDE Women's Candidates Tournament 2026 in **Cyprus and qualify for the World Chess Championship.**

11-year-old Bodhana Sivanandan becomes England's top-rated female player in FIDE rankings



- Indian-origin chess prodigy Bodhana Sivanandan has become England's top-rated female player, according to the latest rating list of the International Chess Federation (FIDE).
- moved from Tiruchirappalli in Tamil Nadu to England in 2007, has 2366 FIDE rating points.
- she has also broken into the world's top 100 women for the first time, currently sitting at number 72,
- Sivanandan became a Woman International Master last year.

Hockey

16th Hockey India sub-junior women's National championship

- **Hockey Jharkhand** continued its dominance at the grassroots level by clinching the 16th Hockey India sub-junior women's National championship, marking a third consecutive title (2024, 2025, 2026)
- The **State has secured an impressive 34 medals** in women's competitions alone, including 10 gold, 11 silver and 13 bronze medals.

Race

Marc Marquez wins Spanish GP 2026

India Launches First Official F1 Sim Racing Championship



- Formula 1 and Mumbai Falcons Racing Limited have announced the launch of India's first Official F1 Sim Racing Championship.
- **This also marks the first time Formula 1 has introduced a programme of this nature, exclusively for India.**
- The F1 Sim Racing India Open 2026 will establish a national competitive platform for emerging talent across the country.



- The Championship is designed to **create a structured pathway from virtual competition to professional motorsport, offering young drivers a credible first step into the wider racing ecosystem.**
- **With e-sports now officially recognised under the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025**, initiatives like the F1 Sim Racing India Open 2026 connect India to the global driver pathway of F1,

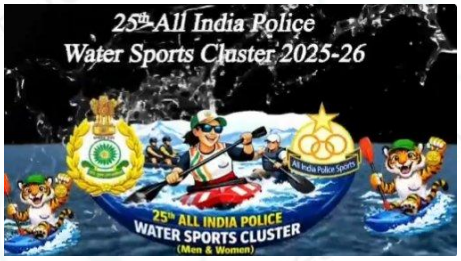
Miscellaneous

Sawan Barwal Breaks India's Oldest Marathon Record



- At the NN Marathon Rotterdam, a World Athletics Gold Label Road Race, the **28-year-old Army havildar Sawan Barwal from Mandi in Himachal Pradesh,** clocked 2 hours 11 minutes and 58 seconds to break the late Shivnath Singh's marathon record of 2:12:00 set in 1978.
- India's oldest athletic record was broken by the long-distance runner making his debut in the marathon.

ITBP to host 25th All India Water Sports Cluster in Uttarakhand



- The 25th All India Police Water Sports Cluster Championship will begin at Tehri Lake in Uttarakhand.
- Organised under the aegis of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police, the event will continue until April 12.
- In this national-level championship, more than 440 athletes from 19 police teams across the country are participating.
- A total of 52 events, including canoeing, rowing, and kayaking, will be organised, providing a platform for state police and central armed forces personnel to showcase their sporting talent.

Rupa Bayor becomes first Indian to reach World Taekwondo Top-5 ranking

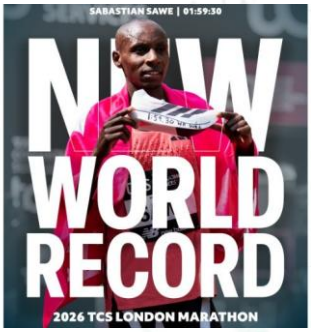


- Rupa Bayor from Arunachal Pradesh has become the first Indian Taekwondo athlete to achieve World Taekwondo (WT) World Ranking No. 5
- She previously made history as the first Indian to reach World Rank 6 and Asia Rank 1.
- She secured a Gold Medal in the Recognized Individual Poomsae U30 category at the 4th Senior National Taekwondo Poomsae Championships.
- Bayor was also recently named Best Taekwondo Poomsae Player of the Year at the 2026 India Taekwondo Gala Awards

World Anti-Doping Agency

- Recently, the Union Minister of Youth Affairs and Sports addressed the inaugural ceremony of the Final Conference of the World Anti-Doping Agency's (WADA) Global Anti-Doping Intelligence & Investigations Network (GAIIN).
- **World Anti-Doping Agency was established on 10 November 1999.**
- Its mission is to promote and coordinate the fight against doping in sport internationally.
- **Role**: To develop, harmonize and coordinate anti-doping rules and policies across all sports and countries.
- **Headquarter**: Montreal, Canada

Sabastian Sawe makes history at London Marathon, becomes 1st athlete to run sub-two-hour marathon in competitive race



- Sabastian Sawe made history at the London Marathon by becoming the first athlete to run a sub-two-hour marathon in a competitive race.
- **The 31-year-old Kenyan crossed the line to win in one hour 59 minutes 30 seconds, more than one minute faster than the late Kelvin Kiptum's previous record** .
- Already on world record pace as he crossed the halfway mark in one hour and 29 seconds

The World Masters Sports Championship 2026 held in Thailand

- The World Masters Sports Championships 2026 held in Sriracha, Thailand, from 17th to 20th April 2026.
- **Bapatla district police personnel, Andhra Pradesh brought laurels at the international level by winning five medals at the World Masters Sports Championship**
- Mr. Subbarao won gold medals in the 100m and 200m sprint events, while Mr. Nagaraju secured gold in shotput and silver medals in discus throw and javelin throw respectively.

International Chess Federation Joins IWGA at AGM in Lausanne

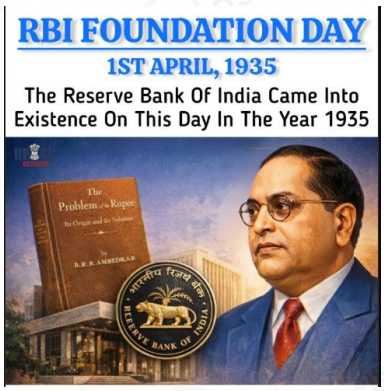
- International Chess Federation joined the **International World Games Association (IWGA) at the Annual General Meeting (AGM) held at the Olympic Museum in Lausanne, Switzerland**
- The decision raises IWGA membership to 40 federations and expands the range of sports in the World Games movement.

Operation Upstream

- **The World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) has decided to collaborate with the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to take a 'top to down' approach to curb anti-doping activities in the nation as the Sports Ministry pushes for criminalization of suppliers of prohibited substances to athletes.**
- Operation Upstream, a joint CBI-WADA action plan, will target supply chains that move prohibited performance-enhancing drugs, and punish coaches, physios of doping athletes.
- Currently, India is the country with the most number of dope offenders in the WADA list of suspended athletes from 2024.

Banking / Finance

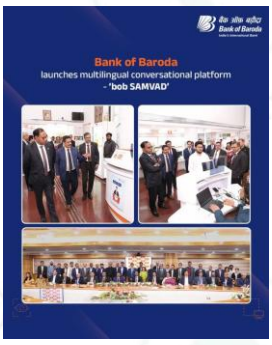
April 1 RBI Foundation Day



- On April 1, 1935, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) was established in accordance with the provisions of the **Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934.**
- It is responsible for monetary stability, currency management, inflation targeting, regulating the banking system, and setting interest rates.
- It was set up on the basis of the recommendations of the Royal Commission on Indian Currency (Hilton Young Commission) which was set up in 1926. It recommended establishing a central bank to be called the 'Reserve Bank of India'.
- RBI is tasked with regulating the issue of banknotes, maintaining reserves with a view to securing monetary stability and to operate the credit and currency system of the country to its advantage.

- The first Governor of the RBI was the Australian Sir Osborne Arkell Smith, one of the two managing governors of the Imperial Bank of India. Sir C D Deshmukh was the first Indian to become Governor.
- The Central Office of the Reserve Bank was initially established in Kolkata but was permanently moved to Mumbai in 1937.
- RBI was nationalised from 1st January, 1949 on the basis of the Reserve Bank of India (Transfer to Public Ownership) Act, 1948.
- As of April 2026, the Governor of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is Sanjay Malhotra

'bob SAMVAD', an AI-powered multilingual conversational platform of Bank of Baroda



- Bank of Baroda (Bank) unveiled its bob SAMVAD, in Mumbai .
- The platform is an industry-first AI-powered multilingual conversational platform aimed at transforming customer interactions at its branches.
- Designed to eliminate language barriers, the platform enables customers and branch staff to communicate seamlessly with each other in their preferred language.

RBI MPC keeps repo rate unchanged at 5.25%



- RBI MPC Meeting 2026 Highlights: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) announced its monetary policy decision, 8 April 2026
- The RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra-led Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) held its first bi-monthly policy meeting for FY27 from April 6 to April 8
- The RBI's rate setting panel - Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) - kept repo rates unchanged at 5.25%, and maintained policy stance at 'Neutral'.
- RBI projected FY27 GDP growth at 6.9%.
- CPI inflation for FY27 has been projected at 4.6%.
- SDF rate at 5.00%
- MSF rate at 5.50%
- Bank Rate at 5.50%

Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana completes 11 years



- **Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY)** is a flagship initiative by the Government of India that was **launched in 2015** and aimed at providing **affordable credit to micro and small enterprises.**
- **Objective:** The scheme is designed to **"fund the unfunded,"** enabling **small borrowers to secure loans from various financial institutions** including Public Sector Banks (PSBs), Regional Rural Banks (RRBs), Cooperative Banks, Private Sector Banks, Foreign Banks, Micro Finance Institutions (MFIs), and Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs).
- **Loan amount: Up to ₹20 lakh** for **non-farm income-generating activities** in sectors such as manufacturing, processing, trading, and services.

Categories of Loans:

- **Shishu:** Loans **up to ₹50,000**, aimed at new and micro enterprises.
- **Kishore:** Loans ranging from **₹50,000 to ₹5 lakh**, for businesses in the growth phase.
- **Tarun:** Loans from **₹5 lakh to ₹10 lakh,** for businesses looking to expand further.

- **Tarun Plus:** Loans from **₹10 lakh to ₹20 lakh**, for those who have successfully repaid previous loans under the "Tarun" category.

Bonus Issue

- India's largest insurer, Life Insurance Corporation of India, recently announced the first ever bonus issue.
- **A bonus issue, also known as a scrip issue or a capitalization issue, occurs when a company listed on a stock exchange decides to offer free additional shares to the existing shareholders.**
- The company decides the number of bonus shares to be allotted to every individual investor for holding a certain number of shares over a set period of time and accordingly rewards them.
- This bonus issue aims to attract further investment and reward its existing shareholders as it improves the entity's market image.
- **A bonus issue of shares will increase a company's share capital but not its market capitalisation.**
- Market capitalisation is calculated by multiplying the company's current stock price and the total number of outstanding shares.
- **Share capital is the amount that the company raises by issuing shares.**

What is a Stock Split?

- A stock split is an action taken in which a company divides its existing shares into multiple shares to boost the liquidity of shares.
- A split is usually undertaken when the stock price is high, making it pricey for investors to acquire.
- **It brings down the share price as the number of shares increases.**
- The market cap of the firm and the value of each shareholder's investment stay unchanged after a stock split.

Windfall Tax

- **Oil marketing company stocks such as IOC, BPCL, HPCL and Reliance came under pressure after the Centre sharply increased the windfall tax** on diesel and ATF exports amid crude prices crossing $100 per barrel due to West Asia tensions.
- A **windfall tax is a higher tax rate levied by the government on specific industries or companies when they experience unexpected, outsized profits**—often referred to as windfall gains—due to favorable external conditions rather than their own business maneuvers or investments.
- In the energy sector, these gains typically occur when global geopolitical tensions drive up crude oil and fuel prices.
- **The tax is generally implemented as a levy on the export of fuels or the production of domestic crude.**
  - Share excess crisis profits with government
  - Fund subsidies/social welfare for consumers
  - Raise revenue during economic/geopolitical instability
- Windfall tax is temporary and fluctuates. It can be reduced to zero if global prices crash.
- **The government monitors global prices (like Brent Crude). When prices exceed a certain threshold, the excess profit per unit is taxed.**



India Slips to Sixth in IMF GDP Rankings 2025

- India has slipped to the 6th spot in global GDP rankings, according to the most recent estimates by the International Monetary Fund (IMF) for 2025–26.

- The Indian economy is estimated at $3.92 trillion in 2025, placing it behind the UK ($4 trillion) and Japan ($4.44 trillion).
- **US tops the list with a GDP of $30.8 trillion, followed by China at $19.6 trillion** and Germany at $4.7 trillion.India ($3.5 trillion) had ranked fifth in 2024, ahead of the UK at $3.4 trillion.

LIC Launches 'MyLIC' and 'Super Sales Saathi' Mobile Applications

- Life Insurance Corporation of India has launched two new mobile applications — MyLIC and Super Sales Saathi — **to strengthen customer service and digital accessibility in the insurance sector.**
- MyLIC is a customer-centric app that integrates policy management, claims, payments, loans, and e-KYC into one platform.
- **Super Sales Saathi is a dedicated app for LIC's agents and intermediaries, enabling digital sales, customer servicing, and performance monitoring.**

MyLIC App (Customer-Facing)

- **Unified Policy Dashboard**: Allows customers to view and manage all policies in one place with real-time benefit tracking.
- **Paperless Services**: Supports online premium payments, e-KYC, policy loans, revival of lapsed policies, and updates.
- **Digital Purchase & Claims**: Enables seamless online purchase of policies and claims-related support.

Super Sales Saathi (Agent/Intermediary-Facing)

- **Digital Sales Tools**: Product explainers, digital kits, and AI-based customer nudges for better sales outreach.
- **Real-Time Tracking**: Instant policy status updates, follow-up reminders, and customer interaction tools.
- **Performance Dashboard**: Helps intermediaries track targets, achievements, and customer insights.

Forex reserves



- Due to ongoing West Asian conflict India is facing pressure on the rupee and foreign exchange reserves.
- Last week, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said India's foreign exchange reserves "remain adequate to provide cushion against external shocks".
- Foreign exchange reserves are an important component of the Balance of Payment (BoP) and an essential element in the analysis of an economy's external position.
- In times of crisis, adequate foreign exchange reserves give comfort, acting as a buffer and giving strength to a country's macroeconomic fundamentals.
- The RBI has the primary responsibility of collection, compilation and dissemination of data relating to foreign exchange reserves.
- India's foreign exchange reserves comprise foreign currency assets (FCA), gold, special drawing rights (SDRs) and reserve tranche position (RTP) in the International Monetary Fund (IMF).
- Special Drawing Rights: SDRs are international foreign exchange reserve assets. Allocated to nations by the IMF, a SDR represents a claim to foreign currencies for which it may be exchanged in times of need. SDRs are the IMF's unit of account.
- The value of SDRs is based on a basket of five currencies – the US dollar, the euro, the Chinese renminbi, the Japanese yen, and the pound sterling.
- As of March 13, India's SDR holdings were worth $18.7 billion.

Cabinet approves additional instalment of Dearness Allowance to Central Government employees and Dearness Relief (DR) to pensioners w.e.f. 01.01.2026

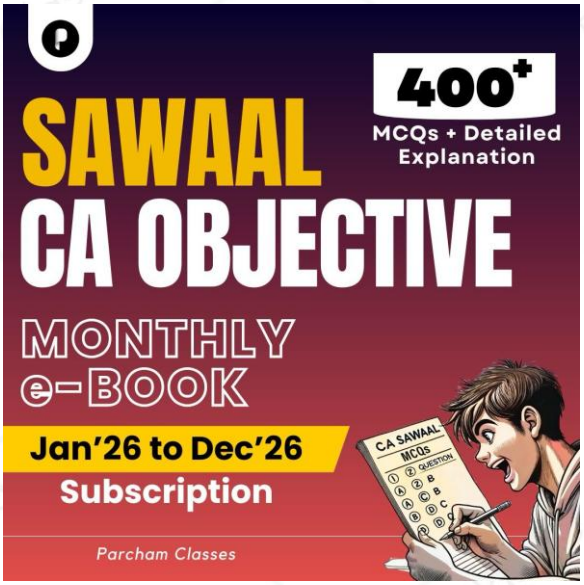
- The Union Cabinet chaired by the Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi has approved to release an additional instalment of Dearness Allowance (DA) to Central Government employees and Dearness Relief (DR) to pensioners w.e.f. 01.01.2026 **representing an increase of 2% over the existing rate of 58% of the Basic Pay/Pension, to compensate against price rise.**
- The combined impact on the exchequer on account of increase in both Dearness Allowance and Dearness Relief would be Rs.6791.24 crore per annum.
- **This increase is in accordance with the accepted formula, which is based on the recommendations of the 7th Central Pay Commission.**

Borrowers' Platform

- Recently, **developing countries have launched the first-ever Borrowers' Platform at the International Monetary Fund (IMF)-World Bank Spring Meetings 2026.**
- Borrowers' Platform is a dedicated space en**abling developing countries that are borrowers to come together, share knowledge, exchange experiences and speak collectively on debt issues.**
- It brings together finance ministers and central bank governors from developing countries to strengthen debt management capacity, enhance coordination and amplify their collective voice in global debt discussions.
- It will be **governed by the ministers of finance of participating countries**. They will be supported by technical officials responsible for debt.
- It is not a forum for collective debt-restructuring negotiations.
- **Members**: It has 30 members including India. Its working group is chaired by Egypt.
- **Secretariat**: It is supported by the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development as its secretariat.

RBI Launches Mission SAKSHAM for Cooperative Banks

- The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has launched Mission SAKSHAM for capacity building of the Urban Co-operative Banking sector.
- It **aims to enhance managerial and operational capabilities, improve compliance culture, and strengthen institutional resilience across UCBs.**
- Under Mission SAKSHAM (Sahkari Bank Kshamta Nirman), a large number of training programmes would be conducted for UCBs, covering about 1.40 lakh participants.






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